

Patristic Theories of Biblical Interpretation

The Latin Fathers

Edited by Tarmo Toom



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TARMO TOOM

Georgetown University



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Tarmo Toom

CHAPTER I

Introduction

Tarmo Toom

This volume provides an assessment of Latin patristic hermeneutical theories and it consists of chapters on a few selected ancient authors who have explicitly reflected on interpretative matters at least somewhere in their works. After some serious consideration, it seemed wiser to invite a team of international experts to write learned essays on particular figures, rather than to imagine that a single scholar can appraise all authors equally well.

There is a modern distinction between hermeneutics, which refers to general principles of the art of interpretation, and exegesis, which refers to the actual application of these principles to particular texts.¹ Such compartmentalization of theoretical and practical approaches tends to make sense to most modern persons. However, this fine and, no doubt, at times rather helpful distinction may be somewhat misleading when it is applied to the art of interpretation of Scripture during the first few centuries. Namely, patristic authors never postulated an abstract, full-blown hermeneutical theory that was envisaged in isolation from the actual practice of interpreting the Word of God.² Neither was patristic biblical exegesis ever a mere procedural affair, some sort of “neutral” application of techniques and theory to scriptural texts, without a simultaneous concern for

¹ A. C. Thiselton, *Hermeneutics: An Introduction* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2009), 4.

² A prime example would be Augustine’s *De doctrina Christiana*, in which books 2 and 3 discuss a hermeneutical/semiotic theory and book 4 addresses the communication of that which the theory has helped to discover in Scripture. See J. A. Andrews, *Hermeneutics and the Church: In Dialogue with Augustine*, *Reading the Scriptures* (Notre Dame, IN: University of Notre Dame Press, 2012), 23–5, 143–52.

the interpreter's spiritual benefit.³ "For Christian interpreters the Bible was . . . a book which had been read and expounded in the Christian liturgy, used for introduction, edification, and prayer. Its interpretation could not be divorced from its use."⁴ Therefore, the fundamental symbiosis of theory and practice in patristic biblical interpretation should never be obscured by this modern, convenient distinction between hermeneutics and exegesis.

Put differently, any attempt to investigate patristic hermeneutical theory has to face the problem of how to understand the word "theory." The modern use of this word can indeed have the overtones of something abstract, conceptual, and, depending on one's view, even impractical. In antiquity, there were several theories about *theōria*. While the Platonic trajectory emphasized the relation between *theōros*' mental gaze at the forms and the consequent informed *praxis*,⁵ the Aristotelian trajectory resolutely severed *theōria*, the "seeing" of something divine, from *praxis* and perceived it as a supreme activity of the highest intrinsic value in itself.⁶ The Stagirite contended that *theōria* constituted "the only activity that is loved for its own sake: it produces no result beyond the actual act of contemplation (*para to*

³ For example, in *Moralia in Iob*, Gregory the Great employed an Origenist hermeneutical theory for the higher purposes of moral edification and spiritual transformation – for which the text was meant in the first place. See Brendan Lupton's Chapter 8 in this volume.

⁴ R. L. Wilken, "Cyril of Alexandria," in C. Kannengiesser (ed.), *Handbook of Patristic Exegesis*, The Bible in Ancient Christianity (Leiden: Brill, 2004), vol. II, 840–69, at 851. In the early fifth century and in his thorough commentary, Augustine contended that Scripture was "expressed in a way designed to nourish our devout hearts" (*Gen. litt.* 1.20.40). For a particular example, see D. Brakke, "Reading the New Testament and Transforming the Self in Evagrius of Pontus," in H.-U. Weidemann (ed.), *Asceticism and Exegesis in Early Christianity*, *Novum Testamentum et Orbis Antiquus* 101 (Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 2013), 284–99.

⁵ Plato, *Rep.* V–VII (449a–541b); cf. A. W. Nightingale, *Spectacles of Truth in Classical Greek Philosophy: Theoria in Its Cultural Context* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2004), 72–138, esp. 82 and 127–38.

⁶ Aristotle, *NE* X.7–9 (1177b1–1179b33); *Pol.* VII.3 (1325b16–21); cf. T. Jürgasch, *Theoria versus Praxis? Zur Entwicklung eines Prinzipienwissens im Bereich der Praxis in Antike und Spätantike* (Berlin: De Gruyter, 2013), 158–66, 189–94; Nightingale, *Spectacles of Truth*, 187–252. Cicero mentions the debate between the ancient hardcore pragmatists and theoreticians in his *Letter to Atticus* 36 (II.16).

theōrēsai).⁷ Plotinus reinforced the idea that the purely intellectual *theōria* was the ultimate single goal, which had to leave behind the inferior and multiple *praxis*.⁸ If this trend of thought is followed and if *theōria* is purged from its original theological–religious content⁹ (that is, if theory is understood as an abstract, generalizing experiment of rational thought, a sort of shuffling of hypothetical notions), then there is no such thing as patristic hermeneutical theory. As mentioned earlier, none of the patristic authors addressed hermeneutical issues merely for the sake of leisurely abstract reflection or speculation. On the contrary, theory was always in the service of practice, be it interpretation of Scripture or virtuous living. Thus, as this volume focuses on the patristic hermeneutical theory, the word “theory” should be understood in a Platonic rather than an Aristotelian/Plotinian sense.

An affirmation of the firm interconnection between patristic hermeneutical theory and exegetical practice enables this introduction to proceed with an explanation of the relatively narrow focus of the given volume. The lead is taken from Cassiodorus, who indeed discriminated between *introductores*, treatises that provided introductory information and general hermeneutical rules for interpreting Scripture, and *expositores*, treatises that actually exegeted Scripture.¹⁰ Nuancing this further, one can differentiate between four interrelated and heavily overlapping, yet not completely identical, phenomena:

1. Patristic exegetical writings (e.g., commentaries);
2. Patristic expository homilies;¹¹

⁷ Aristotle, *NE* X.7 (1177b1).

⁸ Plotinus, *Enn.* III.8.4–6; I. Craemer-Ruegenberg, “Überlegungen zu Plotins Begriff von ‘theoria,’” in E. Jain and R. Margreiter (eds.), *Probleme philosophischer Mystik: Festschrift für Karl Albert zum siebzigsten Geburtstag* (Sankt Augustin: Academia Verlag, 1991), 175–85; A. Linguisti, “Plotinus and Porphyry on the Contemplative Life,” in T. Bénatouil and M. Bonazzi (eds.), *Theoria, Praxis and the Contemplative Life after Plato and Aristotle*, *Philosophia Antiqua* 131 (Leiden: Brill, 2012), 183–97, at 186–90.

⁹ Plato, *Rep.* VI.19–20 (508e–509c); VII.18 (540a); Aristotle, *Metaph.* I.2.8 and 14 (982b9–10 and 983a6–11); XI.7.8 (1064a 36–8); Plotinus, *Enn.* I.6.8–9.

¹⁰ Cassiodorus, *Inst.* 1.10.1–2.

¹¹ Origen, for example, contrasted his commentaries as *exponendi scripturas* to his homilies as *aedificandi ecclesiam* (*Hom. Lev.* 7.1.1).

3. Patristic hermeneutical theory deduced from actual exegetical practice; that is, a theory deduced from both the commentaries and expository homilies;
4. Patristic hermeneutical theory as such to the extent it, or its elements, were explicated by various authors.

Ideally, while addressing the topic of patristic biblical interpretation as such, all four should be taken into consideration. This volume, however, purposely limits itself to point number four – to the contribution of those Latin patristic authors who have said something substantial about hermeneutics vis-à-vis those who interpreted Scripture and occasionally said something about what they were doing. In other words, the four points are made not for artificially separating things that belong together, but for setting closer parameters for determining the limited scope of this volume. At the end of the day, it is a question of choosing one aspect of the aforementioned phenomena on which to focus. At least for the editor of this volume, it seems entirely legitimate to focus on these precious few texts (chapters or sections) where Latin patristic authors actually discussed hermeneutics, while acknowledging that ultimately, patristic hermeneutical theory (4) cannot be cut off from exegetical practice (3), which is found in commentaries and homilies (1 and 2).¹² Although “many works of orthodox and ecclesiastical authors came to us, each of them showing their interpretation (*hermēneia*) of divine Scriptures,”¹³ very few of them provided theoretical analysis.

There is another aspect to restricting the chapters to the more theoretical discussions of the patristic authors that needs to be addressed. To get a “total picture” of someone’s hermeneutics obviously takes

¹² Ancient commentaries, and especially their prologues, often included remarks on various interpretative topics, such as textual criticism and explanation of words and grammar, as well as observations on style and the subject matter discussed in a particular text (see Aline Canellis’ Chapter 3 in this volume). Further special cases were paraphrases which conveyed the supposed meaning of a text in different wordings. (For example, Augustine had originally attached a paraphrase to the Psalms 15–32.) However, such paraphrases restated what the text said rather than discussed how meaning(s) were constituted.

¹³ Eusebius, *HE* 5.27.1.

more than assessing his/her theoretical deliberations.¹⁴ Various historical and ecclesial contexts, audiences, the interpreter's own education, skills, and spiritual life – all this should be included in a reconstructed and purportedly complete account of someone's biblical hermeneutics. This, however, would require a monograph, rather than an chapter, on each author. Consequently and because of the relatively narrow focus of this volume, readers will not find here lengthy analyses of historical contexts, rhetorical situations, and portraits of patristic authors. Neither will they find in-depth assessments of source-critical and linguistic issues, articulated theologies of Scripture, and descriptions of actual exegetical practices. Inevitably, such important topics have to be researched in order to provide an informed account of a given author's understanding of hermeneutics. Yet once again, in this collection of chapters, these topics are not investigated for their own sakes. After all, studying a topic contextually does not mean that a given monograph or chapter has to use most of its textual space for discussing the reconstructed contexts. Analogically, writing on someone's hermeneutical theory obviously presupposes one's knowledge of this person's education, context, theology of Scripture, and exegetical writings, as well as other related topics, but it does not necessarily require a full-length elaboration on these matters.

Perhaps many would also like the introduction of this volume to address the topic of relevance of a hermeneutical theory – although the very need of addressing such a topic itself may betray a modern, embedded pragmatist/utilitarian perspective and theory phobia. Nevertheless, what is gained by a study of interpretative assumptions, principles, and procedures? It was in the prologue of *De doctrina Christiana* where Augustine discussed the necessity of a hermeneutical theory for interpreting Scripture, as well as the naïveté of those who imagined that God's Word was clear and

¹⁴ Since patristic authors usually discussed only a few elements of a hermeneutical theory proper, and did so according to their particular concerns, to reconstruct a more or less complete theory from their sporadic insights remains unfeasible.

accessible without any methodological reflections.¹⁵ The situation Augustine faced was the following:¹⁶ there were some people in the church who had almost no clue as to what the bishop wanted to achieve with his treatise on biblical hermeneutics; others, in turn, did not have enough skill to use his sophisticated *praecepta*.¹⁷ There really was not much Augustine could do for those two groups of people. Still others, “the third group of fault-finders,” declared that “nobody needs these rules (*ista praecepta*),¹⁸ but that it was simply a divine gift (*divino munere*) which made possible the praiseworthy opening up of the obscurities of this sacred literature.”¹⁹ Perhaps they wanted to be “just spiritual” and get everything, including understanding of texts, directly from the Lord, without the mediation of signs, methods, hermeneutical theories, human teachers, and “secular” education.²⁰ Augustine’s argument

¹⁵ Origen, too, had pointed out that “[t]he ignorant . . . have this worst fault of all: they consider those who have devoted themselves to the word and teaching as vain and useless. They prefer their own ignorance (which they call ‘spiritual simplicity’) to the study and labors of the learned” (*Hom. Ps.* 36).

¹⁶ Cicero explained that *insinuatio* – a rhetorical method for securing the good will of the audience – was used “when the spirit of the audience was hostile” (*Inv.* 1.17.23).

¹⁷ Augustine, *doc. Chr.* Prol. 2. Augustine was deeply embedded in the rhetorical tradition that taught him at times rather complicated steps of *interpretatio scripti* (Cicero, *Inv.* 2.40.116–2.51.154; cf. Pseudo-Augustine, *Rhet.* 11). These consisted of four main hermeneutical *topoi*: (1) definition (*definitio, vis verbis*), that is, what exactly a text said; (2) the possible discrepancy between the written words and writer’s intention (*scriptum versus voluntas*); (3) ambiguity (*ambiguitas*), that is, how to disambiguate ambiguous statements; and (4) contradiction (*ex contrariis legibus*), that is, how to solve the perceived contradictions in the texts that belonged together (K. Eden, *Hermeneutics and the Rhetorical Tradition: Chapters in the Ancient Legacy and Its Humanist Reception*, Yale Studies in Hermeneutics [New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1997], 8). Especially Augustine’s sophisticated semiotic theory could have been just a bit too much for sincere but simple students of the Bible.

¹⁸ Already a pragmatist Isocrates thought that theoreticians were “prattling and splitting hairs, since none of these things is useful (*chrēsimon*) either in private or in public life” (*Antidosis* 261–2, cited in Nightingale, *Spectacles of Truth*, 21).

¹⁹ Augustine, *doc. Chr.* Prol. 4; cf. 4.16.33.

²⁰ *Doc. Chr.* 4.16. Mayer suggested that Augustine’s opponents substituted the preposition *per* (“through”) in *res per signa* with the preposition *sine* (“without”) – *res sine*

was “with Christians, who congratulated themselves on knowledge of Holy Scriptures gained without any human guidance (*sine duce homine*),”²¹ with Christians who believed that it was possible to be dependent only on divine illumination.²² He pointed out that it was, in fact, the apostle Philip, another human being, who helped an Ethiopian eunuch to understand the obscure passage of prophet Isaiah.²³ He also wondered, cleverly, why his opponents still lectured and wrote, if understanding came only through divine illumination. Why were his opponents “so eager to explain it to others,” if Scripture was understood only through Christ’s inward teaching?²⁴ Convinced of the importance of a hermeneutical theory, Augustine explained that his *praecepta* were like an alphabet which one had to know before he/she could interpret Scripture adequately.²⁵ Thus, believing that he had provided a “sufficient answer (*convenienter responsum*)” to his critics, Augustine proceeded with the writing of his textbook on hermeneutics.

Agreeing with Augustine’s arguments for the importance of an interpretative *praecepta*, it remains to be said that although this volume contends that hermeneutical theory matters, it nowhere contends that theory is the only thing that matters.

signa (C. P. Mayer, “‘Res per signa’: Der Grundgedanke des Prologs in Augustins Schrift *De doctrina christiana* und das Problem seiner Datierung,” *Revue des Études Augustiniennes* 20 [1974], 100–12, at 104). Arguably, the presence of such people was one of the reasons for Augustine to insert an elaborate discussion about the usefulness of “secular” knowledge for interpreting Scripture in *doc. Chr.* 2.17.27–42.63.

²¹ *Doc. Chr.* Prol. 5.

²² Augustine himself taught the importance of illumination of the Inner Teacher and remained true to his Platonic epistemology (Ps 36:9; Mt 23:10; Augustine, *civ. Dei.* 8.9; *en. Ps.* 118[17].3; *Jo. ev. tr.* 26.7; *mag.* 11.38–12.40, 13.46). His opponents, however, evidently radicalized his teaching on illumination by making it absolutely exclusive of human teachings and theories.

²³ *Doc. Chr.* Prol. 7. ²⁴ *Doc. Chr.* Prol. 8.

²⁵ Augustine understood his hermeneutical *praecepta* as a critical–theoretical reflection on the practice of biblical interpretation. Theoretical considerations were supposed to lead to a better-informed practice. This was already the claim Socrates had made in Plato’s *Rep.* VII.18 (540a) – after having gazed at the good itself, a *theōros* had a better idea of what exactly to implement in the society.

Last, but not least, there are some editorial reasons for limiting this volume to Latin patristic authors only, such as the length of the book and the fact that it enables a restricted yet sufficiently comprehensive selection of representatives of at least one of the Christian geographic/cultural/linguistic areas of late antiquity. Another reason for opting for Latin authors only is their relevance for hermeneutical theory in the medieval western church. All the authors considered in this volume were known, read, and cited in the Middle Ages.²⁶ The envisioned readership of this volume (in English), too, is, in one way or another, the heir of this particular culture.

Exclusive consideration of Latin authors does not mean, however, that there ever existed something like a “pure” Latin trajectory of hermeneutical theory.²⁷ The inclusion of Junillus and Jerome, for example, should make it sufficiently clear that both Syriac and Greek hermeneutical trajectories were accommodated by Latin authors. After all, and as von Balthasar has said, “There is no thinker in the Church who is so invisibly all-present as Origen.”²⁸ This is definitely true about Latin biblical hermeneutics, especially after Rufinus and Jerome made Origen’s commentaries available for Latin speakers.²⁹ Once again, to limit the volume to Latin authors

²⁶ H. de Lubac, *Exégèse médiévale: les quatre sens de l’écriture*, Théologie 41, 42, 59 (Paris: Aubier, 1959–64), and B. Smalley, *The Study of the Bible in the Middle Ages* (Notre Dame, IN: Notre Dame University Press, 1964). Although not focusing on exegesis, helpful volumes are also I. Backus (ed.), *The Reception of the Church Fathers in the West: From the Carolingians to the Maurists* (Leiden: Brill, 2001), vol. I, as well as R. E. McNally, *The Bible in the Middle Ages* (Atlanta, GA: Scholars Press, 1985 [original: Westminster: Newman Press, 1953]), 37–46.

²⁷ It has been argued that, starting with Tyconius’ *Regula*, a certain rule-centered or legalistic approach to hermeneutics was characteristic of Latin authors, but this argument tends to evaporate in a closer look at the comparative material.

²⁸ H. U. von Balthasar, *Origen, Spirit and Fire: A Thematic Anthology of His Writings*, trans. R. J. Daly (Washington, DC: The Catholic University of America Press, 1984), 2.

²⁹ J. Irmscher, “Origenes latinus: gli scritti esegetici de origene nella traduzione Latina,” in *L’esegesi dei padri latini: dalle origini a Gregorio Magno, XXVIII Incontro di studiosi dell’antichità cristiana, Roma, 6–8 maggio 1999*, *Studia ephemeridis Augustinianum* 68 (Roma: Institutum Patristicum Augustinianum, 2000), vol. I, 49–55; C. Jacob, “The Reception of the Origenist Tradition in Latin

does not mean to deny the influences and insights from the authors writing in other languages, but does mean that the selected authors wrote exclusively in Latin.

In *Inst.* 1.10.1, Cassiodorus introduces the hermeneutical works of Tyconius and Augustine, as well as Adrian's *Isagōgē in sacras scripturas*,³⁰ Eucherius' *Formulae spiritalis intelligentiae*, and Junillus' *Instituta regularia divinae legis*. This list, with the exception of Adrianus and Eucherius (see the following), includes basically all there is to read in the Latin patristic literature about Scripture as such and the theory of biblical interpretation. That is, these are the specific extant Latin hermeneutical/exegetical treatises (*introduc-tores*) known to us.³¹ To the aforementioned list, this volume adds Jerome and Cassian, Cassiodorus himself, and Gregory the Great and Isidore of Seville, both of whom lived about half a century later than Cassiodorus. Including and excluding authors was definitely one of the toughest editorial challenges in conceptualizing this volume. The choices made are likely to remain controversial. Therefore, a brief explanation of omissions.

Many readers are probably surprised not to find Tertullian, who has to "be considered supreme,"³² in the selected, celebrated company of Latin patristic hermeneuts. After all, he stands in the very beginning of the Latin exegetical tradition and, as such, he is undoubtedly a foundational figure. To mention just one example, in *Adversus Hermogenem*, Tertullian contended that if Hermogenes

Exegesis," in M. Sæbø et al. (eds.), *Hebrew Bible/Old Testament: The History of Its Interpretation*. Vol. 1: *From the Beginnings to the Middle Ages (until 1300)* (Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1996), 682–700.

³⁰ Adrian's *Isagōgē in sacras scripturas* is written in Greek and therefore omitted from the collection of essays dedicated to Latin fathers. It was translated into Latin only in the seventeenth century by Aloysius Lollinus. A new critical text, translation, and assessment will be available in P. W. Martens, *Adrian's "Introduction to the Divine Scriptures": An Antiochene Handbook for Scriptural Interpretation*, Oxford Early Christian Texts (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2017).

³¹ One may want to add the Latin translations of two introductions to Scripture, one attributed to Athanasius (*PG* 28.283–438) and the other to Chrysostom (*PG* 56:313–86).

³² Vincent of Lérins, *Comm.* 18.

got his doctrine wrong (e.g., believing the preexistence of matter), he also got his biblical interpretations wrong. In other words, if Hermogenes' theological convictions were inadequate, he inevitably misread the creation accounts in Genesis.³³ The correct interpretation³⁴ had to presuppose the *regula fidei*³⁵ and apply the principle *scriptura sacra sui ipsius interpres* to the investigation of the particular passages.³⁶ Nonetheless, apart from occasional, scanty remarks on certain hermeneutical principles, Tertullian did not provide any sustained discussions of theoretical issues of interpretation. The fact that he constantly cited and interpreted Scripture against the exclusively allegorical exegesis of his opponents, as well as employed certain key interpretative devices in his numerous works,³⁷ does not yet qualify him into the company of those authors who actually did elaborate on hermeneutics.

Likewise, Cyprian's anti-Jewish *Testimonia ad Quirinum*, which lists certain intrabiblical correspondences and was perhaps intended as a resource for preachers, comes short of a hermeneutical treatise. In his extant exegetical treatises and letters, like Tertullian, Cyprian quoted, paraphrased, and alluded to Scripture. He even mentioned

³³ Tertullian, *adv. Herm.* 19–34.

³⁴ The word “correct” does not mean that patristic authors imagined there to be one stable and exclusive meaning of a text. Rather, it meant that the possible multiple interpretations should always match with the two criteria stated in this very sentence.

³⁵ Tertullian, *adv. Herm.* 1 and 33; cf. *Praescr.* 12–14 and 19.

³⁶ Tertullian, *adv. Herm.* 32 and 34.

³⁷ G. D. Dunn, “Tertullian's Scriptural Exegesis in *de praescriptione haereticorum*,” *Journal of Early Christian Studies* 14/2 (2006), 141–55; H. Karpp, *Schrift und Geist bei Tertullian*, Beiträge zur Förderung christlicher Theologie 47 (Gütersloh: C. Bertelsmann, 1955), 21–4; O. Kuss, “Zur Hermeneutik Tertullians,” in J. Ernst (ed.), *Schriftauslegung. Beiträge zur Hermeneutik des Neuen Testaments und im Neuen Testament* (Munich: F. Schöningh, 1972), 55–87; T. P. O'Malley, *Tertullian and the Bible: Language-Imagery-Exegesis*, *Latinitas Christianorum Primavera* 21 (Nijmegen: Dekker & van de Vegt, 1967), 117–72; J. Speigl, “Tertullian als Exeget,” in G. Schöllgen and C. Scholte (eds.), *Stimuli: Exegese und ihre Hermeneutik in Antike und Christentum. Festschrift für Ernst Dassmann* (Münster: Aschendorff, 1996), 161–76, esp. 171–3; J. H. Waszink, “Tertullian's Principles and Methods of Exegesis,” in W. R. Schoedel and R. L. Wilken (eds.), *Early Christian Literature and the Classical Intellectual Tradition: In Honorem Robert M. Grant*, *Théologie historique* 53 (Paris: Éditions Beauchesne, 1979), 17–31.

certain interpretative principles, such as intentionality, ambiguity, and multiplicity of senses,³⁸ yet never really elaborated on these.

Then there is Hilary of Poitiers, whose omission from this collection of chapters still causes second thoughts. His writings are hermeneutically very rich,³⁹ but his remarks on the theory of interpretation are scattered and only two or three sentences long. Nevertheless, the undebatable fact that deducing theoretical insights from Hilary's actual exegetical practice (i.e., following the criterion 3) is a true hermeneutical feast is affirmed by many.⁴⁰ To provide a few examples, in his early *Commentarius in Matthaeum*⁴¹ – the first continuous Gospel commentary in Latin still extant in its entirety – as well as in his late *Tractatus super Psalmos*,⁴² Hilary investigated the *ordo narrationis*. Arguably, this means more than noticing the mere sequence of words, phrases, and descriptions of events.⁴³

³⁸ M. A. Fahey, *Cyprian and the Bible: A Study in Third-Century Exegesis*, Beiträge zur Geschichte der biblischen Hermeneutik 9 (Tübingen: Mohr, 1971), 29–56 and 612–22.

³⁹ Cassiodorus recommended Hilary without reservations, because “with God’s aid he reverently reveals the deep abysses of the divine Scripture (*altas que divinarum Scripturarum abyssus*) to enlighten the mind and make distinct what was veiled in dark parables (*parabolis . . . obscuris*)” (*Inst.* 1.18).

⁴⁰ E.g., J. Doignon, *Hilaire de Poitiers avant l’exil: recherches sur la naissance, l’enseignement et l’épreuve d’une foi épiscopale en Gaule au milieu du IV^e siècle* (Paris: Études Augustiniennes, 1971), 170–294; C. Kannengiesser, “L’exégèse d’Hilaire,” in *Hilaire et son temps. Actes de colloque de Poitiers* (Paris: Études Augustiniennes, 1969), 127–42; A. M. Sierra, *La prueba escriturística de los arrianos según S. Hilario de Poitiers*, Publicaciones anejas a “Miscelánea Comillas” (Comillas, Santander: Universidad Pontificia, 1965), 44–187.

⁴¹ P. Smulders, “Hilarius van Poitiers als exegeet van Mattheüs,” *Bijdragen* 44 (1983), 59–81; D. H. Williams, Introduction to *St. Hilary of Poitiers: Commentary on Matthew*, FC 125 (Washington, DC: The Catholic University of America Press, 2012), 10–21.

⁴² P. C. Burns, *A Model for the Christian Life: Hilary of Poitiers’ Commentary on the Psalms* (Washington, DC: The Catholic University of America Press, 2012), 60–100; P. Descourtieux, “Introduction” to *Hilaire de Poitiers: commentaires sur les Psaumes*, SC 515 (Paris: Cerf, 2008), vol. I, 27–54; N. J. Gastaldi, *Hilario de Poitiers: Exégeta del Salterio: un estudio de su exégesis en los comentarios sobre los Salmos* (Paris: Beauchesne, 1969), 77–93, 143–270.

⁴³ Victorinus of Pettau, for comparison, wrote in his *Commentarius in apocalypsin* 11.5, “Interpreting the sequence (*sequentium*) of words means understanding the order of their logic more than the order of the words read.”

Ancient rhetorical manuals distinguished between *ordo naturalis* and a literary *ordo artificialis*.⁴⁴ Origen, in turn, emphasized the exegetical importance of the notions of “series (*heirmos*)” and “sequence (*akolouthia*).”⁴⁵ Likewise, Hilary seems to have suggested that the task of an exegete was to move from the imperfect *ordo* of the sensible levels of history and text to the perfect *ordo* of the intelligible/spiritual level (i.e., the *ordo intellegentiae*)⁴⁶ which represented the divine “metanarrative.”⁴⁷

Hilary’s homiletic exposition on the Psalter (*Tractatus super Psalmos*) mediated the Greek exegetical achievements, especially that of Origen,⁴⁸ to the Latin-only readers in the West as well. In this treatise, one can find brief discussions on etymologies, allegories, and a pervasive Christological interpretation of the Old Testament,⁴⁹

⁴⁴ Fortunatianus, *Ars rhet.* 3.1 and Sulpitius Victor, *Inst. or.* 14, in C. Halm (ed.), *Rhetores Latini minores* (Leipzig: Teubner, 1863), 120 and 320. Cf. H. Lausberg, *Handbook of Literary Rhetoric: A Foundation for Literary Study*, trans. M. T. Bliss et al. (Leiden: Brill, 1998), par. 446–52. Jerome mentions Hilary’s familiarity at least with Quintilian (*ep.* 70.5).

⁴⁵ Origen, *Princ.* 4.2.8–9.

⁴⁶ Hilary, *Tract. Ps.* 63.4 and 118.3.7; cf. *In Matth.* 14.10.

⁴⁷ In *Tract. Ps.* 134.21, Hilary explicitly urges the interpreter to notice the correspondence of the *ordo* on the corporeal level (*corporaliter*) to the *ordo* on the spiritual level (*spiritualiter*); cf. *In Matth.* 7.8, and D. Dawson, “Allegorical Reading and the Embodiment of the Soul in Origen,” in L. Ayers and G. Jones (eds.), *Christian Origins: Theology, Rhetoric and Community* (London: Routledge, 1998), 26–43, at 34–7.

⁴⁸ In *vir ill.* 100, Jerome contended that, in *Tractatus super Psalmos*, Hilary “imitated (*imitatus*)” Origen and translated his (mostly lost) *Tractatus in Iob ad sensum* from Origen’s commentary. Hilary learned about the Origenist exegetical tradition in his exile. Cf. Burns, *A Model for the Christian Life*, 65–77; J. Doignon, “De l’absence à la présence d’Origène dans l’exégèse d’Hilaire de Poitiers: Deux cas typiques,” in G. Dorival and A. le Boulluec (eds.), *Origeniana Sexta: Origène et la Bible/Origen and the Bible: Actes du Colloquium Origenianum Sextum, Chantilly, 30 août–3 septembre 1993*, Bibliotheca ephemeridum theologicarum Lovaniensium 118 (Leuven: Peeters, 1995), 693–9; É. Goffinet, *L’utilisation d’Origène dans le commentaire des Psaumes de Saint Hilaire de Poitiers*, Studia Hellenistica 14 (Louvain: Publications Universitaires, 1965), 1–166.

⁴⁹ In his *Instructio* 5 to *Tract. Ps.*, Hilary contends that the Psalms have to be understood “according to the teaching of the Gospels (*secundum euangelican praedicationem*).”

which are all subsumed into the service of moral edification of the reader. For tracing the historical development of Latin patristic exegesis, *Tractatus super Psalmos* is, no doubt, most important.⁵⁰

Hilary's relatively recently discovered *Tractus mysteriorum* shows, in turn, how the figures of the Old Testament, such as Adam, Noah, Abraham, Isaac, and Moses, function as *exempla* and/or prefigurations of Christ. At the end of this treatise, there is a neat justification of typological exegesis.⁵¹

One should also mention Hilary's *De Trinitate*, which begins with a statement, "When the mind penetrates [the Scriptures], they contain a deeper meaning than when they are heard" (*Trin.* 1.6). In this treatise, Hilary conducted a masterful theological exegesis from a pro-Nicene perspective⁵² with brief explications of hermeneutical principles.⁵³ For example, in *Trin.* 1.30, 4.14, and 9.2, Hilary reminded his readers that, for proper exegesis, there had to be an explanation of the "attendant circumstances" (i.e., the literal and historical context), a knowledge of "the reasons why [certain words] were spoken" (i.e., authorial intention), and "the sense itself of the words" (i.e., semantics), as well as a discernment whether a given passage concerns theology of economy. Yet, for a volume that investigates the precious few patristic discussions of hermeneutical theory that are extant, Hilary's deliberations are unfortunately too random and laconic.

Perhaps the omission of Ambrose, whose exegetical works comprise about half of his extant literary output, deserves a comment as

⁵⁰ Kannengiesser assesses that Hilary's *Tractatus* "represents the first literary productive encounter between an exegesis based on the Septuagint and a Western mind which had been shaped in Christian traditions by the *Vetus Latina*, the Old Latin versions of the Bible" ("The Arian Crisis in the West," in *Handbook of Patristic Exegesis*, vol. II, 997–1018, at 1001).

⁵¹ Hilary, *Tract. myst.* 11–14.

⁵² See T. Toom, "Hilary of Poitiers' 'Ruled' Exegesis in His *De Trinitate*: A Case-Study of John 1:1–2" *Journal of the Bible and Its Reception* (in press).

⁵³ T. F. Torrance, "Hermeneutics, or the Interpretation of Biblical and Theological Statements, According to Hilary of Poitiers," *Abba Salama* 6 (1975), 37–69; M. Weedman, *The Trinitarian Theology of Hilary of Poitiers*, Supplements to *Vigiliae Christianae* 89 (Leiden: Brill, 2007), 119–35.

well.⁵⁴ He was a brilliant allegorist and well familiar with the Greek exegetical tradition. In his only commentary on the New Testament, *Expositio Evangelii secundum Lucam*, Ambrose exhorted rather typically, “We have learned the order of events; we have learned the purpose of these events. But let us also learn the mystery (*discamus et mysterium*).”⁵⁵ Ambrose operated with the three senses – *divina*, *naturalis*, *mystica*⁵⁶ – but, partially because most of his commentaries were reworked homilies, he did not deliberate on the theory of the multiplicity of meanings.⁵⁷

Last, although Eucherius authored two handbooks of interpretation, *Formulae spiritualis intellegentiae* and *Instructionum libri duo*,⁵⁸ neither of them discusses hermeneutical theory at any length. His *Formulae* is basically a catalogue of the figurative meanings of all kinds of items mentioned in Scripture. In the *Praefatio*, Eucherius also mentions three different ways of interpretation: *secundum historiam*, *secundum tropologiam*, and *secundum anagogen*, and remarks that some also add *allegoria* as the fourth way.⁵⁹ In *form.* 8, he further contends that “many meanings may come out in diversity of person, time, and place (*licet in diuersas plerumque significationes pro persona uel tempore uel loco exeant*).” While he provides some examples, he unfortunately never elaborates on these three-plus-one

⁵⁴ T. Graumann, *Christus interpret. Die Einheit von Auslegung und Verkündigung in der Lukaserklärung des Ambrosius von Mailand*, Patristische Texte und Studien 41 (Berlin: Walter de Gruyter, 1994), 7–15, 161–6, 255–75; although focusing on a particular treatise, G. Nauroy, *Exégèse et création littéraire chez Ambroise de Milan: l'exemple du De Ioseph patriarcha*, Collection des Études Augustiniennes, Série Antiquité 181 (Paris: Institut d'Études Augustiniennes, 2007), *passim*, and a short summary on pp. 389–97; L. F. Pizzolato, *La dottrina esegetica di sant'Ambrogio*, *Studia patristica Mediolanensia* 9 (Milan: Vita e Pensiero, 1978), 43–87, 194–313.

⁵⁵ Ambrose, *In Luc.* 2.7.

⁵⁶ Ambrose, *In Psalm.* 36.1. For example, in the first book of *De Abraham*, Ambrose investigates the historical and moral senses, and in the second book, the higher, mystical sense.

⁵⁷ Ambrose did explain though that a triad of *umbra*, *imago*, and *veritas* underlaid the three meanings (Ambrose, *exc. Sat.* 2.109).

⁵⁸ Eucherius: *Formulae spiritualis intellegentiae; Instructionum libri duo*, ed. C. Mandolfo, *CCL* 66 (Turnhout: Brepols, 2004).

⁵⁹ Eucherius, *form.* Praef.; cf. Cassian, *conl.* 14.8 and *conl.* 11 Praef.

ways of interpretation. Furthermore, his examples mostly operate with a simplified distinction between “letter” and “spirit” (2 Cor 3:6).⁶⁰ Because Scripture shines as silver on the surface, but is gold in the hidden parts,⁶¹ Eucherius’ reference work(s) focus on Scripture’s spiritual sense, “But now, let us put forth the clear formulas of spiritual knowledge (*formulas intellegentiae spiritalis*).”⁶² While his treatises supply ample material for reconstructing an underlying hermeneutical theory, Eucherius nowhere explicitly assesses it.

To recapitulate, the overall editorial dilemma is that if Tertullian, Cyprian, Hilary, Ambrose, and Eucherius were included, then why not also Victorinus of Pettau, Reticus of Autun, Marius Victorinus, Gregory of Elvira, *Ambrosiaster*, Arnobius the Younger, and a lot of other Latin exegetes? Patristic literature as such is thoroughly exegetical, and, consequently, to include every exegete is basically to write another patrology. Thus, it was a strict application of the criteria “the existence of an explicit discussion of hermeneutics” and/or “treatises considered have to be *introductores*” that suggested the omission of several aforementioned authors from this volume. Basically all authors would qualify under criterion 3 (“Patristic hermeneutical theory deduced from actual exegetical practice”), but only a few seem to qualify under criterion 4 (“Patristic hermeneutical theory as such to the extent it, or its elements, were

⁶⁰ Eucherius, *form. Praef.*; see C. Curti, “‘Spiritalis intelligentiae’: Nota sulla dottrina esegetica de Eucherio de Lione,” in A. M. Ritter (ed.), *Kerygma und Logos. Beiträge zu den geistesgeschichtlichen Beziehungen zwischen Antike und Christentum: Festschrift für Carl Andresen zum 70. Geburtstag* (Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1979), 108–22. Book One of Eucherius’ *Instructiones* likewise limits itself to the two senses of selected biblical passages, and Book Two lists the etymological meanings of various Hebrew and Greek words (C. Mandolfo, “Osservazioni sull’esegesi di Eucherio di Lione,” *Atti del 6° Seminario nazionale di ricerca su “Studi sulla letteratura esegetica cristiana e giudaica antica,” Acireale 12–14 ottobre 1988*, *Annali di storia dell’esegesi* 6 [Bologna: Ed. Dehoniane, 1989], 217–33).

⁶¹ Eucherius, *form. Praef.*; cf. Ps 67:14 (LXX).

⁶² Eucherius, *form. Praef.*; see T. O’Loughlin, “The Symbol Gives Life: Eucherius of Lyon’s Formula for Exegesis,” in T. Finan and V. Twomey (eds.), *Scriptural Interpretation in the Fathers: Letter and Spirit* (Dublin: Blackrock, 1995), 221–52, at 243–4.

explicated by various authors”). To reiterate *ad nauseam*, the goal of this volume is not to compile another comprehensive patrology with a particular focus on exegesis,⁶³ but rather to concentrate on the passages in Latin patristic writings that discuss hermeneutical issues.

Now, more positively, this volume includes chapters on (the rudiments of) the hermeneutical theories of Tyconius, Jerome, Augustine, Cassian, Junillus, Cassiodorus, Gregory the Great, and Isidore of Seville.

Jean-Marc Vercruysse discusses the hermeneutics of Tyconius (Chapter 2), whose *Liber Regularum* was arguably the first manual for scriptural interpretation in the West. In this treatise, Tyconius postulates seven rules that suggest how Scripture was composed by the Spirit in the first place. In other words, Tyconius’ rules analyze the inner principles that govern the concealed scriptural discourse. A key principle is that references constantly change between the “right” and “left” part of Christ’s bipartite body (i.e., the church), genus and species, general and particular, and whole and its parts. Tyconius believes that by knowing the inner compositional principles, an exegete is ready to ascertain the textual references correctly, solve the seeming contradictions adequately, and gather all Christians around their common Scripture.

Aline Canellis takes on an enormous task of gathering together Jerome’s hermeneutical insights (Chapter 3), which are spread all over his exegetical and historical works. For this task, Jerome’s letters and prefaces to his biblical commentaries prove to be particularly relevant. Several of his letters focus on exegetical conundrums, word studies, the art of translation, comparison of translations, and, almost always, textual issues. His prefaces, in turn, are often sort of mini-treatises on various topics of interpretation. Jerome’s particular fame as an exegete is due to his insistence on the so-called *hebraica ueritas*. In fact, he was the first author ever to write Latin commentaries based on the original Hebrew text. His attention to original languages also raised various hermeneutical issues, such as the alleged normativity of the “original” meaning and the importance

⁶³ For example, Kannengiesser, *Handbook of Patristic Exegesis*, 2 vols.

of the historical/literal sense. For Jerome, the *scientia scripturarum* basically entailed fluency in the biblical languages, a solid grasp of the principles of philology, textual criticism, and encyclopedic knowledge of both Greek and Latin exegetical traditions.

Tarmo Toom assesses Augustine's hermeneutical theory (*scientia signorum*) primarily in his *De dialectica*, *De magistro*, and *De doctrina Christiana* (Chapter 4). Although the last treatise, which is perhaps most well known, is far from being a complete account of Augustine's hermeneutics, it is arguably the best place to look for his semiotic theory of interpretation. Augustine considered a whole range of hermeneutical topics, such as authorial intention, multiplicity of meanings, ambiguity, etymology, the importance of *regula fidei* and *regula dilectionis*, translations, prosopological exegesis, the absurdity criterion, and the role of interpretative communities for determining the meaning(s) of a text. He also did not neglect to emphasize the value of prayer, holy life, *caritas*, and divine illumination for adequate interpretation of Scripture.

Christopher J. Kelly writes about Cassian's hermeneutics (Chapter 5). Although Cassian never authored an entire treatise on hermeneutical theory, he addressed some key issues of interpretation in his *Inst.* 5.33–4, *Conl.* 8.3–4, and 14. His attention was on the interplay between one's moral progress in ascetic life and his/her resultant ability to understand Scripture. In other words, Cassian's problem was with those interpreters who imagined that Scripture could be understood by just knowing the theory and mastering some exegetical techniques, without advancement in moral and spiritual life. For this reason, he emphasized that the grace of interpretative insight comes only to those who have a "pure heart." Cassian is also known for introducing the notion of *quadriga* – the fourfold meaning of Scripture (historical, allegorical, anagogical, and tropological). He contended that some scriptural texts needed "cooking" before their spiritual substance became available.

Peter W. Martens and Alden Bass study Junillus Africanus' *Instituta Regularia Divinae Legis* (Chapter 6), which is actually an oddity among the Latin patristic works on exegesis. Namely, it is composed on the basis of a book called *Regulae*, written by Paul the

Persian. Martens and Bass insightfully compare this sixth-century hermeneutical treatise with the Antiochian and North African hermeneutical traditions. The first part of the *Instituta* discusses the issues of the genre, authority, authorship, and modality of Scripture, as well as the arrangement and chief characteristics of the Old and New Testaments. The rest of the treatise is basically about ascertaining the reference of Scripture as it speaks in so many different ways about the Trinity and the creation.

Rita Copeland analyzes Cassiodorus' hermeneutics in *Expositio Psalmorum* (Chapter 7), which is a unique mega-exposition of the whole Psalter. His grand project, culminating in *Institutes*, was both to ascertain the liberal arts in Scripture and to interpret Scripture through liberal arts. Copeland highlights Cassiodorus' division of the psalms according to the genres of rhetoric, his structural analysis of individual psalms, and use of status theory. Cassiodorus employs these rhetorical devices hermeneutically, that is, for discovering the divine rhetoric in Scripture and demonstrating how the Word of God actually persuades and affects its readers. Cassiodorus also focuses on figures of speech and tropes (including allegory) in the scriptural discourse and finds that there are indeed particular "idioms of Scripture" that do not always follow the grammatical rules.

Brendan Lupton points out that Gregory the Great explained the theoretical foundations of his exegetical practice mainly in two places (Chapter 8): in the preface to his commentary on the Song of Songs and in the dedicatory letter to Leander of Seville, which served as the preface for his *Moralia*. He lamented that fallen humankind was entangled in the world of the senses and had lost the ability to understand Scripture spiritually. For this reason, God addressed humankind in the language that they could understand (i.e., Scripture in its literal sense). However, behind the comprehensible *littera*, there is always the divinely intended *spiritus*. Accordingly, the exegete is expected to find the deeper, "interior" understanding of the text. Scripture is a basic aid in the process which leads to contemplation of the divine. Although Gregory deliberated about allegory and affirmed the existence of *quadriga*, his attention was captured primarily by the moral implications of the text.

Thomas O’Loughlin investigates the hermeneutical convictions embedded in the many handbooks of Isidore of Seville (Chapter 9), in which the bishop organized the patristic inheritance and made it accessible to his own generation and beyond. Isidore presupposed the coherence of Scripture and therefore proposed a threefold interpretative strategy for preserving this coherence: all scriptural texts should be taken in either historical, “mixed,” or spiritual sense (the “mixed” sense being a typological one, which includes both history and its figurative meaning). However, his “natural” (vis-à-vis “conventional”) understanding of language, most evident perhaps in his grand project *Etymologiae*, tends to “demystify” the scriptural discourse and its subject matter.

Finally, it remains to be said that there seems to be a common post-Enlightenment bias against taking patristic hermeneutics seriously. Unfortunately, many still regard patristic and medieval “spiritualizing” exegesis as an annoying obstacle to the proper understanding of the “true meaning” of the biblical texts. However, I hope that the readers of this volume will realize – unless they do so already – that patristic hermeneutics is indeed something quite profound, extremely erudite, methodologically sophisticated, and very much aware of the criteria with which it operates.

*Tyconius' hermeneutics**The way the Holy Spirit expresses itself through Scripture**Jean-Marc Vercruysse*

In the beginning of the fourth century and as a consequence of the four edicts signed by Emperor Diocletian, North Africa was still under the yoke of persecution. The question of the faithful, who had lapsed and submitted to the imperial orders (the *lapsi*), as well as that of the scholars, priests, and laymen, who had given in to threats and delivered the sacred books and the liturgical objects to their persecutors (the *traditores*), had caused a controversy with heavy consequences for the local church. The theological dispute was about ecclesiology. A schism broke out and two communities confronted each other for over a century: one of which was called “catholic” and whose main representatives would soon be Optatus and Augustine of Hippo; and the other that of the Donatists, which derived its name from the rebellious bishop of Carthage, Donatus (nicknamed “the Great”), who was elected shortly after the end of the persecutions. Donatists championed the idea of a “pure” church that was both “without a spot or wrinkle” (Eph 5:27) and indivisible by nature, as the Song of Songs contended: “a garden enclosed, a fountain sealed up” (Sg 4:12).¹

¹ M. A. Tilley, *The Bible in the Christian North Africa: The Donatist World* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 1997), 130–74; S. Lancel and J. S. Alexander, “Donatistae,” in C. Mayer (ed.), *Augustinus-Lexikon* (Basel: Schwabe, 1999), vol. 2, 606–38; E. Romero-Pose, “Estudios sobre el Donatismo, Ticonio y Beato de Liébana,” in J. J. A. Calvo (ed.), *Scripta collecta*, *Studia Theologica Matritensia* 12 (Madrid: Facultad de Teología San Dámaso, 2008), vol. 1, 163–99.

A layman, an exegete, and a dissident

Tyconius, a layman specializing in Scripture, emerged in this particular context. Being of Greek origin, he lived in the second half of the fourth century and belonged to the Donatist movement. He died probably around 395 CE. Augustine never suggested that he had met Tyconius, but he thought that the ex-Donatist had a quick and eloquent mind; Gennadius of Marseilles, in turn, emphasized Tyconius' secular erudition and his deep knowledge of Scripture.²

Earlier, Tyconius had written two treatises – the *De bello intestino* (in three books) and the *Expositiones diuersarum causarum* – in which (or in one of which) he evoked some former councils that had favored Donatists. Both treaties have been lost and it is difficult to say precisely what their subject matter was. It could be, however, as their respective titles suggest, that these treatises dealt with the dissensions the Donatist church faced in that time. In any case, some of the positions held by Tyconius strongly incensed some of his coreligionists. The “party” leader Parmenian, who had succeeded Donatus, sent him a long letter contradicting his beliefs, and pointed out how wrong his opinions really were. The letter has not reached the modern era, but Augustine knew about it and, in ca. 400 and after the death of the two protagonists, he decided to answer the objections it raised. Writing *Contra epistulam Parmeniani* allowed the bishop of Hippo to expound Tyconius' major ideas and to respond to his arguments point by point. Tyconius championed the idea that the church had spread worldwide and, therefore, it was not limited merely to Africa. He also stressed the Christians' individual responsibility and the need for repentance. One's fault, however great, could not deprive him/her of the divine promises. No impiety could weaken God's fidelity to the church universal. Obviously the Donatist bishop and the antiestablishment layman defended a very different vision of the church. Yet Tyconius

² Augustine, *c. ep. Parm.* 1.1.1: *Hominem quidem et acri ingenio praeditum et uberi eloquio*; Gennadius, *uir. ill.* 18: *In diuinis litteris eruditus iuxta historiam sufficienter, et in saecularibus non ignarus fuit.*

was not convinced by Parmenian's arguments and, according to Augustine's testimony, he was excommunicated from the Donatist church. However, he did not join the catholic "party" either and, as a matter of fact, kept out of both churches until his death. Tyconius did not explain his decision. Yet it might be possible to supply an explanation. As he was deeply convinced of the existence of *duae partes in ecclesia*, as we shall see, Tyconius did not deem it beneficial to rally the catholic camp, nor to forsake the Donatist cause. Tyconius' ecclesiology has a prominent place in his hermeneutics.

Tyconius' hermeneutical works

Following the first two books – and if Gennadius' list can be trusted – Tyconius wrote the *Liber regularum*, which is usually regarded as the first western treatise on biblical hermeneutics. This treatise can be dated to the time between 370 and 380 CE.³ Tyconius appears in it as a clever theologian, independent from both catholics and Donatists, and as an brilliant exegete mastering the spiritual interpretation. Although strongly denounced by the decree of the Pseudo-Gelasius in the early sixth century,⁴ the *Liber regularum* has been preserved in half a dozen manuscripts. It basically survived due to Augustine's critical introduction of it in book 3 of his *De doctrina Christiana*.⁵ While highlighting the incoherence of Tyconius' behavior and blaming him for sticking with the schismatic party even though he had questioned the ecclesiological foundations, Augustine acknowledged the pertinence of his hermeneutical principles and recommended them to the future scholars. He himself used these principles often as an inspiration for his exegetical writings.

³ Tyconius: *Le Livre des Règles*, ed. J.-M. Vercruysse, SC 488 (Paris: Cerf, 2004). Every reference to Tyconius' *Liber Regularum* (LR) provides the number of the chapter, paragraph, and line in the Latin text. For an English translation, see W. S. Babcock, *Tyconius: The Book of Rules*, Texts and Translations 31, Early Christian Literature Series 7 (Atlanta, GA: Scholars Press, 1989).

⁴ Pseudo-Gelasius, *Decretum Gelasianum de libris recipiendis et non recipiendis* 5.7.

⁵ See the following.

Tyconius also wrote a *Commentary on the Apocalypse*. In the *De doctrina Christiana*, Augustine reproached the former Donatist for not applying his rules to a “particularly abstruse” passage in the Book of Revelation. This remark may give a false impression that Tyconius' *Commentary* did not put the hermeneutics of his *Liber regularum* into use.⁶

One may wonder why Tyconius chose John's Book of Revelation from among the biblical books. Inspired by Victorinus of Pettau, Tyconius' commentary relinquishes a millenarianist eschatological interpretation. While the other writings of the New Testament are directed to the Christian community itself, the Book of Revelation describes the church facing the “pagans.” Although the Roman persecutions of Christians had come to an end, Tyconius believed that the church at his time was nevertheless undermined by evil forces. Here one encounters the important principle of the bipartite church, which offers numerous parallels for the ordeals described by John. The *novum* of Tyconius' *Commentary* was the spiritual reading of the Book of Revelation in the light of his contemporary circumstances. Such a “contextualizing” approach, where Scripture provided an explanation to the current events, was to influence the subsequent exegesis. Tyconius used the Book of Revelation to demonstrate how the church, both universal and bipartite, progressed throughout history. The reign of Christ and that of the church were perceived as an anticipation of the kingdom to come.

Tyconius' *Commentary on the Apocalypse* has been lost.⁷ Nevertheless, it was much appreciated in Italy and Spain, as well as in England and France. Apart from Apringius of Beja, every pre-Carolingian exegete was inspired by it, as they relied, more or less accurately, on what must have been the original text of Tyconius. The citations in Caesarius of Arles, Primasius of Hadrumetum, Cassiodorus, the Venerable Bede, Autpertus Ambrose, and

⁶ P. Marone, “La continuità esegetica che caratterizza le opere di Ticonio ovvero l'applicazione delle ‘Regole’ nel ‘Commento all’Apocalisse,” *Studi e Materiali di Storia delle Religioni* 67 (2001), 253–70.

⁷ Except for a short passage that is known as the Budapest fragment (Rv 6:6–13).

especially Beatus of Liébana enabled Roger Gryson to restore the alleged common source and reconstruct the original version of Tyconius' commentary.⁸ This unique editorial undertaking is invaluable, as it allows one to appreciate the application of the hermeneutical principles, defined in the *Liber regularum*, to the last book of the New Testament. It is clearly evident that they have been regularly employed in his exegetical commentary.

The Holy Spirit and the seals of Scripture

Tyconian hermeneutics lies within the scope of the Pauline statement: "Every Scripture is inspired by God and useful" (2 Tm 3:16). The Holy Spirit speaks in and through the books of the Bible. This principle is explicitly stated in the Psalms⁹ as well as in the Epistle to the Romans.¹⁰ Likewise, in the beginning of chapter 4 of the *Liber regularum*, Tyconius contends that "the rhetorical art of human wisdom (*artem rhetoricam humanae sapientiae*)" – ornamental and devised for deception – is distinguished from the "mysteries of the heavenly wisdom according to the teachings of the Holy Spirit (*secundum mysteria caelestis sapientiae magisterio Spiritus Sancti*)."¹¹ The divine inspiration endows Scripture with a permanent relevance and induces one to always find a meaning that would be worthy of God and salutary to humankind.

However, the Bible includes difficult passages, some of which are rather abstruse and obscure. For example, mentioning the two

⁸ *Tyconii Afri Expositio Apocalypseos: accedunt eiusdem Expositionis a quodam retractatae fragmenta Taurinensia*, ed. R. Gryson, CCL 107A, *Corpus Christianorum* in Translation 10 (Turnhout: Brepols, 2011). Every reference to Tyconius' *Commentary on the Apocalypse (ExAp)* provides the number of the chapter, paragraph, and line. An annotated French translation, *Tyconius, commentaire de l'apocalypse*, is found in the same edition.

⁹ "The Spirit says in the Psalms (*Dicit Spiritus in Psalmis*)" (LR 6.3.2, 29).

¹⁰ "As the Spirit says (*sicut Spiritus dicit*)," followed by the quotation of Rom 1:21–2 (LR 7.17.1, 432). The same is true about Tyconius' *Commentary on the Apocalypse*. For example, it uses the expression, "As the Spirit pointed out through the apostle (*sicut spiritus per apostolum definiuit*)" (ExAp 1.27, 70).

¹¹ LR 4.1, 1–6 (1 Cor 2:4–5, 7).

witnesses who are killed by the beast let loose from the abyss in Rv 11:7–9, John uses a singular word to refer to “the body which will be thrown onto the square of the large city,” but later he uses the plural form “bodies.”¹² At first sight, the text seems contradictory. Similarly, the evangelists and the Fathers traditionally acknowledged a reference to the Lord in the fourth chant of the suffering servant (Is 53:4–6). Yet, as God promises to show his son the light (Is 53:10–11), the verse cannot mean Christ, because the Son himself is already the “light” that enlightens the world (cf. Mt 4:16; Jn 1:4–9).¹³ In addition, how is one supposed to understand the announcement of the “three days and three nights” that the Son of Man was to spend in the bosom of the earth, following Jonah’s sign (Mt 12:40), when the various passion and resurrection narratives seem to differ in reporting the event’s exact duration?¹⁴ Tyconius believes that such “stumbling blocks,” to use an Origenian expression, are intentional. They have been inserted by the Spirit on purpose, so that the reader might not confine him-/herself merely to a superficial reading.

The prologue to the *Liber regularum* echoes a passage from Isaiah in which God speaks of “obscure treasures and secret riches” (Is 45:3). Tyconius also interprets “the parchment, written on both sides, and sealed with seven seals”¹⁵ to mean that the parchment containing “the sum of all the mysteries is obscured.”¹⁶ In Scripture, various references point to the same reality. Just like the seals protect the celestial book, “mystical rules (*regulae mysticae*)” keep the biblical message hidden. The beginning of chapter 6 of the *Liber regularum* states, “Among the rules with which the Spirit has sealed the law so as to guard the pathway of light, the seal of recapitulation guards some things with such subtlety that it seems more a continuation than a recapitulation of a narrative.”¹⁷ In truth, the pages

¹² *ExAp* 3.71, 2–4. ¹³ *LR* 1.3, 10–14. ¹⁴ *LR* 5.3.3–7, 55–129.

¹⁵ Rv 5:1; see also Rv 10:4 (*ExAp* 3.56, 7–20).

¹⁶ ‘*Signatum sigillis septem*’, *id est omni mysteriorum plenitudine obscurantum* (*ExAp* 2.16, 1–2).

¹⁷ *LR* 6.1, 1–4.

dedicated to recapitulation are among the most complex ones in Tyconius' hermeneutical treatise. The Spirit delivers a "subtle speech" and this requires an interpretative effort on the part of its hearers.¹⁸ It blocks an immediate access to the meaning of some passages of the Bible, as it "breaks up a thing in order to obscure it (*sed unam rem dividit obscurandae rei causa*)."¹⁹

In the beginning of the eighth century, the Venerable Bede quite rightly noticed in his commentary that there are seven seals in the Book of Revelation, just as there are seven rules in Tyconius' *Liber regularum*.²⁰ The seven rules correspond to the seven seals that help to conceal the seven essential teachings of the whole Scripture. Through these rules, the Spirit "guards the pathway of light (*luminis via custodiretur*)."²¹ The Spirit's deliberate obscuring of the biblical message also justifies Tyconius' use of the epithet "mystical."²² The rules are "mystical" in nature, because the Holy Spirit has a particular way of expressing itself (*narrationis genus*).²³ In Scripture, the Spirit has used the seven rules deliberately in order to protect the mysteries from the eyes of the profane.²⁴ They are interpretative devices that articulate Scripture in the life of the constantly evolving church.

It is also important to remove the ambiguity of the genitive in the title of Tyconius' treatise. The *Liber regularum* is strictly speaking the *Book about the Rules*, intrinsic to the biblical text, as Tyconius sets out "to fashion keys and lamps (*velut claves et luminaria fabricare*)" so as to find out their "logic (*ratio*)."²⁵ The double metaphor (*claves et luminaria*) points to the hermeneutic toolbox

¹⁸ *LR* 4.1, 13, and 6.1, 3; *ExAp* 7.26, 3–4: "It has, in a subtle way, confused the understanding, in order that one may believe (*Subtiliter turbavit intellectum, quo putetur...*)."

¹⁹ *ExAp* 5.4, 4. ²⁰ Bede, *Expositio Apocalypseos*, Praef. (CCL 121A:223, 37).

²¹ *LR* 6.1, 1–2.

²² C. Kannengiesser, "Quintilian, Tyconius and Augustine," *Illinois Classical Studies*, 19 (1994), 239–52, at 246–7.

²³ *ExAp* 2.43, 79; 3.2, 2; cf. *LR* 4.4, 86 (*genere locutionis*).

²⁴ Tyconius often refers to the "mystery" that concerns the writing of the Bible (*LR* 2.11, 81; 2.13, 92).

²⁵ *LR*, Proem. 5.

that must enable one to understand all the mystical rules the Spirit has used. The fact that there are seven of them, as rule 5 confirms, is synonymous with totality. Moreover, in the programmatic prologue to the *Libellus regularis* (to use Tyconius' expression), the author promises that, if the hermeneutical principles are properly understood, "whatever is closed will be opened and whatever is dark will be illumined (*clausa quaeque patefient et obscura dilucidabuntur*)."²⁶ The *regulae mysticae* are the cornerstone of Tyconius' hermeneutics.

The reader's task in regards to Scripture

The meaning of a biblical message is not self-evident to an interpreter immediately. Figuring it out requires a deliberate effort. Without classifying its readers according to their level of comprehension or their intellectual maturity, as Origen did, Tyconius explains that the Spirit delights in enhancing "the value of the truth for those who seek it, by making it hard to find (*ut abscondendo quaerentibus gratiorem faceret ueritatem*)."²⁷ The reader should beware the often deceptive literal meaning. More than once, Tyconius employs a rhetorical question introduced by *numquid* ("Is it really . . . ?") to alert the reader to the impossibility of understanding a certain verse literally. The other and more explicit way of drawing the reader's attention to the absolute necessity of careful reading is found in a fluctuating Latin sequence of *non dixit . . . sed*.²⁸ The biblical text either reveals or conceals. However, at times the Spirit is more considerate and offers its famous counsel, "Let he who hath ears hear (*Qui habet aures audiat*)!"²⁹ This urges the reader to find the hidden message behind the apparent wording.

Here is also the reason why reason and faith are essential to the Christian who is anxious to fathom the true and profound meaning

²⁶ LR, Prooem. 7. ²⁷ LR 6.2, 15–16.

²⁸ ExAp 3.17, 10–12; see also 4.49, 3–4; 5.2, 7–9, and 5.43, 37–8. In a more elliptical manner: "*Habent,*" ait, non "*habebunt*" (3.68, 4–5 and 6.15, 1–2). Other variants can be found in 3.73, 7; 6.41, 3; and 7.19, 17–18.

²⁹ ExAp 4.36, 3–5.

of Scripture. First of all, one is expected to use his/her “common sense (*ratio*)” to understand the biblical text as adequately as possible. To do so, one needs to consider the immediate context (*pro locis*) in which a given passage occurs.³⁰ To interpret the phrase “Around the throne, and on each side of the throne, are four living creatures” (Rv 4:6) would be a good example. John has just said that Christ sat in the middle of the throne and that the twenty-four elders were around the throne, but then he indicates that the creatures in their turn stand “in the middle and around the throne.” At first glance, the passage seems confusing and therefore Tyconius draws attention to the many occurrences of the word “throne.” To avoid confusion, the gospels and the elders need to be taken as inseparable. The four animals representing the four gospels stand around the throne just like the elders who symbolize the universal church. They are also inseparable from Christ, who is seated on the throne.³¹

Tyconius contends that the use of the *ratio* is a solid shield against subjective readings. And if all this is still not enough for interpreting particularly difficult passages, the reader can rely on the divine grace, which neither misleads nor errs, and which provides him/her a thorough understanding of the seven mystical rules.

The mystical rules about the bipartite church

The first two rules are about “the Lord and his Body (*De Domino et corpore ejus*)”; that is, about Christ and his church according to the Pauline metaphor.³² Scripture constantly mingles these two entities, which are supposed to be notionally distinguished. This is to say that prophesying about Christ, the Spirit may extend the message to the whole church, without any particular warning, by referring to some features that cannot apply to Jesus. The reader has to watch

³⁰ For example, Tyconius says about Rv 13:1, “This passage must be understood according to the context (*pro locis*) in which the beast is mentioned” (*ExAp* 4.25, 8–9); see also 5.47, 15.

³¹ *ExAp* 2.7, 1–11.

³² P. Marone, “Ticonio e l'autorità apostolica di Paolo,” *Studi e Materiali di Storia delle Religioni* 68 (2002), 275–95.

out for the “passage (*transitus*)” from one reference to another, indicated by the use of the singular and the plural forms in particular. For example, in the song about the suffering servant that has already been mentioned, Isaiah reports, “Thus says the Lord to Christ my Lord, whose right hand I have taken hold that the nations might heed him.” The text is definitely about Christ, the head of the church. But when the prophecy promises to grant hidden and invisible treasures so that we might know that the Lord is the God of Israel, the church is meant instead.³³

The second rule reveals an interesting point about the “body” – it is “bipartite (*De Domini corpore bipertito*).”³⁴ The church is made up of good and bad Christians, as is suggested in the Book of Revelation, “A woman clothed with the sun, with the moon under her feet” (Rv 12:1). The mention of the two planets represents the church, which is made up of a good part (the sun) and an evil part (the moon).³⁵ It is therefore necessary to determine exactly which part of the “body” is meant. Likewise, a Christian reading likens the wife in the Song of Songs to the church. Yet, how can she be described at the same time as “dark and beautiful” (Cant 1:5) when she has been cleansed by the blood of Christ? The apparent contradiction fades away if it is understood that her beauty refers to the faithful (*corpus bonum*), whereas her dark color, perceived as a negative trait, attests to the presence of people within the church whose behavior does not match with the evangelical teachings (*corpus malum*).³⁶ The hermeneutic “key” to this second rule is to be found in the “passage (*transitus*)” from one to the other part of the body of the Lord, from believers to nonbelievers.

The forces of evil stand against the church from without and from within. They represent a permanent danger that justifies the last rule – as a variant of the first one – which concerns the devil and its

³³ Is 45:1, 3–4 (LR 1.7, 61–72).

³⁴ For the origins of the concept, see J. G. Mueller, “Christian and Jewish Tradition Behind Tyconius’ Doctrine of the Church as *Corpus Bipertitum*,” *Theological Studies* 73 (2012), 286–317. Tyconius did not invent this principle, but he employed it in the particular context of the Donatist crisis.

³⁵ *ExAp* 4.6, 1–8. ³⁶ LR 2.10, 62–6.

body (*De diabolo et corpore ejus*). Here again, the Spirit delights in changing the references from one to the other without any indication. When Ezekiel reports the words of the King of Tyre, whose hubris made him cry out, "I am God, I dwelt in the dwelling of God in the heart of the sea" (Ez 28:2), Tyconius contends that such a statement suits both the devil and its body, since both live in the depth of the sea (Ps 46:2), "in the desire or depth of this age."³⁷ On the other hand, when the Bible uses the image of the mountain, if the word is in singular, it refers to the devil, but if it is in the plural, it indicates the members of the devil's body.³⁸ In such cases, the distinction is a matter of common sense, but the reader still has to be attentive.

The third rule (*De promissis et lege*) divides the biblical passages into the two lineages of Abraham – that of the promise and that of the law. In other words, it induces the reader to ponder over the faith of the men and women in the Bible. The rule is warranted by the new aspect of the bipartite church that manifests itself in the continuous presence of the promise and the law in the entire human history. Thus, this mystical rule comes under the Pauline dialectic between law and grace. Bipartition is revealed in the double lineage of Abraham, for Jacob is marked out both as the "beloved" and as the "supplanter of his brother."³⁹ Under the old covenant, people were already divided and, just like it was in Israel, so it continues to be within the church. Even the law, which was introduced 430 years after the promise, benefits everyone. However, it is the way the law is perceived and understood that distinguishes between the bad and the good. It imprisons one in sin and promotes and encourages the other. Indeed, though the law proves to be a hindrance to the harmful deeds of the bad, it cannot shield them from their evil thoughts. As for the good, the law is a stimulus and a test that compels them to seek the grace of God constantly.⁴⁰

The children of Sarah and Hagar, just like those of Rebecca, must grow up together "until the harvest" (Mt 13:30).⁴¹ Even if Ishmael and Esau were separated from the "children of the promise," the succession of the double descent of Abraham became "one people." "For the

³⁷ LR 7.9.1, 255–64. ³⁸ LR 7.4.1, 88–90.

³⁹ *Iacob, qui et 'dilectus' uocatus est et 'fratris supplantator' expressus* (LR 3.26, 499).

⁴⁰ LR 3.21, 414–17. ⁴¹ LR 3.28, 536.

fact that the new covenant has been revealed does not mean that the old has ceased to bear children (*Quia neque reuelato nouo quiescit uetus generando*).⁴² It will naturally fall to God, and not to human beings, to separate the two.⁴³ From that point of view, rule three stands aloof from Donatist theology. The spiritual descent of Abraham, born of the promise, is identified by Tyconius with the many nations God granted to the patriarch, that is, with the church united with Christ. The two sons of Isaac represent the two aspects of the church, which are intimately bound until the end of time. Thus the traditional distinction between Jews and Christians is rejected for a more general interpretation that takes into account the universal plan of God.

This is also how the plural of *de promissis* in the title of rule three is justified. The promise – whole and indestructible – that God granted Abraham is, so to speak, strengthened all along. Human-kind moves toward salvation with the help of other promises that God gave first to the Jewish people and later to all the nations. The word *lege* in the title is in singular, of course, because it refers to the law of Moses. It is set in the second position, after the promise, for historically the law comes after the promise and is consequently less important in the divine economy because of its transitional nature.

In the general structure of the *Liber regularum*, chapter 4 constitutes the backbone of the work as it makes the essential distinction between “the genus and the species (*De specie et genere*).” The Spirit delights in hiding the genus in the species,⁴⁴ or switching from one to another without a warning, which results in sometimes daunting changes of reference. The *Commentary on the Apocalypse* reminds one, “We have said many times that the genus is divided into numerous species, which are one and the same thing.”⁴⁵ Generally speaking, the “genus (*genus*)” corresponds to the spiritual meaning of the prophecies and the “species (*species*)” corresponds to the temporal and historical realities.

⁴² LR 3.27.2, 533–4. ⁴³ LR 3.29, 567–9; see also LR 1.9, 101–4.

⁴⁴ “The species includes the genus, but we cannot perceive the genus until we consider why something is said, and the event, person, and time with which it agrees (*In specie genus insertum est, ut nonnisi dicti ratione perspicui possit, dum consideratur quid cui et quando conueniat*),” writes Tyconius (*ExAp* 1.27, 41–3; see also 2.21, 3–4).

⁴⁵ *ExAp* 4.6, 2–3.

The combinations of genus and species are numerous and Tyconius provides many examples (the fourth rule is the longest of all). In the oracle to the mountains of Israel, Ezekiel begins by recalling the captivity of the Israelites in Babylon and the desecration of the name of God at the time of the exile (*species*).⁴⁶ Then he adds an announcement that Israel will be removed from among the nations that will know the name of God (*transitus*). As it is about the return from exile of the Israelites, the very reference to “all the nations” hints at the universal church.⁴⁷ Finally, the prophecy reaches the genus (*genus*) when God promises his people “a new heart and a new spirit” through “the sprinkling of clean water,” that is, baptism, which is the privilege of Christians, and cleanses them from all idolatry.⁴⁸ This example offers a combination species/species–genus/genus. However, the Holy Spirit increases the variants on purpose and because of that, there are other combinations that correspond to the variety of the situations.⁴⁹

In short, in most cases the task of the reader is to ponder about whether a given biblical passage applies to a particular person or group. Four out of the seven headings of the *regulae mysticae* operate with an explicit distinction between two entities:

1. The Lord and his body (*De Domino et corpore ejus*)
3. The promises and the law (*De promissis et lege*)
4. The species and the genus (*De specie et genere*)
7. The devil and its body (*De diabolo et corpore ejus*)

to which one can add:

2. The bipartite body of the Lord (*De Domini corpore bipartito*)⁵⁰

The last two rules focus on the temporal expressions found in Scripture.

⁴⁶ Ez 36:16–22 (*LR* 4.3.2, 35–48). ⁴⁷ Ez 36:23–4 (*LR* 4.3.3, 49–54).

⁴⁸ Ez 36:25–9a (*LR* 4.3.4, 55–62).

⁴⁹ The *aliquando* anaphora testifies to the enumeration of the various combinations (*LR* 4.2.2, 22–9). Tyconius also mentions the “variety of transitions and orders (*uarietas translationis et ordinis*)” (*LR* 4.2.2, 28–9).

⁵⁰ G. Gaeta, “Il *Liber Regularum* di Ticonio. Studio sull’ermeneutica scritturistica,” *Annali di Storia dell’Esegesi* 5 (1988), 103–24.

The mystical nature of time in the church

The divine economy is situated within a linear history, from the creation of the world to the last judgment. Temporal references abound in the two testaments. However, in the beginning of rule five, Tyconius contends that “temporal quantity, in Scripture, often has mystic significance” and it must not be taken in the literal and strictly numerical sense. One must heed the “consecrated numbers (*legitimi numeri*).”⁵¹ For example, the famous mention of the “one hundred and forty-four thousand elect” from the twelve tribes of Israel (Rv 7:4 and 14:1) is symbolic and represents “the whole church.”⁵² Likewise, number seven indicates totality. “The seven angels who stand before God” (Rv 8:2) represent the seven churches. The seven trumpets herald the universal proclamation that is feasible only after the mystery of the incarnation.⁵³

Yet rule five is not limited to explaining the numbers in the Bible. Its title, *De temporibus*, is wide enough to include various temporal references in Scripture, which often shorten an indefinite length of time into an indefinite number. The designations “day,” “hour,” and “year” are to be taken not in a strict sense, but rather as designations of indeterminate periods. In the first oracle of Isaiah (Is 2:20–21), the phrase “on that day (*in illo die*)” corresponds to “the whole time that has elapsed ever since the Passion of Christ.”⁵⁴ “The final hour,” “the day of salvation,” and “the favorable year of the Lord” are some of the many temporal references that one can find in the Old and New Testaments. Given the impossibility of defining their definite duration, they must communicate the pressing need for conversion. On the other hand, certain temporal

⁵¹ In his *Commentary on the Apocalypse* and while referring to the miracle of the multiplication of the loaves, Tyconius also uses the expression “sacred number (*numerus sanctus*)” (*ExAp* 2.34, 32), as well as the “perfect number (*numerus perfectus*)” (*ExAp* 3.81, 3), for seven and twelve.

⁵² *LR* 5.4.2, 143–4 and *ExAp* 2.48, 11–12.

⁵³ *ExAp* 3.1, 1–4. Also as regards number ten in *ExAp* 4.10, 3–5.

⁵⁴ “He calls the time that has elapsed since the Passion of the Lord a ‘day’ (*Diem totum tempus ex quo dominus passus est dixit*)” (*ExAp* 2.43, 26–7).

designations may indicate a more exact duration of time. Tyconius makes a list of equivalences such as “one day” for a hundred days, as well as “a time” for a year, or for a hundred days.

In the end, rule five considers the last category of temporal references: the “partial recapitulations (*partes recapitulationis*).” For Tyconius, they are part of the hermeneutics about the times, because they fall under synecdoche. In Genesis, when Joseph predicts the first seven years of surplus and after that the seven years of famine for Egypt (*species*), it is tempting to add them up and take them as a prophecy for fourteen years. In fact, one must understand that it is a matter of only seven years in which surplus and famine occur simultaneously, for number seven is a “consecrated number” that designates the whole; that is to say, in this case, from the point of view of the genus, the entire period starts with the passion of Christ and will end with the last judgment. Moreover, within the context of a typological reading of Scripture, Joseph represents the type of Christ since he became the master of Egypt at the same age when the Lord began to preach; that is, he was thirty years old. Consequently, today, in the period that corresponds to the time of the bipartite church, true Christians live in plentitude, while others experience the “dryness” of heart, as they are deprived of the evangelical spirit (*genus*).

Rule six considers another aspect of temporal designations through the notion of recapitulation (*De recapitulatione*). Since Tyconius approaches it hermeneutically, recapitulation does not have the theological dimension that it had in the writings of Irenaeus. Tyconius' *Commentary* states that “it is customary for the prophecy to tell about events to come as if they had already taken place, and about past events as if they were still to occur.”⁵⁵ That being the case, recapitulation comes in two forms: at times the Spirit condenses an entire life into a single moment, as if it were a summary; at others, it focuses on an analogy between events that actually took place at different times.

⁵⁵ *Sic enim habet consuetudinem prophetia narrare futura quasi iam facta, sic praeterita quasi adhuc facienda (ExAp 2.43, 56–8).*

When the evangelist Luke announces the day of the Son of Man, he establishes a parallel between the attitude of Lot, escaping the divine wrath and leaving Sodom, and the attitude that people have on the last day (Lk 17:29–32). “At that hour (*in illa hora*),” it is not the time for Christians to try to recover their material possessions at the risk of losing their lives, just as Lot’s wife did. Tyconius’ habitual questioning indicates that the attitude of Lot’s wife does not concern “that hour” only.⁵⁶ Rather, Christians today must not look back at their former habits that they have forsaken. Thus, the designation *illa hora* comprises the entire time from the first coming of Christ on earth to his second coming. The kingdom of God has already begun. Accordingly, the designations, which, strictly speaking, mark specific moments, are to be interpreted in a sense of a longer time. They inform the reader about the fulfillment of a prophecy. From this point of view, recapitulation compresses longer periods of time into specific moments, which may have occurred earlier.

A passage of Psalm 126 offers another striking example: “When the Lord ended Zion’s captivity, we were like people consoled. Then was our mouth filled with joy and our tongue with rejoicing. Then (*tunc*) will they say among the nations: the Lord has done marvels for them, the Lord has done marvels for us, we were overjoyed.”⁵⁷ Tyconius conducts a close analysis of these verses and focuses on the tenses of the verbs. The use of the future “then will they say (*dicent*)” seems incoherent, for if the Lord freed the captives of Zion, the nations should have acknowledged his goodness at the time it was experienced, that is, in the past and not in the distant future. In fact, recapitulation is indicated by the word “then (*tunc*),” which justifies the use of the indicative future, as the action also concerns the contemporaries of Tyconius and the generations

⁵⁶ LR 6.2, 11: “Is it only at the hour . . . (*Numquid illa hora . . .*)?”

⁵⁷ *Cum auerteret Dominus captiuitatem Sion facti sumus uelut consolati. Tunc repletum est gaudio os nostrum et lingua nostra exultatione. Tunc dicent in gentibus: Magnificauit Dominus facere cum illis, magnificauit Dominus facere nobiscum, facti sumus laetantes* (Ps 125:1–3) (LR 6.3.2, 29–33).

yet to come.⁵⁸ The change in the personal pronouns – from the third person (*tempus suum*) to the first person in the plural (*tempus nostrum*) – confirms this explanation. For this reason, there is also a recapitulation when the Spirit expresses the present and future events in the same sentence, taken together because of the perceived similarities. This happens without any warning to the reader, except by the use of some temporal adverbs or phrases. In the *Commentary on the Apocalypse*, Tyconius explains that recapitulation consists in repeating or describing the same realities under different forms. If so, it may look redundant. The expression “he starts right from the beginning to expound the same things differently (*Recapitulat ab origine eadem aliter disserturus*)”⁵⁹ is repeated several times. Such repetition, which mixes different times, often allows one to clarify and broaden the vision.⁶⁰

The interpretative principles put forward by Tyconius are similar to synecdoche and, depending on texts, apply to people, temporal periods, places, and events. However, Tyconius' hermeneutics cannot be reduced to mere rhetorical technique.

A typological reading

A doctrine about the three or four meanings of Scripture is not to be found in Tyconius' work. Neither is his exegesis ruled by the opposition between the Old and the New Testaments, the categories of the letter and spirit, and the contrast between the image and the truth, as was the case in the works of his predecessors. Rather, it is ruled by the dialectic of species and genus (something that all his rules uphold): Scripture communicates a contingent history (*species*) that has a universal value (*genus*). Without avoiding the traditional terms completely, Tyconius sticks to his own exegetical vocabulary. He does not question the literal meaning, yet gives primacy to the

⁵⁸ LR 6.3.2, 39–41. ⁵⁹ ExAp 2.58, 9–10. See also 2.43, 88 and 4.1, 1–2.

⁶⁰ “He resumes [his account] from the birth of the Lord, to talk differently and more broadly about the same themes (*Recapitulat a natiuitate domini eadem aliter ac latius dicturus*)” (ExAp 4.1, 1–2).

spiritual meaning. The New Testament relates to the Old just like the body of an adult is already potentially present in the body of a child, as rule three puts it in a beautiful, drawn-out metaphor.⁶¹ The major question is to what a specific biblical text must be applied. All the hermeneutical keys draw on synecdoche, as it is considered under its various aspects and applied to individuals, places, and events.

Scripture is supposed to be read typologically.⁶² By this, Tyconius means that the events described in the Bible have a deep resonance in his own time.⁶³ Generally speaking, prophetic admonitions and encouragements are not only meant for the past generations; they are also meant for the Christians of the fourth century. Tyconius finds situations that are specific to the church in his own day in both the Old and New Testaments. For him, the biblical message remains and has to remain relevant in all times. This applies even to the eschatological passages. Rule six evokes a pericope from the Book of Daniel about “the abomination of desolation” (Dn 9:27), which refers to the desecration of the Temple by the Seleucid King Antiochus IV Epiphanes. Tyconius quotes this phrase from Matthew, as the evangelist reports Jesus’ foretelling of the fall of Jerusalem (Mt 24:15). However, he is quick to point out: “But what Daniel mentioned is happening now in Africa, and not at the time of the end (*Quod autem Danihel dixit in Africa geritur, neque in in eodem tempore finis*).”⁶⁴ In other words, the event that took place in the year 167 before Jesus Christ is not restricted to its historical significance. It affects the whole story of the church from the covenant with Abraham until the last judgment. First, the event takes place at a determined date, but second, according to the principle of recapitulation and of the similarity of situations described in rule six, it also applies to a similar moments in later history. Third, in some

⁶¹ LR 3.16, 287–91.

⁶² M. A. Tilley, “Understanding Augustine Misunderstanding Tyconius,” *Studia Patristica* 27 (1993), 405–8.

⁶³ For the Tyconian typology, see Introduction to SC 488, 46–7.

⁶⁴ LR 6.3.1, 23–4. The prophecy is already mentioned in the first rule (1.10, 118).

cases, it may herald the second of Christ as well. Tyconius in no way denies the historical truth of the events that took place in the biblical history, but he does not reject the eschatological significance of the divine promises either. Above all, he develops a "useful" reading for his contemporary church where prophecies are fulfilled "in a spiritual way."

Hermeneutics and theology

The *Liber regularum* is not confined to displaying the principles of hermeneutics only; it also reflects theologically on the nature and vocation of the church. These two aspects are closely linked and form the basis for Tyconius' approach.⁶⁵ In fact, he asserts that the Book of Revelation speaks of nothing else but the church. Without a doubt, this is the main reason for his commentary on the last book of the Bible.⁶⁶ He clearly preferred the ecclesiological interpretation of the Book of Revelation to the eschatological interpretation of Victorinus of Pettau.

As the first rule states by following closely the Pauline metaphor (Col 1:24), the church is *corpus Christi*. Tyconius put this rhetorically: "The church is within God and God is within the church (*in deo ecclesia est, et in ecclesia deus*)."⁶⁷ Christ came to inaugurate the kingdom of God and the church is part of this history of salvation. Its mission is to fight the evil forces led by the devil (see rule seven). For Tyconius, the church is universal; it comprises all the elect, even from the Old Testament times (*ecclesia ab Abel*). Yet, it is also a bipartite body (rule two) to which one belongs through the action of

⁶⁵ For Tyconius' ecclesiology, see K. Forster, "Die ekklesiologische Bedeutung des corpus-Begriffes im *Liber Regularum* des Tyconius," *Münchener theologische Zeitschrift* 7 (1956), 173–83. In some respects, his analysis differs from that of J. Ratzinger (who became Pope Benedict XVI), "Beobachtungen zum Kirchenbegriff des Tyconius im 'Liber regularum,'" *Revue des Études Augustiniennes* 2 (Mémoires Gustave Bardy) (1956), 173–85.

⁶⁶ *ExAp* 2.49, 31–2: "He describes nothing but the church (*Nihil est quam praeter ecclesiam describat*)."

⁶⁷ *ExAp* 7.43, 2–3; see also *LR* 1.11.1, 120–32.

the Spirit through faith alone, because the law cannot redeem (rule three). Sinners will be punished on the day of judgment.

Rules one (“The Lord and his body”) and seven (“The devil and its body”) symbolically frame Tyconius’ entire treatise and thereby emphasize the fundamental division of humankind into these respective “bodies.” Such dualism is expressed successively in the images of two peoples, of the two gates of Jerusalem, and of the two winds, Auster and Aquilon.⁶⁸ However, the opposing “body” (*corpus adversum*) is by no means limited to external enemies, to “pagans.” Opposition exists within the church as well. As a result, there are three groups of human beings: the true and sincere Christians, the external enemies of the church, and the followers of the devil, who are inside the church, but hide beneath the façade of faith and piety (see the end of rule six). These people are hypocrites and pretenders. In rule six, Tyconius employs the First Letter of John to expose these “false prophets (*pseudoprophetae*)” whose words are not in concord with their deeds.

Tyconius calls this conflict “the iniquity mystery (*mysterium facinoris*),” an expression that he takes from 2 Thes 2:7. This phrase appears several times in Tyconius’ two works, either in the form of an entire quotation or in the form of an allusion.⁶⁹ Its function is to alert the reader to the harmful presence of the *corpus adversum* within the church. The good members, who live out *in corde* the evangelical principles and await the coming of the everlasting kingdom, must, on each day, guard themselves against the temptations of the devil.

However, Tyconius never advocates the Donatist ideal of the “pure” church. On the contrary, he believes that both “bodies” or groups will coexist until the last judgment. The good and the evil are mixed until the harvest,⁷⁰ just as the parable of the wheat and the

⁶⁸ LR 3.26, 497–512 (the two peoples); 5.7.2, 235–49 (the two gates); 7.4.2–3, 91–140 (the two parts of the church, one of the South and the other of the North).

⁶⁹ LR 3.29, 564–5; 7.4.3, 124, 130, 133; 7.18.2, 462 and *ExAp* 1.5, 32–3; 2.34, 11; 4.9, 4–5; 4.23, 5; 4.30, 6–7; 4.44, 4.

⁷⁰ *ExAp* 1.11, 135–7.

chaff explains: "It is necessary that 'both grow together until the harvest' (*Oportet 'ambos simul crescere usque ad messem'*)."⁷¹ Thus, it is important that the reader, who waits for the "Day of the Reward," remains alert at the time of his/her pilgrimage of conversion. The bipartite church is a place of conflict in which Christ and the devil spiritually clash with each other through their respective members.⁷² Tyconius finds resonances of the situations, which are specific to the church in his time, in both the Old and New Testaments. For him, the biblical message remains acute in all times. The ultimate fight will be preceded by a thousand-year-long period, which, according to rule five, is to be understood as a symbolic time reference. It designates the period between the passion of Christ and the outbreak of the final persecution, that is, the present time.⁷³ As far as we know, Tyconius was among the first who rejected chiliasm.⁷⁴

The hermeneutics of Tyconius allows one to comprehend the mystery of Christ and his church and the existence of evil in the world, in human beings, and even in the church, as well as the mystery of faith and grace.

Gathering around the reading of Scripture

By reading the hermeneutical manual and applying its ideas in his commentary on the Book of Revelation, Tyconius rejects superficial and partisan interpretations of Scripture and exhorts his contemporaries, who are guilty of it, to repent. He invites the reader to change his/her mind through a rational/sensible reading of the Bible.

Tyconius' concern is to protect the reader from misleading interpretations. An interpreter must be guided to the straight and narrow

⁷¹ Mt 13:30 (*LR* 3.28, 536) and Mt 13:28 (*LR* 7.9.2, 266).

⁷² *LR* 5.6.7, 194–202. Cf. J. S. Alexander, "Some Observations on Tyconius' Definition of the Church," *Studia Patristica* 18/4 (1990), 115–19.

⁷³ P. Fredriksen Landes, "Tyconius and the End of the World," *Revue des Études Augustiniennes* 28 (1982), 59–75.

⁷⁴ M. Dulaey, "L'Apocalypse. Augustin et Tyconius," in A.-M. La Bonnardière (ed.), *Saint Augustin et la Bible*, Bible de tous les temps 3 (Paris: Beauchesne, 1986), 369–86.

path through “the vast forest of prophecy,” which keeps him/her from going astray.⁷⁵ The *Liber regularum* aims at rallying Christians around a common understanding of Scripture. The universality of the biblical message, which is addressed to all nations and, above all, to the divided Christians, supports the quest for such an understanding. So does the concept of the universal church – one of the main causes of the conflict between catholics and Donatists – which Tyconius forcefully championed and which made him reject the schismatic church. Hence his exhortation to all Christians of goodwill: inviting some to conversion and repentance, and others to be faithful to the evangelical message. The quest for a common understanding of Scripture does not leave space for any kind of sectarianism. In such context, the writing of the *Liber regularum* seems to be Tyconius’ attempt to bring his contemporaries together, through hermeneutics, for a shared and reasonable reading of Scripture.

It is also noteworthy that the *Liber regularum* does not ponder over the question of the biblical canon. A consideration of biblical versions of any kind, the exact number of canonical books, and their classifications is not to be found in this work. For Tyconius, the idea of having the Bible is to bring Christians together rather than to separate them. After all, Scripture is a heritage that all Christians have in common. The cacophony of interpretations, however, requires a method of interpretation. Precisely because catholics and Donatists based their beliefs on the same text, which unfortunately was not without obscurities, Tyconius deemed it necessary to reflect deeply on how one was supposed to understand the divine teachings. His postulation of general interpretative principles was to ensure that private readings of Scripture would avoid partisan readings.⁷⁶ In other words, the *Liber regularum* aimed at “controlling,” as it were, biblical interpretation so that Scripture would not

⁷⁵ *LR*, Prooem. 7–9: “And anyone who walks the vast forest of prophecy guided by these rules, as by pathways of light, will be kept from straying into error (*ut quis prophetiae immensam siluam perambulans his regulis quodam modo lucis tramitibus deductus ab errore defendatur*).”

⁷⁶ J.-M. Vercruyse, “L’herméneutique comme arbitre du combat entre les forces du bien et du mal chez Tyconius,” in Y.-M. Blanchard et al. (eds.), *Les forces du mal*

serve any private and sectarian interest. Tyconius' goal was to reconcile all good Christians – of whatever origin, party membership, or competitive agenda – and focus on the most important thing, which is an adequate interpretation of Scripture.

A lasting influence on western hermeneutics

Many authors have discussed and used Tyconius' hermeneutical rules in one or another way. Augustine became interested in Tyconius' hermeneutics after his "conversion" and return to Africa. He mentioned Tyconius' *Liber regularum* first in a letter written around 396 CE (*ep.* 41.2), which may indicate that he had the composition of *De doctrina Christiana* already in his mind. The latter treatise was composed over two periods, about thirty years apart. Initially, Augustine wrote the first three books and then completed his project toward the end of his life, in 426–7. As he resumed his work and finished book three, he also introduced Tyconius' *Liber regularum*.⁷⁷ The tribute paid to Tyconius by the bishop of Hippo was not without reservations, for *De doctrina Christiana* was finished after the council of Carthage in 411, where the imperial measures dealt a fatal blow to Donatus' church. As was mentioned earlier, Augustine highlighted the inconsistency of Tyconius' behavior and blamed him for staying in the schismatic party despite the fact that he had rejected the foundations of Donatist ecclesiology. Nevertheless, Augustine deemed it useful to insert a detailed account of the *Liber regularum*, because "consideration of these rules . . . is quite helpful in penetrating the obscure parts of the divine writings."⁷⁸ More precisely, Augustine presented Tyconius' hermeneutics in a simplified form and for educational purposes, as well as distanced himself from Tyconius' theological presumptions on which his theory was

dans les premiers siècles de l'Église, Théologie historique 118 (Paris: Beauchesne, 2011), 77–90.

⁷⁷ Augustine, *doc. Chr.* 3.30.42–37.55.

⁷⁸ *Doc Chr.* 3.30.42: *Quae quidem considerata . . . non parvum adiuvant ad penetranda quae tecta sunt divinorum eloquiorum.*

based.⁷⁹ The stature and the moral authority of the bishop of Hippo were such that his abridged version of the *Liber regularum* saved its author from being forgotten and disappearing from the scene. However, it also prevented, for a long time, the readers – even the well-informed ones – from considering Tyconius’ original version of the *Liber regularum*. In the beginning of the sixth century, the decree of Pseudo-Gelasius included Tyconius’ rule book among the condemned “apocryphal” works,⁸⁰ the reading of which was definitely not recommended. In fact, in the subsequent ecclesiastical literature, the *Liber regularum* was mostly known and assessed in the form that Augustine gave to it and not in the original form in which Tyconius wrote it. It was not until the second half of the twentieth century that people started considering the original version again.

Finally, some of the main authors who have used Tyconius’ hermeneutics in a more or less explicit manner should be mentioned.

In the first half of the fourth century and during his episcopacy, Eucherius of Lyon wrote his *Instructiones* and dedicated it to his son Salonius. The bishop of Lyon tried to explain the difficulties that literal interpretation caused throughout the Bible. For this task, he employed rules one, two, and five, as well as demonstrated a deep knowledge of the *Liber regularum* in general.⁸¹

⁷⁹ I. Bochet, “Le *Liber regularum* de Tyconius et sa présentation par Augustin,” in a Complementary Note 17, Bibliothèque Augustinienne 11/2 (Brepols: Paris 1997), 562–81, which also provides an extensive bibliography on this issue. One should add R. A. Kugler, “Tyconius’s *Mystic Rules* and the Rules of Augustine,” in P. Bright (ed.), *Augustine and the Bible*, The Bible through the Ages 2 (Notre Dame, IN: University of Notre Dame Press, 1999), 129–48, and C. Kannengiesser, “Tyconius of Carthage, the Earliest Latin Theoretician of Biblical Hermeneutics: The Current Debate,” in M. Maritano (ed.), *Historiam Perscrutari: miscellanea di studi offerti al prof. Ottorino Pasquato*, Biblioteca de scienze religiose 180 (Rome: LAS, 2002), 297–311, as well as I. Bochet, “Le *De Spiritu et littera* d’Augustin et la Règle III, ‘*De promissis et lege*,’ de Tyconius,” in J. Elfassi et al. (eds.), *Amicorum Societas: mélanges offerts à François Dolbeau pour son 65^e anniversaire*, collana Millennio Medievale 96 (Firenze: SISMEL-Edizioni del Galluzzo, 2013), 50–66.

⁸⁰ Pseudo-Gelasius, *Decretum Gelasianum de libris recipiendis et non recipiendis* 5.7.

⁸¹ C. Mandolfo, “Le ‘Regole’ di Ticonio e le ‘Quaestiones et responsiones’ di Eucherio di Lione,” *Annali di Storia dell’Esegesi* 8 (1991), 535–46.

After John Cassian⁸² and Quodvultdeus, who referred to rule five about numbers and mystical times,⁸³ Isidore of Seville was a key figure for the increasing prestige of the *Liber regularum* in the Middle Ages. In the beginning of the seventh century, he provided a detailed account of Tyconius' seven rules in his *Sentences*.⁸⁴ Although Tyconius' name is not explicitly mentioned, he is included among "some wise men" to whom Isidore appealed. The Spanish archbishop's main goal was to offer a summary, as clear as possible, of Tyconius' rules. It is plausible, however, that Isidore did not have access to Tyconius' original version. Instead, he seems to have relied on an anonymous epitome that might have been "the intermediate source between Isidore and Augustine."⁸⁵

The Venerable Bede placed a letter addressed to his friend Eusebius in front of his *Expositio Apocalypseos*, which was written between 703 and 710 CE. In this letter, he deemed it beneficial to remind the addressee of Tyconius' hermeneutical principles, "which considerably help those who study them to understand the Scriptures."⁸⁶ In a few sentences, Bede, the monk of Jarrow, introduced all seven rules, yet followed the interpretation of these in Augustine's *De doctrina Christiana*. Nevertheless, Bede respected Tyconius and praised his hermeneutical method, which he constantly employed in his own commentary on the Book of Revelation.

Another more extensive summary of the *Liber regularum* dates back to the ninth or tenth century. It is a collection of extracts taken from the first six rules and from two passages in Augustine's works (*ench.* 103 and *doc. Chr.* 3,36). It does not mention rule seven,

⁸² John Cassian, *Inc.* 6,23.

⁸³ Quodvultdeus, *Liber Promissionum: Dimidium Temporis* 13,22.

⁸⁴ Isidore of Seville, *Sententiae* 19.

⁸⁵ P. Cazier, "Le Livre des règles de Tyconius: Sa transmission du *De doctrina christiana* aux *Sentences* d'Isidore de Séville," *Revue des Études Augustiniennes* 19 (1973), 241–61.

⁸⁶ Bede, *Expositio Apocalypseos*, Praef. Cf. J.-M. Vercruysse, "Bède lecteur de Tyconius dans l'*Expositio Apocalypseos*," in S. Lebecq et al. (eds.), *Bède le Vénérable: Bilan et perspectives*, Histoire et littérature de l'Europe du Nord-Ouest 34 (Villeneuve d'Ascq: CeGes Université Charles-de-Gaulle-Lille 3, 2005), 19–30. Available online: hleno.revues.org/306.

though. Most of the biblical quotations are either omitted, radically shortened, or given according to the text of the Vulgate.⁸⁷ A comparison between the presentation of the *Liber regularum* in Augustine's *De doctrina Christiana* and the two epitomes proves that the *Liber regularum* was no longer read for its original purpose. Whereas the biblical quotations chosen by Tyconius voiced a broad call for repentance, the changes made to these quotations in the summaries of his hermeneutical rules no longer conveyed this.⁸⁸

Under Charlemagne's reign, Paschasius Radbertus, one of the greatest theologians of the Early Middle Ages, provided a most enlightening explanation of *Jeremiah's Lamentations*. Tyconius' rules showed up yet again. Paschasius referred to rule one in order to distinguish between that which concerned the head (Christ) and that which concerned the body (the church).⁸⁹ Likewise, in his *Commentary on the Gospel of Matthew*, he referred several times to rule four, *De specie et genere*, in order to speak about the church and Mary together, which was a common feature in Paschasius' contemporary writings.

Scholasticism, too, did not ignore Tyconius. In the first half of the twelfth century, Hugh of Saint-Victor taught in the prestigious Parisian monastery. One of his first works, written around 1128, was *Didascalion*.⁹⁰ He intended to teach the art of reading from a

⁸⁷ The text of *Liber regularum* is reproduced in *The Book of Rules of Tyconius*, ed. F. C. Burkitt, Texts and Studies 3/1 (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1894, reprint 2013), appendix, 89–98.

⁸⁸ P. Bright, "Tyconius and His Interpreters: A Study of the Epitomes of the *Book of Rules*," in *Augustine and the Bible*, 109–28.

⁸⁹ Paschasius Radbertus, *Expositio in lamentationes Hieremie libri quinque* 3. Cf. C. Maus, "De modo, quo Paschasius Radbertus regulam 'de specie et genere' circa Mariam et Ecclesiam usurpauit," in *Maria in Sacra Scriptura: acta congressus mariologici-mariani in Republica Dominicana 1965 celebrati* (Rome: Pontificia Academia Mariana Internationalis, 1967), 173–7.

⁹⁰ *Hugonis de Sancto Victore Didascalicon de Studio Legendi: A Critical Text*, ed. C. H. Buttner, Studies in Medieval and Renaissance Latin Language and Literature 10 (Washington, DC: The Catholic University of America Press, 1939). The English translation *Didascalicon of Hugh of St. Victor: A Medieval Guide to the Arts*, trans. J. Taylor, Records of Civilization, Sources and Studies 64 (New York: Columbia University Press, 1961), includes numerous notes.

pedagogical point of view. Thus, after introducing the Bible, the canonical texts, and the sacred authors, Hugh quoted the seven rules that "some wise men have given" quite frequently. Tyconius was, of course, among these "wise men." However, the version of Tyconius' rules is taken again, with some omissions and adaptations, from Isidore's summary. Yet still the rules are strongly recommended as reliable guides for spiritual exegesis.

Between the years 1322 and 1330, a Franciscan Nicholas of Lyra composed his *Postilla litteralis*, which saw great success in the seventeenth century. In the first prologue, he asserted the superiority of the Bible over any other writing and invoked the four senses of Scripture from Augustine of Dacia's famous couplet. In the second prologue, which was "about the author's aim and the way he proceeds," Lyra began with "the seven rules of the exposition of the sacred Scripture, which Isidore mentions in his *Supreme Good* [that is, in *Sentences* I.20]." He also explained, "Some call these rules 'keys,' because in many places they open the understanding of the Scriptures."⁹¹ Lyra's rather detailed summary takes a lead from Augustine, as well as from Gregory the Great. The result is that the scriptural quotations no longer have much to do with the original *Liber regularum*.

To conclude this brief survey of the reception of Tyconius' *Liber regularum*, Erasmus should be mentioned as well. In his *Ratio verae theologiae*, published in 1518, the Dutch humanist highlighted the fact that both Christ and the Apostle Paul used allegory. He substantiated this claim by referring to the most competent authors on the subject: Dionysius the Areopagite and his *De divinis nominibus*, Augustine and his third book of *De doctrina Christiana*, and Tyconius.⁹² Furthermore, in his *Ecclesiastes*, Erasmus considered Tyconius again and listed his seven rules, in Augustine's version, as a kind of appendix to his treatise.⁹³

⁹¹ Nicholas of Lyra, *Postilla litteralis*, second prologue.

⁹² Erasmus, *Ratio verae theologiae*. See P. C. Bori, "La ricezione delle 'Regole' di Ticonio, da Agostino a Erasmo," *Annali di Storia dell'Esegesi* 5 (1988), 125–42.

⁹³ Erasmus, *Ecclesiastae liber* 3.

The making of a *memoria technica* of Tyconius' seven rules represents well the long tradition of his reception. Written in dactylic hexameter, this verse is known to us from a thirteenth-century manuscript. It says:

The first rule joins our Head to the Body.
 The second speaks about the Body, true and mixed.
 The third describes what Law and Grace can do.
 The fourth examines the genus and the species, the whole and the part.
 The fifth distinguishes between longer and shorter times.
 The sixth recalls that which took place in the beginning.
 The seventh destroys the head and the limbs of the serpent for you.⁹⁴

Despite the mediation of Augustine and Isidore, Tyconius' "keys and lamps" – devised in his *Liber regularum* and tested in his *Commentary on the Apocalypse* – were often referred to in the subsequent history of biblical exegesis. It certainly testifies to their lasting importance. Writing his treatise on hermeneutics, Tyconius intended to eliminate arbitrary, partisan, and subjective interpretations of the Bible. No doubt, it was his perception of hermeneutics (a limited number of precise rules having a universal value) that allowed him to believe that all Christians of good faith would unite in a common reading of Scripture.

FURTHER READING

Bright, P. *The Book of Rules of Tyconius: Its Purpose and Inner Logic*, new ed. Christianity and Judaism in Antiquity 2. Notre Dame, IN: University of Notre Dame Press, 2009.

⁹⁴ *Regula prima caput nostrum cum corpore iungit.*
Corpore de uero loquitur mixtoque secunda.
Tertia describit quid lex quid gratia possit.
Quarta genus speciem totum partemque rependit.
Tempora disiungit maiora minoraque quinta.
Sexta refert iterum que primo facta fuerunt.
Septima serpentis sibi membra caputque resoluit.
 (Burkitt, *The Book of Rules of Tyconius*, 86).

The *memoria* draws its inspiration more from Isidore's *Sentences* than from Augustine's *De doctrina Christiana*.

- Camastra, P. *Il Liber regularum di Ticonio. Contributo alla lettura*. Tradizione e vita 8. Rome: Vivere in, 1998.
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CHAPTER 3

Jerome's hermeneutics

How to exegete the Bible?

Aline Canellis

In 1950, A. Penna published a book on Jerome's hermeneutical principles.^{1,2} After that, P. Jay, Y.-M. Duval, M. Graves, and R. Courtray, among others, studied Jerome's exegetical commentaries and reached a new level of understanding of how exactly Jerome exegeted the Bible: by translating the original texts into Latin, addressing various questions on textual criticism in his letters, explaining difficult passages, and commenting on several books of the Sacred Scripture in their entirety. Jerome did not discuss his method at length, but since some deliberations on hermeneutics can be found in all of his works – mostly in the prologues – his exegetical approach and its originality are certainly identifiable.

Linguistic ability and principles of translation

Born in Stridon on the border of the Eastern and Western Roman Empires, the priest Jerome (347–419/20 CE)³ was interested in learning languages. He traveled extensively – to Rome, Trier, Aquileia, Antioch, the desert of Chalcis, Antioch again, Constantinople, Rome, Alexandria, and finally Bethlehem, where after

¹ Thanks to my colleague Florence Garambois-Vasquez (University Jean Monnet, Saint-Étienne), who helped me write this chapter.

² A. Penna, *Principi e carattere dell'esegesi di S. Girolamo*, Scripta Pontificii Instituti Biblici 102 (Roma: Pontificio Instituto Biblico, 1950).

³ See Jerome's biography by J. N. D. Kelly, *Jerome: His Life, Writings, and Controversies* (London: Duckworth, 1975).

387 he lived in a monastery. He learned Greek and Hebrew, a few words of the Syriac/Aramaic language⁴ (*ep.* 17.2; 20.4; 29.7; 30.2; 125.12) and benefited from such notable teachers as the *grammaticus* Donatus in Rome, Apollinaris of Laodicea, Gregory of Nazianzus in Constantinople, and Didymus the Blind in Alexandria (*ep.* 52.8; 84.3). Being *vir trilinguis*,⁵ Jerome was able to read fluently all the Greek and Hebrew texts he desired, even if he sometimes enlisted the help of Hebrew *magistri* such as Baranina (*ep.* 84.3). Jerome's proficiency in languages matched the enormous task of translating several Greek texts into Latin, such as Eusebius' *Chronicle* (380), Didymus' *The Holy Spirit* (ca. 386–91), Eusebius' *Onomasticon* (ca. 389–91), and a few of Origen's homilies (*On Jeremiah* [ca. 375], *On Isaiah* [375–80], *On Ezekiel* [ca. 378], *On the Song of Songs* [ca. 383–4], and *On the Gospel of Luke* [ca. 392–3]).⁶ Just as Cicero mediated several Greek philosophical writings to Latin readers, so Jerome made some intriguing Greek Christian literature available to them. He preferred to translate Origen's homilies rather than his commentaries, because translating commentaries was “beyond [his] powers, [his] leisure, and [his] energy.”⁷ In fact, Jerome aimed at latinizing Origen and making his exegetical works the standard “to Roman ears.”⁸ He worked hard to conserve Origen's style and

⁴ See *Jérôme: préfaces aux livres de la Bible*, ed. A. Canellis, SC (in press).

⁵ D. Brown, *Vir Trilinguis: A Study in the Biblical Exegesis of Saint Jerome* (Kampen: Kok Pharos, 1992).

⁶ Dates are taken from Y.-M. Duval, “Hieronymus,” in J. Fontaine, J. D. Berger, and Y.-M. Duval (eds.), *Handbuch der lateinischen Literatur* 6 (Munich: C. H. Beck, in press), § 647.

⁷ Jerome, *Hom. Luc.*, Praef. (trans.: <http://www.ccel.org/ccel/schaff/npnf206.vii.iv.iii.html> [accessed on Dec. 31, 2014]); see also *Hom. Cant.*, Praef.: “I have left that work on one side, since it would require almost boundless leisure and labour and money to translate so great a work into Latin (*quia ingentis est otii, laboris et sumptuum tantas res tam digne in Latinum transferre sermonem*), even if it could be worthily done; and I have translated these two short treatises” (trans.: www.ccel.org/ccel/schaff/npnf206.vii.ii.ii.html?highlight=preface,to,translation,of,origen,on,song#highlight [accessed Dec. 31, 2014]).

⁸ Jerome, *Hom. Ez.*, Praef.: *Magnum est quidem . . . ut Origenem faciam Latinum et hominem . . . etiam Romanis auribus donem.*

simplicity, and did not use any rhetorical figures for explicating Origen's meaning.⁹

In the preface of Eusebius' *Chronicle*, Jerome gave, for the first time, his opinion on the Greek translations of the Old Testament: "The divine books . . . when published by the LXX translators,¹⁰ did not retain the same flavour in the Greek language"; Aquila, Symmachus, and Theodotion produced "different works from the same work"; "the first expressed it word-for-word, the next preferred to follow the sense, and the third did not differ much from the ancients."

According to Jerome, "the fifth, sixth and seventh versions, although it is unknown from which authors they originate, yet they contain intrinsic variants that are so probably correct, that they have earned authority without having names." For this reason, "Sacred Literature seems unpolished and harsh sounding" to scholarly men, who did not always understand that it was a translation from Hebrew.¹¹

Jerome said more about his theory of translation in *ep.* 57 (*On the Best Method of Translating*) (ca. 395–6). He made a distinction between the translations of "pagan" texts and Holy Scripture. In the latter case, word order was a mystery (*mysterium*), which had to be respected. "For I myself not only admit but freely proclaim that in translating from the Greek (except in the case of the holy

⁹ *Hom. Eζ.*, Praef.: *id magnopere curans ut idioma supradicti uiri et simplicitatem sermonis*; see also *Hom. Cant.*, Praef.: *hoc duos tractatus, quos in morem cotidiani eloquiū paruulis adhuc lactantibusque composuit fideliter magis quam ornate interpretatus sum*. Jerome also translated Origen's *De principis* and his other works.

¹⁰ On Jerome's opinion about the LXX translators, see Canellis, Introduction to *Jérôme: préfaces aux livres de la Bible*.

¹¹ Jerome, *Chron.*, Praef. 3: *et difficultatem rei etiam diuinorum uoluminum instrumenta testentur, quae a Septuaginta interpretibus edita non eundem sorem in Graeco sermone custodiunt. Quam ob rem Aquila et Symmachus et Theodotio incitati diuersum paene opus in eodem opere prodiderunt, alio nitente uerbum de uerbo exprimere, alio sensum potius sequi, tertio non multum a ueteribus discrepare. Quinta autem et sexta et septima editio, licet quibus censeantur auctoribus ignoretur, tamen ita probabilem sui diuersitatem tenent, ut auctoritatem sine nominibus meruerint. Inde adeo uenit ut Sacrae litterae minus comptae et sonantes uideantur* (trans.: www.tertullian.org/fathers/jerome_chronicle_01_prefaces.htm [accessed Dec. 31, 2014]).

Scriptures where even the order of the words is a mystery) I render sense for sense and not word for word.”¹² Thus, the Hebrew Bible could not really be translated *ad sensum*, but had to be translated *ad uerbum*, although this was quite difficult because of the lack of vocalization marks.¹³ As he was translating Scripture from Hebrew, Jerome was blamed, particularly by Rufinus, for despising the LXX translators,¹⁴ whom he hardly ever recognized as being inspired by God.¹⁵ Translating most of the Old Testament from Hebrew, Jerome was interested in the biblical canon as well. For example, in the *Prologue to the Book of Kings*, in the so-called helmeted introduction (*Prologus Galeatus*), he listed the books of the Hebrew canon.¹⁶

Translations of the biblical books

During his second journey to Rome (382–5), Jerome was in the service of Pope Damasus, where he had some responsibility for papal archives as well as for preparing the official correspondence.¹⁷ It was during this time that Damasus requested that he make a revision of the Latin text of the Gospels, based on the Greek original, in order to provide the church a uniform text. It was Jerome's first attempt to emend the biblical text: “You urge me to

¹² Jerome, *ep.* 57.5: *Ego enim non solum fateor, sed libera uoce profiteor me in interpretatione Graecorum absque Scripturis sanctis, ubi et uerbuorum ordo mysterium est, non uerbum e uerbo sed sensum exprimere de sensu* (trans.: www.ccel.org/ccel/schaff/npnf206.v.LVII.html [accessed Dec. 31, 2014]).

¹³ Jerome, *ep.* 73.8: *Nec refert, utrum Salem, an Salim nominetur, cum uocabulis in medio litteris perraro utuntur Hebraei, et pro uoluntate lectorum, ac uarietate regionum, eadem uerba diuersis sonis atque accentibus proferantur.*

¹⁴ *Ruf.* 2.24–35.

¹⁵ *Pr. Par.* (Prologue to Paralipomena) (LXX). See Canellis, Introduction to *Jérôme: préfaces aux livres de la Bible*, which addresses Jerome's opinion about the Septuagint and its inspiration at length.

¹⁶ See Canellis, Introduction to *Jérôme: préfaces aux livres de la Bible*.

¹⁷ Jerome, *ep.* 123.9 (CUF 7:83, 19–22); Y.-M. Duval, “Sur trois lettres méconnues de Jérôme concernant son séjour à Rome (382–385),” in A. Cain and J. Lössl (eds.), *Jerome of Stridon: His Life, Writings and Legacy* (Aldershot: Ashgate, 2009), 32–3.

revise the old Latin version, and, as it were, to sit in judgment on the copies of the Scriptures which are now scattered throughout the whole world; and, inasmuch as they differ from one another, you would have me decide which of them agree with the Greek original.”¹⁸

After that, between 386 and ca. 390, Jerome latinized some Greek books of the Bible (Chronicles, Job, Psalms, three books of Solomon) and translated others, upholding the *hebraica ueritas* (*Psalms* [390–2]; *Samuel/Kings* [391–2]; *Isaiah*, *Jeremiah*, *Ezekiel*, *Daniel*, *Minor Prophets* [before 393]; *Job* [before 394]; *Ezra* [394–5]; *Chronicles* [ca. 396–8]; *Solomon’s three books*: *Proverbs*, *Ecclesiastes*, and the *Song of Songs* [398]; *Pentateuch* [398–400]; *Joshua/Judges/Ruth* [404–5/6]; *Tobit and Judith* [399]; and *Esther* [404–5]).¹⁹ His translation method was based on the one proposed by Origen, who used asterisks and obelus in his *Hexapla* to indicate the differences between various translations or versions of the Bible.²⁰ In his *praefationes* (for example, in the *Prologue to the Pentateuch*), Jerome assessed the procedure used by Origen, who “mixed the translation of Theodotion to the ancient edition, with asterisk and obelus, that is, star and skewer, a work distinguishing everything, while he either makes to shine those things which were previously lacking, or he slays and pierces through everything superfluous.”²¹ Jerome, on the other hand, allegedly never added or omitted anything in his translations. For example, he asked Paula and Eustochium to hold the Hebrew Book of Esther, to “look through each word of [his] translation, so

¹⁸ Jerome, *Pr. Evang.* 1: *Nouum opus facere me cogis ex ueteri ut post exemplaria Scripturarum toto orbe dispersa quasi quidam arbiter sedeam et, quia inter se uariant, quae sint illa quae cum Graeca consentiant ueritate decernam* (trans.: <http://vulgate.org/> [accessed Dec. 31, 2014]). See Canellis, Introduction to *Jérôme: préfaces aux livres de la Bible*.

¹⁹ Dates are taken from Duval, “Hieronymus.”

²⁰ See Canellis, Introduction to *Jérôme: préfaces aux livres de la Bible*.

²¹ Jerome, *Pr. Pent.* 2: *Origenis . . . qui editioni antiquae translationem Theodotionis miscuit, asterisco et obelo, id est stella et ueru, opus omne distinguens dum aut illucescere facit quae minus ante fuerant, aut superflua quaeque iugulat et confodit* (trans.: www.bombaxo.com/prologues.html [accessed Dec. 31, 2014]); see Canellis, Introduction to *Jérôme: préfaces aux livres de la Bible*.

[they] may be able to understand [him] also to have augmented nothing by adding, but rather with faithful witness simply to have translated, just as it is found in the Hebrew, the Hebrew history into the Latin language.”²² Although Jerome was always criticized for his translations, he attempted to correct all the mistakes made by the preceding translators: “How much more should I, a Christian of Christian parents and bearing the standard of the cross on my forehead, whose study was to recover the missing, to correct the corrupted, and to open the sacraments of the Church with pure and faithful language, not be rejected by either disdainful or by malicious readers?”²³

In translating Hebrew books, Jerome explained that some of these were poetic, such as Job, the Psalter, the Lamentation of Jeremiah, as well as almost all the songs in Scripture, and others were prose. In order to give a better grasp of the issue, Jerome offered comparisons with Latin meter:

The verses [in the Book of Job] are in hexameter, running in dactyl and spondee and, according to the idiom of the language, also accepting numerous other (poetic) feet not of the same (number of) syllables, but of the same intervals. Sometimes also, by breaking the law of (poetic metrical) numbers, the rhythm itself is found sweet and ringing, which is understood better by prosodists than by a simple reader.²⁴

²² Jerome, *Pr. Est. 2: tenentes Hester Hebraicum Librum, per singula uerba nostram translationem aspicite, ut possitis agnoscere me nihil etiam augmentasse addendo sed fideli testimonio simpliciter, sicut in Hebraeo habetur* (trans.: www.bombaxo.com/prologues.html [accessed Dec. 31, 2014]); see Canellis, Introduction to *Jérôme: préfaces aux livres de la Bible*. Cf. Jerome's words about the translation of Origen's *Peri Archôn* in ep. 85.3: *Vnde necessitate compulsus sum transferre libros . . . et hanc seruare mensuram, ut nec adderem quid, nec demerem, Graecamque fidem Latina integritate seruarem.*

²³ Jerome, *Pr. Iob (Heb.) 4: quanto magis ego Christianus, de parentibus christianis et uexillum crucis in mea fronte portans, cuius studium fuit omissa repetere, deprauata corrigere et sacramenta Ecclesiae puro et fideli aperire sermone, uel a fastidiosis uel a malignis lectoribus non debeo reprobare!* (trans.: www.bombaxo.com/prologues.html [accessed Dec. 31, 2014]).

²⁴ Jerome, *Pr. Iob (Heb.) 3: hexametri uersus sunt, dactylo spondeoque currentes et propter linguae idioma crebro recipientes et alios pedes non earumdem syllabarum sed eorumdem temporum. Interdum quoque rythmus ipse dulcis et tinnulus fertur*

In addition, Jerome took interest in the Hebrew alphabet²⁵ and words. According to him, Scripture “might preserve the forest of Hebrew names and their division into parts”;²⁶ that is, *per cola et commata*, like one finds in Demosthenes and Cicero.²⁷ Aiming at clarity in his translation, Jerome was always careful to “make the foreignness of the meanings clearer, and to separate lines into members, so that the inextricable spaces and forest of names, which were confused through the error of the scribes, are, as Hismenius says, ‘themselves singing to [him] and [his].’”²⁸ Because of the need to understand the Hebrew names, Jerome continued the work of Eusebius, as well as that of Philo and Origen, by writing a book of his own – *Liber interpretationis Hebraicorum nominum* (ca. 389–91), for “a work of this kind . . . appeared likely to be of use.”²⁹ So he “went through all the books of Scripture in order, and in the restoration which [he has] made of the ancient fabric, [he] think[s] that [he has] produced a work which may be found valuable by

numerus lege solutis, quod metrici magis quam simplex lector intellegunt (trans.: www.bombaxo.com/prologues.html [accessed Dec. 31, 2014]). See Canellis, Introduction to *Jérôme: préfaces aux livres de la Bible* and Jerome, *ep.* 30.3.

²⁵ E.g., *Pr. Reg.* 1: *quinque litterae duplices apud eos sunt: ‘chaph’, ‘mem’, ‘nun’, ‘phe’, ‘sade’; aliter enim per has scribunt principia medietatesque uerborum, aliter fines. . . . Quomodo igitur uiginti duo elementa sunt, per quae scribimus hebraice omne quod loquimur, et eorum initiis uox humana comprehenditur;* see Canellis, Introduction to *Jérôme: préfaces aux livres de la Bible*.

²⁶ Jerome, *Pr. Ios.* 1: *Monemusque lectorem ut siluam Hebraicorum nominum et distinctiones per membra diuisas diligens Scriptura conseruet* (trans.: www.bombaxo.com/prologues.html [accessed Dec. 31, 2014]); see Canellis, Introduction to *Jérôme: préfaces aux livres de la Bible*.

²⁷ Jerome, *Pr. Esaia* 1: *sed quod in Demosthene et Tullio solet fieri ut per cola scribantur et commata, qui utique prosa et non uersibus conscripserunt, nos quoque utilitati legentium prouidentes interpretationem nouam nouo scribendi genere distinximus; Pr. Ez.* 2: *Legite igitur et hunc iuxta translationem nostram quia, per cola scriptus et commata, manifestiorem sensus legentibus tribuit!* See Canellis, Introduction to *Jérôme: préfaces aux livres de la Bible*.

²⁸ Jerome, *Pr. Par. (Heb.)* 4: *idcirco feci ut inextricabiles moras et siluam nominum quae scriptorum confusa sunt uitio, sensuumque barbariem apertius et per uersuum cola digererem, ‘mihimet ipsi et meis’ iuxta Hismenium canens, si aures surdae sunt ceterorum* (trans.: www.bombaxo.com/prologues.html [accessed Dec. 31, 2014]); see Canellis, Introduction to *Jérôme: préfaces aux livres de la Bible*.

²⁹ Jerome, *Nom. hebr.*, n. 31 (Latin text).

Greeks as well as Latins.”³⁰ Moreover, just like Origen but not so much as Philo the Jew, Jerome “added the meaning of the words and names in the New Testament, so that the fabric might receive its last touch and might stand complete.”³¹ At the same time, he wrote in another work, *The Hebrew Questions on Genesis*, that his goal was

to rebut the errors of those who make different kinds of conjectures about the Hebrew books, and to restore to their proper authority those things which in the Latin and Greek codices seem to burst forth in abundance; and to make plain through consideration of the native language the etymologies of objects, of names, and of territories which have no meaning in our own language.³²

Because he read both Hebrew and Greek fluently, and knew the works of the Greek exegets, such as Philo, Origen, and Eusebius, Jerome was able to exegete the Sacred Scripture to his Roman friends and communicate the fruits of his learning in his many letters and commentaries.

Hermeneutical theory and practice in Jerome's letters

Over the course of his career, Jerome wrote letters of different literary genres, including those that discussed exegetical problems (see the synopsis that follows).³³ Most of the letters discussing

³⁰ Ibid.

³¹ *Nom. hebr.*, Praef.: *et rei ipsius utilitate commotus, singula per ordinem Scripturarum uolumina percucurri, et uetus aedificium noua cura instaurans, fecisse me reor quod a Graecis quoque adpetendum sit; . . . imitari uolens ex parte Origenem, quem post apostolos ecclesiarum magistrum nemo nisi inperitus negat. Inter cetera enim ingeni sui praeclara monimenta etiam in hoc laborauit, ut quod Philo quasi Iudaeus omiserat, hic ut Christianus inpleret* (trans.: www.ccel.org/ccel/schaff/npnf206.vii.ii.iii.html [accessed on Dec. 31, 2014]).

³² Jerome, *Quaest. hebr.*, Praef.: *Studii ergo nostri erit uel eorum, qui de libris hebraicis uaria suspicantur, errores refellere uel ea, quae in latinis et graecis codicibus scatere uidentur, auctoritati suae reddere, etymologias quoque rerum, nominum atque regionum, quae in nostro sermone non resonant, uernaculae linguae explanare ratione.* (*Jerome's Hebrew Questions on Genesis*, trans. C. T. R. Hayward, Oxford Early Christian Studies [Oxford: Clarendon, 1995], 29).

³³ See A. Canellis, “La lettre selon saint Jérôme. L'épistolarité de la correspondance hiéronymienne,” in L. Nadjo and E. Gavaille (eds.), *Epistulae antiquae II: actes du*

exegetical problems belonged to the genre of *quaestiones et responsiones* (*ep.* 20.25; 26.28–30; 34.36, 37, 55, 59, 85, 119–21). While some letters, especially those written in Rome, focused on words or phrases in the Hebrew Bible, others explained entire passages (*ep.* 21, 65, 78, 140 [in Table 3.1, these letters are in bold font]). In *ep.* 64, 72–4, 106, and 129, one finds rather long responses to the issues raised by the letter recipients. Since *ep.* 53 summarized the content of most of the biblical books, it was later used as a prologue to the *Vulgate*.³⁴ Among the letters that dealt with biblical matters, ten were written between 383 and 385 to friends (Damasus, Marcella, Paula) in Rome. Sixteen were written in Bethlehem and sent to Christian friends such as Principia or to otherwise unknown recipients, such as Hedibia from Gaul or the Goths Sunnia and Fretela.

All these letters shed some light on Jerome's hermeneutical principles. In the exegetical letters written in Rome,³⁵ Jerome began to discuss his exegetical techniques. Instead of being satisfied with simple but often wrong solutions to textual problems, which he called *quaestio* or *problema*, Jerome always sought the truth.³⁶ To explain difficult words, Jerome consulted phrases and passages from

Ile colloque international "Le genre épistolaire antique et ses prolongements" (Université François-Rabelais, Tours, 28–30 septembre 2000) (Louvain: Peeters, 2002), 311–32, at 327–8; A. Cain, *The Letters of Jerome Asceticism, Biblical Exegesis, and the Construction of Christian Authority in Late Antiquity*, Oxford Early Christian Studies (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2009), 168–96 and 218–21. Unlike Cain (pp. 169 and 218), I do not think that *ep.* 18A and 18B to Pope Damasus (?) (the vision of Is 6) are "letters," and that *ep.* 69 and 146 are "exegetical letters." Cain also contends that *ep.* 53 belongs to the grouping of "exhorting letters" (p. 214), and *ep.* 37 to "censuring letters" (p. 214). Therefore, in *ep.* 37, which I consider an "exegetical letter," Jerome corrects two mistakes in the Commentary of Reticus of Autun.

³⁴ See Canellis, Introduction to *Jérôme: préfaces aux livres de la Bible*.

³⁵ See A. Canellis, "Les premières lettres exégétiques de saint Jérôme," in L. Nadio and E. Gavaille (eds.), *Epistulae antiquae III, actes du IIIème colloque international "L'Épistolaire antique et ses prolongements européens" (Université François Rabelais, Tours, 25–27 septembre 2002)* (Louvain: Peeters, 2004), 365–84, at 378–83.

³⁶ Jerome, *ep.* 20.2; 20.5: *quia facile et nos potuimus aliquid ementiri, quod ex una uoce solueret quaestionem, sicuti et ceteros fecisse monstrauimus. Sed magis condecet ob ueritatem laborare paulisper et peregrino aures commodare sermoni, quam de aliena lingua fictam ferre sententiam*; cf. *ep.* 28.5; 29.3.

Table 3.1 *Jerome's exegetical letters*

Date*	Letter	From	To	Subject
Rome				
383	19	Damasus	Jerome	<i>Question on the sense of the word "Hosanna"</i> [†]
383	20	Jerome	Damasus	Answer on the word " <i>Hosanna</i> "
383	21	Jerome	Damasus	Exegesis of Lk 15:11–32 (Parable of the Prodigal Son) [‡]
384	25	Jerome	Marcella	The ten names of God in Hebrew (<i>Hel, Eloim, Eloie, Sabaoth, Eliton, Eser ieie, Adonai, Ia</i> , tetragrammum = <i>iod, he, uau, he, Sadai</i>)
384	26	Jerome	Marcella	The words <i>Alleluia, Amen</i> , and <i>Maran-atha</i>
384	28	Jerome	Marcella	The word <i>Sela</i> (= <i>Diapsalma</i>)
384	29	Jerome	Marcella	The words <i>Ephod bad</i> and <i>Teraphim</i>
384	30	Jerome	Paula	The alphabetical Psalms (110, 111, 118, 144)
384	34	Jerome	Marcella	Two phrases in Psalm 126:2 and 4 (<i>leem aasabim</i> = <i>panis doloris; chen bene annaurim</i> = <i>filii excussorum</i>)
384	35	Damasus	Jerome	<i>Five questions on the Old Testament</i> (Gn 4:15; 7:2; 15:16; 17:11; 27:26)
384	36	Jerome	Damasus	Three Old Testament passages (Gn 4:15; 15:16; 27:26)
384–5	37	Jerome	Marcella	The words <i>Tharsis</i> and <i>Ofaz</i> (by Reticus of Autun)
Bethlehem				
394 [§]	53, 8–9	Jerome	Paulinus (of Nola)	Sense of the Books of the Bible (Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy, Job, Joshua, Judges, Ruth, Samuel, Kings, Minor Prophets – Joel, Amos, Obadiah, Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi – Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, Daniel, David, Solomon, Esther, Chronicles, Ezra, Nehemiah, Paul, (Hebrews), Acts, James, Peter, John, Jude, Revelation).
393–7	55	Jerome	Amandus	Three New Testament passages (Mt 6:34; 1 Cor 6:18; 15:25–28)
394–7	59	Jerome	Marcella	Four New Testament passages (1 Cor 2:9; Mt 25:33; 1 Thes 4:14–16; Jn 20:17)
395–7	64	Jerome	Fabiola	Aaron's priestly vestments (Lv 21:10–15; Ex 28:1–43)

397	65	Jerome	Principia	Psalms 44
398	72	Jerome	Vitalis	Solomon and Ahaz (1 Kgs 11:42; 14:21; 2 Chr 9:30; 2 Kgs 16:2; 18:2; 1 Chr 29:1), who became fathers at the age of eleven
398	73	Jerome	Evangelus	Melchizedek (Gn 14:18–20)
398	74	Jerome	Rufinus	The judgement of Solomon (1 Kgs 3:16–28)
400	78	Jerome	Fabiola	Numbers 33 (1–49)
399	85	Jerome	Paulinus (of Nola)	Two New Testament passages: Rom 9:16 (while quoting Ex 4:21); 1 Cor 7:14
400/ca. 404–10	106	Jerome	Sunnia and Fretela	Psalter of LXX (corrupted); Jerome's translation from Hebrew
406	119	Jerome	Minervius and Alexander	Two New Testament passages (1 Cor 15:51; 1 Thes 6:14–16)
407	120	Jerome	Hedibia	Twelve Questions/eleven New Testament passages (life of a widow without children; Mt 26:29; 28:1/Mk 16:1–2; Mt 28:1 and 9/Jn 20:1 and 11; Mt 28:1 and 9/Jn 20:17; Jn 20:6–10; Mt 28/Mk 16; Mt 27:52–3; Jn 20:22/Lk 24:49; Acts 1:4–8; Rom 9:14; 2 Cor 2:16; 1 Thes 5:23)
(before Ep. 120)	121	Jerome	Algasia	Eleven New Testament passages (Jn 1:29; Mt 12:20; 16:24; 24:19–20; Lk 9:53; 16:1–8; Rom 5:7; 7:8; 9:3; Col 2:18; 2 Thes 2:3)
414	129	Jerome	Dardanus	The Promised Land
414	140	Jerome	Cyprianus	Psalms 89

* Following *Jérôme, lettres*, 8 vols., ed. J. Labourt, CUF (Paris: Les Belles Lettres, 1949–63), and P. Lardet, *L'Apologie de Jérôme contre Rufin, un commentaire* (Leiden: Brill, 1993), 489–99 (Chronology of Jerome's Works).

† Letters of Damasus to Jerome are in italics.

‡ Letters explaining entire passages are in bold font.

§ See A. Canellis, "Une amitié par lettres et ses aléas: la correspondance entre Paulin de Nole et Jérôme," in P. Laurence and F. Guillaumont (eds.), *Epistulae antiquae IV, actes du IV^{ème} colloque international "L'Épistolaire antique et ses prolongements européens"* (Université François-Rabelais, Tours, 1–3 décembre 2004) (Louvain: Peeters, 2006), 215–32.

the whole Scripture (*ep.* 20.3; 30.3). He tirelessly investigated the texts in original languages – Hebrew in the case of the Old Testament,³⁷ and less often Greek in the case of the New Testament (*ep.* 55.1)³⁸ – justifying his procedure by using the metaphor of a fountain-head (*fons*).³⁹ He transliterated Hebrew sentences and vocalized⁴⁰ and spelled out words,⁴¹ especially when he had to correct mistakes.⁴² Above all, he preferred to make his own translations, although at times he was not satisfied with the results.⁴³ He provided the text of the LXX and added either his own or a preexisting Latin translation (*ep.* 36.12). Working with Origen's *Hexapla*, he compared all Greek translations of the Old Testament⁴⁴ with Hebrew and Latin texts.⁴⁵

As an outstanding educator, Jerome studied a given biblical text in its historical or literary context⁴⁶ in order to guide the real or implied readers in their understanding of every detail.⁴⁷ He pointed out that passages of the Sacred Scripture could be explained by other passages of the Sacred Scripture.⁴⁸ At the same time, he tried to keep everything simple.⁴⁹ In addition, he made references to classical culture,⁵⁰ comparisons or allusions to Roman culture, and observations on the grammar of Latin language.⁵¹ Most often and among others whose

³⁷ *Ep.* 20.2; 28.5; 29.1; 34.2, 4; and 121.2.

³⁸ E.g., *In Philem.* 20; *In Tit.* 1.1a; 1.5a; 1.8–9; 2.2; 2.11–14; 2.15a–b; *In Gal.* 1.1, 4–5; 2.2, 13b–14; 2.4, 4–5; 3.5, 19–21; *In Eph.* 1.4–5.

³⁹ *Ep.* 20.2; 28.5; 34.4: *restat igitur ut rursum ad fontem sermonis recurramus Hebraei.*

⁴⁰ *Ep.* 20.3; 25.2; 34.2; 36.2; 36.13. ⁴¹ *Ep.* 20.3; 25.2; 26.3.

⁴² *Ep.* 29.1: *Quasi uero Phariseorum teneam cathedram ut, quotienscumque de uerbis Hebraicis iurgium est, ego arbiter et litis sequester exposcar;* cf. *ep.* 29.5; 34.3–5; 36.13.

⁴³ *Ep.* 29.1: *si sacramenta diuina nostri codices, qui de Hebraeo in Latinum non bene resonant peruidendi.*

⁴⁴ *Ep.* 20.3; 25.1–2; 26.4; 28.2; 29.4; 34.2, 4–5; 36.2, 4, 12–13; 212.2; and especially *ep.* 106.

⁴⁵ For the comparisons, see par. 31, 35, 46, 50, 60, 63, 65, 86. ⁴⁶ *Ep.* 21.2.

⁴⁷ *Ep.* 20.2; 36.5; 55.4; 59.

⁴⁸ Jerome's exegetical method varied when he considered the texts of the New Testament – he paid much more attention to theological and moral issues (*ep.* 55, 119, 120, 121).

⁴⁹ *Ep.* 36.14: *mihi sufficit sic loqui ut intellegar, et ut de Scripturis disputans Scripturarum imiter simplicitatem.*

⁵⁰ *Ep.* 29.7; 121.8. ⁵¹ *Ep.* 20.5; 25.2; 28.4; 121.6; 121.10.

names are not given,⁵² he interacted with Christian authors – in addition to the anonymous ones, Greek authors, such as Origen (*Adamantius* [ep. 34.1]),⁵³ Didymus (ep. 36.1; 121.6), Pamphilus (ep. 31.1), and Theophilus of Alexandria (ep. 121.6), as well as Latin ones, such as Tertullian (ep. 21.3; 85.5), Novatian (ep. 36.1), Marcion (ep. 121.7), Cyprian (ep. 30.14), Victorinus of Pettau (ep. 36.16), Hilary of Poitiers (ep. 21.1; 34.3; 55.3), Reticus of Autun (ep. 37.1), Ambrose of Milan (ep. 121.6), and Hippolytus (ep. 36.16). He also studied Hebrew authors, such as Philo and Josephus (ep. 29.7; 37.2) and consulted “Hebrews,” that is, Jews, about various linguistic problems (ep. 36.5). Only after having done all this did he present his own point of view (ep. 28.2). For example, in ep. 119, in order to solve the *quaestio* on 1 Cor 15:51, he examined some opinions of Diodore of Tarsus, Apollinaris of Laodicea, Didymus, Origen, and Acacius of Caesarea, and *in fine* gave his own opinion (ep. 119.11). Even if ep. 120 and 121 belong to the same literary genre of *questiones et responsiones*, these letters were not written in the same style.⁵⁴ Just as he did in his exegetical commentaries, Jerome wrote a *praefatio* and afterward explained the meaning of the biblical texts. The prologue of ep. 120 is a sort of manifesto, synthezizing several ideas:

So I tell you then, without fear that I shall be accused of vanity, that in this letter I shall not use any pompous terminology, which belongs to the human wisdom that God must destroy one day, but instead the language of faith, treating spiritually spiritual things (1 Cor 2:23), so that the “deep” of the Old Testament “calls to the deep” of the Gospel “with the roar of the waterfall” (Ps 42), that is the prophets and the apostles, and that the truth of the Lord shall rise up to the “clouds” which he has commanded not to rain on the unbelieving Jews and instead to water the lands of the gentiles, and soften the torrent of thorns and the Dead Sea.⁵⁵

⁵² Ep. 28.2; 36.6–8; 55.2; 120.10. ⁵³ Ep. 28.7; 36.1, 9; 37.3; 85.3; 121.6.

⁵⁴ See Canellis, “La lettre selon saint Jérôme,” 328.

⁵⁵ Jerome, ep. 120, Praef.: *Vnde libere profiteor (nec dictum superbiae pertimesco) me scribere tibi non in doctis humanae sapientiae uerbis, quam Deus destructurus est; sed in uerbis fidei, spiritualibus spiritualia conparantem: ut abyssus ueteris Testamenti inuocet abyssum euangelicam, in uoce cataractarum, id est, prophetarum et apostolorum suorum, et ueritas Domini perueniat usque ad nubes, quibus mandatum est, ne super incredulum*

Contrary to what is commonly believed, at the end of the same letter and while commenting on 1 Thes 5:19, Jerome did not lay out his hermeneutical procedure. Following Origen's *Peri Archôn*, Jerome writes, "We can describe the *three ways* by which the instructions and regulations of Scripture are set forth in our hearts. First there is the literal and historical sense. Second, there is the moral sense. And, finally, it may be taken in the spiritual sense."⁵⁶ Although Jerome was clearly influenced by Origen's ideas, he actually did not use the system of three levels of meaning the way Origen did.⁵⁷

In the letters written in Rome, which commented on the texts of either the Old Testament (*ep.* 36)⁵⁸ or the New Testament (*ep.* 21), Jerome's developing exegetical techniques are already clearly identifiable. Just as earlier in Constantinople (ca. 380–1), when he commented on the vision of Isaiah 6 (*ep.* 18A and 18B to Pope Damasus = *De Seraphim*),⁵⁹ before explaining the meaning of the text, Jerome first quoted and then compared it with the text in the original language (or with other translations). He used two (and not three) different levels of meaning: the literal/historical sense and the spiritual sense.⁶⁰ Jerome's goal was to understand the "mystery

Israhel imbrem pluerent; sed ut rigarent arua gentilium, et torrentem spinarum ac mare mortuum dulcorarent (trans.: www.tertullian.org/fathers/jerome_letter_120.htm [accessed Dec. 31, 2014]). See also Jerome, *ep.* 120, Praef.: *et quicquid ad proposita respondero, scias me non confidentia respondisse sermonis; sed eius fide, qui pollicitus est: "Aperi os tuum, et implebo illud"* (Ps 80:11).

⁵⁶ Jerome, *ep.* 120.12: *Triplex in corde nostro descriptio et regula Scripturarum est: prima ut intellegamus eas iuxta historiam, secunda iuxta tropologiam, tertia iuxta intellectum spiritalem. In historia eorum quae scripta sunt ordo seruatur; in tropologia de littera ad maiora consurgimus, et quicquid in priori populo carnaliter factum est iuxta moralem interpretamur locum, et ad animae nostrae emolumenta conuertimus; in spiritali theoria ad sublimiora transimus, terrena dimittimus, de futurorum beatitudine et caelestibus disputamus, ut praesentis uitae meditatio umbra sit futurae beatitudinis* (trans.: www.tertullian.org/fathers/jerome_hedibia_2_trans.htm [accessed Dec. 31, 2014]).

⁵⁷ See P. Jay, "Saint Jérôme et le triple sens de l'Écriture," *Revue des Études Augustiniennes* 26 (1980), 214–27.

⁵⁸ See Canellis, "Les premières lettres exégétiques de saint Jérôme," 381–3.

⁵⁹ Jerome, *ep.* 18A: *Non sunt, ut quidam putant, in Scripturis uerba simplicia; plurimum in his absonitum est. Aliud littera, aliud mysticus sermo significat.*

⁶⁰ *Ep.* 21.13: *Huius sapientiae typus et in Deuteronomio sub mulieris captivae figura describitur; ep.* 15 and 16: *Differo paulisper typos . . . Quoniam autem polliciti sumus et*

(*mysterium*)" (*ep.* 53.4) of the Sacred Scripture: "All that we read in the divine books," he says, "while glistening and shining without (*in cortice*), is yet far sweeter within (*in medulla*)."⁶¹ He used the same interpretative method in three other letters that commented on a passage of Scripture: *ep.* 65 and 140 (which explained Psalms 44 and 89 much more thoroughly than his *Commentarioli in Psalmos* [ca. 386–91])⁶² and *ep.* 78 (which exegeted Nm 33). Commenting on Ps 44, Jerome provided the Greek translation of the Hebrew text. Comparing his translation with other Greek versions, he explained all the textual differences that he could find. To help lady Principia understand his exposition, Jerome also identified mistakes in manuscripts and made illustrative references to daily life. Taking a lead from the commentaries of Origen and Hilary,⁶³ he supplied the eschatological, tropological, Christological, and ecclesiological senses of this Psalm. A particular study of Ps 89 – a most difficult one, says Jerome in *ep.* 140.1 – is also of value here, especially because Jerome commented on this text several times.⁶⁴ Before explaining the meaning of the Psalm, in *ep.* 140 (and unlike in

de eo quid in figura significaret adiungere . . . sed quo possit occasionem praebere lectori ad intelligentiam latiore. See also *ep.* 30.5: *Post interpretationem elementorum intelligentiae ordo dicendus est.*

⁶¹ *Ep.* 58.9: *Totum quod legimus in diuinis libris nitet quidem et fulget etiam in cortice, sed dulcius in medulla est* (trans.: www.ccel.org/ccel/schaff/npnf206.v.LVIII.html [accessed Dec. 31, 2014]).

⁶² *In Ps.*, Praef.: *Igitur pro familiaritate, quae inter nos est, studiose et sedule postulasti, ut quaecumque mihi digna memoria uidebantur, signis quibusdam potius quam interpretationibus adnotarem; et (quod solent ii facere, qui in breui tabella terrarum et urbiu situs pingunt, et latissimas regiones in modico spatio conantur ostendere) ita in Psalterii opere latissimo quasi praeteriens aliqua perstringerem, ut ex paucis quae tetigissem, intellegantur et cetera, quae ommissa sunt, quam uim habeant atque rationem. Non quo putem a me posse dici quae ille [= Origen] praeteriit: sed quod ea quae in tomis uel in omeliis ipse disseruit, uel ego digna arbitror lectione, in hunc angustum commentariolum referam.*

⁶³ See A. Canellis, "L'exégèse du *Psaume 44* selon Jérôme (*Ep.* 65 à Principia)," in A. Canellis et al. (eds.), *Caritatis scripta: mélanges de littérature et de patristique offerts à Patrick Laurence*, Collection des Études Augustiniennes (Paris: Institut d'Études Augustiniennes, 2015), 177–90.

⁶⁴ See A. Canellis, "Saint Jérôme et l'exégèse du *Psaume 89* (*Epist.* 144 à Cyprien, *Tractatus et Commentarioli*)" (will be presented at a conference in October 2015).

ep. 65), for each verse, he quoted the Hebrew text and a complete translation of the Septuagint. *Ep.* 78 (and unlike *ep.* 65 and 140), which was dedicated to Fabiola after her death, is not so much a letter as a small exegetical treatise on Nm 33:1–49. Even though Jerome's exegesis was based on Origen's *Homilies on Numbers* (without mentioning his name) and on Eusebius' *Onomasticon*, he held tight to the "Hebrew truth," corrected the mistakes of Origen and Eusebius,⁶⁵ and his own errors as well!⁶⁶ He offered his own alternative meanings of the Hebrew names of the forty-two stations (or campsites) of the Israelites, as well as explanations of the spiritual sense of the whole pericope, that is, of the pilgrimage of Christians – the Hebrews hastening to pass from earth to heaven, and from Egypt to the Promised Land (*uerus Hebraeus, qui de terra transire festinat ad caelum, et Aegypto saeculi derelicta, terram repositionis ingreditur*) (*ep.* 78.2).⁶⁷

In addition to a few commentaries on biblical passages, Jerome also wrote what might be called "essays" on biblical themes where, whenever possible, he explained the two senses of Scripture. Based on the comments of Philo, Josephus, Origen, and Epiphanius of Salamis,⁶⁸ Jerome provided the literal/historical (*simpliciter*) and spiritual (*mystica intelligentia*) senses of Aaron's priestly vestments (*ep.* 64).⁶⁹ In order to respond to Evangelus about Melchizedek (*ep.* 73), Jerome read Greek scholars (Origen, Didymus,

⁶⁵ Jerome, *ep.* 78.40: *Alii (= Origen) autem 'spiritualibus spiritualia conparentes,' nolunt regiones significari; sed per locorum nomina, uirtuteum profectus esse.*

⁶⁶ *Ep.* 78.11: *In libro autem Hebraicorum Nominum, 'adhaesionem, remissionemque' transtulimus, quod lectorem turbare non debet. Nec putet nos dissonantia scribere; ibi enim iuxta id quod uulgo habetur, edidimus, si medium uerbum scribatur per 'Beth' litteram; hic autem in Hebraico uolumine scriptum repperi per 'Phe', quod elementum magis pulsationem quam glutinum sonat; sensusque manifestus.*

⁶⁷ See A. Canellis, "L'exégèse de *Nombres* 33, 1–49: d'Origène à saint Jérôme (*Ep.* 78 à Fabiola)," *Collection des Études Augustiniennes* (in press).

⁶⁸ See A. Canellis, "La *Lettre* 64 de Saint Jérôme et le symbolisme des couleurs: Les vêtements sacerdotaux d'*Exode*, 28, 1–43," *Maison de l'Orient et de la Méditerranée* (in press).

⁶⁹ Jerome, *ep.* 74.9: *et antequam mysticam scruter intelligentiam, more Iudaico quae scripta sunt simpliciter exponam.*

Hippolytus, Iraeneus, Eusebius of Cesarea, Eusebius of Emesa, Apollinaris, and Eustathius of Antioch) before he said anything about the history of the Hebrews. He insisted that Melchizedek, even though a type of Christ, was a real person. For Jerome, it was absurd to reject the obvious historical sense.⁷⁰ Explaining the judgment of Solomon, he distinguished between *historiae ueritas* and *tropologiae umbrae*.⁷¹ He repeated this distinction in the case of the Promised Land (*ep.* 129)⁷² and also highlighted the fact that Israel's history announced the Christian era: *omnia illius populi imagine et umbra et typo praecessisse, scripta autem pro nobis* (*ep.* 129.6). However, questions about Solomon and Ahaz, who became fathers at the age of eleven (*ep.* 72), were extremely difficult: in fact, Jerome could not explain the problem by referring to the difference between Hebrew and Greek texts (*confugere ad solita praesidia*). Thus, he only reported the opinions of several other authors without, as usual, giving their names.⁷³

So, in his letters, Jerome spoke in various ways about the two senses of Scripture and demonstrated his keen interest in Israel's history. While mostly imitating Origen in his allegorical

⁷⁰ *Ep.* 73.9: *Et reuera stultum est, id quod in typo dicitur . . . sic quosdam referre ad anagōgēn ut historiae auferant ueritatem, et dicant non fuisse regem, sed in imagine hominis angelum demonstratum*; 73.10: *Habes quae audierim, quae legerim de Melchisedech. Meum fuit citare testes, tuum est de fide testium iudicare. Quod si omnes refelleris, tuum certe illum spiritalem interpretem non recipies, qui inperitus sermone et scientia, tanto supercilio et auctoritate Melchisedech Spiritum sanctum pronuntiauit, ut illud uerissimum comprobari, quod apud Graecos canitur: 'inperitia confidentiam, eruditio timorem creat' (Thucyd. 2.40.3).*

⁷¹ *Ep.* 74.2: *Interpretatio iudicii Salomonis super iurgio duarum mulierum meretricum, quantum ad simplicem historiam pertinet, perspicua est . . . Quantum ad typicos pertinet intellectus*; 74.6: *Haec sub nubilo allegoriae dicta sint. Ceterum optime nouit prudentia tua, non easdem regulas esse in tropologiae umbris, et quae in historiae ueritate.*

⁷² *Ep.* 129.1: *ad spiritalem nos perspicue trahit intelligentiam . . . iuxta litteram sibi uidetur esse contrarium*; 129.2: *secundum litteram.*

⁷³ *Ep.* 72.2: *Et si quidem in his historiis aliter haberent septuaginta interpretes, aliter Hebraica ueritas, confugere poteramus ad solita praesidia, et arcem linguae tenere uernaculae; nunc uero, cum et ipsum authenticum et ceteri interpretes pari auctoritate consentiant, non in Scriptura sed in sensu est difficultas*; 72.5: *In rebus obscuris diuersas ponimus opiniones.*

explanation of the divine books, Jerome based his comments on Hebrew and Greek texts. (Origen did not comment on the Hebrew Bible.) To elucidate the divine books, Jerome constantly referred to both secular and Christian knowledge. The hermeneutical approach in his commentaries on Scripture, most of which concern the Old Testament, is basically the same as in his letters.

Hermeneutical theory and practice in Jerome's commentaries

Over a period of more than forty years, Jerome commented on a few books of the New Testament (four Pauline Epistles and the Gospel of Matthew) and on most of the books of the Old Testament, in particular Ecclesiastes and the sixteen prophets (see Table 3.2; the commentaries on the New Testament are in bold font). The earliest commentary on Obadiah is lost, but the work is known due to a colourful anecdote in the prologue of the second *Commentary on Obadiah*. During the first Origenist controversy, Jerome severely criticized the Alexandrian allegorizing, although he himself had allegorized as well and continued to do so in later works.⁷⁴ He complained that Origen used allegorical interpretation (*allegorice*) without, at the same time, considering the historical interpretation (*historia*).⁷⁵

Jerome's hermeneutical principles were not exactly the same when he was exegeting the books of the Old and New Testament. Neither were they the same in the beginning and the end of his long exegetical career. As he often explained in his prologues, the choice of the technique depended on the type of text and on the

⁷⁴ *In Abd.*, Praef.: *Ille praedicabat, et ego erubescerebam, ille quasi mysticos intellectus ferebat ad caelum, ego demisso capite confiteri meum pudorem prohibebam*. See A. Canellis, "L'art de la consequentia dans l'*In Abdiam* de saint Jérôme," in P. Galand-Hallyn and V. Zarini (eds.), *Actes du colloque international "Manifestes littéraires dans la latinité tardive. Poétique et rhétorique"* (Université Paris IV Sorbonne, 23–24 mars 2007), Collection des Études Augustiniennes, Série Antiquité 188 (Paris: Institut d'Études Augustiniennes, 2009), 187–204, at 188–93.

⁷⁵ Jerome, *In Abd.*, Praef.: *allegorice interpretatus sum Abdiam prophetam, cuius historiam nesciebam*.

Table 3.2 *Jerome's biblical commentaries*

Date	To	Title
ca. 375 (lost) in Antioch		In Abdiam
380–1 in Constantinople	Damasus (?)	<i>De Seraphim</i> (= ep. 18A and 18B)
386	Paula and Eustochium	<i>In Philemonem</i>*
386	Paula and Eustochium	<i>In Galatas</i>
386	Paula and Eustochium	<i>In Ephesios</i>
386**	Paula and Eustochium	<i>In Titum</i>
388–9	Paula and Eustochium	<i>In Ecclesiasten</i>
392–3	Paula and Eustochium	<i>In Nahum</i>
392–3	Paula and Eustochium	<i>In Michaeam</i>
392–3	Paula and Eustochium	<i>In Sophoniam</i>
392–3	Paula and Eustochium	<i>In Aggaeum</i>
392–3	Chromatius of Aquileia	<i>In Habacuc</i>
396	Chromatius of Aquileia	<i>In Ionam</i>
396	Pammachius	<i>In Abdiam</i>
397	Amabilis, bishop	<i>In Visiones Esaiae</i>
398	Eusebius of Cremona	<i>In Matthaeum</i>
406	Exuperius of Toulouse	<i>In Zachariam</i> , promised to Chromatius in 393 (<i>in Hab.</i> 1, Praef.)
406	Minervius and Alexander	<i>In Malachiam</i> , promised to Chromatius in 393 (<i>in Hab.</i> 1, Praef.)
406	Pammachius	<i>In Osee</i>
406	Pammachius	<i>In Ioel</i>
406	Pammachius	<i>In Amos</i>
407	Pammachius and Marcella	<i>In Danielelem</i> , promised to Paulinus of Nola (ep. 85.3)
408–10	Eustochium	<i>In Esaiaem</i>
410–14	Eustochium	<i>In Ezechielem</i>
414–16	Eusebius of Cremona	<i>In Hieremiam</i> (unfinished because of Jerome's death)

* Commentaries on the New Testament are in bold font.

** On the relative order, see Duval, *Handbuch der lateinischen Literatur*.

particular purpose of his exegesis. Consequently, there are three kinds of commentaries: polemical, undetermined (i.e., without a clear articulation of methodology), and deliberate (i.e., with definite methodology).

Commenting on the Pauline Epistles and the Gospel of Matthew, Jerome addressed the issue of the canon of the New Testament (e.g., *ep.* 73.4 [on the Epistle to the Hebrews] and 129.3 [on the Epistle to the Hebrews and the Book of Revelation]). He polemicized against heretics, such as Marcion, Basilides, and Tatian, who “[tore] up the Old Testament (*uetus laniant Testamentum*),”⁷⁶ and repudiated some Pauline Epistles.⁷⁷ Similar criticisms can be found in Jerome’s *Commentary on Galatians*.⁷⁸ He never sufficiently acknowledged the fact that he used Origen’s works in the commentaries on the Pauline Epistles and the Gospel of Matthew. However, unlike in the

⁷⁶ Jerome, *In Tit.*, Praef.: *Licet non sint digni fide qui fidem primam irritam fecerunt, Marcionem loquor et Basilidem et omnes haereticos qui uetus laniant Testamentum, tamen eos aliqua ex parte ferremus, si saltem in nouo continerent manus suas et non auderent Christi (ut ipsi iactitant) boni Dei Filii uel euangelistas uiolare uel apostolos. Nunc uero cum et Euangelia eius dissipauerint et apostolorum epistulas non apostolorum Christi fecerint esse sed proprias, miror quomodo sibi Christianorum nomen audeant uindicare . . . Nunc uero cum haeretica auctoritate pronuntient et dicant: ‘Illa epistula Pauli est, haec non est,’ ea auctoritate refelli se pro ueritate intellegant qua ipsi non erubescunt falsa simulare. Sed Tatianus, Encratitarum patriarches, qui et ipse nonnullas Pauli epistulas repudiavit, hanc uel maxime, hoc et ad Titum, Apostoli pronuntiandam credidit, paruipendens Marcionis et aliorum qui cum eo in hac parte consentiunt adsertionem.*

⁷⁷ *In Philem.*, Praef.: *Qui nolunt inter epistulas Pauli eam recipere quae ad Philemonem scribitur, aiunt non semper Apostolum, nec omnia Christo in se loquente dixisse; . . . His et ceteris istiusmodi uolunt aut epistulam non esse Pauli, quae ad Philemonem scribitur, aut, si etiam Pauli sit, nihil habere quod aedificare nos possit; . . . Et quoniam Marcionis fecimus mentionem, Pauli esse ad Philemonem epistulam saltem Marcione auctore ducantur; qui, cum ceteras epistulas eius uel non suscepit, uel quaedam in his mutauerit atque corroserit, in hanc solam manus non ausus est mittere, quia illam breuitas defendebat.* See B. Jeanjean, *Saint Jérôme et l’hérésie*, Collection des Études Augustiniennes, Série Antiquité 161 (Paris: Institut d’Études Augustiniennes, 1999), 200–5, 322–5.

⁷⁸ Jerome, *In Gal.* 1.3.1a: *Interrogemus hoc loco Marcionem, qui prophetas repudiat, quomodo interpretetur id quod sequitur; 2.4.24b–26: Marcion et Manichaeus hunc locum.*

praefationes of those texts, in his commentaries on Galatians⁷⁹ and Ephesians,⁸⁰ he at least listed his sources. While profiting from his readings, Jerome picked up some ideas and dropped others (*pauca decerpimus, adiecimus, subtraximus*). He never merely translated the works of his Greek predecessors, as he would do in his *Commentary on Zechariah*, which mediated the work of Didymus.⁸¹

The most important matter for Jerome was “the meditation and the science of Scripture (*meditatio et scientia Scripturarum*)” – things that made one wise.⁸² This *scientia* was to be linked to the pursuit of simplicity and clarity, which enabled everyone to understand Jerome's explanations.⁸³ “The language of this publication,” says Jerome, “has not been long thought over or highly

⁷⁹ *In Gal.*, Praef. 1: *Gaium Marium Victorinum . . . Quin potius in eo, ut mihi uideor, cautior atque timidior, quod imbecillitatem uirium mearum sentiens Origenis Commentarios sum secutus. Scripsit enim ille uir in Epistolam Pauli ad Galatas quinque proprie uolumina et decimum Stromatum suorum librum commatico super explanatione eius sermone compleuit; Tractatus quoque uarios et Excerpta, quae uel sola possent sufficere, composuit. Praetermitto Didymum, uidentem meum, et Laodiceum de ecclesia nuper egressum et Alexandrum, ueterem haeticum, Eusebium quoque Emesenum et Theodorum Heracleoten, qui et ipsi nonnullos super hac re commentariolos reliquerunt.*

⁸⁰ *In Eph.*, Praef. 1: *Illud quoque in praefatione commoneo, ut sciatis Origenem tria uolumina in hanc Epistolam conscripsisse, quem et nos ex parte secuti sumus. Apollinarium etiam et Didymum quosdam commentariolos edidisse, e quibus licet pauca decerpimus, et nonnulla, quae nobis uidebantur, adiecimus, siue subtraximus, ut studiosus statim in principio lector agnoscat hoc opus uel alienum esse, uel nostrum.*

⁸¹ See A. Canellis, “Le Livre I de l’*In Zachariam* de saint Jérôme et la tradition alexandrine,” in L. Perrone et al. (eds.), *Origeniana octava: Origen and the Alexandrian tradition = Origene e la tradizione alessandrina: Papers of the 8th International Origen Congress*, Pisa, 27–31 August 2001, Bibliotheca Ephemeridum Theologicarum Lovaniensium 164 (Leuven: Peeters, 2003), 861–75; A. Canellis, “Le Livre II de l’*In Zachariam* de Jérôme et le Commentaire de Didyme l’Aveugle,” *Sacris Erudiri* 46 (2007), 111–41; A. Canellis, “Le Livre III de l’*In Zachariam* de Jérôme et le Commentaire de Didyme l’Aveugle,” *Adamantius* 13 (2007), 66–81.

⁸² Jerome, *In Eph.*, Praef. 1: *Si quidquam est . . . quod in hac uita sapientem uirum teneat, et inter pressuras et turbines mundi aequo animo manere persuadeat, id esse uel primum reor, meditationem et scientiam Scripturarum.*

⁸³ *In Gal.*, Praef. 3: *Breuius uobis meae mentis fatear arcanum: qui per me intellecturus est Apostolum nolo ut mea scripta difficulter intellegat et ad interpretem cognoscendum alium quaerat interpretem.*

polished. In revealing the mysteries of Scripture I use almost the language of the street, and sometimes get through a thousand lines a day, in order that the explanation of the Apostle which I have begun may be completed with the aid of the prayers of Paul himself, whose Epistles I am endeavoring to explain.”⁸⁴ Jerome talked about apocryphal Gospels (*iuxta Aegyptios et Thoman et Mathian et Bartholomeum, duodecim quoque apostolorum et Basilidis atque Apellis ac reliquorum quos enumerare longissimum est*), before quoting the four canonical Gospels (Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John) in a rather unpolished style (as he says in the prologue to his historical *Commentary on Matthew*).⁸⁵ He just did not have enough time to write and pick up intriguing ideas from everyone who had previously written on this text.⁸⁶ Jerome wrote yet another polemical commentary on Daniel, which refuted Porphyry the philosopher. His goal was to prove both the authenticity of Daniel's prophecies and the canonicity of this book. In doing so, he supplied innovative explanations, which were based on Theodotion's version.⁸⁷

⁸⁴ *In Eph.*, Praef. 2: *in commune precor ut sciatis me non cogitatum diu limatumque proferre sermonem, sed ad reuelanda mysteria Scripturarum, uti uerbis pene de truiuo, et interdum per singulos dies usque ad numerum mille uersuum peruenire, ut coepta in Apostolum explanatio, ipsius Pauli, cuius conamur exponere, orationibus compleatur* (trans.: www.ccel.org/ccel/schaff/npnf206.vii.iv.v.html [accessed Dec. 31, 2014]).

⁸⁵ Jerome, *In Matth.*, Praef.: *Igitur, omissa auctoritate ueterum quos nec legendi nec sequendi mihi facultas data est, historicam interpretationem quam praecipue postulasti digessi breuiter et interdum spiritualis intelligentiae flores miscui, perfectum opus reseruans in posterum.*

⁸⁶ *In Matth.*, Praef.: *Primum enim difficile est omnes legere qui in euangelia scripserint, deinde multo difficilius adhibito iudicio quae optima sunt excerpere. Legisse me fateor ante annos plurimos in Mattheum Origenis uiginti quinque uolumina et totidem eius homelias commaticumque interpretationis genus, et Theophili Antiochenae urbis episcopi commentarios, Hippolyti quoque martyris, et Theodori Heracleotae Apollinarisque Laodicensi ac Didymi Alexandrini et Latinorum Hilarii, Victorini, Fortunatiani opuscula, e quibus etiam si parua carperem, dignum aliquid memoriae scriberetur.*

⁸⁷ *In Dan.*, Praef.: *Contra prophetam Danielem duodecim librum scribit Porphyrius . . . Verum iam tempus est ut ipsius prophetae uerba texamus, non iuxta consuetudinem nostram proponentes omnia et omnia disserentes ut in duodecim prophetis fecimus, sed breuiter et per interualla ea tantum quae obscura sunt explanantes, ne librorum innumerabilium magnitudo lectori fastidium faciat.* See R. Courtray, *Prophète des*

In addition to these commentaries, where it is somewhat difficult to determine Jerome's hermeneutical principles, there are others where these principles are articulated much more clearly. To begin with, his *Commentary on Ecclesiastes* has to be regarded as an original and innovative undertaking. It allows one to surmise that Jerome was on the way to becoming an exceptional exegete.⁸⁸ "I would only point this out," said Jerome,

that I have followed no one's authority. I have translated directly from the Hebrew, adapting my words as much as possible to the form of the Septuagint, but only in those places in which they did not diverge far from the Hebrew. I have occasionally referred also to the versions of Aquila, Symmachus, and Theodotion, but so as not to alarm the zealous student by too many novelties, nor yet to let my commentary follow the side streams of opinion, turning aside, against my conscientious conviction, from the fountainhead of truth.⁸⁹

His translation was a sort of compromise, which aimed at correcting mistakes without, at the same time, being too innovative. Jerome presented his translation from Hebrew, compared it with Greek versions, and then commented on the historical/literal and spiritual senses of the Book of Ecclesiastes. He used different words to introduce these two levels of meaning. The following expressions introduced the historical/literal sense: *secundum historiam* (1.1), *iuxta litteram* (1.1; 3.18–21), *secundum litteram* (2.24–6; 7.26–7), *simplex sensus*, *historiae paupertas* (2.24–2), *carnaliter* (2.9), *iuxta simplicem intelligentiam* (3.5), *prior sensus* (3.14), *simpliciter*

temps derniers: Jérôme commente Daniel, Collection Théologie Historique 119 (Paris: Beauchesne, 2009), 30–41.

⁸⁸ See A. Canellis, "Le Commentaire sur l'Ecclésiaste de saint Jérôme," in L. Mellerin (ed.), *La réception du livre de Qohélet, Ier–XIIIe siècle, Acts of the Colloquium of Lyon, 17–19 octobre 2013* (Paris: Cerf, in press).

⁸⁹ Jerome, *In Eccl.*, Praef.: *Hoc breuiter admonens, quod nullius auctoritatem secutus sum; sed de Hebraeo transferens, magis me Septuaginta interpretum consuetudini coaptavi, in his dumtaxat, quae non multum ab Hebraicis discrepabant. Interdum Aquilae quoque et Symmachi et Theodotionis recordatus sum, ut nec nouitate nimia lectoris studium detererem, nec rursus contra conscientiam meam, fonte ueritatis omisso, opinionum riuulos consectorer* (trans.: www.ccel.org/ccel/schaff/npnf206.vii.ii.vi.html [accessed Dec. 31, 2014]).

(4.9–12), *secundum simplicem sensum* (4.12–16), *simplex intelligentia* (8.12), *iuxta sensus Hebraici ueritatem* (8.13), and *umbratili (uita)* (9.7–8). The spiritual sense was introduced by *secundum intelligentiam spiritalem* (1.1), *ad spiritalem intelligentiam* (3.18–21), *secundum intelligentiam spiritalem* (7.26–7), *aliter* (1.4, *passim*), *ad superiorem sensum* (1.13), *secundum superiorem interpretationem* (4.7–8), *spiritaliter* (2.9; 8.15; 9.2), *secundum anagōgēn* (2.12; 7.12; 9.11), *iuxta anagōgēn* (3.12–13), *altius* (2.18–19), *spiritales diuinitates* (2.24–6), *ut altius eleuemur* (5.12–16), *tropikōs* (7.26–7), *tropice* (7.28–30), *spiritalite (oleum)* (9.7–8), and *secundum allegoriam* (9.12).⁹⁰ To talk about the various senses of Scripture,⁹¹ Jerome did not use all these words all the time. Commenting on Ecclesiastes, he also referred to various authors: Jews (such as Bar Akiba [4.7–13]), Gregory Thaumaturgos, Apollinaris, Origen, and Victorinus of Pettau, as well as Greek philosophers and a myriad of Latin poets. With stinging irony, he refuted the hedonistic interpretations of the Book of Ecclesiastes.⁹²

Turning to the other books of the Old Testament, Jerome continued to perfect his exegetical method. With the exception of his *Commentaries on Haggai* and *Nahum*,⁹³ he always presented both lemmas (a translation first from Hebrew and then from Greek [LXX] [either an amended *Vetus Latina*, or his own translation from Greek]). Interestingly, he usually based the historical/literal sense on his translation from Hebrew and the spiritual sense on his translation from the LXX.⁹⁴ The reason for such order was

⁹⁰ See also Jerome, *In Eccl.* 10.8: *Ex parte simplex et ex parte mysticus intellectus est; 10.16–17: uerum mihi sacratius quid latere uidetur in littera; 11.6–8: sic quaeramus spiritalem . . . intelligentiam.*

⁹¹ See P. Jay, “Le vocabulaire de saint Jérôme dans le *Commentaire sur Zacharie*,” *Revue des Études Augustiniennes* 14 (1968), 3–16; *Jérôme: commentaire sur Jonas*, ed. Y.-M. Duval, SC 323 (Paris: Cerf, 1985), 51–104, especially 89–90.

⁹² See A. Canellis, “Le recours aux poètes latins dans le *Commentaire sur l’Ecclésiaste* de saint Jérôme,” *Latomus* (in press).

⁹³ See Duval, *Jérôme, commentaire sur Jonas*, 44–9.

⁹⁴ E.g., Jerome, *In Es.*, Praef. 1: *Vnde post historiae ueritatem, spiritualiter accipienda sunt omnia; In Ez.: ut terra quae sibi speculatorem constituit, uel iuxta litteram terra Iudaea sit, uel iuxta spiritalem intelligentiam ecclesia quae saepe de nouissimis populi*

suggested by the “building (*aedificium*) metaphor” – just as walls were built on a foundation, so was the spiritual sense built on the historical/literal one. For example, in his *Commentary on Obadiah* 2–4, Jerome wrote: “*In interpretatione prophetica debemus morem nostrum sequi, ut primum historiae fundamenta iaciamus, deinde si possumus, excelsas turres et tectorem culmina subrigamus.*”⁹⁵ The two levels of meaning were linked by 2 Cor 3:6 (“for the letter kills, but the Spirit gives life”),⁹⁶ which was a key verse for Jerome’s hermeneutical theory. For example, in the *Commentary on Zechariah* 2.10, he taught: *nos qui Christi censemur nomine, occidentem relinquitur litteram, et sequimur Spiritum uiuificantem, immo spiritalia spiritalibus comparantes*. A similar point is made in Jerome’s many commentaries⁹⁷ and his other works.⁹⁸ He did not always

sui speculatorem eligit; In Ier. 2.17.2: Quidquid iuxta litteram intellegimus super Hierusalem, iuxta intelligentiam spiritalem referamus ad ecclesiam, si offenderit Deum.

⁹⁵ For an explanation of this metaphor, see Duval, *Jérôme, commentaire sur Jonas*, 55, n. 123.

⁹⁶ *Qui et idoneos nos fecit ministros noui testamenti, non litterae sed Spiritus. Littera enim occidit, Spiritus autem uiuificat* (Vulgate 2003).

⁹⁷ E.g., Jerome, *In Am. 1.1: Hos ego arbitror iudaeorum magistros, et omnes qui occidentem sequuntur litteram, noluntque recipere spiritum uiuificantem, sed quaecumque interpretantur et sapiunt, uolunt esse terrena, nec audiunt cum discipulis parabolas dominum disserentem; In Es. 1.1: Beatus est autem qui seminat in eloquiis Scripturarum tam ueteris quam noui instrumenti; et calcit aquas occidentis litterae, ut metat fructum spiritus uiuificantis; 11.6: Ceterum iuxta uiuificantem spiritum facilis intelligentia est; In Mich. 2.4: Nos ergo qui non occidentem litteram, sed spiritum uiuificantem sequimur, dicimus aduersum filiam Sion, quae interpretatur ecclesia, multas nationes daemorum congregari; In Abd.: Igitur transmigratio filiorum Israel quando occidentem dimiserint litteram, et ad spiritum uenerint uiuificantem, mouebit cuncta quae legis sunt; In Ion., Praef.: Illi habent libros, nos librorum dominum; illi tenent prophetas, nos intelligentiam prophetarum; illos occidit littera, nos uiuificat spiritus; apud illos Barabbas latro dimittitur, nobis Christus Dei filius soluitur; In Dan. 4.12: Et uenit uox, dicens: ne plores; ecce uicit leo de tribu iuda, radix Dauid, aperire librum et soluere signacula eius – librum autem istum potest soluere qui Scripturarum sacramenta cognouit, et intellegit aenigmata et uerba tenebrosa propter mysteriorum magnitudinem, et interpretatur parabolas, et occidentem litteram transfert ad spiritum uiuificantem.*

⁹⁸ *Hom. Marc. 6.9.2: Qui amant historiam, qui solum iudaicam sequuntur sententiam, qui sequuntur occidentem litteram et non uiuificantem spiritum* (see Jérôme, *Homélies*

necessarily elaborate on every possible sense of Scripture, nor did he distinguish constantly between various spiritual senses (e.g., between the ecclesiological and Christological sense).

In order to detect the historical/literal sense, Jerome employed codicological, philological (literary or grammatical),⁹⁹ etymological,¹⁰⁰ and historical analysis.¹⁰¹ In addition, he always consulted the *hebraica ueritas* and the Greek texts of the *Hexapla*.¹⁰² He was also very interested in the *consequentia*, in the logical structure of the biblical text.¹⁰³ To detect the spiritual senses, however, he employed four types of analysis: tropological (which focussed on the life or the soul),¹⁰⁴ ecclesiological¹⁰⁵ (which explained, for example, the tiresome battle with the heretics),¹⁰⁶ Christological (which presented a given Old Testament person as the *typus Christi*), and eschatological (which pointed to the resurrection).¹⁰⁷ He never discussed these four senses simultaneously or consistently throughout a whole commentary.¹⁰⁸

sur Marc, SC 494, ed. J.-L. Gourdain [Paris: Cerf, 2005], 33–9); *ep.* 121.56: *Vnde et centesimus octauus decimus psalmus et omnes alii, qui litteris praenotantur, per ethicam nos ducunt ad theologiam et ab elementis occidentis litterae, quae destruitur, transire faciunt ad spiritum uiuificantem*; *ep.* 129.56: *Si enim occidentem tantum sequuntur litteram et non spiritum uiuificantem, ostendant terram repromissionis lacte et melle manantem; sin autem per tropologiam dictum putant pro rerum omnium abundantia, et nos confessionis terram terramque uiuentium terrae ueprium praeferimus dicente Domino ad Moysen de abiectioe Israhelis et adsumptione gentium.*

⁹⁹ E.g., *In Ioel* 1.6–7: *sub metaphora* (CCL 76:167, 236 and 259); 2.12–14: *per translationem* (CCL 76:182, 240).

¹⁰⁰ E.g., *In Ioel*, Praef.: *Et quia semel omnes unius uoluminis prophetas enumerauimus, utile nobis etymologias singulorum et Graece et Latine breuiter annotare . . . Ioel archomenos, id est incipiens* (CCL 76:159, 11–15).

¹⁰¹ E.g., *In Ioel* 3.1–3 (CCL 76:199, 55–57); 3.4–6 (CCL 76:201, 111–13).

¹⁰² E.g. *In Ioel* 1.8 (CCL 76:168, 292); 1.13–14 (CCL 76:172, 434–6); 1.19–20 (CCL 76:175, 529); 2.15–17 (CCL 76:185, 334–40).

¹⁰³ *In Ioel* 2.1–11 (CCL 76:179, 134–5). See Duval, *Jérôme, commentaire sur Jonas*, 58; Canellis, “L’art de la *consequentia* dans l’*In Abdiam* de saint Jérôme,” 187–204.

¹⁰⁴ E.g. Jerome, *In Ioel* 2.18–20 (CCL 76:187, 425–6).

¹⁰⁵ E.g. *In Ioel* 2.1–11 (CCL 76:180, 152).

¹⁰⁶ E.g. *In Ioel* 3.7–8 (CCL 76:202, 173–5).

¹⁰⁷ E.g. *In Naum*, Praef. (CCL 76:526; 37–9).

¹⁰⁸ “Du pointillé . . . au fil continu” (Duval, *Jérôme, commentaire sur Jonas*, 97–8); A. Canellis, “L’érudition dans le Livre I du *Commentaire sur Amos* de saint Jérôme,” *Eruditio Antiqua* 1 (2009), 45–62.

Although he had an encyclopedic knowledge of Jewish traditions, as well as Greek, pagan, and Christian authors, he always labored to make his commentaries distinctively Roman by making references to Latin authors (both pagan and Christian), culture, and *realia*.¹⁰⁹ This demonstrates his wonderful complicity with his Latin readership.

In conclusion, even though Jerome rarely stated his hermeneutical principles in one place, it is possible to reconstruct several of these by reviewing his numerous works, their prologues, and especially Jerome's letters and commentaries.¹¹⁰ Being exceptionally gifted in languages, Jerome always relied on *hebraica ueritas* and appealed to Jewish traditions. He had an encyclopedic knowledge of the church fathers, in particular the Alexandrian ones, and so he exegeted the texts according to the two senses, historical/literal and spiritual. Last but not least, he had an admirable rhetorical education and an extraordinary polemical verve, which enabled him to use "the language of faith (*in uerbis fidei*)" skillfully for exegeting the Bible.¹¹¹ During the Middle Ages, his hermeneutical principles were used by authors such as Haimo of Auxerre.¹¹²

¹⁰⁹ A. Canellis, "Saint Jérôme et les passions: sur les 'quattuor perturbationes' des *Tusculanes*," *Vigiliae Christianae* 54 (2000), 178–203; A. Canellis, "Hiezechiel quoque uidit Dominum in forma hominis sedentem super Cherubim . . . L'exégèse de la première vision d'Ezéchiel dans l'*In Hiezechielem* de saint Jérôme," in F. Vinel (ed.), *Les visions de l'Apocalypse: Héritage d'un genre littéraire et interprétation dans la littérature chrétienne des premiers siècles (cahiers de biblia patristica)* (Turnhout: Brepols, 2014), 127–54; A. Canellis, "Le recours aux poètes latins dans le *Commentaire sur l'Ecclésiaste* de saint Jérôme."

¹¹⁰ Jerome used almost the same technique for exegeting the Bible when he wrote his homilies and *Tractatus*, without systematically retriving to original texts (cf. *In Marc*); A. Canellis, "Jérôme prédicateur: A propos du *Tractatus in Ps. CXLVII*," in J.-L. Breuil and B. Jacquinod (eds.), *En koinōnía pása filía: mélanges offerts offerts à Bernard Jacquinod* (Saint-Étienne: Centre Jean Palerne, 2006), 63–79.

¹¹¹ Jerome, *ep.* 120, Praef.

¹¹² E.g., A. Canellis, "Haymon d'Auxerre, lecteur de saint Jérôme: l'exemple de l'*In Malachiam*," in R. Brent at al. (eds.), *Les réceptions des Pères de l'Église au Moyen Âge. Le devenir de la tradition ecclésiale, Congrès du Centre Sèvres – Facultés Jésuites de Paris (11–14 juin 2008)*, *Archia Verbi/Subsidia* 10.2/1 (Münster: Aschendorff, 2013), 389–406.

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Augustine's hermeneutics
The science of the divinely given signs
Tarmo Toom

Augustine of Hippo (354–430 CE) is not among those church fathers who needs a thorough introduction. His name is well known, his works have been translated into many modern languages,¹ and his views are still discussed – hailed and debunked with equal ferocity. In *Confessiones*, Augustine provided his own retrospective account of his growing up and becoming catholic. Shortly after Augustine's death, Possidius, a loyal friend of Augustine for some forty years and a rather uncritical admirer, wrote his *Vita Augustini*. These foundational accounts of Augustine's life were followed by many medieval and modern biographies.²

Once again, the problem with Augustine is not that he is unknown. Rather, the problem is that there are so many different reconstructions of him. Augustine himself is at least partially responsible for this situation, for he “stylizes himself differently in different works and contexts.”³ No wonder, then, that “from his death in

¹ A. Keller, *Translationes patristicae graecae et latinae* (Stuttgart: Anton Hiersemann, 1997–2004), vol. I, 89–151; <http://augustinus.de/bwo/dcms/sites/bistum/extern/zfa/textevon/uebersetzungen> (accessed May 1, 2014), which includes translations into English, German, French, Italian, and Spanish.

² E. L. Saak, “Lives of Augustine,” in K. Pollmann and W. Otten (eds.), *The Oxford Guide to the Historical Reception of Augustine* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2013), vol. III, 1314b–1322b; cf. D. Weber, “*Confessiones*,” in *ibid.*, vol. I, 167a–174b, at 168b–169a, 170b.

³ K. Pollmann, “*Alium sub meo nomine*: Augustine between His Own Self-Fashioning and His Later Reception,” *Zeitschrift für Antikes Christentum* 14 (2010), 409–24, at 409.

430 CE to the emergence of modernity and beyond, there were multiple Augustines.”⁴

In a sense, this is true about Augustine the hermeneut as well. One can focus, for example, on his holistic theological formation,⁵ his philosophical formation,⁶ or his rhetorical/grammatical formation.⁷ All these approaches are very much in need of one another for providing a fuller picture of Augustine as an interpreter. For the task of reconstructing his ever-developing hermeneutical theory, however, it is most fitting to adopt yet another approach, which focuses on semiotics. Semiotics is a comprehensive metatheory of signs and signification which, in the Latin world, owes its very existence to Augustine.⁸ The claim is not that such an approach is the best one in

⁴ E. L. Saak, “Augustine in the Western Middle Ages to the Reformation,” in M. Vessey (ed.), *A Companion to Augustine*, Blackwell Companions to the Ancient World (Oxford: Wiley-Blackwell, 2012), 465–77, at 465. For example, there was a famous fifteen century controversy between the Augustinian canons and hermits over the question of how exactly to depict Augustine in art (K. A. Gersbach, “Massari, Ambrose,” in Pollmann and Otten, *Oxford Guide*, vol. III, 1381b–1383a, at 1382a).

⁵ E.g., I. Bochet, “*Le firmament de l'Écriture*”: *l'herméneutique augustinienne*, Collection des études augustinienes, Série Antiquité 172 (Paris: Institut d'études augustinienes, 2004); M. Cameron, *Christ Meets Me Everywhere: Augustine's Early Figurative Exegesis*, Oxford Studies in Historical Theology (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2012).

⁶ Respectively focusing on Neoplatonism and Stoicism, P. Cary, *Outward Signs: The Powerlessness of External Things in Augustine's Thought* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2008) and B. D. Jackson, “Semantics and Hermeneutics in Saint Augustine's *De doctrina Christiana*,” unpublished Ph.D. dissertation, Yale University, 1967.

⁷ E.g., K. Eden, “The Rhetorical Tradition and Augustinian Hermeneutics in *De doctrina Christiana*,” *Rhetorica: A Journal of the History of Rhetoric* 8/1 (1990), 45–63, and at least partially K. Pollmann, *Doctrina Christiana: Untersuchungen zu den Anfängen der christlichen Hermeneutik unter besonderer Berücksichtigung von Augustinus*, “*De doctrina christiana*,” *Paradosis: Beiträge zur Geschichte der althristlichen Literatur und Theologie* 41 (Freiburg, Switzerland: Universitätsverlag, 1996).

⁸ J. Deely, “The Latin Foundation for Semiotic Consciousness: Augustine (5th century AD) to Poinot (17th century),” in F. Stjernfelt and P. F. Bundgaard (eds.), *Semiotics. Vol. I: Philosophy*, Critical Concepts in Language Studies (London: Routledge, 2011), 19–40, at 21–5 (original: *Recherches Sémiotiques/Semiotic Inquiry* 20 [2000], 11–32).

itself, but arguably it is the most helpful one for reconstructing Augustine's "science of signs (*scientia signorum*)."⁹

"Augustine is our archetypical example of a writer who went to considerable pains to formulate the principles which underlay his exegetical practice."¹⁰ Despite the fact that basically all Augustine's works provide some hermeneutical insights, the core of his interpretative principles as *scientia signorum* stems mainly from *De dialectica*, *De magistro*, and *De doctrina Christiana*. His biblical commentaries, sermons, and other works complement these three and enforce the more theoretical points with further discussions and concrete examples of application. Following the chronology provided by the *Zentrum für Augustinus-Forschung* (ZAF),¹¹ the main treatises considered for this chapter are:

- *De Academicis* (or *Contra academicos*) (386)
- *De dialectica* (387)
 - *De Genesi aduersus Manicheos* (389)
- *De magistro* (389)
 - *De Genesi ad litteram liber imperfectus* (393, 426)
 - *Expositio epistulae ad Galatas* (394–5)
- *De doctrina Christiana* (396–426)¹²
 - *Confessiones* (397)
 - *Contra Faustum Manicheum* (397–8)
 - *Enarrationes in Psalmos* (392[?]-412)
 - *De Genesi ad litteram* (401–14)
 - *In Iohannis euangelium tractatus* (414–16/17)
 - *De ciuitate dei* (413–27)

⁹ Thiselton's recent book on hermeneutics ends with a striking acknowledgement. After going through the whole history of the subject, he says that "today things have turned full circle, and we are compelled, like Augustine, to hold . . . [a] theory of signs" (A. C. Thiselton, *Hermeneutics: An Introduction* [Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2009], 354).

¹⁰ R. A. Markus, *Signs and Meanings: World and Text in Ancient Christianity* (Liverpool: Liverpool University Press, 1996), 2.

¹¹ <http://augustinus.de/bwo/dcms/sites/bistum/extern/zfa/augustinus/werke/werkechrono.html> (accessed May 1, 2014).

¹² *PL* 40 places *De doctrina Christiana* at the head of Augustine's exegetical works.

De dialectica

*De dialectica*¹³ is Augustine's earliest treatise, in which he studies logical features of discourse and begins to investigate the idea of signification. This incomplete treatise of Augustine is "a highly intelligent (albeit compressed) rendition of Stoic semantics."¹⁴ It addresses at least four topics, which prove to be important for Augustine's evolving hermeneutical theory, in the larger context of ascent from the sensual to the intelligible world.

The first topic is the fundamental idea that words are signs. Augustine puts it this way: "Words are signs of things (*verba sint signa rerum*)."¹⁵ Although Augustine is not concerned with Scripture in *De dialectica*, his understanding of words as signs pointing to extralinguistic realities will serve as a key supposition in his theory of biblical interpretation.

By "word," Augustine means a spoken word that has both a sound and a signification. A soundless but signifying written word is a sign of a spoken word, a sign of a sign.¹⁶ To mention the sound of a word is important for semiotics, because a sign must be sensible.

¹³ The Latin text and the English translation are taken from B. D. Jackson, *Augustine: De dialectica*, Synthese Historical Library 16 (Dordrecht: D. Reidel, 1975).

¹⁴ A. A. Long, "Stoic Linguistics, Plato's *Cratylus* and Augustine's *De dialectica*," in D. Frede and B. Inwood (eds.), *Language and Learning: Philosophy of Language in the Hellenistic Age. Proceedings of the Ninth Symposium Hellenisticum* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2005), 36–55, at 55.

¹⁵ Augustine, *dial.* 5. Augustine's innovative attention on linguistic signification (i.e., on language as a system of signs) is stated by G. Manetti, *Theories of the Sign in Classical Antiquity*, trans. C. Richardson (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1993), 157; R. A. Markus, "St. Augustine on Signs," *Phronesis* 2 (1957), 60–83, at 64–5. For the *novum* of Augustine's claim that words are signs, including his fusion of semantics (meaning) and semiotics (inference), see U. Eco, *Semiotics and the Philosophy of Language*, *Advances in Semiotics* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1984), 26–34; Cary, *Outward Signs*, 17–34, 69–70.

¹⁶ Augustine, *dial.* 5. Such hierarchical understanding of the spoken and written word is both traditional and long lasting: Plato, *Phdr.* 275a–276a; Aristotle, *Int.* 16a4–6; and F. de Saussure, *Course in General Linguistics*, trans. R. Harris, ed. C. Bally et al. (Chicago, IL: Open Court, 1986, reprint 1997), 24–6.

“A sign is something which is itself sensed (*Signum est quod et se ipsum sensui*).”¹⁷ That is, as a sign, a word must have either audibility or visibility.

The semiotic approach that Augustine adopts early on has significant implications. One of them is that the fourfold scheme of *quadriga*, which came to be popular in the Middle Ages, does not become the basis of Augustine’s biblical hermeneutics. True, in *Gn. litt. imp.* 2.5, he mentions that “the four ways of expounding the law have been laid down by some scripture commentators” and lists his own *quadriga*: history, allegory, analogy, and aetiology.¹⁸ After the 390s, however, Augustine never mentions *quadriga* again, not even in *De doctrina Christiana*. The reason is fairly simple – in *scientia signorum* he found a more comprehensive system in which all possible cases of literal and figurative utterances could be considered.

Perceiving words as signs implies that what ultimately matters are not the signs (or the signs of signs), but the *res* to which signs point.¹⁹ The semiotic conviction “all words are signs” basically sets one up for looking beyond word-signs, because by definition, a sign is not isomorphic with that of which it is a sign. Hence, the second notion that words as signs point beyond themselves. Words are referential signs.²⁰ “A sign . . . indicates to the mind

¹⁷ Augustine, *dial.* 5. Although not talking about linguistic signs, Cicero contended that a sign had to be sensible (*Inv.* 1.30.48); cf. F. L. Piparo, “Aristotle: The Material Conditions of Linguistic Expressiveness,” *Versus* 50/51 (1988), 83–102. Augustine explains that words seek the “service of the voice (*ministerium vocis*)” (s. 288.3–4), which is a basic “material for words (*uox materia uerborum est*)” (*Gn. litt.* 1.15.29). In *Jo. ev. tr.* 37.4, he reiterates that, in order to communicate, the internal word requires a sensible medium, a “sound for a vehicle” (*sonum quasi uehiculum*) (cf. *doc. Chr.* 1.13.12).

¹⁸ A similar fourfold scheme is found in *util. cred.* 3.5–9, where Augustine admits that he has received such approach from the Greeks – perhaps via Valerius (M. Dulaey, “L’apprentissage de l’exégèse biblique par Augustin [3]: Années 393–394,” *Revue d’études augustiniennes et patristiques* 51 [2005], 21–65, at 23–6).

¹⁹ Cf. Augustine, *mag.* 9.25.1–2, “I want you to understand that the things signified should be valued more than their signs (*Intellegas uolo res, quae significantur, pluris quam signa esse pendendas*).”

²⁰ Augustine never said that the only thing words did was referring. He merely stated that the primary function of words was to refer. Even the kid Adeodatus

something beyond the sign itself (*Signum est quod . . . praeter se aliquid animo ostendit*).²¹

Words as signs often signify the otherwise nonaccessible entities and they do so according to the conventions in a given language. Augustine dedicates a whole chapter (*dial.* 6) to the issue of the origin of words. He basically dismisses the natural theory of names and doubts altogether in the usefulness of investigating “the cradle of words (*cunabula verborum*).”²² Like Hermogenes in Plato’s *Cratylus* and Aristotle, Augustine is convinced that, in a given language, the relation between words and things is conventional and arbitrary.²³ As he later puts it, a word signifies a *res* “not because of its nature (*natura*), but because of some kind of decision and agreement (*placito et consensione*) about what it should signify.”²⁴

The third and a related idea, which proves to be important for Augustine’s evolving hermeneutical theory, is that words as signs

understood that “it is stupid to utter a word when we don’t have anything to signify (*quando non habemus quid significemus*)” (*mag.* 2.3.28–9). Furthermore, the distinction Augustine made between the sign signifying itself (metalanguage, *verbum*) and the sign signifying an extralinguistic object (object language, *dictio*) shows clearly his awareness of the complexity of reference (*dial.* 5 and 10, *mag.* 8.23.94–109). Nevertheless, he contended that at least in their most common use, words were not self-referential, but referred to things.

²¹ Augustine, *dial.* 5.

²² The reference is to the Stoic imitative “primary sounds (*tōn prōtōn phōnōn*)” (Origen, *c. Cels.* 1.24; cf. J. Allen, “The Stoics on the Origin of Language and the Foundations of Etymology,” in *Language and Learning*, 14–35; M. Frede, “Principles of Stoic Grammar,” in J. M. Rist (ed.), *The Stoics*, Major Thinkers Series [Berkeley: University of California Press, 1978], 27–75, at 68–73; H. Ruef, *Augustin über Semiotik und Sprache: Sprachtheoretische Analysen zu Augustins Schrift “De Dialectica”* [Bern: K. J. Wyss, 1981], 117–25). While the natural theory of names purports that knowledge of reality can be gained through an analysis of (the etymological roots of) words, conventional theory is not so optimistic. For Augustine, even the *hebraica veritas*, as truth expressed in the words of a particular (conventional) language, comes short of the *Veritas*.

²³ Plato, *Crat.* 384c–d; Aristotle, *Int.* 16a20–21, 26; cf. Augustine, *doc. Chr.* 2.1.2–2.2.3, 2.20.30–2.24.37. In *dial.* 6, Augustine investigates a case where a particular *res* is “covered over (*decore*)” by a signifying word and points out that no etymological analysis can help an interpreter to discover the extralinguistic thing in the root of the word.

²⁴ Augustine, *doc. Chr.* 2.24.37.

are carriers of meaning.²⁵ Words carry something valuable; they themselves are not the treasure – just like 2 Cor 4:7 says, “We carry this treasure in earthen vessels.” To nuance his discussion of meaning, in *dial.* 5, Augustine makes a fourfold distinction between *verbum*, *dicibile*, *dictio*, and *res*. Here the two middle elements enable him to distinguish between speaker’s meaning and utterance-meaning. He explains that an uttered word or proposition carries an intelligible semantic content called *dicibile*,²⁶ which is “kept (*tenetur*)” or “contained (*continetur*)” in someone’s mind²⁷ “prior to utterance (*ante vocem*).”²⁸ Yet, an uttered word is also a *dictio* which, in turn, signifies both the *verbum* and the *dicibile*. *Dictio* is spoken “for the sake of signifying something else (*propter aliud aliquid significandum*)” (i.e., referring to the extralinguistic something rather than to itself). What is important here is that *dictio* has semantic properties in addition to those what *dicibile* provides; it has meanings beyond the intended “authorial” meanings. Long deliberates, “The words that we use in order to converse and think have meanings independently of our immediate thoughts and intentions; otherwise they would not be available to us as our lexicon.”²⁹

²⁵ *En. Ps.* 141.1; *Jo. ev. tr.* 24.5.

²⁶ *Dicibile*, if it does not concern a single word, arguably corresponds to the Stoic *lekton* (Diogenes Laertius 7.63; Sextus Empiricus, *M.* 8.12, 70; M. Frede, “The Stoic Notion of a *Lekton*,” in S. Everson [ed.], *Language: Companions to Ancient Thought*: 3 [Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1994], 109–28; Long, “Stoic Linguistics, Plato’s *Cratylus* and Augustine’s *De dialectica*,” 36–55; G. Verbeke, “Meaning and Role of the Expressible [*lekton*] in Stoic Logic,” in G. Manetti [ed.], *Knowledge Through Signs: Ancient Semiotic Theories and Practices*, Semiotic and Cognitive Studies 2 [Bologna: Brepols, 1996], 133–54).

²⁷ *Dicibile* is a possible prototype for Augustine’s *verbum in corde*, which came to be one of his favorite expressions for internal speech or (always linguistically constituted) thinking (cf. Wisdom 2:1; Plato, *Theaet.* 189e–190a; Augustine, *civ. Dei* 7.14; *conf.* 1.6.10; *doc. Chr.* 1.13; 2.3.4; *mag.* 1.2.71–6; *s.* 225.3; *Trin.* 15.10.17–19).

²⁸ Since Augustine also says that *dicibile* is “what is understood in the word (*quod in verbo intellegitur*),” the point is not that *dicibile* denotes the intelligible content only *before* its being uttered, but rather that it concerns something which is perceived by a rational mind.

²⁹ Long, “Stoic Linguistics, Plato’s *Cratylus* and Augustine’s *De dialectica*,” 55.

In case of written texts, including Scripture, an exegete has to interpret the referential *diciones* through which the authorial *dicibilia* may or may not be accessible.

The fourth idea mentioned in *De dialectica* is that words as signs are ambiguous and obscure.³⁰ Naturally, this posits particular “hindrances (*impedimenta*)” for interpreters and does it differently in both cases.³¹ Augustine carefully distinguishes the two “hindering phenomena” from each other, yet limits his discussion mostly to ambiguity.

Ancient rhetoricians paid much attention to ambiguity coming from intentional ambivalence (*voluntas*) and relatively less attention to ambiguity coming from the natural linguistic properties of a text (*scriptum*).³² In the case of the hermeneutical theory for Scripture, however, the reverse has to be the case. While, for obvious reasons, intentional and especially deliberately misleading ambiguity is relatively irrelevant for interpreting Scripture,³³ ambiguity coming from the natural linguistic properties of a text demands a serious consideration. Before the abrupt ending of *De dialectica*, Augustine takes up the specific case of ambiguity that “is found only in writings (*in scriptis solis*).”³⁴ Indeed, reading a text, an interpreter obviously faces special difficulties, because written texts lack the additional ambiguity-reducing devices, such as intonation, gesticulation, pauses in articulation, and the immediacy of the conversational context. Unfortunately, Augustine managed to write only one paragraph about the three kinds of ambiguities caused “by either the length of syllables, or by accent, or by both.” A bit earlier, however, he already mentioned at least one important remedy for

³⁰ Cf. Diogenes Laertius 7.62.; Gellius, *Noct. Att.* 11.12.1–3; Quintilian, *Inst.* 8.2.12–16. For closer analysis of ambiguity and obscurity in *dial.* 8–10, see Ruef, *Augustin über Semiotik und Sprache*, 145–57; T. Toom, “Augustine on Ambiguity,” *Augustinian Studies* 38/2 (2008), 407–33, at 409–19.

³¹ Augustine, *dial.* 8. ³² E.g., Aristotle, *Rhet.* 3.4.5 (1407a); Quintilian, *Inst.* 7.9.

³³ However, see the analysis of Acts 17:22 in M. D. Given, *Paul's True Rhetoric: Ambiguity, Cunning, and Deception in Greece and Rome* (Philadelphia: Trinity Press International, 2001), 68–70.

³⁴ Augustine, *dial.* 10.

ambiguity. Whether in speech or writing, an ambiguous word “becomes clear by a statement (*per sententiam clarescat*) in which it occurs.”³⁵ That is, the particular literary context helps at least to reduce the ambiguity of a given word or statement.

De magistro

Augustine’s elenctic dialogue *De magistro*³⁶ was composed in 389 CE and it was based on the discussion between a rather proud father Augustine and his talented son Adeodatus.³⁷ It is a dialectical exercise, a *pro* and *contra* discussion of precisely how words as signs function in one’s gaining of knowledge,³⁸ and another relatively early treatise, besides the unfinished *De dialectica*, which addresses the issue of linguistic signification in any significant way.

For Augustine’s hermeneutical theory, *De magistro* is relevant for several reasons. To begin with, Augustine reaffirms his basic semi-otic conviction – “words are signs (*uerba signa esse*)”³⁹ – and asserts again that written words are “signs of words (*signa uerborum*).”⁴⁰ The ensuing discussion shows that Augustine extends the function of signification to every little word, even to conjunctions and

³⁵ *Dial.* 9.

³⁶ The Latin text is that of *CCL* 29, *Pars* II.2, ed. W. M. Green (Turnhout: Brepols, 1970); English translation is from *Augustine: Against the Academics and the Teacher*, trans. P. King (Indianapolis, IN: Hackett, 1995).

³⁷ Augustine, *b. vita* 1.6; *conf.* 9.6.14.

³⁸ Already in one of his earliest treatises, in *sol.* 2.14, Augustine asserts that “truth cannot be better pursued than by question and answer.” In *mag.* 10.31.72–3, he recommends a Skeptic methodology (Cicero, *Orat.* 3.21.80) in which “easy and ready approval” of something should always be undermined by “contrary arguments (*contrariis disputationibus*)” (cf. Augustine, *c. Faust.* 11.5).

³⁹ While before the Fall, God illuminated the human mind internally and directly, after the Fall, any teaching requires the mediation of human words (Augustine, *Gn. adv. Man.* 2.5.6; cf. *en. Ps.* 103[1].8; Bochet, “*Le firmament de l'Écriture*,” 37–9). However, see *Gn. lit.* 8.18.37; 8.27.49–50 and 11.33.43, as well as the objections of J. C. Davies, “Augustine on Original Cognition,” *Augustinian Studies* 40/2 (2009), 251–76.

⁴⁰ Augustine, *mag.* 2.3.1 (cf. 7.19.12–13) and 4.8.35–6 (cf. 4.8.62–3).

prepositions,⁴¹ as they stand either for a thing or for a state of mind.⁴² Next, in *mag.* 4.8.35–6, he offers a definition that he repeats several times⁴³ and that depicts word-signs as carriers of meaning: “A word is that which is uttered by means of an articulated sound⁴⁴ accompanied by some significate (*ut uerbum sit, quod cum aliquo significatu articulata uoce profertur*).”⁴⁵ He does not mention the term *dicibile*

⁴¹ *Mag.* 4.9.127; 5.15.154. cf. *Gn. litt.* 8.16.34. Being perfectly aware of the difference between a word (*verbum*) and a phrase (*locutio*) (*doc. Chr.* 2.14.21; cf. *dial.* 1–2, which considers first simple words [*verba simplicia*] and then the combined words [*verba coniuncta*]), in *mag.* 2.3.13–2.4.66, Augustine nevertheless discusses the signification of some syncategorematic words which occur in a sentence taken from Vergil, *Aeneid* 2.659, such as “if (*si*),” “nothing (*nihil*),” and “from (*ex*)” (cf. *mag.* 7.19.16–30). Stoics had claimed that every syntactic category had its semantic counterpart and signification in addition to that of a proposition itself (Diogenes Laertius 7.58, 71–4; Frede, “Principles of Stoic Grammar,” 59–67; J. M. Rist, *Augustine: Ancient Faith Baptized* [Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1994], 26–30, 314–16. The grammatical background of Augustine’s deliberation is assessed in *La signification et l’enseignement: texte latin, traduction française et commentaire du De magistro de Saint Augustin*, ed. and trans. E. Bermon, *Textes et Traditions* 15 [Paris: Librairie Philosophique J. Vrin, 2007], 166–9, and syncategorematic words on pp. 195–218). Since Augustine may have brought up the idea of the signification of syncategorematic words for the sake of dialectical argumentation, a caution is needed before this idea is ascribed to him as his “final” position and then condemned as an unfortunate philosophical misunderstanding of language (e.g., by C. Kirwan, “Augustine’s Philosophy of Language,” in E. Stump and N. Kretzmann (eds.), *The Cambridge Companion to Augustine* [Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2001], 186–204; M. J. Sirridge, “Augustine: Every Word Is a Name,” *The New Scholasticism* 50 [1976], 183–92; L. Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations*, trans. G. E. M. Anscombe, 3rd ed. [Engelwood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice Hall, 1958], nos. 1 and 13).

⁴² Augustine, *mag.* 2.3.38–41; cf. Aristotle, *Int.* 164a–9; *Soph. Elenc.* 165a7–8. Marius Victorinus mediated for the western reader not only Aristotle’s *Categories*, but also his *De Interpretatione* (Cassiodorus, *Inst.* 2.3.18), which was lost very early.

⁴³ Augustine, *mag.* 4.9.82–6; 4.10.143–4; 5.11.23–4; 5.12.32–3; 5.12.47–8.

⁴⁴ Cf. *mag.* 7.20.60–61. Articulated sounds are also distinguished from inarticulate noises in *mag.* 10.34.136 and *quant.* 32.65–6.

⁴⁵ Cf. Aristotle, *Poet.* 1457a; Diogenes Laertius 7.57; Sextus Empiricus, *M.* 8.80; Augustine, *ord.* 2.34–5. For contrast, in *mag.* 8.23.88–9, Augustine mentions sounds “without any signification (*sine ulla significatione*).” Later, in *s.* 288.3, he explains to his congregation again that a sound without an intelligible content is a mere noise. “A word, however, unless it signifies something, unless it carries something to the ears and something else further in to the mind, is not called a

here, but the “accompanying significate” clearly refers to the intelligible content of an utterance. The important thing is that by acknowledging the existence of a mediating mental entity (i.e., the intelligible content of an utterance) between words and things, Augustine postulates a semiotic triangle of words/thoughts/things.⁴⁶ After that, Augustine elaborates on yet another semiotic triangle, with some twists and turns, between “name (*nomen*),” “word (*uerbum*),” and “thing (*res*),” which secures the distinction between metalanguage and object language, between a sign signifying itself and the thing.⁴⁷

Augustine also does not forget to bring up the topic of ambiguity of signs yet again. This time he makes some observations about gesticulation⁴⁸ that show that not only linguistic signs (i.e., words) but any kind of signs are ambiguous.⁴⁹

Augustine’s real interest, however, is in the cases where signs signify things, and not themselves or other signs. In the middle of his treatise, Augustine signals the intended direction of the rest of the discussion by proposing, “Let’s consider the division [of signs] where signs do not signify other signs but instead things, which we call ‘signifiables’ (*cum signis non alia signa significatur, sed ea, quae*

word (*uerbum autem, nisi aliquid significet, nisi aliud ad aures ferat, aliud menti inferat, uerbum non dicitur*).”

⁴⁶ This is just one of the semiotic triangles that Augustine investigates. Arguably, in order to overcome the stalemate position reached in Plato’s *Cratylus*, it was Aristotle who first added a new element of mental experiences (*pathēmata tēs psychēs*) to the elements of spoken words and an object (L. De Cuyper and K. Willems, “Meaning and Reference in Aristotle’s Concept of the Linguistic Sign,” *Foundations of Science* 13 [2008], 307–24, at 314 and 318).

⁴⁷ Augustine, *mag.* 4.9.91–102, cf. 4.10.139–41, 152–3; 6.18.36–7; 10.34.142; Bermon, *La signification et l’enseignement*, 243–57; K. Kahnert, *Entmachtung der Zeichen? Augustin über Sprache*, *Bochumer Studien zur Philosophie* 29 (Amsterdam: B. R. Grüner, 2000), 86–7.

⁴⁸ “Gestures themselves are signs (*eosdem . . . gestus signa esse*)” (Augustine, *mag.* 7.19.33–4; cf. *ord.* 2.34).

⁴⁹ More particularly, Augustine assesses the ambiguity of ostensive definition (*mag.* 3.5.7–3.6.53; 10.34.140–55) as well as a question of whether a given action qualifies as walking or hurrying (*mag.* 3.6.53–73; cf. 10.29.9–17).

significabilia nominamus).”⁵⁰ As one can see, the focus will be almost entirely on the functioning of words as signs in one's gaining of knowledge of things.

An insight emerging from the interplay between the two theses of *De magistro* is particularly important for Augustine's hermeneutical theory, as well as for the epistemology it presupposes. The first thesis contends, “I see nothing, therefore, that can be shown without signs (*Nihil itaque uideo, quod sine signis ostendi queat*).”⁵¹ The second thesis contends that “nothing is learned through its signs (*nihil . . . per sua signa discatur*).”⁵² These two theses enable Augustine to bring out a paradox that nothing is shown or taught without signs and, at the same time, nothing is learned by means of them alone.⁵³ Applied to hermeneutics, although communication often makes use of verbal signs (i.e., words), these signs, by themselves, do not teach anything, unless the thing they signify is known by other means and beforehand. As Augustine puts it, “A sign is learned when the thing is known, rather than the thing being learned when the sign is given (*magis signum re cognita quam signo*

⁵⁰ *Mag.* 8.22.25–7. Adeodatus concedes almost immediately, “I do agree with you that we can't carry on a conversation at all unless the words we hear direct the mind to the things of which they are signs (*nisi auditis uerbis ad ea feratur animus, quorum ista sunt signa*)” (*mag.* 8.22.72–4; cf. 8.23.86–7; 8.24.150). Bermon explains that the word “signifiable” simply means a signified thing that is not used as a further sign (*La signification et l'enseignement*, 261).

⁵¹ Stated by Adeodatus in *mag.* 3.6.51–2 (cf. 3.6.73, 10.29.4–5) and confirmed by father Augustine in 10.31.49–50.

⁵² *Mag.* 10.33.114–15; cf. 10.34.154–5; 12.40.59–60. Identifying no fewer than ten hypotheses in *De magistro*, Schultess nevertheless highlights the prime importance of the two seemingly contradictory theses (Hypotheses 4 and 7) (P. Schultess, “Sprechen, Erkennen und Lehren/Lernen in *De Magistro*,” in T. Fuhrer (ed.), *Augustinus. De Magistro – Der Lehrer*, Augustinus Opera/Werke 11 [Paderborn: Ferdinand Schöningh, 2002], 26–82, at 41–2).

⁵³ In *mag.* 3.6.60, Augustine raises the problem that if one is completely ignorant of something, then how can he/she be taught about this thing? It is a hint at Meno's paradox (Plato, *Meno* 80d–e), which Augustine reformulates in *mag.* 10.33.115: “When a sign is given to me, it can teach me nothing if it finds me ignorant of the thing of which it is the sign; but if I'm not ignorant, what do I learn through the sign? (*Cum enim mihi signum datur, si nescientem me inuenerit, cuius rei signum sit, docere me nihil potest, si uero scientem, quid disco per signum?*)”

dato ipsa res discitur).⁵⁴ He offers an example from Dn 3:94 (Vulgate). The word *sarabara* is a sign of something, but in order to understand the word's signification, one has to have at least some knowledge of the *res* called *sarabara*.⁵⁵ Said differently, one cannot recognize a sign as a sign of something unless one knows what this something is.⁵⁶ Notably, such epistemological consideration determines the order in which topics are discussed in Augustine's textbook on scriptural interpretation, in *De doctrina Christiana* (see the following). The reason is apparent – "signs cannot make intelligible things intelligible to us."⁵⁷

To respond to a further problem, raised by the second thesis, of how things can be known before words signify them, Augustine postulates (a sketch) of his theory of illumination in the very end of his *De magistro*. He claims that understanding, "getting it," is something internal; it cannot be brought about by the external, sensible things, including the use of words. What provides the true knowledge of things is the mental "seeing," the interior enlightenment by Christ.⁵⁸ Christ as light enables the mind's "eye" to have the intellectual vision of truth.⁵⁹ Consequently, "People can produce

⁵⁴ Augustine, *mag.* 10.33.132–3; cf. *Trin.* 10.1.2.

⁵⁵ The confusion about the spelling of the word *sarabara* in the ancient manuscripts "makes it brutally clear, that if a sign is to be worth anything in language, one must be able to refer it . . . to a thing" (L. G. Kelly, "Saint Augustine and Saussurean Linguistics," *Augustinian Studies* 6 [1975], 45–64, at 55).

⁵⁶ For Stoics, who believed in the revelatory character of signs, such an assertion was absurd (Sextus Empiricus, *M.* 8.167). By juxtaposing the respective epistemologies in columns, Kahnert helpfully highlights the differences between the empiricist Stoics and a Platonist Augustine (Kahnert, *Entmachtung der Zeichen?*, 44–5, 62–3).

⁵⁷ This is a memorable phrase of Phillip Cary (*Outward Signs*, 4, 6, 43, 88).

⁵⁸ "Words prompt us to consult [Him] (*uerbis . . . ut consulamus admoniti*)" (*mag.* 11.38.46), the "Inner Truth (*interiorem ueritatem*)" (*mag.* 12.39.5; cf. 12.40.48–73; *c. Acad.* 3.6.13; *div. qu.* 9; *doc. Chr.* 1.9.9; *en. Ps.* 26[2].15; *Gn. adv. Man.* 2.4.5; *retr.* 1.12; *sol.* 1.8.15). While interpreting the very beginning of the Book of Genesis, in *conf.* 12, Augustine uses at least seven times the phrase "[the Lord says] in a loud voice to my inner ear."

⁵⁹ Schulthess, "Sprechen, Erkennen und Lehren/Lernen in *De Magistro*," 73–8. Augustine elaborates, "When we deal with things that we perceive by the mind (*mente*) . . . we're speaking of things that we look upon immediately in the inner

some reminder by means of verbal signs (*signis uerborum*). But the one true teacher, the incorruptible truth, the sole interior teacher, does the teaching (*docet . . . solus magister interior*).⁶⁰ In *en. Ps.* 118 (17).3, Augustine stresses that humans “cannot do what the Lord did, for the gospel tells us, *Then he opened their minds to understand the scriptures (tunc aperuit eis sensum, ut intellegent scripturas, Lk 24:45)*. . . . [The disciples] took in what he said only because he had opened their minds (*aperuit*) and enabled them to do so.” After all, it is God who “gives wisdom (*sapientiam*), and from his face there is knowledge and understanding (*scientia et intellectus*).”⁶¹

What is then the main insight that emerges from the interplay between the two theses of *De magistro*? The insight is that both words and things are somehow involved in one's gaining of knowledge.⁶² The first thesis is deconstructed in the first half of *De magistro*⁶³ and the second thesis does not stand unmodified in its exclusiveness for long either. After all, if nothing – nothing at all – is learned through its signs, then whole dialogue would be rather pointless and Adeodatus would not be edified at all by the words of his father. So there seems to be a bit more to signs than their blunt uselessness. In *mag.* 14.46.17–18, Augustine promises indeed that

light of truth (*in . . . interiore luce ueritatis*)” (*mag.* 12.40.30–33; cf. *Gn. litt.* 12.31.59; *Jo. ev. tr.* 15.19; 26.7).

⁶⁰ *C. ep. Man.* 36.41. ⁶¹ Prov 2:6, cited in Augustine, *doc. Chr.* 3.37.56.

⁶² Ferretter assesses that Augustine came to think “simultaneously of the inner light of knowledge and of the proliferating series of signs” (L. Ferretter, “The Trace of the Trinity: Christ and Difference in Saint Augustine's Theory of Language,” *Journal of Literature & Theology* 12/3 [1998], 256–67, at 262).

⁶³ Countering the first thesis, Augustine immediately begins his elenctic investigation into whether certain things “can be pointed out without signs (*sine signis*)” (*mag.* 4.7.2; cf. 7.20.46). He proceeds in a way very similar to *Contra Academicos*, where he attempted to demonstrate that at least some cases of certain knowledge could be established (starting from *c. Acad.* 3.9.21). Analogically, Augustine raises doubts about the credibility of his first thesis by giving an example of how the purposes of a birdcatcher's instruments were learned by observing a man in a wordless action. Then he summarizes, “It's surely enough for the matter at hand that some men can be taught about some things . . . without sign (*satis est namque ad rem et de quibusdam rebus . . . et quosdam homines doceri posse sine signo*)” (*mag.* 10.32.96–7, 102–3).

one day he will return to “the whole [problem] of the usefulness of words (*de tota utilitate uerborum*).” No good reason seems to be available to exclude the possibility that this promise materializes in *De doctrina Christiana*, which partially rehabilitates the first thesis of *De magistro*, the contention that words teach at least something. In this treatise, Augustine argues for the usefulness of word-signs in getting to know the divine things. He points out that words direct one’s attention and initiate an access to things. Words do not impart knowledge, but they provide one a stimulus to discover the knowledge of things; they provide an occasion to learn.⁶⁴ “Words have force only to the extent that they remind us to look for things (*hactenus uerba ualuerunt . . . admonent tantum, ut quaeramus res*).”⁶⁵ “Instructions from outside are kinds of aids and suggestions (*adiutoria . . . et admonitiones*).”⁶⁶ As is evident, Augustine calls such teachable moments in which one is exhorted to turn away from the sensible realm toward the intelligible realm *admonitiones*.⁶⁷

Augustine concludes his discussion in *De magistro* as if with a programmatic statement for his forthcoming treatise on scriptural interpretation: “He himself will teach us . . . He Who prompts us externally through men by means of signs (*a quo etiam per homines signis admonemur foris*) [i.e., Scripture], so that we are instructed to be inwardly (*intro*) turned toward Him.”⁶⁸

⁶⁴ Burnyeat explains, “The argument will not be that information cannot be transmitted from one person to another, but that the appreciation or understanding of any such information is a task that each person must work at himself . . . We still describe the moment when this is achieved as a moment of illumination” (M. F. Burnyeat, “Wittenstein and Augustine *De magistro*,” in *The Proceedings of the Aristotelian Society*, supp. vol. 61 [Cambridge: The Aristotelian Society, 1987], 1–24, at 8 and 21). So also A. Hoffmann, “Hermeneutische Fragen,” in V. H. Drecoll (ed.), *Augustin Handbuch* (Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 2007), 461–70, at 467.

⁶⁵ Augustine, *mag.* 11.36.1–2; cf. 10.34.149–54; 10.35.170; 14.46.34–7. A concrete example of how Augustine’s own words prompt his son to comprehend something is found in *mag.* 5.14.121–4.

⁶⁶ *Ep. Jo.* 3.13.

⁶⁷ G. Madec, “*Admonitio*,” in C. Mayer (ed.), *Augustinus-Lexikon* (Basel: Schwabe, 1986–1994), vol. I, 95–9.

⁶⁸ Augustine, *mag.* 14.46.23–5.

De doctrina Christiana

Arguably, Augustine was the first to apply the idea of words being signs extensively to the task of interpreting Scripture.⁶⁹ He took on this task in *De doctrina Christiana*,⁷⁰ which was composed seven years after *De magistro* and finished in 426 or 427 CE. It is a textbook on hermeneutical theory and praxis, on ascertaining the proper meaning of Scripture and communicating it.⁷¹ The Prologue to *De doctrina Christiana* begins with what may be called a statement of intent: "There are certain rules for interpreting the scriptures (*praecepta quaedam tractandarum scripturarum*) . . . It is my intention to communicate these rules."⁷² That is, Augustine's hermeneutical *praecepta* were devised for opening up "the hidden secrets of the divine literature (*divinarum litterarum opera*)."⁷³ Supposedly, one should take these rules as a *magister's* finger-pointing gestures in *mag.* 10.34.149–54 that direct one's attention to how Scripture, a special set of word-signs, operates.⁷⁴

In *doc. Chr.* 1.2.2, Augustine proposed a simple division of the subject matter that suited for his textbook-like discussion: "All

⁶⁹ B. D. Jackson, "The Theory of Signs in St. Augustine's *De doctrina Christiana*," *Revue des Études Augustiniennes* 15 (1969), 9–49, at 28, 30, and 49; Jackson, "Semantics and Hermeneutics," 191–3.

⁷⁰ The Latin text and the English translation, sometimes modified, are taken from *Augustine: De Doctrina Christiana*, ed. and trans. R. P. H. Green, Oxford Early Christian Texts (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1995).

⁷¹ As such, the treatise is divided between *modus inveniendi* and *modus proferendi* (*doc. Chr.* 1.1.1; 2.37.55; 3.37.56; 4.1.1); cf. Theophrastus, *Frag.* 1 (A. Graeser [ed.], *Die logischen Fragmente des Theophrast*, Kleine Texte für Vorlesungen und Übungen [Berlin: Walter de Gruyter, 1973], 4). The former corresponds to books 1 to 3 and the latter to book 4. However, while Eugippius' *Excerpta* 246–74 ignored Book Four of *De doctrina Christiana*, in the fifteenth century, it was nevertheless printed separately under the title *De arte predicandi* (F. Van Fleteren, "*De doctrina Christiana*," in *The Oxford Guide to the Historical Reception of Augustine*, vol. I, 285a–291b, at 287a–b).

⁷² Augustine, *doc. Chr.* Prol. 1. ⁷³ Ibid.

⁷⁴ *Doc. Chr.* Prol. 3. In Augustine's s. 288.1, John the Baptist, "pointing him [i.e., Christ] out with his finger," provides a comparison to the words of Scripture which point to the intelligible divine things.

teaching is teaching of either things or signs (*Omnis doctrina uel rerum est uel signorum*).⁷⁵ In a mirror image of the two-part structure of *De magistro*, “things” are considered in book 1 of *De doctrina Christiana*, and “signs” in books 2 and 3.⁷⁶ In fact, Augustine had a good epistemological reason to begin with the *res* of Scripture, with the “big picture,” because words in Scripture make sense only when that which they point to is known.

However, in *doc. Chr.* 1.2.2, he also reasserts a slightly modified first thesis of *De magistro*: “But things are learnt through signs (*sed res per signa discuntur*).” He clarifies that by signs he means words. “Nobody uses words except in order to signify something (*Nemo enim utitur verbis nisi aliquid significandi gratia*).” Since Augustine is going to consider a linguistic entity (i.e., Scripture), he obviously needs to emphasize the usefulness of word-signs.⁷⁷ In fact, his task is semiotic – “to ascertain what is eternal and spiritual from corporeal and temporal things (*ut de corporalibus temporalibusque rebus aeterna et spiritalia capiamus*).”⁷⁸ Thus, while the second thesis of *De magistro* is never given up,⁷⁹ the first thesis – the usefulness of sensible signs in getting to know something – is nevertheless emphatically affirmed. Such tight coexistence of the seemingly contrary theses in the very beginning of book 1 suggests again that

⁷⁵ Cf. Cicero, *Orat.* 3.5.19; Quintilian, *Inst.* 3.3.1; 3.5.1.

⁷⁶ Augustine, *doc. Chr.* 1.40.44; 2.1.1.

⁷⁷ A theological qualification, which affirms the usefulness of the sensible, takes its lead from the incarnation of Christ. Augustine addresses this principal analogy between the visible flesh of Christ and the audible/visible words in Scripture in *doc. Chr.* 1.11.11–13.12. Both the humanity of Christ and Scripture were to be “used” as pointers to the corresponding higher realities which were to be “enjoyed” (1.3.3–1.35.39). For the important differences between the signification of word-signs and the flesh of Christ, see Cameron, *Christ Meets Me Everywhere*, 228–38.

⁷⁸ Augustine, *doc. Chr.* 1.4.4; cf. *Rm* 1:20. Humankind’s postlapsarian attachment to the sensible (“the habits and inclinations of the soul to enjoy what is inferior [*consuetudines et inclinationes animae ad fruendum inferioribus*] [*doc. Chr.* 1.24.24]) “required” God to operate through the sensible (1.34.38). “The whole temporal dispensation was set up by divine providence for our salvation (*facta est tota pro nostra salute per divinam providentiam dispensatio temporalis*)” (*doc. Chr.* 1.35.39).

⁷⁹ Augustine, *doc. Chr.* Prol. 2 and 8; Kahnert, *Entmachtung der Zeichen?*, 111–14.

both illumination and signification have their respective epistemic functions. In a hermeneutical “synergy,” the former provides the first-hand knowledge (*scientia*) and the latter, through authoritative witness, the secondhand belief that leads to knowledge.⁸⁰

Very well, but what is the *res* toward which the scriptural word-signs point? In order to figure out what linguistic signs refer to, patristic exegetes attempted first to ascertain the overall reference of Scripture.⁸¹ Augustine, too, began with ascertaining the reference of Scripture, by focusing on “the things which are objects of our faith (*de rebus continentibus fidem*).”⁸² A brief analysis of the articles of the creed in *doc. Chr.* 1.5.5–1.21.19,⁸³ which cover God’s salvific activity in the incarnated Christ, leads to an even briefer summary of what Scripture is all about: “a double love of God and one’s neighbor (*dilectio et ea gemina, id est dei et proximi*)” (Mt 22:37–40).⁸⁴ Such summation has an enormous hermeneutical significance, because if the double commandment of love is the *skopos* of Scripture, then

⁸⁰ Augustine, *mag.* 11.37.32–43; cf. *retr.* 1.13. *Nisi credideritis, non intelletis* (Is 7:9 [LXX]) is quoted again in *doc. Chr.* 2.12.17.

⁸¹ Young contends that “ascertaining reference was far more fundamental to patristic exegesis than determining the sense of words” (F. M. Young, *Biblical Exegesis and the Formation of Christian Culture* [Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1997], 117).

⁸² Augustine, *doc. Chr.* 1.40.44.

⁸³ G. Istace, “Le livre 1er du *De doctrina christiana* de saint Augustin,” *Ephemerides Theologicae Lovanienses* 32 (1956), 289–330, at 297–8. A creed (and/or *regula fidei*) is supposed to function as one’s theological preunderstanding in understanding the things to what Scripture refers. For example, in *Gn. litt. imp.* 1.2–4, and before he exegetes the Book of Genesis, Augustine states his catholic faith. Likewise, in *Trin.* 1.7, Augustine affirms the *regula fidei* and only then begins to assess the scriptural data which, at times, is ambiguous. The *regula* does not provide a “correct” interpretation, but it certainly excludes incorrect interpretations (e.g., *civ. Dei* 15.26).

⁸⁴ *Doc. Chr.* 1.26.27; cf. 1.22.21; 1.30.32–3; 1.35.39; 2.7.10; 3.10.15–16; I. Bochet and G. Madec, “Herménétique platonicienne ou herménétique chrétienne?,” in *La doctrine chrétienne/De doctrina Christiana*, Oeuvres de Saint Augustin 11/2 (Paris: Institut d’Études Augustiniennes, 1997), 471–3; H.-J. Sieben, “Die ‘res’ der Bibel: Eine Analyse von Augustinus, *De doctr. christ.* I–III,” *Revue des Études Augustiniennes* 21 (1975), 72–90, at 72–80.

everything in it has to be interpreted in accordance with this.⁸⁵ Any interpretation that fails “to build up this double love of God and neighbor (*non aedificet istam geminam caritatem dei et proximi*)” is ultimately a misinterpretation – even if it seems to conform to the (humanly) intended meaning of a passage.⁸⁶ In fact, Augustine’s rule is a wonderful test for the adequacy of possible interpretations: if these promote love, they are right even if these interpretations are less than perfect in secondary, technical matters. Expressed differently, one has understood Scripture correctly only if his/her conduct and activities promote *caritas*.⁸⁷ Modern hermeneutics calls the final phase, which shows whether something is actually understood or not, “application” or “appropriation.”⁸⁸

After explaining what Scripture is all about, in books 2 and 3, Augustine assesses various kinds of word-signs and how they are to be interpreted. The more theoretical aspects of *scientia signorum* are discussed in *doc. Chr.* 2.1.1–2.5.6 and this provides the foundation for the subsequent discussion.

To begin with, Augustine offers another definition of signs: “A sign is a thing which of itself makes some other thing come to mind, besides the impression that it presents to the senses (*Signum est . . . res praeter speciem*⁸⁹ *quam ingerit sensibus aliud aliquid ex se faciens in*

⁸⁵ E.g., Rm 13:10; Augustine, *cat. rud.* 4.8; *doc. Chr.* 3.12.20; *en. Ps.* 103(1).9; 140.2; Pollmann, *Doctrina Christiana*, 121–47. Since the divine intention captured in the “double commandment” provides the larger context in which everything in Scripture needs to be interpreted, it “overrules” the humanly intended meanings of any canonical utterance. Already Aristotle taught that the whole (*to holon*) had to be given a priority over the part (*to meros*) (*Rhet.* 1.13.18).

⁸⁶ Augustine, *doc. Chr.* 1.36.40–37.41; cf. 1.40.44; 3.27.38.

⁸⁷ Since *caritas* includes the concern for the physical, moral, and spiritual good of the other, it can never be twisted into justifying sin. Augustine’s *De fide et operibus* makes a wonderful commentary on this point.

⁸⁸ H.-G. Gadamer, *Truth and Method*, 2nd ed., trans. J. Weinsheimer and D. G. Marshall (New York: Crossroad, 1989), 307–41; P. Ricoeur, *Interpretation Theory: Discourse and the Surplus of Meaning* (Fort Worth: Texas Christian University Press, 1976), 43–4, 91–5; D. Simon, “*Ad Regnum Caritatis: The Finality of Biblical Interpretation in Augustine and Ricoeur*,” *Augustinian Studies* 30/1 (1999), 105–27.

⁸⁹ *Species* is a technical term that corresponds to the Greek epistemological concept of “appearance” or “impression” (*phantasia*). In *Gn. adv. Man.* 2.20.30, Augustine

cogitationem venire).”⁹⁰ In order to get from this definition to the words of Scripture, Augustine eliminates “natural signs (*signa naturalia*),” including physiognomic signs, and focuses exclusively on linguistic “given signs (*signa data*).”⁹¹ While “natural signs” are given “without a wish or urge to signify (*sine voluntate atque ullo appetitu significandi*),” “given signs” occur because the sign-giver has something in his/her mind that is then deliberately communicated through the use of a particular language.⁹² Words, the linguistic signs, “have gained an altogether dominant role among humans in signifying the ideas conceived by the mind (*significandi quaecumque animo concipiuntur*) that a person wants (*velit*) to reveal.”⁹³ “Given signs” are intentional signs, and Scripture – the *litteras Dei* – consists of such intentional signs.⁹⁴

A major complication here is that Scripture is a double-authored text. Therefore, Augustine immediately adds, “The divinely given

admits that “it is also through them [i.e., sensible impressions (*phantasmatibus*)] that instruction about truth enters in.” In other words, through the sensible *phantasia/species* a sign-receiver perceives that which is not evident to senses – the intelligible content of signs (L. Spruit, *Species intelligibilis: From Perception to Knowledge*, vol. I, Brill’s Studies in Intellectual History 48 [Leiden: Brill, 1994], 179–86).

⁹⁰ Augustine, *doc. Chr.* 2.1.1; cf. 2.2.3; 2.3.4. In *mag.* 2.3.38–41, Augustine mentioned the correspondence between words and states of mind. Accordingly, and like previous definitions, this definition in *doc. Chr.* 2.1.1, too, includes the semiotic triangle of word/mind/thing.

⁹¹ *Doc. Chr.* 2.1.2. The whole *scientia signorum* is really concerned with the special case of the *signa data*. Augustine did not study signs as such either for their own sake or for the sake of developing a full-blown semiotic theory. That would have qualified as “curiosity.” Instead, he was interested in signs only “as far as words are concerned (*quantum ad verba pertinet*)” (2.14.21) and how they signify the intelligible realities in Scripture. The art of “defining, dividing and partitioning (*in definiendo neque in dividendo aut partiendo*)” enabled him to eliminate irrelevant topics (2.35.53).

⁹² *Doc. Chr.* 2.1.2. Because words as “given signs” always exist in a particular language, they are also conventional (cf. 2.24.37–2.35.38).

⁹³ *Doc. Chr.* 2.3.4; cf. *mag.* 1.2.45–7, “Anyone who speaks gives an external sign of his will by means of an articulated sound (*suae uoluntatis signum foras dat per articulatum sonum*).”

⁹⁴ *En. Ps.* 73.5.

signs (*signa divinitus data*) contained in the holy scripture⁹⁵ have been communicated to us by the human beings who wrote them.”⁹⁶ The conviction that, in the case of Scripture, God’s intention is primary has major hermeneutical implications, of course. The first is that without ever denying the importance of the human authorial intention,⁹⁷ the existing double intentionality nevertheless prevents it from being the ultimate hermeneutical criterion. What matters most in interpreting Scripture, the Word of God, is what God intends to say. Accordingly, one’s aim should be “to find out the thoughts and wishes of those by whom it was written down and, through them, the will of God (*voluntatem dei*), which we believe these men followed as they spoke.”⁹⁸ Second, the meaning of a scriptural utterance cannot be restricted to the humanly intended historical meaning in the original context of an utterance, because the Spirit of God may intend meanings beyond it to people in other circumstances and times.⁹⁹

Next, Augustine divides the *signa data* according to the senses through which they are perceived. He singles out signs that are directed to hearing, among which words constitute the largest subgroup. With words one is able to give an account of all the other kinds of sign and thus words constitute a fundamental

⁹⁵ The phrase “holy scripture,” in which God’s will is to be sought, means the canonical books (*doc. Chr.* 2.9.14; cf. 2.8.12–13).

⁹⁶ *Doc. Chr.* 2.2.3 (cf. Jer 36:6); cf. *civ. Dei* 18.41; *en. Ps.* 30(2).2; *mag.* 14.46.23–5. In *doc. Chr.* 3.7.11 and 3.9.13, Augustine also uses the phrase “divinely instituted sign (*signum divinitus institutum*).” For the double intentionality, see T. Toom, “Was Augustine an Intentionalist? Authorial Intention in Augustine’s Hermeneutics,” *Studia Patristica* 70/18 (2013), 185–93.

⁹⁷ Augustine, *doc. Chr.* 1.36.41; 2.12.18; 2.13.19; 3.27.38.

⁹⁸ *Doc. Chr.* 2.5.6; cf. 3.1.1; *civ. Dei* 16.2; *conf.* 12.23.32, 32.43; 13.15.16; *en. Ps.* 36 (3).2; 77.5; 103(1).8. Hence the subtitle of this chapter – “The Science of the Divinely Given Signs.” For the Platonic interest in the intended hidden sense, see J. A. Coulter, *The Literary Microcosm: Theories of Interpretation of the Later Neoplatonists*, Columbia Studies in the Classical Tradition 2 (Leiden: Brill, 1976), 19–31.

⁹⁹ See T. Toom, “Augustine’s Case for the Multiplicity of Meanings,” *Augustinian Studies* 45/2 (2014), 183–201.

category of signs.¹⁰⁰ Words are a “primary modeling system” that enable the other systems to be expressed.¹⁰¹

There was yet one further *partitio* to be made before Augustine could get to the type of signs that concerned him most. Because of the unstable and momentary character of the spoken words, letters were invented.¹⁰² This means that in the case of Scripture, one faces the task of interpreting signs of signs and, consequently, one has to take seriously the possible “communication gaps” that such manifold signification may cause.¹⁰³ In order to address the issue of biblical exegesis, Augustine also has to adopt a sign receiver's perspective. In *dial.* 5, he already mentioned that words as signs were understood “by the hearer (*ab audiente*).” The definition of sign in *doc. Chr.* 2.1.1 likewise includes the mind of a sign receiver. So, after all the introductory “elimination dust” settles, after Augustine has zoomed in on the written word-signs and adopted the interpretative perspective of a sign receiver, he is ready to discuss his hermeneutical theory for interpreting Scripture.¹⁰⁴ The

¹⁰⁰ Augustine, *doc. Chr.* 2.3.4; cf. *dial.* 5, “A word is a sign of any sort of thing (*Verbum est uniuscuiusque rei signum*).”

¹⁰¹ J. Lotman in Eco, *Semiotics and the Philosophy of Language*, 32.

¹⁰² Augustine, *doc. Chr.* 2.4.5; cf. 3.29.40; *dial.* 5 and *mag.* 4.8.35–6. This, in turn, has created the postlapsarian situation in which Scripture exists in various written languages. Translations create their own share of problems for exegetes (*doc. Chr.* 2.5.6; cf. 2.11.16–2.15.22). For example, Augustine can complain, “The translators have made it so obscure (*obscurum*)” (*en. Ps.* 135.4), or worse still, translators may have also stated what is “plain wrong (*falsa*)” (*doc. Chr.* 2.12.18).

¹⁰³ Rist, *Augustine*, 25–32; T. Toom, “Augustine on the ‘Communicative Gaps’ in Book Two of *De doctrina Christiana*,” *Augustinian Studies* 34/2 (2003), 213–22. There are various phases of signification operative in the case of Scripture. The Word in God's mind is “signified” by the “uttered” Word; the “uttered” Word is perceived by the sign receivers (i.e., those who witnessed the historical incarnation of Christ); what God “said” in the words and deeds of Christ causes the birth of the internal word in the minds of the human authors of Scripture; the inspired internal word is expressed and recorded in the written Scripture; an interpreter perceives the written and often translated signs (or audible signs, when Scripture is read aloud) that communicate that which God “said” in the incarnated Christ (cf. Augustine, *Jo. ev. tr.* 54.8).

¹⁰⁴ The specificity of the task of scriptural interpretation, vis-à-vis the interpretation of nonscriptural texts, is recently emphasized by I. Bochet, “Le fondement de

process of communication through written *signa data* becomes the prime object of Augustine's investigation.

Starting with *doc. Chr.* 2.10.15, Augustine applies his *scientia signorum* to the text of Scripture. He organizes various signs into several subgroups so that all possible cases of linguistic signification would be covered. That is, he distinguishes between "unknown signs (*signa ignota*)" and "ambiguous signs (*signa ambigua*)" and discusses both groups according to whether they are literal (*propria*) or figurative (*translata*).¹⁰⁵ Augustine discusses unknown literal signs in *doc. Chr.* 2.11.16–2.15.22, unknown figurative signs in 2.16.23–26, ambiguous literal signs in 3.1.1–3.4.8, and ambiguous figurative signs in 3.5.9–3.37.56.¹⁰⁶

In *doc. Chr.* 2.11.16, Augustine launches his investigation of the "unknown literal signs (*ignota signa propria*)." Basically, he tackles the "sarabara problem" of *mag.* 10.33.114 again – if it is unknown what a word signifies, the word simply cannot function as a signifier. Therefore, an interpreter needs to learn first for what words stand in a particular system of linguistic signification (i.e., Hebrew, Greek, or Latin).

l'herméneutique augustinienne," in G. Nauroy and M.-A. Vannier (eds.), *Saint Augustin et la Bible. Actes du colloque de l'université Paul Verlaine-Metz (7–8 avril 2005)* (Bern: Peter Lang, 2008), 37–57. Westphal, too, writes, "For example, the witness of the Holy Spirit, not only in attesting to the Bible as divine revelation but also in teaching us what it means, is a distinctively theological assumption that the church brings with it to the interpretation of Scripture" (M. Westphal, *Whose Community? Which Interpretation? Philosophical Hermeneutics for the Church, The Church and Postmodern Culture* [Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2009], 14).

¹⁰⁵ Classification of words into *propria* and *translata* was common in Latin rhetoric (e.g., Cicero, *Orat.* 3.37.149, 38.155; Quintilian, *Inst.* 1.5.71). Green renders *translata* as "metaphorical," evidently because in *doc. Chr.* 3.10.14, Augustine uses the phrase "figurative (that is, metaphorical) expression (*figuratam locutionem, id est translata*)." However, while the word "metaphor" denotes, strictly speaking, a particular figurative trope, the word "figurative" denotes a more general category of discourse. Furthermore, while not all the examples Augustine considers in books 2 and 3 can be called metaphors, they are certainly examples of a figurative use of language.

¹⁰⁶ C. P. Mayer, *Die Zeichen in der geistigen Entwicklung und in der Theologie Augustins, II. Teil: Die antimanichäische Epoche* (Würzburg: Augustinus Verlag, 1974), 302–34.

"An important antidote to the ignorance of literal signs is the knowledge of languages (*linguarum cognitio*)."¹⁰⁷ Augustine immediately warns though that the original biblical languages of Scripture, like all languages, are obscure and ambiguous. Indeed, the basic hermeneutical problem is that interpreters of Scripture are constantly misled by many "obscurities and ambiguities (*obscuritatibus et ambiguitatibus*)."¹⁰⁸ Hence he postulates a basic yet all-important rule that obscure and ambiguous passages are explained by the plain(er) passages.¹⁰⁹ For example, in *en. Ps.* 147.4, he says, "What we find obscure (*obscura*) in the psalm can be understood in the light of what is openly (*aperta*) taught elsewhere." Presuming a fundamental unity of Scripture – the fact that it is "one single utterance of God (*unus sermo Dei*)"¹¹⁰ – Augustine emphatically affirms the traditional intracanonical principle of *scriptura sacra sui ipsius interpretres*.

Next, there are two main remedies for discovering the meaning of the "unknown figurative signs (*ignota signa translata*).¹¹¹ Augustine recommends the knowledge of languages (*notitia linguarum*) yet again, as well as the knowledge of things (*notitia rerum*).¹¹¹ First, he considers Hebrew names. Forgetting, for a moment, his theoretical dislike of etymological analysis, Augustine concedes that "many Hebrew names (*nomina*) . . . have considerable significance and much help to give in solving the mysteries of Scripture."¹¹² As Augustine's sermons and commentaries amply testify, he actually found etymologies to be quite handy.¹¹³ Perhaps it should also be

¹⁰⁷ Augustine, *doc. Chr.* 2.11.16–2.13.20; cf. 3.1.1. ¹⁰⁸ *Doc. Chr.* 2.6.7.

¹⁰⁹ *Doc. Chr.* 2.6.8; cf. 2.9.14; 3.27.38–9; *civ. Dei* 11.19; 17.17; *div. qu.* 53.2; *en. Ps.* 76.18. *Regula fidei*, which was brought up in book 1, is based on plainly stated, clearly elucidated scriptural teachings. Therefore, it can and should function as the hermeneutical criterion for interpreting all obscure and ambiguous passages. In case of a problem, "We must consult the rule of faith (*regulam fidei*), as it is perceived through the plainer passages of the scriptures (*de scripturarum planioribus locis*) and the authority of the church" (3.2.2; cf. 2.7.10; *en. Ps.* 74.12).

¹¹⁰ *En. Ps.* 103(4).1. "Understand the harmony of scriptures (*intellege concordiam scripturarum*)!" (*Jo. ev. tr.* 19.7; cf. *c. Faust.* 3.5).

¹¹¹ *Doc. Chr.* 2.16.23. ¹¹² *Doc. Chr.* 2.16.23; cf. 2.39.59.

¹¹³ For example, Augustine could admonish, "Now observe that both these names [i.e., Jerusalem and Zion] suggest something worth looking at" (*en. Ps.* 147.8) or, "Listen to those two names (of Egypt and Pharaoh) . . . for when interpreted they

pointed out here that, in this section, Augustine considers the smallest syntactic units, names or single words, and investigates the figurative use of these in relative independence from the sentences in which they occur. Contemporary hermeneuts contend, however, that it requires more than one term to create a figurative statement, for there needs to be predication rather than a denomination.¹¹⁴

The passage discussing the second remedy has to be understood within the larger section in which it occurs. Under the “things” Augustine does not mean the *res* discussed in book 1, but rather the sensible things which can be used for further signification.¹¹⁵ He looks at “the qualities of animals or stones or plants or other things (*rerum*) mentioned in Scripture.”¹¹⁶ Familiarity with such things enabled the writers of Scripture to employ these qualities for constructing creative figurative utterances in the first place.

have symbolic meaning, heavy with wisdom!” (*en. Ps.* 134.19). Most often, Augustine made use of etymological digressions on the titles of the Psalms (e.g., *en. Ps.* 7.1; 52.7). See also for a whole list of folk etymologies *civ. Dei* 15, as well as *c. Faust.* 22.87 and *Gn. adv. Man.* 2.10.13.

¹¹⁴ Ricoeur, *Interpretation Theory*, 49–50. In other words, figurative use of language does not just rename something (e.g., “arrow” for the “gospel”), but makes a statement about the entity (e.g., “the gospel is like an arrow,” because both pierce something) (Augustine, *en. Ps.* 76.20). On the other hand, *en. Ps.* 77.27 provides an example of a mere renaming of individual words that does not consider at the same time the meaning of the whole sentence/proposition.

¹¹⁵ In *doc. Chr.* 3.9.13, Augustine calls a thing (*res*) that signified another thing *rem significantem*. In 3.37.56, he further defines figurative expressions as those “in which one thing is to be understood from another” (*ubi aliud ex alio intellegendum est*), for which he most often uses the term *figura*. “A *figura* . . . preserves the significance of the historical reality while embracing the subsequent temporal unfolding of the fullest meaning of that reality” (D. Dawson, “Figure, Allegory,” in A. D. Fitzgerald (ed.), *Augustine through the Ages: An Encyclopedia* [Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1999], 365–8, at 366).

¹¹⁶ Augustine, *doc. Chr.* 2.16.24. In 2.16.24–6, Augustine adds herbs, numbers, and musical instruments; in 2.25.38–26.40, human nonsuperstitious institutions; in 2.27.41–2.42.63, history, topography, astronomy, and other arts, such as logic, rhetoric, and philosophy; and in 3.29.40–41, he also affixes tropes and figures of speech. “There is a possibility of gleaning from [the knowledge of all these things] something of value for understanding holy Scripture (*ad intellegendas sanctas scripturas*)” (2.18.28; cf. 2.42.63).

Consequently, one's knowledge of various things helps to make similarity judgments, and to perceive the system of associations with which figurative language operates.¹¹⁷ "Knowledge of things," in turn, presupposes "secular" learning and so Augustine provides a lengthy digression about how precisely a Christian should adopt and use "all the wisdom of the Egyptians" (Acts 7:22).¹¹⁸

Book 3 of *De doctrina Christiana* assesses "ambiguous signs (*signa ambigua*),"¹¹⁹ and divides them again according to whether they are literal (*propria*) or figurative (*translata*).

"Ambiguous literal signs (*ambigua signa propria*)" are disambiguated by correct punctuation, consulting the rule of faith, and considering the words' immediate literary context.¹²⁰ In the particular case of liturgical reading (i.e., reading aloud), the reader should likewise disambiguate the text by the rule of faith and the "nearby word (*vicinio verbo*)."¹²¹ In the end of this section, Augustine also mentions the importance of "a comparison of different versions" and "an inspection of the original languages."¹²²

A special consideration is given to toughest case of the "ambiguous figurative signs (*ambigua signa translata*)."

Here the interpretative difficulty is not only ambiguity but also the need to make an adequate distinction between literal and figurative uses of words or statements and not to mistake one for another. According to Augustine, the looming hermeneutical "danger" is twofold: "One must take care not to interpret a figurative expression literally (*ne figuratam locutionem ad litteram accipias*) . . . [and] not to accept a literal one as if it were figurative (*ne propriam quasi figuratam velimus accipere*)."¹²³ Augustine admonishes accordingly, "The greatest care

¹¹⁷ *Doc. Chr.* 3.25.35; cf. *en. Ps.* 8.13.

¹¹⁸ *Doc. Chr.* 2.17.27–2.42.63.

¹¹⁹ This is precisely where the incomplete *De dialectica* left the discussion hanging – the ambiguity of the written word-signs.

¹²⁰ Cf. *Gn. litt.* 1.21.41. For a more thorough analysis of ambiguity and disambiguation in *De doctrina Christiana*, see Toom, "Augustine on Ambiguity," 419–33.

¹²¹ Augustine, *doc. Chr.* 3.3.7.

¹²² Cf. *c. Faust.* 11.2; *ep.* 261.5.

¹²³ *Doc. Chr.* 3.5.9; 3.10.14; cf. *civ. Dei.* 15.27. Already Plato bemoaned that "the young can't distinguish what is allegorical from what isn't" (*R.* 378d).

must therefore be taken to determine whether the expression that we are trying to understand is literal (*propria*) or figurative (*figurata*).¹²⁴

While only briefly mentioning *ambigua signa propria*, Augustine discusses *ambigua signa translata* at length. He offers a rule of thumb, which he at once carefully qualifies in many respects: “Anything in the divine discourse that cannot be related either to good morals or to the true faith should be taken as figurative (*ut quidquid in sermo divino neque ad morum honestatem neque ad fidei veritatem proprie referri potest figuratum esse cognoscas*).”¹²⁵ Augustine explains that “good morals” means the double commandment of love, and “true faith” means one’s adequate consideration of God and the neighbor. The problem is that not everything said in Scripture, if taken literally, promotes faith and love. Therefore, and once again, it is most important to connect every interpretation “with the reign of love (*ad regnum caritatis*).”¹²⁶

The very distinction between literal and figurative signs is another major feature of Augustine’s hermeneutical theory.¹²⁷ It “parallels the division between visible and invisible orders of being.”¹²⁸ That is, it is grounded on the Platonic understanding that the intelligible should be sought behind the sensible.¹²⁹ The conviction that an interpreter’s ultimate task is to decipher the intelligible, divinely intended “hidden meanings” of Scripture through the sensible word-signs basically defines the hermeneutical program for Augustine. In *en. Ps.* 46.2, he summarizes the issue: “[Words in Scripture] point to a sweet mystery, hinting at a holy meaning hidden under a sign (*sacramentum*).”

¹²⁴ Augustine, *doc. Chr.* 3.24.34; cf. 3.5.9; 3.10.14, *civ. Dei* 17.3; *Gn. adv. Man.* 2.2.3.

¹²⁵ *Doc. Chr.* 3.10.14; cf. *ex. Gal.* 19; Mayer, *Die Zeichen*, 326–8.

¹²⁶ Augustine, *doc. Chr.* 3.15.23. ¹²⁷ Hoffmann, “Hermeneutische Fragen,” 468.

¹²⁸ J. Whitman, *Allegory: The Dynamics of an Ancient and Medieval Technique* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1987), 63.

¹²⁹ Augustine explains, “Everything we perceive, we perceive either by one of the bodily senses or by the mind (*aut sensu corporis aut mente*). We name the former sensible (*sensibilia*), the latter intelligible (*inintellegibilia*)” (*mag.* 12.39.8–9).

It is well known that, with his *De Genesi ad litteram imperfectus liber*, Augustine started to pay more attention to the literal interpretation of Scripture. In fact, already in his earliest attempt to comment on the Book of Genesis, Augustine uttered some harsh words against those who scorned the literal sense of Scripture, as well as suggested that the one who interpreted Scripture *ad litteram* should be hold up “as an outstanding and wholly admirable understander (*intellector*) of the text.”¹³⁰ And soon enough he wrote a massive *De Genesi ad litteram*. Therefore, it is often contended that Augustine pretty much abandoned (what is taken to be embarrassing) allegorical interpretation and finally understood that the true sense of the text was the literal sense. Arguably, there are at least two problems with such a perception of things, which is itself based on a preference of a particular philosophy of meaning. First, Augustine never contended that the literal sense, which he wanted to assess, was *the* sense of the text.¹³¹ He merely said that discussing figurative senses was not appropriate for his *literal* commentary on Genesis.¹³² Second, while assessing the literal sense and affirming its legitimacy,¹³³ Augustine did not thereby deny the legitimacy of the

¹³⁰ *Gn. adv. Man.* 2.2.3; cf. *civ. Dei* 17.3; *Gn. litt.* 1.1.1.

¹³¹ The roots of the understanding in which the literal sense is proper and figurative is “ornamental” goes back to Aristotle and his empiricist epistemology (A. N. Katz, “Figurative Language and Figurative Thought: A Review,” in A. N. Katz et al. [eds.], *Figurative Language and Thought* [Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1998], 3–43, at 20 and 25). However, when Augustine uses the adjective *proprius* for a literal sense (e.g., *Gn. litt.* 8.2.5; s. 89.4), he does not mean that the literal sense is the only “proper/right/correct” one, but rather that it is a sense which restricts itself to the first level of signification (i.e., it “belongs to one thing only”).

¹³² *Gn. litt.* 1.17.34; 8.2.5; 9.12.22; *retr.* 2.24.

¹³³ Literal sense is “the first thing that has to be established with every possible care” (Augustine, *Gn. litt.* 6.7.12). Furthermore and with good justification, Green-McCreight asserts that for Augustine, “plain sense reading [of Scripture] is a religious activity, not merely a literal activity alone, and entails basic presuppositions about the text and about God” (K. E. Green-McCreight, *Ad Litteram: How Augustine, Calvin, and Barth Read the “Plain Sense” of Genesis* 1–3, Issues in Systematic Theology 5 [New York: Peter Lang, 1999], 49). Indeed, contemporary understanding of literal sense does not really match with that of Augustine because in time, his understanding of literal sense broadened to include various figurative/spiritual interpretations (Y. K. Kim, *Augustine's Changing*

figurative senses of the text. On the contrary, he emphasized that what the Scriptures said needed to be taken “first in their literal sense (*ad litteram*), and then to chisel out from them what future realities the actual events described may figuratively stand for (*quid etiam futurorum res ipsae gestae significauerint exculpatur*).”¹³⁴ In fact, throughout his whole literary corpus, Augustine condemns those who say that there is nothing beyond the literal sense.¹³⁵ Most significantly, his massive literal commentary on Genesis begins with the words “No Christian . . . will have the nerve to say that [Scripture] should not be taken in a figurative sense (*figuraliter*).”¹³⁶ Again, “We can see now what these verses mean when interpreted literally (*ad litteram*); we know the sense of them and we praise God. But it may be that they signify something further (*si autem aliquid significant*).”¹³⁷

Augustine does not equate the “letter that kills” with the intended literal sense.¹³⁸ Instead, he draws one’s attention to the fact that while Scripture can be read literally, it should not be read “carnally.” To follow the “letter,” in the sense of not discerning the intention of the Holy Spirit, was a “carnal way” (*carnaliter*) of understanding.¹³⁹ Distinguished from literal, “carnal” reading means readings in which a supposedly intended figurative or spiritual meaning(s) of an utterance is not recognized, in which the signified things themselves become signs.¹⁴⁰ This applies

Interpretations of Genesis 1–3: From De Genesi contra Manichaeos to De Genesi ad litteram [Lewistown, NY: Edwin Mellen, 2006], 47–57). This also means that Augustine does not consider literal and figurative senses to be mutually exclusive.

¹³⁴ Augustine, *Gn. litt.* 8.1.2; cf. 8.7.13; *civ. Dei* 20.21; *en. Ps.* 68(2).6; 131.2; *Gn. adv. Man.* 2.2.3.

¹³⁵ E.g., *conf.* 5.14.24, 6.4.6; *en. Ps.* 33.1.7, 2.14; *mor.* 1.10.17; *s. Dom.* 1.10.25; *util. cred.* 3.9.

¹³⁶ *Gn. litt.* 1.1.1. One may also want to mention Mk 4:1–20 here, where Jesus himself provides a figurative interpretation of his parable.

¹³⁷ Augustine, *en. Ps.* 134.16; cf. 33(1).7; 103(1).13; 104.35; *Gn. litt.* 4.10.20.

¹³⁸ Arguably, the main impetus for Augustine’s attention to figurative exegesis came from Ambrose’s use of 2 Cor 3:6, “The letter kills but the spirit gives life (*littera occidit, spiritus autem vivificat*)” (*conf.* 6.4.6; cf. *doc. Chr.* 3.5.9; *spir. et litt.* 4.6).

¹³⁹ *Doc. Chr.* 3.5.9; cf. 3.7.11; *c. Adim.* 12.5.

¹⁴⁰ For example, the subject matter referred to in the conversations of Nicodemus and the Samaritan woman with Jesus (Jn 3:5–15; 4:4–26).

especially to the Christological interpretation of the Old Testament. Those who deny the legitimacy of such interpretation take signs merely “as if they were things.”¹⁴¹ But not to see Christ everywhere in Scripture is just to have an inadequate, non-Christian theology of Scripture. “In the prophets he was proclaiming himself, for he is the Word of God, and everything they said was full of the Word of God (*nec illi tale aliquid dicebant, nisi pleni uerbo dei*).”¹⁴²

Before assessing the *regulae mysticae* of Tyconius,¹⁴³ Augustine offers another important rule, which he had known for quite some time, for distinguishing between literal and figurative statements:¹⁴⁴ “When a meaning based on the literal interpretation of a word is absurd (*cum sensus, ad proprietatem verborum si accipiat, absurdus est*) we must investigate whether the passage that we cannot understand is perhaps being expressed by means of one or other of the tropes [i.e., figuratively].”¹⁴⁵ “Absurdity criterion” means that when

¹⁴¹ Augustine, *doc. Chr.* 3.6.10. “Those scriptures [i.e. the Old Testament] are also from the Lord, but they have no flavor, unless Christ is recognized in them” (*Jo. ev. tr.* 9.5).

¹⁴² Augustine, *en. Ps.* 142.1; cf. *Lk* 24:27, 44; *Jn* 5:46; *Col* 2:17; *1 Pt* 1:11; Augustine, *cat. rud.* 4.8, *civ. Dei* 18.28–36; *c. Faust.* 12.27; *en. Ps.* 45.1; 98.1. In *doc. Chr.* 3.22.32, Augustine explains that the whole Old Testament needs to be interpreted “not only literally but also figuratively (*non solum proprie sed etiam figurate*),” in order to “observe or trace a prefiguration of future events (*figuram rerum futuram*) in them” “since the Lord’s coming in flesh.”

¹⁴³ Augustine assesses Tyconius’ rules under figurative ambiguous signs, because at least six out of seven rules teach how to understand one thing from another. Rule 7 says that “the Spirit wanted one thing to sound forth, another to be understood.” In *doc. Chr.* 3.37.56, Augustine explains that “all these rules result in one thing being understood from another (*aliud ex alio*),” which is his short definition of figurative discourse.

¹⁴⁴ One of the reasons for the 30-or-so-year interruption of his writing of *De doctrina Christiana* (*retr.* 2.4) may have been that, despite having suggested various *praecepta*, Augustine might have felt that the problem of determining whether a discourse was figurative or not still lacked a definite solution.

¹⁴⁵ *Doc. Chr.* 3.29.41; cf. *cat. rud.* 26.50; *civ. Dei* 11.19; *en. Ps.* 120.12; 121.4; *ex. Gal.* 36; *Gn. adv. Man.* 2.2.3; *Gn. litt.* 4.28.45; 11.1.2; G. R. Evans, “*Absurditas* in Augustine’s Scriptural Commentary,” *Downside Review* 99 (1981), 109–18; R. J. Teske, “Criteria for Figurative Interpretation in St. Augustine,” in D. W. H. Arnold and P. Bright (eds.), “*De doctrina Christiana*”: *A Classic of Western*

something, taken literally, stands in fundamental contradiction either to what God is believed to be, or to the double-commandment of love, it should be taken in a figurative sense instead.

After Augustine decides that he has discussed figurative utterances “sufficiently (*satis*),”¹⁴⁶ the *inventio* part of *De doctrina Christiana* ends with Augustine’s injunction “to pray for understanding (*orent ut intellegant*),” which is “paramount and absolutely vital (*quod est praecipuum et maxime necessarium*).”¹⁴⁷ As Augustine fashions his hermeneutical theory, he never forgets the ultimate end of one’s reading of the Bible – to get to know God, the only one to be “enjoyed,” through the *signa divinitus data* of Scripture. For this purpose, prayer and moral purification are a “must” for all “theorists.”¹⁴⁸ “If anyone desires to know God’s will (*voluntatem dei*), they should first become friends of God . . . Nobody, however, becomes a friend of God except by total integrity of life and conduct (*purgatissimis moribus*).”¹⁴⁹ Evidently, understanding God’s will in Scripture has its own unique prerequisites besides having a solid hermeneutical theory.

FURTHER READING

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Culture, Christianity and Judasim in Antiquity 9 (Notre Dame, IN: University of Notre Dame Press, 1995), 109–22, at 111–14.

¹⁴⁶ This does not mean that Augustine has said everything he has to say about hermeneutics. For example, his *scientia signorum*, reconstructed on the basis of *De dialectica*, *De magistro*, and *De doctrina Christiana*, addresses neither prosopological exegesis, prophecy/fulfillment typology, nor interpretation of tropes and figures of speech, except by listing some of them.

¹⁴⁷ *Doc. Chr.* 3.37.56.

¹⁴⁸ Mt 5:8; Augustine, *doc. Chr.* 2.7.9–11; *civ. Dei* 11.2; *en. Ps.* 26(2).15; 39.21; 99.5; *f. et sym.* 10.25; *Jo. ev. tr.* 1.19.

¹⁴⁹ *Gn. adv. Man.* 1.2.4; cf. *agon.* 13.14.

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*Cassian's hermeneutics**Purity of heart and the vision of God**Christopher J. Kelly*

The task assigned to the contributing authors of this volume presented a considerable challenge. Given the diverse, fluid, and occasionally confusing nature of patristic literature, attempting to achieve the goals of the proposed study was a daring endeavor. Additionally, many of the figures contained herein did not attend themselves to a precise delineation of the means by which Scripture ought to be understood. How does one present a given church father's hermeneutical method when he does not clearly articulate one? The present chapter concerns John Cassian and had to face just such a question. Yet, the problem is not insurmountable. Fortunately, Cassian is an erudite figure who spends a considerable amount of time attesting to the value of Scripture in the three texts he composed in the early fifth century.¹ As the most influential transmitter of an eastern monastic ideal to the western regions of the empire he has a careful agenda in mind that, when considered, helps to contextualize a hermeneutical method that places a primacy on striving to realize the beatific vision so desired by his desert forebears. As with all patristic authors, the sacred text is omnipresent in Cassian, but nowhere does he make its interpretation an object of study. Yet, we do find some tantalizing suggestions here and there that make it possible to add some dimension to what has to remain

¹ In chronological order these are the *Institutiones*, the *Conlationes*, and *De incarnatione Christi*. The last of Cassian's texts is a polemical work written to counter the Nestorian heresy that exceeds his area of expertise. As such, it lacks the impetus and reflective cohesion present in the earlier works and will not be considered here.

an incomplete scaffolding. For instance, in *Conl.* 8.3, Cassian asserts that the meaning of some verses of scripture is eminently clear, but there are other sections that need to be “cooked (*coctione*)” and “made tender by a probing spiritual fire (*spiritualis ignis examinatione mollita*)” in order for them to be nourishing for the reader.² Therein lies his hermeneutical method. But in what way can the text be “cooked,” and what is the nature of this probing spiritual fire?

Although his influence is hard to overstate, John Cassian remains an unknown or obscure figure for many not familiar with the early monastic milieu of Christian late antiquity. Unfortunately, there is very little biographical information that can be gleaned from his own works or from other antique sources. Other than identifying himself as “Iohannes” on two occasions in his works,³ Cassian reveals no details about who he is – family, home, schooling, occupation, and so on all remain frustratingly unknown. He is mentioned in a handful of other late antique sources, including Innocent I’s *Epistula* 7 and Palladius’ *Dialogus de vita Chrysostomi*. In *De viris illustribus*, Gennadius of Marseilles informs us that Cassian hails from Scythia, which places him in the region around the Black Sea that we would recognize as Romania and Bulgaria today. The area is indeed a good candidate, for it was known to be a meeting place for Latin and Greek culture.⁴ Cassian’s Latin is excellent, and it is clear that he is very familiar with Greek; he uses Greek terms correctly and appropriately and he quotes from Greek sources. The ease of movement he has between the two both in his writings and in his travels suggests a familiarity that supports

² The Latin cited in this chapter follows *CSEL* 13 and 17, ed. M. Petschenig (Wien: Verlag der Österreichischen Akademie der Wissenschaften, 2004). English translations follow *John Cassian: The Institutes*, trans. B. Ramsey, ACW 58 (New York: Paulist, 2000), and *John Cassian: The Conferences*, trans. B. Ramsey, ACW 57 (New York: Paulist, 1997).

³ See Cassian, *Inst.* 5 and *Conl.* 14.

⁴ The best source, really for all things Cassian, remains C. Stewart, *Cassian the Monk*, Oxford Studies in Historical Theology (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1998). W. Harmless, *Desert Christians: An Introduction to the Literature of Early Monasticism* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2004), 373–413, also provides an excellent biographical overview and synthesis of Cassian’s main concerns.

Gennadius' assertion. Our best approximation is that he was born during the latter half of the fourth century of the Common Era, presumably around the year 360.

We know his family had some land and we know he had a teacher, but what we do not know is why, sometime around 380, he and an older companion named Germanus traveled to Bethlehem in Palestine and joined a monastery.⁵ In his characteristic self-effacing manner Cassian provides no reasons for embracing an ascetic life. Considering the time period, it may well be that he, like many other Christian men and women, was inspired by the example of the desert fathers already advanced in their dedication to a spiritual ideal of renunciation and isolation. Bishop Athanasius' *De vita Antonii*, for example, an account of the iconic founder of Christian monasticism, was certainly responsible for leading many away from the empire's cities and towns toward the desert wastes of its fringes. It could be that Cassian and Germanus felt the need to dedicate their lives in like manner. Not long after joining a monastery not far from the traditional site of Jesus' birth, the companions receive a cellmate traveling from Egypt by the name of Abba Pinufius. The term "abba," or "father," is a title for those monks recognized for their sanctity and, indeed, Pinufius had received such notoriety in this regard that his humility forced him to run away, lest he fall victim to pride.⁶ During his stay at Bethlehem, Pinufius regaled Cassian and Germanus with tales of the great desert fathers whom he had left behind in the deserts of Egypt. He stressed the supremacy of Egyptian monasticism and the marvelous sanctity of the Egyptian abbass and inspired the two to ask permission of their superiors to visit some of the monastic communities across the Red Sea away to their south and west. Sometime around 385, they acquired said permission and set off on their own zealous, spiritual quest.

For the next fifteen years or so, Cassian and Germanus journeyed throughout the Nile delta, moving from monastic community to monastic community and soaking up the wisdom of various desert abbass. These years are pivotal for the development of Cassian's

⁵ Cassian, *Conl.* 24.1.2 and *Conl.* 14.12.

⁶ See *Conl.* 20.1.

thought. Indeed, his experiences form the basis of his greatest work – the *Conlationes*, which receives its title from its contents: “conferences,” or conversations, with ascetic masters regarding the nature and means of the monastic enterprise. Right before the turn of the century Cassian, Germanus, and many other religious people left Egypt in the wake of Bishop Theophilus’ campaign against those who were sympathetic to Origen’s allegorical interpretation of scripture, particularly with reference to anthropomorphic depictions of God. The two made their way to Constantinople where they entered the service of John Chrysostom, bishop of the city. Here they made such a good impression that Germanus was ordained to the presbyterate and Cassian to the diaconate, and Chrysostom utilized the pair as his representatives on several trips to Rome. Not much else regarding their activities over the next fifteen years or so is clear. It seems likely, though, that Cassian remained in Rome until Alaric’s invasion in 410. At some point during the interim he was also ordained.⁷ Around the year 415, Cassian retired from public service, so to speak, and settled in Massilia, the modern port city of Marseilles in the south of France. Here he founded two monasteries, one for women and one for men, and it was here that he composed the three works for which he is remembered. Two of these works – the *Institutiones* and the *Conlationes* – constitute the reasons why Cassian is important. Cassian provides the link between eastern monasticism and its Latin incarnation. It was Cassian’s understanding of the goals and means of the monastic endeavor that become foundational for the way the tradition developed in the western regions of the empire.

There is very little in the way of sustained consideration of various methods for faithfully interpreting scripture in Cassian. The most significant portions appear in *Inst.* 5.33–4, *Conl.* 8.3–4, and *Conl.* 14, and these shall constitute the focal points of the present chapter. Smatterings can be gathered from comments made here and there in both texts, and they shall be included accordingly. Yet, of course, scriptural interpretation itself pervades every page of his

⁷ Stewart offers alternate possibilities in *Cassian*, 4–6.

texts, as does a desire on Cassian's part to institute orthodox Egyptian monastic ideals and practices in Gaul. This latter point affects everything Cassian writes, which makes any attempt to isolate a particular aspect of his work problematic. Although the nature of Cassian's hermeneutics is the question at hand, any answer to that question ought to include some understanding of Cassian's overall intent in writing the *Institutiones* and the *Conlationes* and the means by which he attempts to accomplish said intent. In short, Cassian's hermeneutics cannot and should not be separated from his grand schema.

Institutiones 5.33–4

Written at the behest of Bishop Castor circa 415, the *Institutiones* is Cassian's earliest work. Its explicit goal is to provide the "rules (*instituta*)" of the monasteries with which Cassian was familiar as a result of his travels learning from various monastic communities in Egypt and Palestine. Although he does supply some of the basic tangible requirements common to eastern eremitic and cenobitic traditions, *instituta* is a more inclusive term that includes the fundamental guiding principles that serve as foundations upon which authentic monastic practice is predicated. Egypt had long been revered as a seedbed of sanctity and its desert ascetics had been held in awe as almost superhuman, so Cassian's words and advice would have been held in high esteem. Cassian's acuity and practicality, though, establish that he is not interested in any miraculous considerations in his treatment of the monastic vocation. It may well be that at one time Cassian himself had been captivated by stories of ascetics performing marvelous deeds in their course for perfection, but he learned to see past their impressive veneer and unequivocally notes that other than wonderment, such things contribute nothing to the instruction of the perfect life.⁸

What appear, then, in the twelve books that constitute the *Institutiones* are the basic practical and theoretical building blocks

⁸ See Cassian, *Inst.* Praef. 7.

Cassian considered essential for authentic monastic practice. The first four books concern themselves with the more everyday aspects of what it means to adopt the monastic lifestyle. Books 5 through 12 each tackle what Cassian identifies as the eight principal vices that have to be eliminated if the monk is to make any spiritual progress. Book 5 tackles the vice of gluttony, but in chapter 33, buried toward the book's end, Cassian gives us as clear a statement of his hermeneutical method as we can find in any of his works. Throughout the *Institutiones*, Cassian relates encounters he experienced with notable abbats in the eastern deserts and stories he heard that help to frame his intentions. In *Inst.* 5.33, we are introduced to Abba Theodore, who responds to the queries "from some of the brothers," as Cassian directs us, regarding certain interpretations of scripture.

Even before the question is raised, though, Cassian primes the response by noting several characteristics of the abba that have a direct bearing on his hermeneutical stance. Theodore is described as being "endowed with the greatest holiness and knowledge not only in practical affairs but also in familiarity with scripture."⁹ Now, extolling the holiness of a desert abba is routine in eremitic literature, but what makes Theodore noteworthy is that Cassian specifies the ways in which his sanctity was manifest, that is, in a fullness of knowledge (*scientia*) of both the everyday activities and struggles of monastic life and the meaning of scripture. Articulating it in this way suggests two fields of knowledge in which one can become expert, one practical and one having to do with engagement with the sacred text. Cassian will detail this further in *Conl.* 14, but here makes the essential point that these two arenas are intimately related. He explains that Theodore achieved his scriptural expertise not from an innate desire to learn more or from the strictly intellectual endeavors that Cassian describes as "worldly learning (*litteratura mundi*)."⁹ Indeed, Cassian goes so far as to inform us that the abba could speak and understand but a few words of Greek.

⁹ *Summa sanctitate et scientia praeditum non solum in actuali vita, sed etiam notitia scripturarum (Inst. 5.33).*

Theodore's erudition sprang from somewhere else, a singular source Cassian identifies as "purity of heart (*puritas cordis*)."¹⁰

The abba's insight was of a kind that depended more upon a state of being than intellectual analysis. Remarkably, Cassian ends his short introduction by suggesting that whenever Theodore was unsure about some scriptural concern "he would pray untiringly for seven days and nights until, thanks to a revelation from the Lord, he reached the solution to the question at issue."¹¹ Theodore's perseverance and dedication to a routine occupation of monastic life, and not exegetical exercises, are rewarded with the grace of insight. This is a key point for any attempt to articulate the means by which scripture is to be read and interpreted for Cassian. One's development in virtue and monastic fealty has a direct effect on one's ability to understand the biblical narrative. Theodore then advises that a monk who "desires to attain to a knowledge of scripture should never toil over the works of the commentators."¹² He is living proof that scholarly erudition is unnecessary. For Theodore, scripture was not communicated by the Holy Spirit in order for its meaning to be obscure or unattainable, and the confusion lies not in the text, but in the person attempting to make sense of it. It is possible for the monk to "naturally contemplate the mysteries of scripture (*sacramenta scripturarum naturaliter contemplarentur*)" with the "eye of the heart (*cordis oculi*)" if he attends to the real problem. If he would direct the "full effort of the mind (*omnem mentis industriam*)" and the "attentiveness of his heart (*intentionem cordis*)" to the elimination of vice, the practical purpose of the *Institutiones*, in his carnal and spiritual life then the meaning of scripture will become clearer and clearer. The narrative is obscure only to the extent that the monk's vision is blinded by the passions that exist within him. Conquering sin dissipates the mists of vice that cover the eye of the heart and

¹⁰ The concept is central to Cassian's thought and is the main concern of the *Conlationes*. It will, therefore, warrant further attention as we proceed.

¹¹ *Septem diebus ac noctibus in oratione infatigabilis perstitit, donec solutionem propositae quaestionis domino revelante cognosceret* (*Inst.* 5.33).

¹² *Monachum scripturarum notitiam pertingere cupientem nequaquam debere labores suos erga commentatorum libros impendere* (*Inst.* 5.34).

thereby allows for the simple reading of scripture to be the medium for true insight. Relatedly, the words of those offering commentaries on various biblical excerpts cannot be trusted because experience has shown that many errors and misunderstandings have resulted from those who offer their opinions without first attending to the "cleansing of their minds (*purgationem mentis*).¹³ Interpreting scripture is dangerous business for those whose hearts are less than pure. Their impurity impedes their reason and blinds them to the light of truth, yet they may not even realize the depths of their ignorance and, indeed, may lead others into the darkness in which they dwell.

Conlationes 8.3–4

The *Conlationes* is Cassian's longest and most important work. It contains "conferences (*conlationes*)," or conversations, between Germanus and Cassian and various desert fathers, each divided into twenty-four books. Having established the practical norms of daily life according to Egyptian monastic tradition and articulating the eight principal vices in the *Institutiones*, Cassian intends the *Conlationes* to delve deeper into the workings of the "inner person" and provide insight into the spiritual ideals communicated to him by the abbas with whom he visited more than twenty years prior. Given the length of time elapsed and Cassian's overall instructive intent, it is not unreasonable to suggest that the dialogues contained in the work reflect Cassian's own rationale for and understanding of an eastern monastic ideal that he wants make normative in Gaul, albeit with some concessions.¹³ *Conlationes* 8 is the second of two successive conferences with Abba Serenus, both of which have to do with one of the mainstays of monastic literature: the encounter with demonic forces. Combat with diabolical spirits was almost a *sine qua non* for an

¹³ Cassian already has noted in the preface to the *Institutiones* (Praef. 7) how difficult the standards of Egyptian monasticism could appear to be, so his plan is to temper them by drawing on the somewhat less arduous customs of the Palestinian tradition. He also recognizes very real difficulties in terms of climate and culture and is willing to make adjustments accordingly.

authentic quest for holiness in late antiquity. It had biblical precedent, of course, in the gospel accounts of Jesus' temptation in the desert and, importantly, in Athanasius' *De vita Antonii*. For Cassian, victory over demonic assault was concomitant with one's ability to uproot vice and develop virtue. This is made explicit in the opening chapters of *Conl.* 7, in which Cassian introduces the abba.

It is standard practice for the *Conlationes* to extol the virtues of each of the fifteen abbats around whom the text is organized. However, Abba Serenus receives extended attention in this regard. Cassian relates that above all else Serenus was filled with the gift of chastity to such an extent that even while sleeping he was free from the effects of "natural impulses (*naturalibus incentivis*).” He goes on to explain the manner in which the abba was able to experience such corporeal transcendence. We learn that, like Abba Theodore from *Inst.* 5, Serenus pursued his goal “with prayers day and night, then, and with fasting and vigils he pleaded tireless for internal chastity of heart and soul.”¹⁴ Again it is perseverance and commitment in monastic practice that produce profound spiritual gain. Cassian is careful to note, though, that Serenus did not achieve such mastery by any effort of his own. His zeal set him on a path, but perfect chastity was a gift from God, not a purchase paid for and inevitably received. Indeed, the purity of spirit that he achieved was of such a caliber that it could not be achieved by “human effort or toil (*humano labore vel studio*).” In the midst of constant and tearful supplications Serenus had a remarkable experience. One night he was visited by an angel who “seemed to open his belly, pull out a kind of fiery tumor from his bowels, cast it away, and restore his entrails to their original place.”¹⁵ The result of this seraphic surgery was the complete excision of all sexual impulses, the attainment of perpetual purity in thought and deed. This is important for Cassian to note because mastery of the flesh equates to sanctity, which in

¹⁴ *Hic igitur pro interna cordis atque animae castitate nocturnis diurnisque precibus, ieiuniis quoque ac vigiliis infantigabititer insistsens* (*Conl.* 7.2.1).

¹⁵ *Eiusque velut aperiens uterum quandam ignitam carnis strumam de eius visceribus avellens atque proiciens suisque omnia ut fuerant locis intestina restituens* (*Conl.* 7.2.2).

turn affords the abba's words the force of experienced authority. It is also important for our purposes, because perfect chastity is one of the hallmarks of purity of heart, a spiritual state of being that makes it possible to correctly interpret scripture.

Conl. 8 concerns the origin and nature of evil spirits and begins in earnest when Germanus enquires from whence such a variety of diabolical beings springs. Before addressing the question, Serenus makes some remarks about scripture that relate to Cassian's hermeneutical theory. For Serenus, the sacred text is comprised of books, chapters, verses, and words of varying levels of clarity. The meaning of some sections is so clear and obvious that no explanation is needed, since these can be plainly understood even by those of "limited intelligence (*qui acumine ingenii carent*).” Others, however, are so veiled in obscurity that great effort is required to uncover their hidden meanings. In a way that seems at odds with Abba Theodore's assertion, Serenus suggests this mixture of clear and unclear, obvious and hidden is part of a divine arrangement whose purpose is to distinguish between "the lazy and the zealous (*inertes ac studiosos*)" with regard to the development of "virtue and prudence (*virtutis prudentiaeque*)."¹⁶

To characterize its complex nature Serenus likens Scripture to an "abundant and fertile field (*agro opimo ac fertili*)" that produces all manner of sustenance. Some of the food to which it gives rise is fit for human consumption without the need for any preparation. In its raw state it provides valuable nutrients. Other materials are too bitter and have to be cooked in order to be made "tender and digestible (*mitigate atque mollita*)" enough for human ingestion. Still other produce can be eaten either way, "although cooking makes them more healthful."¹⁷ This agrarian allusion resonates with an earlier image from *Conl.* 1.4 in which Abba Moses likens the monk's calling to a farmer preparing a field. In the same way the farmer must clear the land of weeds and roots, till the soil, and plant the seed in order to

¹⁶ Recall that for Theodore it was not the intent of the Holy Spirit that Scripture be obscure. Lack of understanding was the result of a mind/heart clouded by the passions, not some elaborate puzzle.

¹⁷ *Tamen ignis calore decocta salubriora reddantur* (Cassian, *Conl.* 8.3.3).

eventually reap a bountiful harvest, so must the monk uproot vice and plant virtue in order to inherit the kingdom of heaven.

The allusion also brings us back to the beginning of this chapter and the curious question of “cooking” scripture. Serenus suggests that the biblical text operates on two levels: one literal and one allegorical. Many passages are abundantly clear and a literal understanding of them in their “raw” state yields much nourishment, and the abba offers the *Shema* from Deuteronomy 6 as a good example. Simply hearing those words feeds the spirit. Other sections have to be interpreted allegorically by means of the aforementioned probing spiritual fire in order to become efficacious. To leave them “uncooked” is potentially dangerous to one’s spiritual well-being. Serenus’ suggestions here include, “Whoever does not have a sword should sell his tunic and buy himself a sword” (Lk 12:35) and “Whoever does not take up his cross and follow me is not worthy of me” (Mt 10:38). Understanding such verses literally leads one into trouble. Of what use is a sword for a monk? Lugging around a real cross of wood yields the temptation to vainglory and merits the derision of onlookers.

Before directly addressing Germanus’ original questions about the origin of demonic spirits, Serenus offers the following advice. If a literal interpretation of a particular verse seems efficacious, then one may confidently offer an opinion. If, however, the meaning is obscure, then there is reason for caution. The section in question must be considered slowly, carefully, and prayerfully. Any interpretations that may emerge have to be measured against the rule of faith in order to ensure fidelity and avoid erroneous belief.

Conlationes 14

Conlationes 14 is Cassian’s longest and most focused treatment of the manner in which scripture ought to be interpreted. It is presided over by Abba Nesteros, whom Cassian introduces very briefly as a man “of the highest knowledge and outstanding in every regard.”¹⁸ His credentials established, the abba’s teaching follows directly and

¹⁸ *Praeclari in omnibus summaeque scientiae* (Conl. 14.1.1).

begins with the assertion that there are many different kinds of arts and disciplines in the world.¹⁹ Each contains its own kind of knowledge, instruction methods, and governing principles. In order to become adept in any profession one must adhere to its particular modes of development. So, too, for those who choose to adopt the religious life.

For Nesteros, unlike other professions, the monastic endeavor is oriented toward the contemplation of “secrets of invisible mysteries (*invisibilium sacramentorum arcana*)” and eternal salvation rather than any material or earthly gain. As such, it has its own defined procedures and is comprised of two kinds of knowledge. The first is identified as *praktikē* (*actualis*) and concerns the eradication of vice and the development of virtue. The second Nesteros labels *theōrētikē* (*theoretica/contemplativa*) and is more narrowly confined to the contemplation and interpretation of scripture.²⁰ Nesteros then addresses each form of knowledge in turn using language of ascent to assert repeatedly throughout the remainder of the conference that one cannot gain the insight of *contemplativa* (spiritual/theoretical knowledge) without first having mastered the *actualis* (practical knowledge). The abba sees this as a divinely scripted order that, if followed assiduously, allows for the monk to rise from mundane experience to sublime heights. Yet, no shortcuts exist for the one who “strives for the vision of God (*ad conspectum dei tendit*).” One must have a firm understanding of what must be accomplished in order for progress to be made.

To this end Nesteros teaches that the attainment of practical knowledge is a two-step process. One must first learn the nature of the vices that pollute the soul and the means by which they may be

¹⁹ Like Abba Serenus' image of scripture as an abundant field, Nesteros' words here point to Cassian's *Conl.* 1 and Abba Moses' assertion that all the “arts and disciplines” have their own goals and ends.

²⁰ Although *praktikē* and *theōrētikē* are not specified until Cassian's *Conl.* 14.1 and 14.2, they are conceptually present throughout the *Conlationes*. Cassian feels compelled here to use the Greek terms, which suggests their centrality in eastern monastic thought.

overcome.²¹ The second step involves “discerning the sequence of the virtues and forming our mind by their perfection.”²² As the monk progresses in overcoming the temptations and distractions of human existence and begins to practice virtue, so these virtues begin to have an ontological effect. Slowly they shape his mind so that their continued exercise becomes a joy, and the monk is filled with delight as he climbs the “hard and narrow way (*arduum atque angustam viam*)” of religious life. Again and again the image of climbing and reaching upward is used to emphasize the difficulty of the task, and any heights achieved do not preclude the possibility of a fall. Yet, the prize – the vision of God – is at the summit, so a base camp first must be maintained before any attempt to reach the top is possible.

Nesteros also divides theoretical knowledge, deep insight into the sacred text, into two kinds. Echoing Abba Serenus, the meaning of scripture is communicated according to either “historical interpretation (*historicam interpretationem*)” or “spiritual understanding (*intellegantiam spiritalem*).” The spiritual sense is further subdivided into three kinds: allegory (*allēgoria*), anagogy (*anagōgē*), and tropology (*tropologia*). Nesteros gives each a brief description. A historical understanding equates to Serenus’ literal reading, the text in its “raw” state. On this level, scripture is easily understood, because it relates real events and proclaims universal truths the very recitation of which is efficacious.²³ The biblical narrative also can be read allegorically when it is recognized that some historical person, place, thing, or event could have “prefigured the form of another mystery (*alterius sacramenti formam praefigurasse*).” Anagogical interpretation comprises the third level and is appropriate when scripture points to the most sublime and heavenly secrets that are not realized on earth, but shall come to pass eschatologically. The text speaks tropologically when it provides “moral explanation pertaining to correction

²¹ Of course, the implicit suggestion on Cassian’s part is that such information exists in the *Institutiones*.

²² *Discernatur ordo virtutum earumque perfection nostra formatur* (Conl. 14.3.1). This is, arguably, one of the goals of the *Conlationes*.

²³ Cassian again uses the *Shema* as an example.

of life and to practical instruction.”²⁴ Cassian provides just a few examples of scripture that can be read each way but rather succinctly moves on to a point of singular importance that underlies any access to scriptural obscurity.

At the beginning of chapter 9, Cassian has Nesteros proclaim that those who genuinely wish to gain the ability to read and understand scripture beyond the literal level, those who aspire to the light of spiritual knowledge, first will be “inflamed with desire (*cupiditate flammamini*)” to fulfill the words of Mt 5:8, “Blessed are the pure of heart, for they shall see God.” Significantly, it is the monk’s encounter with these words of Scripture that leads him toward a path whose end is profound understanding of scriptural mystery. Scripture becomes the beginning and ending of the monastic endeavor. So, too, does it become the very medium by which the process unfolds. For Nesteros, continual engagement with the biblical narrative is a fundamental exercise for those who forsake worldly concerns for the kingdom of heaven. He advises Germanus and Cassian to maintain their diligence in reading it, but even while doing so they need to “get a complete grasp of practical – that is, ethical – discipline as soon as possible,” because this is the only way the text will begin to make more and more sense.²⁵ Those who have achieved the fullness of theoretical insight have done so as a reward for their efforts in purifying their minds and hearts first.²⁶ They have found perfection “not in the words of other teachers but in the virtuousness of their own acts.”²⁷ Nesteros then cites Ps 101:1–2, “I will sing and I will understand in the undefiled way,” for two reasons. First, the verse stands as a proof text for his argument. Second, recitation of the Psalms constituted one of the primary

²⁴ *Moralis explanatio ad emundationem vitae et instructionem pertinens actualalem* (Conl. 14.8.3).

²⁵ *Omni studio festinate actualam, id est ethicam quam primum ad integrum comprehendere disciplinam* (Conl. 14.9.2).

²⁶ Nesteros does not specify from whom the reward originates, but given Cassian’s overall emphasis on the need for grace in the pursuit of sanctity, the intended giver is divine.

²⁷ *Non alium docentum verbis, sed propriorum actuum virtute* (Conl. 14.9.2).

means of prayer in monastic practice and therefore belonged to the realm of practical discipline. So Nesteros can confidently assert that “the one who is singing the psalm, who is moving forward in the undefiled way with the stride of a pure heart, will understand what is sung.”²⁸ The abba then sums up his teaching thus far by declaring it impossible for any monk even slightly distracted by worldly concerns to gain spiritual insight into the meaning of scripture or faithfully commit them to memory.

The monk ought to address any terrestrial deviations in terms of intent and orientation and then devote himself “assiduously and even constantly to sacred reading” so that the text “fills [the] mind and forms it in its likeness.”²⁹ Herein we see the value of scripture as the means for scaling the heights of spiritual perfection. Being so engaged with its content and with the goal of memorizing it in its entirety provides the mind with a focus that ought to prevent the intrusion of distracting and harmful thoughts. The more the monk is able solely to live within scripture, so to speak, the clearer its meaning becomes to such an extent that Nesteros suggests that hidden mysteries will become apparent even while the monk slumbers. The profundity of a monk’s insight, or lack thereof, is directly related to the monk’s moral growth. In a rare moment of self-disclosure, Cassian notes that he despondently reacted to the abba’s words, for he has a particular problem that he believes inhibits his spiritual progress and is stubbornly resistant to his attempts to overcome it. As the result of secular learning acquired before his adoption of the monastic vocation, Cassian’s mind is plagued by images produced from fables and mythic literature. Now when he sings the psalms or offers prayers of supplication a “vision of warring heroes passes before my eyes” and daydreams mock and frustrate any attempt to purge the distractions.³⁰

²⁸ *Psallens intellet quae canuntur, qui in via immaculata gressu puri cordis innititur* (Conl. 14.9.3).

²⁹ *Adsiduum te ac potius iugem sacrae praebeas lectioni, donec continua meditation inbuat mentem tuam et quasi in similitudinem sui format* (Conl. 14.10.2).

³⁰ *Bellantium heroum ante oculos imago versetur* (Conl. 14.12).

Nesteros is unfazed by Cassian's admission and offers a "speedy and effective (*satis atque efficax*)" remedy that already has been emphasized. Demonstrating a level of psychological acumen that recalls *Conl.* 1, the abba asserts that the storehouse of Cassian's mind is filled with the poems he has learned in his youth, so it will naturally indulge in them until it has some other material to harvest.³¹ If Cassian could dedicate himself to the reading and consideration of Scripture with the same level of intensity he displayed as a student, then his flights of fancy will gradually be replaced by more sublime pursuits. Yet constant and diligent attention is required, for any lapse allows the mind to revert back to its old ways. If successful, though, Nesteros speaks of scripture in a way that suggests it infiltrates the monk's very being and finds expression in his life. Key, then, for Cassian is a constant immersion in the sacred text, which has a formative effect based on the extent to which the individual can remain diligent and work toward a purification of mind/heart and intent.

Purity of heart

As one can glean from the prefaces to his works, when Cassian arrived in Marseilles he found a Gallic form of monasticism that according to his standards was loose and lacking in discipline, definition, and heritage.³² He seized the opportunity offered by ecclesial request to provide something of a corrective by composing the *Institutiones* and *Conlationes*.³³ Cassian understood the monastic

³¹ Nesteros' observations recall Abba Moses' characterization of the mind as a millstone that by nature of the human condition is constantly spinning. We cannot prevent it from spinning, but we can decide what subjects, or "grain," to have it grind. Worldly topics produce nothing of value, but spiritual ones contribute to the purification of the heart. See Cassian, *Conl.* 1.17–18.

³² For instance, in *Inst.* Praef. 8 Cassian contrasts western Gallic practices with those of the East, which have rigor and apostolic tradition on their side. See C. Leyser, "Lectio divina, oratio pura: Rhetoric and the Techniques of Asceticism in the *Conferences* of John Cassian," in G. Barone et al. (eds.), *Modelli di santità e modelli di comportamento* (Turin: Rosenberg and Selier, 1994), 79–105.

³³ As noted earlier the *Institutiones* is composed ostensibly at the request of Castor, bishop of Aptia Iulia until 426, who was seeking Cassian's counsel regarding the

life to be a progressive and emulative endeavor. A way of life is rooted in instruction, discipline, emulation, and contemplation. To advance this view he organized his writings around several concepts that introduce and nurture the eremitic ideals in which he was trained. Perhaps the most basic of these is the *scopos/telos* (*destinatio/finis*) point of view articulated in *Conl.* 1 that orients a monk's life and establishes lived experience as the primary hermeneutical medium for understanding the sacred text.³⁴

The first image Cassian uses in the *Conlationes* proper is that of "spiritual soldiery (*militiae spiritalis*)."³⁵ The Christian life as one of spiritual combat was a common enough motif in antiquity, and even more so for Christian monastic life, yet Cassian introduces it here in order to emphasize the seriousness with which he understands the monastic endeavor and identify an unwavering standard with which all who seek to pursue such a life ought to be familiar. The aspirant ought to have a sense of what to expect and what measure of effort will be expected of him. As in any combat scenario, determination and strategy are key to success. To be a good spiritual soldier one must identify his enemy, become familiar with what weapons one has available and how best to use them, and develop an action plan designed to attain victory. Cassian's action plan for monastic success is fundamentally eschatological. It identifies a finite goal, or *scopos*, toward which the monk must progress, and a transcendent end, or *telos*, that a monk may briefly sense in this life but can only fully experience after his death. Via the person of Abba Moses in *Conl.* 1 Cassian identifies the *scopos*, the primary goal of monastic life, as "purity of heart (*puritas cordis*)" and the *telos* as the kingdom of heaven. Achieving the former makes entrance into the latter

establishment of monasteries in his diocese. The *Conlationes* is similarly dedicated to other recognized authorities including Leontius and Helladius (*Conl.* 1–10), Honoratus and Eucherius (*Conl.* 11–17), and Jovinianus, Minervus, Leontius, and Theodore (*Conl.* 18–24).

³⁴ In *Conl.* 1.2, Cassian transliterates *scopos* and *telos* from Greek, which again hints at their centrality for the eastern eremitic tradition.

³⁵ Cassian does so as he introduces his friendship with Germanus in *Conl.* 1.1: *cum quo mihi ab ipso tirocinio ac rudimentis militiae spiritalis*.

possible. Therefore, Cassian insists that a monk's success hinges on his ability to commit unreservedly with "an encompassing diligence and perseverance (*omni studio perseverantiaque*)" to the attainment of purity of heart.³⁶

The nature of *puritas cordis* and how it may be achieved are the main concerns for both the *Institutiones* and the *Conlationes*. Here one can note another theme important to his progressive strategy when, in the preface to the *Conlationes*, Cassian purports to "proceed from the external and visible life of the monks, which we have summarized in the previous books, to the invisible character of the inner man."³⁷ The previous books to which he refers are the *Institutiones*, the first four books of which concern themselves with the seemingly mundane things of ordinary monastic life. They represent a kind of "boot camp" for those wishing to become spiritual soldiers. Cassian wants his audience to know what is expected of those who choose to enter the vocation, so he tells them exactly the sort of clothes they should wear, how their days ought to be structured, what sort of prayers should be said, how novices ought to be received, and so on. Although such practicalities appear mundane since they suggest no obvious relation to deep spiritual insight, Cassian is convinced that one can make no spiritual progress whatsoever if one does not have a firm foundation. Cassian explains to his audience the way things were done while he was in Egypt studying with the acknowledged masters. The implication is that if these Gallic monks want to get this thing right, they ought to follow Cassian's advice. Mastering the external features of monastic life, making it through boot camp, prepares the "inner man" to focus on the much more daunting challenge of approaching purity of heart. The remaining eight books of the *Institutiones* begin this turn inward by identifying the eight principle vices that inhibit spiritual insight and growth: gluttony, fornication, avarice, anger, sadness, acedia, vainglory, and pride. Here the monk comes face to face with his enemy, and it is he. By adopting and

³⁶ *Conl.* 1.4.1.

³⁷ *Ab exterior ac visibili monachorum cultu, quem prioribus digessimus libris, ad invisibilem interioris hominis habitum transeamus* (*Conl.* 1, Praef. 5).

faithfully maintaining the rigorous and “external” obligations of practical monastic life, though, the monk has created conditions favorable for him to arm himself by cultivating virtue and embracing the spiritual ideals expressed in the *Conlationes*. It is in this text that what Cassian means by purity of heart and its importance as a hermeneutical concept come into better focus.

In the preface to the *Conlationes*, Cassian urges those who have read and assimilated the *Institutiones* to consider themselves worthy of the name of Jacob, since they have proven themselves ready to receive further spiritual instruction toward the transformation of the inner man. This is a significant image to which we shall return, for it has a direct bearing on Cassian’s hermeneutics. At this point, however, the transformation to which Cassian alludes means the cultivation of purity of heart. What this means precisely is somewhat problematic, for nowhere does the *Conlationes* provide a concise definition of *puritas cordis*. Rather, the term is a comprehensive one used to describe a state of being experienced by those who have advanced far along the path of overcoming self. In the text it is linked and equated with love, chastity, holiness, tranquility, perfect prayer, and, most notably for the present volume, profound spiritual insight.³⁸ Cassian’s source for the term is, of course, Mt 5:8, “Blessed are the pure in heart, for they shall see God.” As such, it is the biblical proof text that links Cassian’s monastic goal with its eschatological end. Just as the concept has a biblical origin, so too for Cassian does it point as much back to the sacred text in a way that allows for some sense of divine revelation that is penultimate to the heavenly beatific vision. In other words, scripture is both the beginning and ending of the monastic endeavor. More so, it provides the *scopos* and is itself a principal medium by which one can progress toward it.

One of the metaphors Cassian uses to describe monastic life is the “royal road (*via regia*).” It is a difficult but exalted path along which

³⁸ See J. Raasch, “The Monastic Concept of Purity of Heart and Its Sources,” *Studia Monastica* 8 (1970), 7–41; Stewart, *Cassian*, 42–7; J. Morgan, “Obedience in Egyptian Monasticism According to John Cassian,” *St. Vladimir’s Theological Quarterly* 55/3 (2011), 271–91.

the monk must travel, moving ever closer to the *telos*. Like purity of heart, the image derives from the sacred text. In this case Cassian references Nm 20, in which Moses, still leading Israel back to the Promised Land, sends envoys to the Edomites pledging to remain on the “king’s road” and not turn off to the right or left into their territory and thereby make a nuisance of themselves.³⁹ The Israelites just want to pass through Edomite territory, and the royal road was the straightest and surest path. Cassian allegorizes Israel’s journey to the Promised Land as the monk’s journey toward the kingdom of heaven. Along this path the monk must cultivate a similar focus and not “turn left or right” by being distracted by successes or failures in the spiritual life. This singular attention can be maintained as the monk develops the virtue of “discretion (*discretio*),” a key ability for Cassian. Embarking on this journey means taking the first steps toward purity of heart. To mix metaphors for a minute, it also means igniting the “probing spiritual fire” to which Abba Serenus referred in *Conl.* 8 and on which scripture ought to be “cooked.”

For Cassian, one begins to walk along the *via regia* after accepting a vocational calling that ultimately originates with God. Progress is then measured by one’s ability to make it through the boot camp and basic training of monastic garb and routine articulated in the *Institutiones*. The focus then shifts to the elimination of vice and the cultivation of virtue, for it is by such means that purity of heart is nurtured. As part of this process the monk learns how to use various tools at his disposal to assist his growth. Abba Moses recalls the constant labor, deprivation, and loneliness of an eremitic life. So too for the sake of the kingdom “the hunger of fasting does not weary us, the exhaustion of keeping vigils delights us, and the continual reading of and meditating on scripture does not sate us.”⁴⁰

³⁹ For other uses of the *via regia*, see J. Leclercq, *The Love of Learning and the Desire for God: A Study of Monastic Culture*, 3rd ed., trans. C. Misrahi (New York: Fordham University Press, 1982), 102–5.

⁴⁰ *Ob quem nos ieiuniorum inedia non fatigat, vigiliarum lassitudo delectat, lectio ac meditatio scripturarum continuata non satiat* (Cassian, *Conl.* 1.2.3).

Asceticism, prayer, and engagement with scripture are mainstays for Cassian's monastic ideal. However, they can be beneficial only to the extent that the monk realizes that they are means and not ends in themselves. Frustration over failure or elation over success with regard to such practices can blind one to their true purpose, thereby causing the monk to veer to the left or right of the *via regia*. These spiritual exercises are undertaken in order to prime the conditions for the maturation of purity of heart, and their value is determined by the aforementioned virtue of discretion. Cassian spends an entire conference (*Conl.* 2) on what *discretio* means and how it ought to be cultivated. Ramsey adroitly summarizes his thought when he suggests that discretion is "the judgment whereby a person discerns what is correct and, in particular, avoids excess of any kind, even of the apparent good."⁴¹ It is a skill that is learned through instruction and emulation. The monk receives instruction from those superiors who already have advanced toward the monastic *scopos* and attempts to emulate their dedication and zeal. However, scripture also plays an integral part in this quest. In its pages also can be found archetypes who model the kind of spiritual accomplishment toward which the monk must strive.

Within the *Conlationes* Cassian names Abraham, Moses, Job, and many others as exemplars of various monastic virtues, but a striking reference that most succinctly expresses his *scopos/telos* agenda appears in *Conl.* 1 when he relates Jesus' visit to the home of Martha and Mary in the tenth chapter of Luke's gospel. When Jesus and his disciples arrive Martha heads straight to the kitchen and busies herself with providing for her guests. Mary, however, drops to Jesus' feet and is enraptured by his presence. Martha is frustrated by her sister's lack of assistance and asks Jesus to tell her to come and help. Jesus' response is that Martha is distracted by too many things and that Mary has made the better choice. For Cassian, Martha represents a novice monk, one who has not progressed far along the *via regia* and requires further purification of worldly distraction and cultivation of virtue, symbolized in the biblical

⁴¹ Ramsey, *Conferences*, 78.

narrative as charity. Mary, however, has advanced into the realm of *theoria* and has the ability to recognize as suitably contemplative the divine presence. She anticipates in some measure the final *scopos* (purity of heart) and *telos* (the beatific vision) that orient the monastic endeavor. Cassian uses the two sisters as spiritual benchmarks whose examples the diligent monk should strive to emulate by internalizing the narrative and bringing it to life in his own quest. So, if engagement with scripture fosters the development of purity of heart, how does the achievement of that *scopos* affect scriptural interpretation? For Cassian, everything hinges on Mt 5:8. As the practical exercises of monastic life begin to eliminate vice and cultivate virtue, so the monk's being becomes more attuned to the deeper significance of the sacred text, which is itself a reflection of the divine visage. This is why Cassian's use of Jacob in the first preface of the *Conlationes* is so important. Gn 32 relates the curious wrestling match Jacob endures with a stranger by the river Jabbok. After prevailing in the night-long struggle Jacob's name is changed to Israel, a word Cassian would have understood to mean "the one who sees God."⁴² The patriarch's perseverance merits him the beatific vision. Symbolically, Jacob's contest represents the monk's own battle to persevere along the path to purity of heart and ascend into *theoria*, in which the face of God is reflected in the scriptural text.

Method or antimethod?

A hermeneutical strategy that suggests that scripture reveals itself in relation to the sanctity of the reader can be construed as rather unmethodical. In addition, Cassian warned against the interpretations of biblical commentators. Yet his is not a wholesale rejection of learning. His critique is with those who have not proven themselves by the examples of their lives and veracity of intent. The boastful

⁴² For the etymology of the term see R. Hayward, *Interpretations of the Name Israel in Ancient Judaism and Some Early Christian Writings: From Victorious Athlete to Heavenly Champion* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2005), 330–3.

words of those swelled with pride by their rhetorical flourish may sound impressive to novices, but their intellectual ability devoid of practical humility can only contribute to error. So the fault lies in the moral fiber of the individual, not in the practice of instruction. Indeed, it was common practice for eastern monks who would live isolated or apart for most of the time to come together on an at least weekly basis for what became known as the synaxis, or “gathering.” At such meetings the order of the day was for monks to ask questions of their abba. The synaxis offered an opportunity for confusion to be cleared up and goals to be set. The practice was communal, conversational, and practical. Surely, too, instruction is the very *raison d’être* for the *Institutiones* and the *Conlationes*.

Cassian wrote the latter work in the form of dialogue precisely because it is faithful to the way that the earliest monks learned. In choosing to adopt this format Cassian echoed the practice of the ascetic forefathers and does justice to the tradition. Additionally, dialogue is a sophisticated means by which an author can affect the reader. The question and answer format arranged in the context of a conversation between individuals puts Cassian’s readers into the presence of the desert abbats in a virtual sense. A form of role-playing is possible, in which the reader assumes the role of the monk seeking perfection and Cassian’s book becomes the portable abba. Although he would have been held in high esteem as someone who had actually lived and trained in Egypt, Cassian’s astute use of desert fathers as characters in his conferences removes their advice from the possibility of error. Recall that his goal is to institute orthodox, Egyptian monastic ideals and practices in a place that has no heritage or common rule of its own. What better way than to produce a text that becomes, *de facto*, authoritarian?

Cassian’s articulation of the fourfold senses of scripture in *Conl.* 14 demonstrates his acumen for discerning multiple interpretations within the biblical narrative. Yet, underlying all such intellectual exercise is his firm resolve that only the lived experience of the monk dedicated to the pursuit of purity of heart affords the possibility of ascending to the light of spiritual insight and thereby contemplating the divine presence hidden in scripture.

FURTHER READING

- Harmless, W. *Desert Christians: An Introduction to the Literature of Early Monasticism*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2004, 373–413.
- Kelly, C. *Cassian's Conferences: Scriptural Interpretation and the Monastic Ideal*. Burlington: Ashgate, 2012.
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Junillus Africanus' hermeneutics
Antioch and beyond

Peter W. Martens and Alden Bass

Introduction

Junillus Africanus served as the chief legal minister in the court of Justinian I from 542 to his death, ca. 549 CE.¹ During his imperial service in Constantinople he wrote a Latin treatise on biblical interpretation entitled the *Instituta Regularia Divinae Legis* (*Handbook of the Basic Principles of Divine Law*).² This hermeneutical treatise was first mentioned by Cassiodorus, who probably received his copy of the work during an extended stay in Constantinople in the 550s. In book 1 of his *Institutions of Divine and Secular Learning* (ca. 560s) Cassiodorus writes:

After reading this work [i.e., the *Institutions*], our first concern should be to consider introductory manuals to Divine Scripture that I previously found, i.e., Tyconius the Donatist, St. Augustine *On Christian Learning*, Adrian, Eucherius, and Junilius. I have acquired their works with great care, and have united and gathered them into one collection since they have a similar purpose. By arranging the rules of usage to elucidate the

¹ For more on Junillus (with bibliography), see M. Maas, with E. G. Mathews, Jr., *Exegesis and Empire in the Early Byzantine Mediterranean: Junillus Africanus and the Instituta Regularia Divinae Legis*, Studien und Texte zu Antike und Christentum 17 (Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 2003), 1–6. Junillus' name is sometimes spelled "Junilius"; see E. Stein, "Deux questeurs de Justinien et l'emploi des langues dans ses nouvelles," *Académie Royale de Belgique Bulletins de la Classe des Lettres* 23 (1937), 365–90, at 378–9.

² *CPL*: 872. There have been a few debates about the dating of the work. For a helpful overview, see Maas, *Exegesis and Empire*, 13–16.

text, and by comparisons of various examples, they have clarified what was hitherto obscure.³

Cassiodorus' endorsement of Junillus ensured that his *Handbook* was read by medieval and early modern exegetes and theologians, among whom traces of this work can be detected.⁴ The *editio princeps* of the *Handbook* was printed in 1545 by Johannes Gastius in Basel on the basis of a single manuscript.⁵ A number of subsequent editions were produced before Heinrich Kihn published the last modern critical edition based on a wider (though still incomplete) examination of the manuscript tradition.⁶ This text, including its apparatus, has been reproduced by Michael Maas and supplied with a facing English translation.⁷

The *Handbook* is addressed to Primasius of Hadrumentum, a North African bishop introduced to Junillus when he came to Constantinople to conduct business for his province.⁸ It is composed in the form of a dialogue "with the students asking questions and

³ Cassiodorus, *Inst.* 1.10.1 (*Cassiodori Senatoris Institutiones*, ed. R. A. B. Mynors [Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1937], 34; Cassiodorus, *Institutions of Divine and Secular Learning and On the Soul*, trans. J. W. Halporn, Translated Texts for Historians 42 [Liverpool: Liverpool University Press, 2004], 133). In addition to Augustine's *On Christian Learning* and Junilius' *Handbook of the Basic Principles of Divine Law*, the works to which Cassiodorus refers are: Tyconius, *Book of Rules*, Adrian, *Introduction to the Divine Scriptures*, and Eucherius, *Formulas of Spiritual Intelligence and Instructions to Saloni*.

⁴ Maas, *Exegesis and Empire*, 3, n. 10; 33, n. 124; 34, n. 127 (bibliographies).

⁵ See discussion by H. Kihn, *Theodor von Mopsuestia und Junilius Africanus als Exegeten, nebst einer kritischen Textausgabe von des letzteren: Instituta regularia divinae legis* (Freiburg: Herder, 1880), 299–301.

⁶ For discussion of these previous editions, including the manuscript basis of Kihn's own edition, see *Theodor und Junilius*, 299–312; for Kihn's critical text, 465–528.

⁷ J. F. Collins has produced another more literal, though also more accurate, translation to which we have also referred: <http://faculty.georgetown.edu/jod/texts/junillus.trans.html> (accessed February 2015).

⁸ It is likely that Primasius was part of a larger North African delegation that visited Constantinople after the Synod of Byzacena in 541/2 CE. For more on Primasius, see Kihn, *Theodor und Junilius*, 248–54; J. Haussleiter, *Leben und Werke des Bischofs Primasius von Hadrumentum: Eine Untersuchung* (Erlangen: E. Th. Jacob, 1887); Stein, "Deux questeurs," 365–90.

the teacher answering” (Pref.)⁹ and published “in two very slender books” (Pref.). The break between these books, however, does not coincide with the division between the two main topics of this work. In 1.1, Junillus draws a distinction between the “form of its discourse (*species dictionis*)” – which he also calls its “surface (*superficies*; *superficies dictionis*)” – and its content (*res*).¹⁰ This distinction provides the thematic structure of the work. The first part of the *Handbook* discusses five subtopics of Scripture’s *superficies*: genre (history, prophecy, proverbs, and simple teaching) (1.3–6), authority (canonicity) (1.7), authorship (1.8), modality (prose and verse) (1.9), and the arrangement and chief characteristics of the Old and New Testaments (1.10). At this juncture (still in book 1), Junillus transitions the reader to his second main topic: the message of Scripture. “It teaches us three things: it speaks either about God, or about our own age, or about the future” (1.11). For the remainder of the *Handbook*, Junillus elucidates various ways in which Scripture speaks of God (1.12–20) and discusses a range of topics that concern the “present age” (2.1–13), as well as the “age to come” (2.14–25).

⁹ Junillus marks the inquiry by the students (*discipuli*) with the Greek letter *delta* (Δ) and the teacher’s (*magister*) response with the letter *mu* (Μ). The question-and-answer format suggests use in a schoolroom, though we have no knowledge of formal catechetical schools in North Africa. The treatise was likely composed with a view toward Justinian’s vision of Christian education across the empire. During this period, several such textbooks were published in Latin for the benefit of students, including a condensation of Priscian’s eighteen-volume work on Latin grammar, the *Quaestiones medicinales* by Ps.-Soranus, as well as the legal work of Justinian himself. See J. A. S. Evans, *The Age of Justinian: The Circumstances of Imperial Power* (New York: Routledge, 1996), 19.

¹⁰ Maas renders *species dictionis* (1.1) as “sort of discourse,” but this is not what is meant here. T. F. Martin renders this phrase “architecture,” which is closer to the sense (“*Vox Pauli*: Augustine and the Claims to Speak for Paul: An Exploration of Rhetoric at the Service of Exegesis,” *Journal of Early Christian Studies* 8 [2000], 237–72, at 251). Maas also misleadingly renders *superficies dictionis* (2.1) – which is intended by Junillus as a synonymous expression with *species dictionis* – as “literal meaning.” The *superficies dictionis* of Scripture is not its “literal meaning,” as is clear from the subtopics that constitute it: Scripture’s “genre, authority, author, manner, and order” (1.2). S.v. *superficies*, *Oxford Latin Dictionary*, ed. P. G. W. Glare (Oxford: Clarendon, 1982), definition 1: “the upper part of anything, the top; b. the upper layer, surface.”

This is by far the longer of the two sections. The work concludes with a series of theological reflections loosely connected to the foregoing material (2.26–30).

Junillus' *Handbook* remains an underappreciated early Christian introduction to the Bible.¹¹ Yet there are a number of interesting features of this work, including its continual use of distinctions that go back to Aristotle's *Categories*;¹² how it represents (or does not represent) Justinian's orthodoxy; the ways in which it is *not* an introduction to Scripture (there are a number of chapters where no biblical texts are discussed and the *Handbook* appears to slide in the direction of straightforward catechesis: e.g., 1.18, 2.9); its audience and how it might have been used in mid-sixth-century North Africa; its place in the transmission of documents and ideas around the Mediterranean world, particularly from the East to the West; and its relationship to other North African biblical commentary of the same time.

This chapter will tackle one of the most striking and debated features of the *Handbook*: its relationship to the so-called Antiochene school of biblical scholarship. For our purposes, "Antiochene" writings will include the works of Diodore of Tarsus (d. ca. 390), Theodore of Mopsuestia (ca. 352–428), and Adrian (ca. fifth through sixth centuries), whose *Introduction to the Divine Scriptures* draws extensively from Theodore's *Commentary on the Psalms*. The *Handbook* provides us a window into one of the ways in which the

¹¹ Fleeting mention by M. Simonetti, *Biblical Interpretation in the Early Church*, trans. J. A. Hughes (Edinburgh: T & T Clark, 1994), 115–16, and by C. Kannengiesser, *Handbook of Patristic Exegesis*, vol. 2 (Leiden: Brill, 2004), 1326. It is not mentioned by F. M. Young, *Biblical Exegesis and the Formation of Christian Culture* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1997); P. Magdalino and R. Nelson (eds.), *The Old Testament in Byzantium*, Dumbarton Oaks Byzantine symposia and colloquia (Washington, DC: Dumbarton Oaks Research Library and Collection, 2010); the first two volumes of A. J. Hauser and D. F. Watson (eds.), *A History of Biblical Interpretation* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2003–9); nor J. C. Paget and J. Schaper (eds.), *New Cambridge History of the Bible*, vol. I, *From the Beginnings to 600* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2013).

¹² See especially P. Bruns, "Bemerkungen zur biblischen Isagogik des Junilius Africanus," *Studia Ephemeridis Augustinianum* 68 (2000), 401–3.

Antiochene exegetical tradition was transmitted into the sixth century via the Nisibene school, one of its students, Paul, and ultimately the author of our treatise, Junillus. While Junillus never mentions these Antiochene authors by name, he speaks warmly of the School of Nisibis, an institution that was shaped in some measure by Theodore in the sixth century.¹³ In the preface addressed to Primasius, Junillus recounts the aforementioned conversation that they had had in Constantinople:

As is your [Primasius'] custom, you asked straightaway whether there might be someone among the Greeks who burned with a passion for understanding the divine books. I replied to this question that I had seen a certain man called Paul, a Persian by origin, who was educated at the Syrian School in the city of Nisibis, where the Divine Law is taught in a disciplined and orderly fashion by public teachers in the same way that in a secular education grammar and rhetoric are taught in our cities.

Junillus continues:

Then, when you asked repeatedly if I possessed any of his works (*ex eius dictis*), I said that I had read certain rules (*regulas quasdam*) with which he used to initiate his students who were being trained in the surface (*superficies*) of the divine scriptures, before he disclosed the depths (*profunda*) of interpretation (Maas modified).

Then Junillus links Paul's exegetical program with his own *Handbook*:

You, Father, judged these matters to be essential for all Christians willing to be enlightened, and you have compelled me, excusing myself

¹³ That Junillus, employed in Justinian's court, should not mention Theodore by name is not surprising, since Justinian was in the process of condemning Theodore in an attempt to mollify miaphysite Christians. See A. H. Becker, "The Dynamic Reception of Theodore of Mopsuestia in the Sixth Century: Greek, Syriac, and Latin," in S. F. Johnson (ed.), *Greek Literature in Late Antiquity: Dynamism, Didacticism, Classicism* (Aldershot: Ashgate, 2006), 29–47, at 31. On the reception of Theodore in Nisibis, see chapter 6 of A. H. Becker, *Fear of God and the Beginning of Wisdom: The School of Nisibis and the Development of Christian Scholastic Culture in Late Antique Mesopotamia*, Divinations (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2006).

for a long time, to the impudence of publishing. For this reason I collected in two very slender books these basic rules (*regularia haec institute*) (Maas modified).¹⁴

Junillus is circumspect in this preface about the relationship between his treatise and Paul's Greek exegetical rules: he tells his readers that he collected (*college*) these rules, and a few lines later says that his two books were "furnished by another (*ab alio commodatis*).” Did he publish all of these rules, only some of them, or more than what he received from Paul? And did he modify these rules in any way, or was he offering a straightforward translation? Junillus is silent on these matters. However, a number of scholars, following Theodore Kihn's major study of Junillus, have read into this silence, presenting the *Handbook* as a straightforward transmission of Paul's principles for interpreting Scripture, principles that were ultimately derived from Theodore of Mopsuestia.¹⁵ Some have even asserted that the *Handbook* was a translation of Paul's Greek work.¹⁶ However, Junillus never claimed to be translating Paul. Indeed, a careful

¹⁴ There is some debate about the Paul to whom Junillus here refers. He is described as a Persian, who was educated in the Syrian school of Nisibis, the East Syrian intellectual center located within the borders of the Sassanian Empire. He apparently was fluent in Greek, since he answered to Primasius' request for a Greek zealous for Scripture. There are three potential Pauls of Persia, but most scholars have settled on the Paul who entered into numerous religious debates in Constantinople, some at Justinian's request. Cf. P. Bruns, "Paul der Perser," *Römische Quartalschrift* 104 (2009), 28–53; D. Gutas, "Paul the Persian on the Classification of the Parts of Aristotle's Philosophy: A Milestone between Alexandria and Baghdad," *Der Islam* 60 (1983), 231–67, at 238–9, n. 14; Becker, "Dynamic," 36; Maas, *Empire and Exegesis*, 17–18.

¹⁵ Representative of this trajectory is A. Vööbus, *History of the School of Nisibis*, CSCO 266 (Leuven: Peeters, 1965), 179–87. For additional literature, see Maas, *Exegesis and Empire*, 11, n. 20.

¹⁶ Vööbus, *School of Nisibis*, 179, n. 13; W. A. Bienert, "Die 'Instituta Regularia' des Junilius (Junillus) Africanus: Ein nestorianisches Kompendium der Bibelwissenschaft im Abendland," in M. Tamcke et al. (eds.), *Syrisches Christentum weltweit: Studium zur Syrischen Kirschengeschichte. Festschrift für Prof. W. Hage*, Studien zur orientalischen Kirchengeschichte 1 (Münster: LIT, 1995), vol. I, 307–24, at 308; Kannengiesser writes, "A loose Latin translation of a work written in Greek by the Persian, Paul of Nisibis" (*Handbook of Patristic Exegesis*, vol. II, 1326).

reading of the preface indicates that he did *not* produce a straightforward translation, since Junillus states that he actively recast Paul's Greek rules in the form of a dialogue between students and their teacher.¹⁷ Thus, the preface already indicates some form of revision. This observation is strengthened – as we will demonstrate in the following – by the recognition that a number of Junillus' exegetical remarks in the *Handbook* are more obviously attributed to a North African theological culture and Chalcedonian Christology than the Nisibene school regime of East Syria that Junillus was presenting to Primasius.

If Kihn represents one side of the spectrum on the Theodoran backdrop of the *Handbook*, Maas and Mathews represent the other. After providing a number of examples where Junillus departs from what we find in Theodore, Mathews concludes: "Thus, in light of these last few observations on certain aspects of the teaching found in Junillus' *Instituta*, it is no longer possible to accept the premise that the *Instituta* reflects the teaching of Theodore of Mopsuestia."¹⁸ But this conclusion overreaches the evidence. It does not follow that because there are some places where Junillus does not transmit Theodore's teaching; his teaching is *nowhere* to be found in the *Handbook*. As will become clear in the following, there are a number of passages where signature Antiochene stances on the process of exegesis and message of Scripture surface in Junillus' work. Without suggesting that the Nisibene exegetical culture was a Theodoran monolith, it nevertheless stands to reason that the Antiochene principles we find in the *Handbook* derived from Paul and the larger Nisibene exegetical culture. This chapter, then, is an exercise in mapping. Through a detailed analysis of several passages in the *Handbook*, we will argue that this treatise is a hybrid document, colored by a number of otherwise discrete exegetical traditions in early Christianity. While the voices of Antiochene authors are often

¹⁷ For more on this question-and-answer format in Junillus, see B. M. Mannino, "Gli *Instituta* di Giunilio: alcuni aspetti esegetici," *Annali di Storia dell'Esegesi* 8/2 (1991), 405–19.

¹⁸ Maas, *Exegesis and Empire*, 93–4.

heard in its pages, a number of other authors can also be detected.¹⁹ We are not offering an exhaustive source analysis of the *Handbook*. Nor are we claiming that Junillus had a first-hand acquaintance with all of these authors whose presence we detect in his work. But we do think that there are features of the treatise that reveal characteristic themes from a spectrum of authors, in particular those associated with the "Antiochene school."

Antiochene themes

In the concluding paragraphs of the *Handbook*, Junillus presents a summative principle for interpreting Scripture. The student interlocutor asks: "What are the particular things that we must observe in an understanding of the Divine Scriptures?" The response runs: "That the things that are spoken suit the speaker; that they are not out of accord with the reason for which they were said, and that they agree with the times, places, order, and intention" (2.28).²⁰ This response captures a foundational Antiochene exegetical procedure: to outline the *hypothesis* of a biblical book before examining its wording in a detailed fashion.²¹ The *hypothesis* usually concerns

¹⁹ Our argument deepens the insights expressed by Robert Devreesse over a half century ago, in which he quickly challenged Kihn's thesis that Junillus' work was deeply indebted to Theodore's oeuvre (cf. *Essai sur Théodore de Mopsueste*, Studi e testi 141 [Vatican City: Biblioteca Apostolica Vaticana, 1948], 273–4). More recently, Adam Becker has extended Devreesse's claim. Drawing upon research into figures such as Narsai, Jacob of Sarug, and Cosmas Indicopleustes, Becker argues that Junillus did in fact transmit Theodore's thought, but a version of it that was current in Nisibis in the sixth century. This "sixth-century Theodorism" was especially characterized by "its intermingling with a number of philosophical [Aristotelian] ideas" ("The Dynamic Reception of Theodore of Mopsuestia," 42–3).

²⁰ On this passage, see H. Kihn, *Die Bedeutung der Antiochenischen Schule auf dem exegetischen Gebiete* (Weisenberg: C. F. Meyer, 1866), 143–5.

²¹ On the importance of *hypothesis* in Diodore and Theodore's exegesis, with discussion of a number of examples, see C. Schaublin, *Untersuchungen zu Methode und Herkunft der Antiochenischen Exegese*, Theophaneia 23, Beiträge Zur Religions und Kirchengeschichte des Altertums (Köln-Bonn: P. Hanstein, 1974), 84–94.

the particular historical situation in which the book was composed: the author and circumstances of writing are identified, and there might also be observations about the audience and the larger themes or plot that run through the book. In his *Commentary on Ephesians*, Theodore outlines at length the *argumentum* (the Greek original would be *hypothesis*) of this letter, which includes a discussion of Paul's audience, its themes both doctrinal and moral, the letter's form, and a number of chronological remarks about Paul and his letters. Thereafter he writes, "We have said this for the sake of accuracy, so that no one might suppose the meaning of the divine scriptures should be accepted without reference to the occasion and historical connection (*ut ne quis absolute sensus divinarum scripturarum fortuitu existimet*)."²² Attending to the *hypothesis* of a biblical book is a guiding principle in Antiochene exegesis. Perhaps the clearest statement of the priority of the *hypothesis* is found in the concluding paragraphs of Adrian's *Introduction*. There he writes:

it is fitting that students first attend to the meaning expressed by the *hypothesis* of individual passages; then, in such a manner, this meaning properly furnishes the interpretation of the wording to them, since the link between words would be lost if the meaning is not there first. For just as with those who steer ships, if some defined target does not lie somewhere before them, toward which they intend to direct the whole weight of the rudders, they are driven through the whole sea, forced to entrust their expertise here and there to every wind as they search wanderingly for refuge in a harbor. This is what will also certainly happen in the exegetical exercises of classroom teaching, whenever it is offered without some foundational study.²³

In Junillus' preface, there is additional language, redolent of Antioch, about the larger aims and concerns surrounding scriptural interpretation at the Syrian school in Nisibis. In that city "the

²² Theodore of Mopsuestia, *The Commentaries on the Minor Epistles of Paul*, trans. R. A. Greer, Writings of the Greco-Roman World 26 (Atlanta, GA: Society of Biblical Literature, 2010), 178–9.

²³ Adrian, *Intro.* §131 (trans. Martens) (*Adrians ΕΙΣΑΓΩΓΗ ΕΙΣ ΤΑΣ ΘΕΙΑΣ ΓΡΑΦΑΣ aus neu aufgefundenen Handschriften*, ed. and trans. F. Goessling [Berlin: Reuther, 1887]).

Divine Law is taught in a disciplined and orderly fashion by public teachers in the same way that in a secular education grammar and rhetoric are taught in our cities.” A few lines later, Junillus recounts Paul’s agenda in teaching Scripture: “His purpose was that they [i.e., his students] might initially come to understand the purpose and arrangement (*intentionem ordinemque*) of these very principles which operate in Divine Law, so that each detail (*singular*) might be taught not in a haphazard and confused way, but in an orderly manner (*sed regulariter*)” (Pref.).²⁴ There are a number of points here that echo what we find in earlier Antiochene scholarship: the laudatory comparison between the Christian teaching of Scripture in Nisibis and the way grammar and rhetoric are taught by non-Christians, the importance of grasping the “purpose” and “arrangement” of Scripture, and the need to avoid “haphazard and confused” approaches to Scripture.

The closing paragraphs of Adrian’s *Introduction* offer the lengthiest surviving account of the procedures of the Antiochene project of biblical interpretation. All the points made by Junillus are also found there. While stressing the importance of attending to the *hypothesis* of passages before studying their wording, Adrian writes:

For how would it not be incredibly absurd, if it is impossible for scholars to interpret the epic poems which contain fictions . . . in any other way than by first learning the narrated setting (*hypothesis*) of each of these poems, so as to reasonably bring forth the usage of the words in regard to this setting – and not the winds – but we were to subject the words of our divine counsel to some unfounded conjectures, not being ashamed to impose random and disconnected interpretations on them?!²⁵

Here Adrian offers a similar endorsement of the “pagan” literary critics who set a standard for careful literary scholarship. He also warns, as Junillus does, against “random” interpretations of scriptural passages. In the lines that follow Adrian insists that teachers of Scripture “ought also to point out the lucidity of the word-for-word

²⁴ Maas trans. revised (taking *singula* as the subject of *docerentur*, with Collins).

²⁵ Adrian, *Intro.* §131 (trans. Martens).

interpretation”²⁶ – here Junillus’ concern to get the “details” of Scripture right are expressed. Finally, Junillus uses two technical terms that surface in high concentration in Antiochene writings: *ordo* (Greek: *akolouthia* or *taxis*) and *intentio* (Greek: *skopos*). Adrian, as well as the other Antiochenes, also argues for the importance of attending to the “sequence of words”²⁷ and grasping the “intent” of a scriptural author.²⁸

Amidst a robust analysis of scriptural types – one of the longest surviving discussions in patristic literature – Junillus delimits the circumstances in which interpreters should analyze them. Typological interpretation, he avers, “does not belong to the teaching of the rules, but to the exposition of the text (*non ad regularum doctrinam, sed ad expositionem textus pertinent*)” (2.17; trans. Martens). This striking distinction appears to echo Theodore’s famous programmatic division between exegetical commentary and exegetical preaching. In the preface to his *Commentary on John* (in Syriac), he writes, “Indeed we think that the duty of the interpreter is to explain those words which are difficult to many, while the duty of the preacher is to speak about those topics which are already clear enough.”²⁹ This distinction was directly relevant to typological interpretation – when it was suitably practiced and when it was not. In the preface to his *Commentary on Jonah*, Theodore provides a lengthy dossier of types (*tupoi*) in the Old Testament and the realities they symbolized – including the ways in which the career of Jonah forecast the ministry of Jesus. However, this is not the focus of his commentary, which leaves such a typological reading behind and studies “in detail” the story of Jonah itself: “But the happenings of that time and their record in the book [of Jonah], which provided to the people in those days the greatest

²⁶ Adrian, *Intro.* §132 (trans. Martens).

²⁷ On *akolouthia*: Adrian, *Intro.* §133; Diodore, *Ps. Prol.*; Theodore, *Ps.* 9:10, 14, 23–4 (LXX).

²⁸ On *skopos*: Adrian, *Intro.* §131; Theodore, *Comm. Hagg.* Prol.; Theodoret, *Ps. Prol.*

²⁹ Theodore of Mopsuestia, *Commentary on the Gospel of John*, trans. M. Conti, ACT (Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2010), 2.

benefit and advantage at that time, we shall come to know in detail from them.”³⁰ While working in the exegetical mode of commentary Theodore eschews a discussion of types. But not so in the homiletic setting. In his *Catechetical Homilies*, Theodore laid down the principle that the visible liturgy was a symbol of other realities:³¹ for instance, Adam in the garden was linked to the catechumen in the baptistery.³² Thus, returning to Junillus, when he assigns a discussion of types to the *expositio* of the scriptural text and not its “rules,” he appears to be endorsing Theodore’s division of exegetical labor. Typological exegesis does not belong to the part of their exegetical project that concerns its basic, orienting inquiry.

Another major distinction made by Junillus concerns the threefold content of Scripture – this is the distinction, as noted earlier, according to which most of the material in the *Handbook* is organized. Scripture speaks “either about God, or about our own age, or about the future” (1.11). The discussion of God (1.11–20) subdivides into discourse about God’s essence, persons, work, and analogical language; that is, the comparison of God with creatures (1.12). The discussion of the present age concerns primarily the creation and governance of this world. The future age concerns the long history of God’s gracious callings, beginning with Abraham and ending with the election of the nations. Each of these callings is forward looking: those in the Old Testament look forward to Christ, his calling points to the nations, and their calling points to the future, eternal life. Junillus’ threefold classification of Scripture’s message also has strong Antiochene roots. In Adrian’s *Introduction*, the author presents the central thought or theme (*dianoia*) of Scripture to be its portrayal of God’s actions in anthropomorphic terms: “It is a peculiarity of thought to fashion God’s actions – whether they transpire for benefit or for harm – from human characteristics.

³⁰ Theodore of Mopsuestia, *Commentary on the Twelve Prophets*, trans. R. C. Hill, FC 108 (Washington, DC: The Catholic University of America Press, 2004), 193.

³¹ Theodore of Mopsuestia, *Catechetical Homilies* 12.2, 10.

³² Theodore of Mopsuestia, *Catechetical Homilies* 12.25–6; 14.8. See similar *tupoi* in Junillus, *Handbook* 2.16–17.

I mean, for example, [portrayals of God fashioned] from bodily parts, or from the senses.”³³ Here Adrian anticipates Junillus’ prioritization of God as one of the central themes of Scripture, and in particular, his fourth category for how God is named: by comparison with creatures. The doctrine of present and future *katastaseis* (“ages,” “states,” “aeons”) is a hallmark of Theodore’s thought, as well as of several later authors indebted to him.³⁴ Brian Daley distinguishes the two states in Theodore as follows: “the present state, caused and dominated by Adam – a state of slavery to sin, corruption and death; and the state inaugurated by Christ, the ‘new Adam,’ which still lies ahead of us – a state of moral and physical freedom and integrity, of immortality and incorruption.”³⁵ This basic conception of salvation history in Theodore not only surfaces in Junillus’ *Handbook*, but is deemed to constitute Scripture’s overarching message.

Two other striking similarities with Antiochene writings call for attention in Junillus’ discussion of the genres of Scripture. His analysis of prophecy is nearly identical to what we find in Diodore and Adrian. Junillus defines prophecy as “the divinely inspired revelation of hidden things past, present or future” (1.4). “In the beginning God created heaven and earth” (Gn 1:1) is an example of a past prophecy; the theft committed by Gehazi (4 Reg 5:26) and Peter’s recognition of the theft by Ananias and Sapphira (Acts 5:3) are examples of concurrent prophecies; Mary’s future virginal conception is prophesied in Is 7:14. In the prologue to his *Commentary on the Psalms*, Diodore similarly writes, “Every prophetic form is

³³ Adrian, *Intro.* §2 (trans. Martens). For other programmatic statements from the Antiochenes about Scripture’s anthropomorphic language, see especially Theodore, *Ps.* 5:2; 32:6; Theodoret, *Ps.* 5:2.

³⁴ See, for instance, Theodore, *Cat. Hom.* 1.4; 3.9; *Ep. ad Gal.* 2:15; Adrian, *Intro.* §97. Cf. B. Daley, *Hope of the Early Church: A Handbook of Patristic Eschatology* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1991), 111–15; 197; P. Bruns, “Eschatologischer Ausblick: Die neue Katastase und das Leben der kommenden Welt,” in P. Burns (ed.), *Theodor von Mopsuestia: Katechetische Homilien*, Fontes Christiani 17 (Freiburg: Herder, 1994), vol. I, 63–9.

³⁵ Daley, *Hope of the Early Church*, 111–12.

divided into three – future, present, and past.”³⁶ Adrian also speaks of the “three temporal references” of prophecy and, interestingly, in the second recension of his *Introduction*, we find the exact same set of passages listed as in the *Handbook*.³⁷ Diodore's list differs only slightly: the past is found in the recollection of events in Adam's day, the present is illustrated by Peter's detection of the theft, and the future in all those passages that predict the coming of Christ.

Finally, there is the genre of proverbs, the only place in the *Handbook* where Junillus discusses allegory. He defines the proverb as “a figurative manner of speaking, saying one thing but meaning another (*Quaedam figurate locution aliud sonans, aliud sentiens*)” (1.5). This is a ubiquitous Greco-Roman definition of rhetorical allegory³⁸ and leads Junillus into a reflection on allegorical exegesis. His interlocutor asks, “Why in this form of discourse [i.e., proverbs] do we have license to consider not the text itself of the Scripture but rather its meaning (*non textum . . . sed sensum*), whereas in the other kinds [of discourse] we admit allegory mystically on the condition that it is necessary to demonstrate the reliability of the narrative?” (1.5, trans. Martens). The answer betrays a typically Antiochene worry: “Because if we are willing to admit allegory everywhere outside the proverbial form of discourse, in such a way that the truth of the narrative is weakened, we are giving our enemies room to interpret the divine books however they wish” (1.5). Here we encounter one of the recurring criticisms of allegorical exegesis by Diodore, Theodore, and Adrian: that the allegorist weakens the truth of the biblical narratives by denying their historical referents. The stock illustration of this point is Paul's “allegorization” of

³⁶ Diodore, *Ps. Prol. (Commentary on Psalms 1–51)*, trans. R. C. Hill, *Writings of the Greco-Roman World* 9 [Atlanta, GA: Society of Biblical Literature, 2005], 3; trans. modified).

³⁷ Adrian, *Intro.* §130; in the second recension, these passages can be found at *Vaticanus Graecus* 1447, f. 13r.

³⁸ E.g., Quintillian, *Inst.* 8.6.44: “Allegory . . . presents one thing in words and another in sense (*allegoria . . . aut aliud verbis aliud sensu ostendit*).” See H. Lausberg, *Handbook of Literary Rhetoric: A Foundation for Literary Study*, trans. M. T. Bliss et al. (Leiden: Brill, 1998), §§895–901.

Hagar and Sarah (Gal 4). Despite the apostle's use of "allegory," he was never denying the truthfulness of the Genesis narratives, that is, claiming that Hagar and Sarah had never actually existed when he asserted that they were symbolic of the earthly and heavenly Jerusalem, respectively.³⁹

In this section we have not provided an exhaustive analysis of the ways in which Junillus' treatise transmits earlier Antiochene biblical commentary.⁴⁰ The preceding discussion has simply aimed to demonstrate that the *Handbook* resonates with the nomenclature and themes of leading Antiochene authors such as Diodore, Theodore, and Adrian.

North African milieu

Though the *Handbook* served primarily as a vehicle for translating Antiochene interpretive strategies in the Latin West, certain western, and specifically African, elements are also embedded in the text. Junillus was a North African émigré who arrived in Constantinople around the time of Belisarius' conquest of the Vandalic kingdom in 534. His rank of *vir illustris* indicates that he probably enjoyed high social standing even before leaving North Africa.⁴¹ Certainly whatever education he received was African and Christian. A mark of his distinctive training is his preference for the *Vetus Latina* in the *Handbook*; although Jerome's Vulgate was widely accepted from the fourth century on, North Africans continued to use the more ancient translation, particularly of the Old Testament, into the sixth century.⁴² Junillus apparently knew little Greek, in spite of his high

³⁹ Diodore, *Ps. Pref.* 118; Theodore, *Ep. ad Gal.* 4:24a. For a discussion of this critique of allegory, see P. W. Martens, "Origen against History?: Reconsidering the Critique of Allegory," *Modern Theology* 28/4 (2012), 635–56.

⁴⁰ For more analysis, see Kihn, *Theodor und Junillus*, on biblical canon (344–82), and then a discussion of similarities between parts one (382–92) and two (393–464) of the *Handbook*.

⁴¹ *PLRE* IIIA, 742.

⁴² For examples of the *Vetus Latina* in the *Handbook*, see Mass, *Empire and Exegesis*, 91. For more on the Old Latin versions, see P.-M. Bogaert, "La Bible latine des origines au Moyen Âge," *Revue Théologique de Louvain* 19 (1988), 137–59, 276–314.

position in the court, and he remained most at home among the small community of Latin expatriates in Constantinople, many of whom were also native Africans.⁴³ At a moment when the Eastern imperial bureaucracy was shifting from Latin to Greek, the number of prominent Latin authors in Constantinople – including the grammarian Priscian, Marcellinus Comes, Jordanes, the African poet Corripus, and Junillus – attests to a wide Latin readership in the capital and an open line of communication to the western provinces.⁴⁴ Throughout his life, Junillus remained rooted in Roman African soil.

Indeed, the surviving evidence indicates that his primary interlocutors were North African clergy, so that he was long believed to be an African bishop until Kihn demonstrated otherwise. As a lay scholar, Junillus was in regular contact with ecclesiastical figures, and correspondence with Fulgentius of Ruspe and Fulgentius Ferrandus survives.⁴⁵ Most importantly, Junillus maintained contact with Primasius of Hadrumentum (d. 560), an African bishop who had met Junillus in 541 while he was stationed in Constantinople on ecclesiastical business and to whom he addressed the *Handbook*. Primasius was a leading western biblical scholar who had written a commentary on the Pauline epistles and on John's *Apocalypse*, the latter of which was largely derivative of Tyconius' lost commentary.⁴⁶ While in Constantinople, he had requested from Junillus a

⁴³ Procopius, *Secret History* 20.17–20. Regarding the Latin community in Eastern empire, see J. Conant, *Staying Roman: Conquest and Identity in Africa and the Mediterranean, 439–700*, Cambridge Studies in Medieval Life and Thought, 4th series, 82 (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2012), 343–49.

⁴⁴ G. Cavallo, "La circolazione libraria nell'età di Giustiniano," in G. G. Archi (ed.), *L'imperatore Giustiniano. Storia e mito*. Giornate di studio a Ravenna, 14–16 ottobre 1976, Circolo toscano de diritto romano e storia del diritto 5 (Milan: A. Giuffrè, 1978), 202–30. See also F. Nicks, "Literary Culture in the Reign of Anastasius I," in S. Mitchell and G. Greatrex (eds.), *Ethnicity and Culture in Late Antiquity* (London: Duckworth, 2000), 183–203.

⁴⁵ Mass, *Exegesis and Empire*, 29. Fulgentius, *CCL* 91; S. Stevens, "The Circle of Bishop Fulgentius," *Traditio* 38 (1982), 327–41, at 336; Ferrandus, *Epistulae*, ed. A. Mai and A. Reifferscheid, in *Florilegium Casinense* 1 (Monte Cassino: Badia di Montecassino, 1873), 193–202.

⁴⁶ *CPL* 873; *CCL* 92.

sampling of Greek exegetical texts, and the next year Junillus dutifully sent him the *Handbook*. Primasius was at the center of a network of African scholars engaged in writing, translating, and transmitting Christian works across the Mediterranean. In addition to Primasius, Verecundus of Junca (d. 551), who had accompanied Primasius to Constantinople, wrote a learned commentary on the canticles of the Old Testament.⁴⁷ Fulgentius Ferrandus (d. 552), with whom Junillus corresponded, was an important canonist responsible for transmitting and translating Eastern canons to the West.⁴⁸

The interest in Eastern theology and biblical scholarship voiced by Primasius' request was not unprecedented in North Africa. Despite the lack of Greek speakers, Antiochene theology and scriptural commentaries seem to have been present in Africa by at least the fifth century. Augustine cites Theodore as an exponent of sound teaching in his dispute with Julian of Eclanum, though he was probably unread in his theology.⁴⁹ Facundus knew of a Latin translation of Theodore in 548; some have suggested that it was translated by someone from the circle of Primasius, yet given Facundus' complaint of the poor quality of the translation, the translator was probably unknown to him.⁵⁰ Whatever their familiarity with Antiochene writers, the African bishops fiercely defended

⁴⁷ CCL 93.

⁴⁸ L. Fields, *On the Communion of Damasus and Meletius: Fourth-Century Synodal Formulae in the Codex Veronensis LX*, Studies and Texts 145 (Toronto: Pontifical Institute of Mediaeval Studies, 2004), 95–105. Likewise, Cresconius Africanus, who may have lived in this period, composed the *Concordia canonum*, a collection of canons of the fourth- and fifth-century councils and papal decretals (PL 86:829–982).

⁴⁹ Augustine, *c. Iul. imp.* 3.111.

⁵⁰ See H. B. Swete, *Theodori Episcopi Mopsuesteni in Epistolas B. Pauli commentarii: The Latin Version with the Greek Fragments* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1880), vol. I, xli. According to Bishop Pontianus of Thaenae in Byzacena, however, the works of the three condemned Antiochene theologians were not well known in Africa in the mid-sixth century. He pleads with the Emperor to at least let the bishops read them and decide for themselves regarding their orthodoxy (PL 67:995–8).

them in the Three Chapters Controversy (ca. 544–53).⁵¹ The reception of Junillus' *Handbook* in North Africa as well as the transmission and translation of Theodore's works indicates that there was a network of adherents receptive to Theodore's thought in the early Medieval West.

Besides the historical and social context of the *Handbook*'s publication and transmission, textual evidence also confirms that Junillus belongs in the African exegetical tradition. It is striking that Cassiodorus in the passage quoted earlier inserts Junillus' treatise alongside the earlier works of Tyconius and Augustine, both native Africans. The biblical text was of central importance to North African Christians; the book itself was considered divine by some Africans, not only a source of salvific revelation, but also divine as a cultural product, saturated with the Holy Spirit.⁵² African scholars had a reputation for careful biblical analysis, reaching back to the earliest Latin translations of the New Testament.⁵³ This tradition continued through the African elder Tyconius, who produced the first handbook of biblical hermeneutics in the Latin West, and reached into the sixth century when, at the outset of the Three Chapters Controversy, the papal deacons in Rome, Anatolius and

⁵¹ S. Adamiak, "Carthage, Constantinople, and Rome: Imperial and Papal Interventions in the Life of the Church in Byzantine Africa (533–698)," unpublished doctoral dissertation, Pontifical Gregorian University in Rome, 2011; R. A. Markus, "Reflections on Religious Dissent in North Africa in the Byzantine Period," *Studies in Church History* 3 (1966), 118–26. For more on the political and cultural implications of their resistance, see Conant, *Staying Roman*, 316–30.

⁵² Such divergent views on the nature of Scripture, rooted in differing conceptions of the Holy Spirit, led in part to the rupture of the African church in the early fourth century. Optatus accused the Donatists of worshiping the "law," though this veneration of Scripture was likely not confined to the *pars Donati* (*On the Donatist Schism* 7.2). For more on this phenomenon, see C. Kannengiesser, "Augustine and Tyconius: A Conflict of Christian Hermeneutics in Roman Africa," in P. Bright (ed.), *Augustine and the Bible* (Notre Dame, IN: University of Notre Dame Press, 1999), 149–77, at 157.

⁵³ G. Quispel, "African Christianity before Minucius Felix and Tertullian," in J. den Boeft and A. H. M. Kessels (eds.), *Actus: Studies in Honor of H. L. W. Nelson* (Utrecht: Instituut voor Klassieke Talen, 1982), 257–335.

Pelagius (future Pope Pelagius I), consulted the North African church because of their *scientia scriptorum*.⁵⁴

Junillus does not explicitly cite Tyconius, Augustine, or any other African exegetes. The only Latin figure mentioned by name is Jerome, who is cited as an authority on the Jewish canon.⁵⁵ Nevertheless, some of the terminology in the *Handbook* bears the imprint of the African theological tradition.⁵⁶ For instance, the terms *regula* and *lex* in the title, *Instituta Regularia Divinae Legis*, link Junillus' work to the African interpretative tradition.⁵⁷ Tyconius, in the introduction of his original exegetical work, describes it as a "little book of rules (*libellum regularem*)" which will reveal the "secrets of the law (*secretorum legis*)." "For there are certain mystic rules," he wrote, "which obtain the inner recesses of the entire law."⁵⁸ Anyone who reads Scripture by these rules will receive "illumination" and "will be kept free from straying into error."⁵⁹ The term *regula* originated as a term of forensic interpretation in the late Republican period, when it replaced the original term *definitio*, or summary description of the law as practices. A *regula* was more than a

⁵⁴ Ferrandus, *ep.* 6 (*PL* 67:921–8).

⁵⁵ Junillus explains that the Maccabees are noncanonical because "among the Jews as well they used to be received in a different fashion, as Jerome and the rest (*sicut Hieronymus ceterique*) tell us" (1.3).

⁵⁶ For more on the African background of Junillus' statements, see Mannino, "Gli *Instituta* di Giunilio," 405–19. It is difficult to judge how well *On Christian Teaching* was known in the East, but a native African such as Junillus was likely familiar with his work. Augustine's works were brought to the capital in the fifth and sixth century by Latin monks such as John Maxentius (ACO IV.2 and CCL 85A).

⁵⁷ Maas' translation of the preface is misleading in that it suggests that Paul the Persian's exegetical handbook was "entitled *Rules*" (Maas, *Empire and Exegesis*, 121). Junillus actually says that he had read "certain rules (*legissem regulas quasdam*)" of his. Unlike Tyconius, who sets out "mystical rules" for uncovering "hidden things," Junillus applied the term *regula* to the "surface (*superficies*)" of Scripture rather than its "depths (*profunda*)."⁵⁸ Hence the contention (already analyzed earlier) that the interpretation of types "does not belong to the teaching of rules but to the explication of texts" (2.17).

⁵⁸ *Tyconius: The Book of Rules*, trans. W. S. Babcock, Texts and Translations 31 (Atlanta, GA: Scholars Press, 1989), 2–3.

⁵⁹ *Ibid.*

description; it was a normative proposition which governed all situations which fell within its rationale. "In contrast to *definitio*, which looked to the past, a *regula* looked to the future since its ratio was applicable to many cases which had not yet arisen."⁶⁰ Tertullian used the word in the general sense of the *regula fidei* and other Latin writers spoke often of the *regula veritatis*, but Tyconius was the first to apply it to exegetical principles.⁶¹ Augustine's exegetical handbook, *On Christian Teaching*, expressly follows Tyconius in introducing "certain rules (*quaedam regulae*)" for interpreting Scripture in order to "illuminate" the reader.⁶²

An even clearer echo of the African exegetical tradition occurs in Junillus' discussion of the "proverbial form (*proverbialis species*)" of Scripture. Because of their metaphorical character, proverbs are the only form of biblical discourse that allow an immediate figurative interpretation. Junillus follows almost word for word the Tyconian and Augustinian distinction between the sound and the sense of texts: proverbs are "a kind of figurative speech (*figurate locution*) that says (*sonare*) one thing but means (*sentiens*) another" (1.5). Junillus' definition corresponds to that of Tyconius' sixth rule "On Recapitulation" in the *Liber regularum*: "The Spirit, without mysteries and allegories, wanted one thing to be heard (*sonare*) and another to be understood (*intelligi*)."⁶³ Augustine likewise echoed the formula in his *Enarrationes*: "Some things seem to be heard (*sonare*) in words and others to signify in the understanding (*in intellectu*)."⁶⁴

⁶⁰ P. Stein, "Interpretation and Legal Reasoning in Roman Law," *Chicago-Kent Law Review* 70/4 (1995), 1539–56, at 1540.

⁶¹ For an overview of the use of the term, see P. Blowers, "The *Regula Fidei* and the Narrative Character of Early Christian Faith," *Pro Ecclesia* 6 (1997), 199–228.

⁶² Augustine, *doc. Chr.*, Pref.

⁶³ Tyconius, *LR*, Rule 6: *Spiritus sine mysteriis vel allegoria aliud sonare aliud intelligi voluit* (Babcock, 110–11, trans. Bass).

⁶⁴ *Cum aliquid aliud uidetur sonare in uerbis, et aliud in intellectu significare* (Augustine, *en. Ps.* 103.13). Along similar lines, Junillus utilizes the Augustinian terminology of *verba*, *res*, and *opera* to distinguish between prophecy, which is a foretelling in words (*verba*), and types, which are foretellings in action (*res*) (2.16) (Augustine, *doc. Chr.* 1.6.6; *Trin.* 5.10; 7.7; *civ. Dei* 10.13; see also Mannino, "Gli *Instituta* di Giunilio," 415).

Just as Junillus betrays his African theological roots in the discussion of figurative speech in the proverbs, he also falls back on African material in his comments on the relationship between the testaments. In a seemingly marked departure from Theodore's theology, Junillus avers that the purpose of the Old Testament is "to point ahead to the New Testament by means of prefigurations and predictions (*figuris praenuntiationibusque*)" (1.11). In the second book, he repeats the principle, "The 'figures' of the Old Testament, at least in their intention, anticipate the New Testament" (2.17). Augustine likewise taught that the Old Testament was a type or shadow of the New: "For no other reason were all the things that we read in the holy Scriptures written before our Lord's coming than to announce his coming and to prefigure the Church to be."⁶⁵ He argued against the Manicheans that the Old Testament is a witness (*testificatio*) to the New and ultimately to Christ himself.⁶⁶

Perhaps the clearest hybrid element in the *Handbook* is Junillus' use of Augustine's schema of three temporal dispensations. The second book of the *Handbook* is organized around Theodore's teaching of the two ages (*katastaseis*), the present age and the age yet to come. In the works of Theodore, the present age is a time of mutability, corruption, and sin, while the coming age holds immutability, incorruption, and perfection. Biblical matters whose purpose (*intentio*) concerns the coming age include types, predictions, and effects of predictions (2.14). In the sections covering each of these three topics, Junillus introduces Augustine's tripartite subdivision of salvation history: *ante legem*, *sub lege*, *sub gratia*.⁶⁷ For example, concerning types Junillus writes:

[Types] have difference of temporal reference. For some references are before the Law (*ante legem*), as for example, Abel's murder by his brother prefigured the sufferings of Christ, and the ark of Noah was prefiguring the Church. There are other similar examples, too. Some temporal references are in the time of the Law (*sub lege*), as for example, the death of Moses and glory of Jesus. Some temporal

⁶⁵ Augustine, *cat. rud.* 3.6 and 4.8. ⁶⁶ *C. Faust.* 4.2.

⁶⁷ *C. Faust.* 6.2; see also *ex. prop. Rm.* 13–18, and *div. qu.* 67.

references are during the time of Grace (*sub gratia*), such as the clothing of the baptized and the vestments of the priests, and the sharing in the body of the Lord, and other particular things. (2.17)

Junillus likewise employs this threefold dispensational structure to “foretellings (*praedictiones*)” and the “effects (*effecti*)” of the foretellings in the following section (2.18; 2.25). It might also be noteworthy that Junillus’ repeated use of *praedictio* to refer to future events mirrors Augustine’s language,⁶⁸ and especially the language of his disciple, the Carthaginian bishop Quodvultdeus (d. ca. 453).⁶⁹ That Junillus would draw on African nomenclature for eschatological issues is unsurprising, given the prominence of scholarship on John’s Apocalypse in that region.

Finally, a series of appendices are attached to the second book of the *Handbook*, two of which bear an Augustinian stamp. First, in 2.28, the teacher asks, “What is the intention of divine teaching (*divinae doctrinae*)?” The student replies with Mt 22:37–9, “That we should love God with all our heart and from all our soul, and that we should love our neighbor as ourselves.” Augustine frequently cited the “twofold commandment” as the basis of all biblical interpretation, in *On Christian Teaching*, as well as in *On Catechizing the Uninstructed*:

It is manifest that on those two commandments of love to God and love to our neighbor hang not only all the law and the prophets, . . . but also all those books of the divine literature which have been written at a later period for our health, and consigned to remembrance . . . Take this love, therefore, as the end that is set before you, to which you are to refer all that you say, and, whatever you narrate, narrate it in such a manner that he to whom you are discoursing on hearing may believe, on believing may hope, on hoping may love.⁷⁰

⁶⁸ E.g., *s. Dom.* 1.76; *div. qu.* 45.

⁶⁹ The term is ubiquitous in his *Book of the Promises and Predictions of God* (CCL 60).

⁷⁰ Augustine, *cat. rud.* 4.8; see also *doc. Chr.* 1.26; *ep.* 155.14; *conf.* 12.25.35. Robert Grant also observed this connection between Augustine and Junillus (*A Short History of the Interpretation of the Bible* [New York: Macmillan, 1963; revised ed. 1984], 98–101).

According to Junillus, the twofold commandment is the only “unchangeable command” mentioned, the only one which is “useful in itself” (2.8). All other commands of the law, such as the prohibition of murder or the order for Sabbath observation, are grounded therein.

Second, the last section of Junillus’ work considers the relationship between faith (*fides*) and religion (*religio*), specifically, the role of belief if Scripture is all-sufficient. He responds that faith is *super rationem*, beyond reasoning, since “faith comprehends what reason teaches, and when reason flags, faith runs ahead (*ubi ratio defecerit, fides praecurrit*)” (2.20). This statement reflects Augustine’s own distinction between faith and reason, and even the wording closely follows what we find in *s.* 190: “What human reason does not discover, faith grasps: and where human reason fails, faith succeeds (*ubi humana ratio deficit, fides proficit*).”⁷¹ Faith and reason are not rivals, each competing for the mind, but rather *fides* is the disposition which motivates *ratio* in its quest for understanding.⁷²

Christological allegiance

Junillus’ correspondence with the African bishops occurred in the midst of the most significant theological debate of the sixth century, the Three Chapters Controversy. Justinian sought to reconcile East and West theologically through the condemnation of the Christology associated with Theodore of Mopsuestia.⁷³ To that end he published an edict known as the Three Chapters, which formally condemned the allegedly Nestorian writings of Theodore, Theodoret of Cyrus, and Ibas of Edessa. The emperor hoped by this gesture to mollify the powerful miaphysite faction in Egypt. Instead,

⁷¹ *PL* 38:1008.

⁷² See also W. Hankey, “*Ratio*, Reason, and Rationalism,” in A. Fitzgerald (ed.), *Augustine throughout the Ages: An Encyclopedia* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1999), 696–702.

⁷³ For background on the Three Chapters Controversy, see R. Price, *Acts of the Council of Constantinople of 553*, Translated Texts for Historians 45 (Liverpool: Liverpool University Press, 2009), vol. I, 1–103.

the plan backfired: the miaphysites were unimpressed, and the edict was vehemently opposed by Latin bishops in Africa and Italy, including the bishop of Rome. The African bishop Facundus of Hermiane in Byzacena composed a twelve-book treatise defending the condemned authors, and Theodore's work began to be translated and circulated through the West.⁷⁴ Ferrandus of Carthage was also staunchly opposed to the edict, and pressured Pope Vigilius to condemn the measure in his visit to Constantinople in 547. Vigilius initially stood by the western bishops, but finally capitulated to Justinian, and was forthwith condemned at the Council of Carthage in 550, his name removed from the diptychs of bishops. In response, Justinian punished recalcitrant African bishops such as Repartus of Carthage with arrest and exile. These events were recorded by the chronicler Victor of Tunnuna, who was present in Constantinople.⁷⁵ In the midst of this drama, the *Handbook* was composed and circulated in Africa, the heart of the opposition to Justinian's Christological program.

Where did Junillus stand in these battles over Christology? The question is not easy to answer, and perhaps deliberately so, given Junillus' own sympathies with Antiochene exegetical culture, as already noted earlier. He never weighs in directly on the ongoing theological controversies, but in the course of outlining the content of Scripture he briefly discusses the ways in which it refers to the Son (1.16). His approach is careful and closely tied to the biblical text. Scripture speaks of the Son in five ways: (1) as divinity alone (*solas deitas*), (2) as assumed man alone (*solus homo ab eo susceptus*),⁷⁶ and (3) as both God and man. Subsets of the third category

⁷⁴ R. Eno, "Doctrinal Authority in the African Ecclesiology of the Sixth Century: Ferrandus and Facundus," *Revue des Études Augustiniennes* 22 (1976), 95–113; L. Fatica, "La 'Defensio' di Facondo di Ermiane," *Asprenas* 38 (1991), 359–74; P. Bruns, "Zwischen Rom und Byzanz," *Zeitschrift für Kirchengeschichte* 106 (1995), 151–78.

⁷⁵ A. Cameron, "Justin I and Justinian," in A. Cameron et al. (eds.), *The Cambridge Ancient History: Late Antiquity: Empire and Successors, A.D. 425–600* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2000), vol. XIV, 63–85, at 80.

⁷⁶ This expression is rendered oddly by Collins: "Human nature alone that has been taken up by him" (<http://faculty.georgetown.edu/jod/texts/junillus.trans.html>) and by Maas: "The mortal being that he assumed" (153).

are (4) passages that speak principally of Christ's divinity and (5) those that speak principally of his humanity. In their brief commentary on this part of the *Handbook*, Maas and Mathews contend that Junillus was a spokesperson for Justinian's "neo-Chalcedonian" theology, in keeping with their larger argument that the exegete played court to the emperor and distanced himself strongly from Theodore.⁷⁷ However, the matter is not nearly so straightforward.

A few lines later, in 1.16, Junillus refers to the "distinct characteristics (*inconfusas proprietates*)" of the divine and human natures of Christ, a formula reminiscent of the Chalcedonian declaration of "distinctly in two natures (*in duabus naturis inconfuse*)."⁷⁸ At the same time, noticeably absent from the *Handbook* are neo-Chalcedonian buzzwords such as *compositio* and the theopaschite language used by Justinian to placate the miaphysites.⁷⁹ Furthermore, in presenting the five ways in which Scripture speaks of the Son, Junillus uses the phrase *homo susceptus* ("man assumed") to speak of Christ, language famously present in Theodore's surviving writings.⁸⁰ This sort of language throws into doubt the claim that Junillus was a "neo-Chalcedonian" theologian advancing the imperial critique against the Three Chapters. As Adam Becker has already suggested, the situation is more likely the reverse: "Rather than being a strong voice for neo-Chalcedonianism, one might argue that

⁷⁷ Maas, *Empire and Exegesis*, 65–6. ⁷⁸ Cf. Becker, "Dynamic Reception," 37.

⁷⁹ A. Grillmeier, *Christ in Christian Tradition*, trans. J. Bowden (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 1979), vol. II, 421–38.

⁸⁰ See Theodore, *Commentary on the Psalms* 2:5 (*Susceptus itaque homo ius super omnia dominationis accipit ab inhabitatore suo, Verbo suo*), and 8:1 (*Nondum est sane illud contra hereticos . . . quoniam grandem differentiam inter Deum Verbum et susceptum hominem profetiae ipsius carmen ostendit, et tantam distinctionem inter susceptum et suscipientem facti quanta discretio inter Deum et reliquos omnes invenitur*). This language also surfaces in a fragment from *On the Incarnation*, preserved in a letter by Facundus, *Pro defensione trium capitulorum* 9.3.5–6 (CCL 90A:273, 275–81). See also T. Jansen, *De incarnatione: Überlieferung und Christologie der griechischen und lateinischen Fragmente einschliesslich Textausgabe*, Patristische Texte und Studien 65 (New York: De Gruyter, 2009), 285; G. Kalantzis, "Duo Filii and the Homo Assumptus in the Christology of Theodore of Mopsuestia: The Greek Fragments of the Commentary on John," *Ephemerides Theologicae Lovanienses* 78 (2002), 57–78.

Junillus is walking a fine line between a Chalcedonian position and the more questionable versions of dyophysitism.”⁸¹

Such an alignment with Chalcedonian orthodoxy, we would add, makes additional sense when we attend to the mainly African audience for the *Handbook*, an audience that had little sympathy for the miaphysites and that had already indicated a strong proclivity for Theodore of Mopsuestia.⁸² Indeed, on this matter, the distinction between the Antiochene and the North African roots of the treatise should not be pressed too strongly. In referring to Christ as *homo susceptus*, we need to be cautious about assigning Junillus' language exclusively to Theodore. The very same phrase was *also* used by Augustine, and *homo assumptus/susceptus* terminology was relatively common in the Latin tradition.⁸³ Here then is one instance – and it is surely not the only – where the Antiochene and North African voices behind the *Handbook* spoke in unison.

Conclusion

Junillus' *Handbook* is testament to how deeply attractive the Antiochene exegetical culture appeared to later generations of biblical scholars. Yet this treatise did more than recycle a number of exegetical theses articulated over the course of the preceding two

⁸¹ Becker, “Dynamic Reception,” 37–8.

⁸² In his commentary of Revelation written around 540, Primasius roundly condemned Timothy Aelurus, the miaphysite patriarch of Alexandria who died in 477 (CCL 92:179–80).

⁸³ See H. M. Diepen, “L’assumptus homo patristique,” *Revue Thomiste* 63 (1963), 225–45, 363–88; H. M. Diepen, “L’assumptus homo patristique,” *Revue Thomiste* 64 (1964), 32–52, 364–86. The question of Augustine's reception of Theodore has been debated by J. McWilliam Dewart and J. McGuckin. McWilliam Dewart, on the basis of seven textual parallels between Theodore's *De incarnatione* and Augustine's *ep.* 187, argued that Augustine's theology of the Incarnation relies on an Antiochene framework. McGuckin disagreed, suggesting that the *homo susceptus* language is nothing more than a parallel evolution. See McWilliam Dewart, “The Influence of Theodore of Mopsuestia on Augustine's Letter 187,” *Augustinian Studies* 10 (1979), 113–32; J. McGuckin, “Did Augustine's Christology Depend on Theodore of Mopsuestia?,” *Heythrop Journal* 31/1 (1990), 39–52.

centuries in the Greek east. As we have argued, it is better viewed as a hybrid document that also captured the language and concerns of its North African author and audience. The *Handbook* is a remarkable hermeneutical treatise because it offers us a vantage point – admittedly not always as clear as we might like – for studying the circulation, transformation, and integration of diverse exegetical principles in the late antique Mediterranean.

FURTHER READING

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Cassiodorus' hermeneutics
The Psalms and the arts of language
Rita Copeland

Flavius Magnus Aurelius Cassiodorus Senator (ca. 484/90–ca. 580 CE) was born at Squillace on the southern coast of Italy to a distinguished Roman family. He was a product of the elite schools of Roman rhetoric and letters, and had a long career in public office at Ravenna, serving under Theodoric, ruler of the Ostrogothic kingdom. In 519, he wrote a chronicle of the Roman antecedents to Theodoric and his family that cast the ruling family in a flattering light. We possess fragments of the panegyrics he dedicated to members of Theodoric's family, and an abridgement of his history of the Goths, published around 530. He occupied prestigious positions as *quaestor*, *consul ordinarius*, *magister officiorum*, and finally praetorian prefect. In the late 530s, just as his public career in Ravenna was about to come to an end, he compiled a selection of his official correspondence, the *Variae*. When the forces of the eastern Empire overwhelmed Ravenna, Cassiodorus left public office and went to Constantinople, remaining there for over a decade. It was while he was in the East that he began to turn his attention to theological and spiritual writings. During this period he most likely wrote the treatise *De anima* (On the Soul) and conceived and drafted his only sustained work of exegesis, the *Expositio psalmorum*, an exhaustive commentary on the Psalms that will be the focus of this chapter. In the second half of his long life he retreated into contemplative seclusion at Vivarium, the monastery that he founded on his family estate at Squillace. Here he produced his influential encyclopedia of “divine” and “secular” readings, the *Institutiones*, and here also,

in his nineties, he wrote an elementary grammatical treatise for the benefit of the monks, *De orthographia*.¹

Cassiodorus imagined a clear entryway into the interpretation of Scripture: through grammar, rhetoric, and the other liberal arts. He fashioned a visible form of this entryway through the marginal *notae* (signs) that he devised to accompany his *Expositio psalmodum*. These signs were intended to index the various recurring topics that his commentary covered. In this way his commentary is a decidedly readerly text, fitted out for eyes that will peruse the page rather than ears that will hear a master's lecture or a preacher's homily.² His explanatory list of these *notae*, or orthographical symbols, and the *notae* as they appear throughout the margins of the text were reproduced in many manuscripts of the *Expositio* and in the *editio princeps* of 1491, although his system of notation was ignored in the seventeenth-century print of the work by Garet, and then by Migne's edition in the *Patrologia latina*.³ The edition of Adriaen in 1958 restored the *notae* to modern readers.

These *notae*, thirteen in all, express the encyclopedic ambitions of the *Expositio psalmodum*, and also link it with Cassiodorus' own compendium of religious and secular knowledge in the *Institutiones divinarum et saecularium litterarum*. In a sense the *Expositio* is the fulfillment of the propaedeutic outline of knowledge that is the *Institutiones*, even though the *Expositio* surely preceded the *Institutiones* in date of first composition. The thirteen topics represented by the symbols he devised signify the aims of a complete sacred knowledge and then the disciplinary instruments that are necessary to achieving that knowledge through Scripture (Table 7.1).⁴

¹ A good overview of Cassiodorus' literary career is by F. Brunhölzl, *Histoire de la littérature latine du Moyen Âge*, tome 1, trans. H. Rochais (Turnhout: Brepols, 1990), vol. 1, 35–49.

² J. W. Halporn, "Methods of Reference in Cassiodorus," *The Journal of Library History* 16 (1981), 71–91, at 73.

³ Halporn, "Methods of Reference," 90, n. 16.

⁴ The typography of these symbols is based on that provided in Cassiodorus, *Expositio psalmodum: tradizione manoscritta, fortuna, edizione critica*, ed. P. Stoppacci (Florence: SISMEL-Edizioni del Galluzzo, 2012), 1 and 379. This superior edition to be completed in three volumes is still in progress, and I have had access only to volume I.

Table 7.1 *Cassiodorus' explanation of the symbols (notae) in his Expositio Psalmorum*

ⲡⲓ	<i>hoc in idiomatis, id est propriis locutionibus legis divinae</i>
✱	<i>hoc in dogmatibus valde necessariis</i>
Ⲕ	<i>hoc in definitionibus</i>
ⲚⲈⲎ	<i>hoc in schematibus</i>
Ⲉⲧ	<i>hoc in ethymologiis</i>
Ⲛⲡ	<i>hoc in interpretatione nominum</i>
Ⲛⲧ	<i>hoc in arte rhetorica</i>
ⲧⲖⲡ	<i>hoc in topicis</i>
ⲚⲢⲚ	<i>hoc in syllogismis</i>
ⲚⲚ	<i>hoc in arithmetica</i>
ⲒⲈⲖ	<i>hoc in geometrica</i>
Ⲙ ^{ca}	<i>hoc in musica</i>
✱	<i>hoc in astronomia</i>

The first two explanations of symbols in Table 7.1, the idioms of Scripture and its fundamental doctrines, signal the agent of true theological understanding and then the understanding itself. The agent of understanding, scriptural idiom, is infused with theological mystery and must be apprehended in its peculiar and specific totality before it is broken down into the elements of human-produced grammatical discourse, as in the phrase from Psalm 7 (in Cassiodorus' preferred reading), *secundum innocentiam manuum mearum* ("according to the innocence of my hands"), where, as Cassiodorus notes, the "meanings of words are exchanged" (*Exp. ps. 7.9*).⁵ Theological dogma is similarly indivisible and is to be solemnly affirmed and understood, for example, the truth of the Trinity coeternal with itself. But it was in the other eleven symbols and the topics they stand for that he found the true originality of his purpose: reconstituting the secular liberal arts through Scripture.⁶ In view of that large ambition, his exposition of the

⁵ Where not otherwise noted, translations are my own.

⁶ Cf. M. Vessey, Introduction to *Cassiodorus: Institutions of Divine and Secular Learning; On the Soul*, trans. J. W. Halporn (Liverpool: Liverpool University Press, 2004), 35.

Psalms gave expression to a more particular intention: to discover the workings of rhetoric in the Psalter, and so to forge an intimate connection between his secular intellectual formation and his religious conviction. In this respect Cassiodorus' achievement remains unrivaled even among the innovative and visionary company of the early Christian scriptural exegetes. While Cassiodorus pays sincere homage to his predecessors, especially to Augustine's eloquence and rich insight, and while he presents the *Expositio psalmorum* as a derivative of the latter's *Enarrationes in psalmos* (see Cassiodorus, *Ex. ps.* Praef. 4–10), his expository motive (or at least accomplishment) is of a different order. If for Augustine the secular arts, and rhetoric in particular, are necessary to serve the understanding and preaching of Scripture and must be reconditioned to that sacred end, for Cassiodorus the human arts are plainly to be found in Scripture and thus the Psalms become a veritable textbook of all of the arts.

This multifaceted purpose underlies Cassiodorus' conception of the *Expositio psalmorum* as an encyclopedia of the arts; from this perspective, book 2 of the *Institutiones* constitutes a later outline or compendium of that secular knowledge.⁷ While the dating of neither work is secure, it is generally accepted that the *Expositio psalmorum* was composed between 540 and 548, during the period of Cassiodorus' sojourn in Constantinople, and that the *Institutiones* was undertaken when he returned to Italy and established his monastery Vivarium on his family's estate at Squillace. The completion of the *Institutiones*, written for the guidance of the monks at Vivarium, is usually placed around 562, and it is also assumed that Cassiodorus continued to revise the *Expositio* during that time. The necessary theoretical relationship between the two works comes into sharper focus when we see how it is predicted in the preface of the *Expositio psalmorum*. There Cassiodorus elaborates the idea, already promoted by early Christian apologists and by their Hellenistic Jewish predecessors, that the human sciences were first implanted in Scripture and belatedly codified by the learned traditions of

⁷ On the level of student that Cassiodorus had in mind for the *Expositio*, see M. Simonetti, "L'*Expositio psalmorum* di Cassiodoro," *Cassiodorus* 4 (1998), 125–39.

Greece and Rome.⁸ His elaboration involves the supporting idea that the divine law has been universally known, for in it all of human knowledge originated:⁹

As Scripture says: *Their sound hath gone forth into all the earth, and their words unto the ends of the world* [Ps. 18:5]. So the greatest proof lies in the fact that the divine law is known to have been received through every part of the world. It exploits its varieties of language in sundry ways, being clothed in definitions adorned by figures, marked by its special vocabulary, equipped with the conclusions of syllogisms, gleaming with forms of instruction . . . Those experienced in the secular arts, clearly living long after the time when the first words of the divine books were penned, transferred these techniques to the collections of arguments which the Greeks call topics, and to the arts of dialectic and rhetoric. So it is crystal clear to all that the minds of the just were endowed to express the truth with the techniques which pagans subsequently decided should be exploited for human wisdom. In the sacred readings they shine like the brightest of stars, aptly clarifying the meanings of passages most usefully and profitably. *Exp. ps. Praef. 15.45–74.*¹⁰

The theme that the liberal sciences had their origin in Scripture is revisited elsewhere in the *Expositio*,¹¹ and buttresses Cassiodorus' understanding of the Psalter as a repository of such knowledge:

We have shown that the series of psalms is packed with points of grammar, etymologies, figures, rhetoric, topics, dialectic, definitions, music, geometry, and astronomy, expressions peculiar to divine Scripture, in so far as the Lord has deigned to grant this. Thus those who have already read these features may gladly acknowledge them, and those who are as yet novices may observe them most clearly delineated without coming to grief. *Exp. ps. 150.6, 147–51* (Walsh, 3:465).

⁸ Vessey, Introduction, 30.

⁹ See J. J. O'Donnell, *Cassiodorus* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1979), 158.

¹⁰ Translation from *Cassiodorus: Explanation of the Psalms*, 3 vols., trans. P. G. Walsh (New York: Paulist, 1990–1), 1 and 37–8. Hereafter this will be cited in the text. The standard complete edition is *Magni Aurelii Cassiodori Expositio psalmorum*, 2 vols., ed. M. Adriaen, CCL 97–8 (Turnhout: Brepols, 1958). Section numbers of the exposition of the psalm and line references are to the Adriaen edition; the Walsh translation is cited by volume and page numbers.

¹¹ For example, Ps. 6.2, 94–107; Ps. 23.10, 193–7.

The theme reappears in the *Institutiones*, but under a newly targeted purpose: since Scripture already contains the human sciences, it is useful to know about them in advance, and this will be the pedagogical object of book 2 of the *Institutiones*:

In the second book on the arts and disciplines of liberal studies a few things need to be imbibed . . . Whatever has been found in Divine Scripture on such matters will be better understood if one has prior acquaintance with them. It is well-known that, at the beginning of spiritual wisdom, information on these subjects was sowed, as it were, that secular teachers afterwards wisely transferred to their own rules as I have perhaps shown at suitable places in my *Psalms Commentary*.¹²

This surely and deliberately echoes the “gold out of Egypt” theme in Augustine’s *De doctrina Christiana* and Augustine’s own advice there to turn to the arts of the trivium and quadrivium to elucidate unknown signs in Scripture (*doc. Chr.* 2.19.29–42.63). But as Vessey observes, Augustine did not use the acknowledged relevance of the human sciences as an occasion to teach them himself, nor did he approach Scripture as an encyclopedic textbook of the sciences.¹³ It was Cassiodorus’ distinct innovation to reconstitute the liberal arts in Scripture not as an apology for the usefulness of the secular arts but as an explanation of their very genesis and as a trajectory for human knowledge of the sacred text.¹⁴ Cassiodorus offers a “restoration” of the secular sciences to their original sacred purpose, because in “passing through them” we arrive at the redemptive knowledge of Scripture (*Inst.* 1.28.3).¹⁵

In his approach to arts, Cassiodorus takes one further step that crowns the originality of his project in the *Expositio psalmorum*. This

¹² *Institutiones* 1, Praef. 6 (Halporn, 107–8). Standard edition, *Cassiodori Senatoris Institutiones*, ed. R. A. B. Mynors (Oxford: Clarendon, 1937), 6.

¹³ Vessey, Introduction, 34–5.

¹⁴ Cf. O’Donnell, *Cassiodorus*, 158; J. Fontaine, “Cassiodore et Isidore: l’évolution de l’encyclopédisme latin du VI^e au VII^e siècle,” in S. Leanza (ed.), *Flavio Magno Aurelio Cassiodoro (Cosenza-Squillace 19–24 settembre 1983)* (Soveria Mannelli: Rubbetino, 1986), 72–91, at 81.

¹⁵ On the notion of restoration, see A. Astell, “Cassiodorus’s *Commentary on the Psalms as an Ars rhetorica*,” *Rhetorica* 17 (1999), 37–75, at 41.

is its contribution to rhetorical culture. For Cassiodorus, rhetoric was not simply to be discovered in Scripture; it became the very navigational map through which he could discover Scripture. The opening remarks in his preface describe the initial confusion that the psalter produced in him:

Some time ago at Ravenna I thrust aside the anxieties of official positions and the flavour of secular cares with their harmful taste. Once I had sampled that honey of souls, the divine psalter, I did what longing spirits often do, and plunged eagerly in to examine and to drink in sweet draughts of the words of salvation after the deep bitterness of my active life. But I was confronted with the obscurity, familiar to beginners, interwoven in the different personages and shrouding itself in allegories. *Exp. ps. Praef.* 1–7 (Walsh, 1:23).

The desire for the scriptural text is confounded by difficulty, the text's obscurity and its resistance to even a trained textual understanding. Behind this statement of humility in the face of the interpretive challenges of the psalter also lies the confrontation between the elite secular learning of late antiquity, with its established aesthetic principles and calibrated reasoning, and the unfamiliar opacity of the scriptural text, with its common language, chaste eloquence, and yet mysterious truths buried within (*Exp. ps. Praef.* 15). This confrontation between elite learning and scriptural simplicity has a long history: one of its most memorable evocations is Augustine's record of his early encounter with Scripture, which seemed to him unworthy when compared with Ciceronian dignity (*Conf.* 3.5.9).¹⁶ Cassiodorus came to his exegetical enterprise formed by the rhetorical culture of the sixth century, a product (like Augustine in the fourth century) of the highest order of secular professionalism. In its ingenious attempt to grasp the meaning of the

¹⁶ On rhetoric and Christianity in late antique culture, see A. Cameron, *Christianity and the Rhetoric of Empire: The Development of Christian Discourse* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1991), 19–33, 47–88; and P. Brown, *Power and Persuasion in Late Antiquity: Towards a Christian Empire* (Madison: University of Wisconsin Press, 1992), 41–7, 74–7. On Cassiodorus' own career, see S. J. B. Barnish, "The Work of Cassiodorus after His Conversion," *Latomus* 48 (1989), 157–87.

psalms through a rhetorical map imposed on them, Cassiodorus' exposition of the psalms records his struggle to gain not only interpretive mastery but also aesthetic understanding of the text.

As is clear from the table of *notae* with which Cassiodorus prefaced the *Expositio*, the language arts of the trivium play the largest role in elucidating the text: the principles of figurative language, the word lore of etymology, the principles of rhetorical composition, and the dialectical knowledge of topical and syllogistic reasoning. The identification of *schemata*, that is, figures of speech and figures of thought, as well as tropes, could be classed under both grammar and rhetoric, since the teaching of figurative language was a field shared by the two disciplines. Cassiodorus' sources for this material thus come from both kinds of textbooks, especially Donatus' grammatical *Ars maior* (fourth century CE) and Quintilian's rhetorical *Institutio oratoria* (first century CE).¹⁷

But rhetoric takes on a larger role in the *Expositio psalmorum* than might be suggested by the single *nota* assigned to it (RT), and thus also a greater role than the other arts. For not only does Cassiodorus continually identify uses of figures and tropes in Scripture; he also finds in Scripture the grounds of rhetoric itself, the persuasive core of rhetorical argumentation. He apprehends each psalm as an oratorical production, reading the psalms through the lens of rhetorical understanding, grasping and charting their power through the formal and aesthetic literary categories that were familiar to him.

At the most general level of rhetorical analysis, he classifies the psalms according to the three genres of rhetoric, depending on what he understands to be the psalm's aim and subject matter: the forensic or judicial, the deliberative or political, and the epideictic or demonstrative (panegyric or praise and blame). The genres or "species" of rhetoric had been part of the systematic tradition of rhetorical teaching from Aristotle onward and were essential to the actualization of rhetorical theory in public speaking. The elements of

¹⁷ M. Agosto, *Impiego e definizione di tropi e schemi retorici nell'Expositio psalmorum di Cassiodoro* (Montella: Accademia Vivarium Novum, 2003), 53–7. See further note 25 of this chapter.

constructing and delivering an argument would be modified to some degree depending on whether one was defending or prosecuting a case before a judge or jury (judicial rhetoric); persuading a political body to take action (deliberative or political rhetoric); or commemorating, praising, or in some instances castigating a famous person (epideictic rhetoric). Cassiodorus, who lived his professional life as a public official and speech maker, would have had an almost instinctive recourse to the genres of rhetoric as a literary template. Among the psalms he finds the epideictic genre most frequently, giving eleven explicit mentions of the demonstrative genre.¹⁸ This is not surprising, given that the psalms are overwhelmingly expressions of praise. In his preface, he also models a panegyric by offering an extended praise of *Ecclesia*, intending by this *isagoge* or *introductio* to fan the flames of his "listeners'" desire for the mysteries of the psalms about to unfold (*Praef.* 17, 56–60): at this point he imagines his audience in public, aural terms, hearing a living speaker. The deliberative (or political) genre is explicitly marked three times. The judicial genre is marked for the seven psalms of confession or penitence; Cassiodorus' commentary is the earliest formal testimony to the tradition of the penitential psalms.¹⁹ While he does not mark every psalm according to one of the genres of rhetoric, these categories nevertheless represent a plan of reading to make the collection of psalms legible according to what is perceived as an immanent thematic structure. By mapping the genres of rhetoric onto the psalter he has also apprehended each psalm as a form of public speech that proclaims or argues a truth. Thus the genres themselves are reconditioned to serve sacred purposes. The deliberative genre now applies to the psalms of meditation and seeking instruction; the judicial genre is redefined as confession or penitence, using the legal terminology of *concessio* or conceding a crime or sin;

¹⁸ Astell, "Cassiodorus's *Commentary on the Psalms*," 45; Walsh, Introduction to *Explanation of the Psalms*, 1:16.

¹⁹ Astell, "Cassiodorus's *Commentary on the Psalms*," 49; C. Costley King'oo, *Miserere mei: The Penitential Psalms in Late Medieval and Early Modern England* (Notre Dame, IN: Notre Dame University Press, 2012), 4–5.

and the epideictic genre is for the psalms of inspiration, revelation, and *demonstratio* of a sacred truth.

Alongside the general level of the genres of oratory, the Cassiodorian rhetorical analysis also takes a narrow focus on the structure of the individual psalm. Each psalm commentary proposes a *divisio psalmi* in which the architecture of argument, as it were, is laid out. Cassiodorus' terminology in the *divisio* section of each exposition is rarely overtly rhetorical. But he does use an explicit rhetorical template for some of the penitential psalms, deploying the Ciceronian language for the parts of an oration. The traditional Ciceronian doctrine usually divides an oration into six parts: the exordium, by which the speaker introduces the subject and tries to win the favor of the audience (*captatio benevolentiae*); the *narratio*, in which the case is laid out as a narration and the nature of the case is explained; the *partitio*, which anticipates the divisions of the argument; the *confirmatio*, the main body of the speech containing the proof or evidence (*probatio*) of the argument; the *refutatio*, in which opposing arguments are refuted; and the *peroratio*, or conclusion.

A psalm is not an oration, but the penitential psalms can be treated on analogy with the genre of the judicial oration, in which the prosecution lays out the sins of the defendant or the defense concedes the crime but begs the judge for mercy. Cassiodorus is most precise in this application early in the *Expositio*, with Psalm 6, *Domine, ne in ira tua arguas me*. He notes that the psalm has an exordium to make "the judge well disposed to him" and compel the mind of the auditor by appealing to "the power of the judge," "[the speaker's] own weakness," and "God's habitual clemency" (*Exp. ps. 6.1, 61–6* [Walsh, 1:91]). It has a *narratio* that lays out the afflictions of the speaker and the state of his contrition (*Exp. ps. 6, 67–70*). The next division consists of what Cassiodorus calls *correctio*, "where he separates himself from the wicked, a gesture which he knew was most welcome to the good Judge" (*Exp. ps. 6.1, 71–2* [Walsh, 1:91]). This refers to verse nine, *discedite a me omnes qui operamini iniquitatem, quoniam exaudivit Dominus vocem fletus mei*. *Correctio* is not one of the classical divisions of the speech, but as

Astell interprets it serves the function of the proof.²⁰ This may be suggested by the phrase *ut ab illis mens redderetur aliena, quibus et ipsa iustitia probabitur adversa* ("so that his mind might be alienated from those who clearly regarded justice as foreign to them") (*Exp. ps.* 6.1, 72–3 [Walsh, 1:91]), as if the psalm has now delivered the proof of its arguments. But we could also see Cassiodorus' *correctio* as an equivalent of the *refutatio*, which turns the opposing arguments on their heads. If we read verse eight as refutation, it enacts the abjuring of iniquity and signals a decisive turn away from the narration of afflictions to embrace self-correction and acknowledge God's merciful reception of the plea. Finally, the *conclusio* signifies that the arguments are completed and nothing more needs to be said.

The use of this terminology for the penitential psalms has the effect of reinforcing their status as quasi-legal discourse. Unlike their counterparts in the secular courtroom, these exemplars of a sacred judicial genre do not mount defenses on behalf of the accused, but rather reveal the penitent as the witness to and prosecutor of his own iniquities, appealing through contrition and humility to a divinely merciful judge. But while Cassiodorus seems to reserve the formal terminology of the *partes orationis* only for the penitential psalms and the judicial genre, this structural template offers an interpretive potentiality for any of the psalms, no matter which rhetorical genre it may be seen to represent. Each *divisio* engages the formal construction of the psalm, showing how we encounter each turn in an argument. For example, the *divisio* of Psalm 5 tells us how the speaker is *Ecclesia*, who first asks that her prayer be heard and that heretics and schismatics be excluded from her communion, then makes a plea to be guided by God's kindness in her progress to that *felix patria* which the unfaithful cannot enter, and finally proclaims the rewards that the blessed will receive in order to convert the wicked and inspire the just (*Exp. ps.* 5.1, 22–30). The immanent rhetorical structure that any professional reader of late antiquity might see is that of exordium, *confirmatio*, and *peroratio*.

²⁰ Astell, "Cassiodorus's *Commentary on the Psalms*," 57; cf. the notes on this by Walsh, *Explanation of the Psalms*, 1:534.

Beneath this local structural analysis lies the heart of rhetorical theory, the doctrine of *stasis* (status theory), which pertains especially to the judicial genre. Through the theoretical system of *stasis*, the orator was able to determine exactly what kind of case was to be argued, thus laying the groundwork for the “invention” of arguments, the most important part of rhetorical theory. Was the dispute about a fact (the “conjectural issue”), about a definition (what was the act?), or about the quality or nature of the act (for example, was the act justifiable?), or should the charge be framed for another kind of court (the “translative issue,” i.e., moving a case from criminal to civil court)?²¹ A subset of the qualitative issue is the juridical (the act is admitted or conceded, but the rights and wrongs of it are in question). Cassiodorus summarizes this complex theory toward the beginning of his chapter on rhetoric in his *Institutiones*, an indication that this material, deriving from republican Rome, was still being studied in the late antique schools, whatever its relevance to the law courts under Ostrogothic rule.²² Cassiodorus invokes status theory on a number of occasions in the *Expositio psalmorum* when he wants to illustrate how the psalms should have a legal hold on our understanding. But of all the baroque filiations of status theory, his interest lies in uncovering the theological dimensions of one element: *concessio*, a rare subdivision of the juridical issue.²³ The concession involves acknowledging the charge, with either exculpation for various reasons or an outright plea for mercy. In secular courts, *concessio* is a rare strategy because it is tantamount to accepting legal defeat. But divine justice overturns the competitive triumphalism of the secular estate, and Cassiodorus develops his theological exposition out of this ironic vein of Augustinian history.²⁴ Thus for example in the exposition of Psalm 31, another of the penitential psalms, he observes:

²¹ Cicero, *De inventione* 1.8.10–1.14.19; (Pseudo-Cicero), *Rhetorica ad Herennium* 1.11.18–1.15.25.

²² Cassiodorus, *Inst.* 2.2.4–5.

²³ *Rhetorica ad Herennium* 1.14.24; cf. Cicero, *De inventione* 1.11.15.

²⁴ Astell, “Cassiodorus’s *Commentary on the Psalms*,” 53–9.

Status autem principalis huius causae concessio est, quae cunctis paenitentibus datur. Concessio est enim, ubi adversariis omnia conceduntur et per solas lacrimas supplices defenditur reus.

The primary "status" or point at issue of this plea is the concession granted to all who repent; such a concession is granted when the whole case is conceded to opponents, and the guilty person is defended by tears of supplication alone. *Exp. ps.* 31, 24–7 (Walsh, 1:305).

This casts the psalm as a legal speech whose argument will be discovered in the status at issue, and at the same time casts away the rhetorical fittings to reveal the more profound truth of penitence, which needs no exculpatory argument because it is assured of divine mercy.

At the levels of genre, structural analysis, and the inventional principle of status theory, Cassiodorus develops an approach to reading Scripture that is far more original than most of his modern readers have recognized: he converts the methods of rhetorical composition into a hermeneutics. Cassiodorus would have recognized in Augustine's *De doctrina Christiana* a watershed for the transference of elite rhetorical learning to a Christian exegetical use. Augustine famously presents Scripture as the only valid site of arguments to be discovered, and those arguments will be about the meaning of Scripture itself to explain Scripture's fundamental message of salvation and reveal its hidden truths. Augustine calls the means of discovering such arguments the *modus inveniendi*, taking the notion of *inventio* or discovery of one's argument from rhetorical theory and conscripting it now to the purpose of scriptural hermeneutics. Augustine turns invention, the primary intellectual process of rhetorical composition, into the driving ethical and intellectual engine of the reading of Scripture, thus also redirecting invention away from its original purpose, reasoning toward producing persuasive speech, to a new purpose, reasoning to discover truth in a written document, the Bible. Scripture is understood to contain all the truth that can be known and revealed, so the process of inventional reasoning is now directed to a textual object. Where the orator discovered his basic arguments or proofs in reasoning about a case, in legal precedent, and in material evidence, the scriptural exegete finds his body of

proof in the theological and historical truths of the Bible; here looking beyond the text to the knowledge contained in the various arts will be only a supplementary aid to overcome some practical ignorance. Thus Augustine definitively textualized rhetoric.

Cassiodorus, however, was to take this further by understanding Scripture itself as a rhetorical product and thus as open to ethical analysis through the theoretical system of rhetoric. If Augustine turned rhetorical thought into a hermeneutics, Cassiodorus fulfilled that purpose by delivering a precise method of reading, implementing rhetorical principles to read by showing exactly how Scripture can reveal its own rhetorical structures. It is as if Cassiodorus (unlike Augustine) cannot be fully persuaded that Scripture is a persuasive discourse until he discovers the proof of that in Scripture. Thus his readings lay out that process of recognition, using the codified classical rhetoric as a navigational map to discover the psalms as an originary, divine rhetoric. The psalter speaks both *ex arte* and *de arte rhetoricae*: it is both a monument of rhetorical art and an art of rhetoric, teaching about divine eloquence through its own example of sacred persuasion.

The smallest element of rhetorical teaching that Cassiodorus brings to his exposition of the psalms is also what most occupies his attention on the ground: his elucidations of the figures and tropes. He presents and defines 105 rhetorical figures, comprising tropes, figures of speech, and figures of thought.²⁵ As noted earlier, the teaching of figurative language was a field intimately shared

²⁵ Agosto, *Impiego e definizione*, 53. Ancient rhetoricians and grammarians came to distinguish between tropes and figures (*schemata*). Tropes, in Quintilian's canonical definition, involve a transference of words from their "natural and principal" signification to another meaning for the sake of ornamentation; *Institutio oratoria* 9.1.4–6 (LCL 126, ed. and trans. D. A. Russell, 5 vols. [Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2002] 4:12–13). Figures, however, involve an unusual shaping or "configuration" (*conformatio*) of language or turns of thought. Figures were thus also divided into figures of speech (*schemata lexeos*) and figures of thought (*schemata dianoías*): see Quintilian, *Inst. or.* 9.1.17–21 (4:18–21). Cassiodorus does not usually remark the finer distinctions in his explanations, being more interested in giving definitions than in minutely classifying the rhetorical ornaments of Scripture.

between the grammarians and the rhetoricians, as Cassiodorus himself noted in the *Institutiones*: "These are shared by grammarians and orators, and are nicely suited to each group."²⁶ His citations of both figures and tropes are signaled by the marginal notation he devised for these, *schē*, and even a casual glance at the *Expositio psalmorum* will reveal a preponderance of this particular *nota* throughout the text. Thus a later scholar such as Bede, using Cassiodorus' *Expositio* as a source for his own Christian textbook *De schematibus et tropis*, could easily peruse the margins of his copy of the commentary to identify the *loci* containing definitions and examples.²⁷

Although in one respect the *Expositio* can be read as Cassiodorus' attempt to address his own confusion about the aesthetic value of Scripture by bringing his professional rhetorical education to bear on the psalms, it is also and always a pedagogically directed text. Thus while the exposition can operate at a fairly high theoretical level, at the same time Cassiodorus assumes little technical knowledge on the part of his prospective readers. At almost every point he supplies basic teaching and explanations of the sort that a reader of his own professional class would never need. This is the case with his approach to figurative language. Early in the *Expositio* he realizes that he must furnish a global definition of "figure":

Figura est, sicut nomine ipso datur intellegi, quaedam conformatio dictionis a communione remota, quae interioribus oculis velut aliquid vultuosum semper offertur, quam traditione maiorum ostentationem et habitum possumus nuncupare.

A "figure," as may be understood from the term itself, is a configuration of a phrase beyond common use that is always presented, like a certain facial expression, to the inner eye. Following the tradition of our forbears we can call it a (self-) presentation or demeanor. *Exp. ps.* 2.2, 67–71.²⁸

²⁶ Cassiodorus, *Inst.* 2.1.2 (Halporn, 177).

²⁷ Halporn, "Methods of Reference," 87.

²⁸ Compare Walsh, 1:59, whose translation here is too loose to convey the technical value of this definition. Cassiodorus' definition is close to Quintilian, *Inst.* 9.1.4.

It is fortunate for us that Cassiodorus anticipated the needs of his audience so carefully, because the definition that he supplies gives an insight into his theory of how readers experience the psalms. The definition of *figura* here involves figures: the simile “like a certain facial expression” and the metaphor (or catachresis) “inner eye.” In this explanation Cassiodorus presents the text on the page as a kind of proxy for human speech, and the figure itself as the textual counterpart of direct emotional expression between speaker and hearer. This comparison with the human face “reading” another face seems to be of Cassiodorus’ own making. The phrase *quae interioribus oculis . . . offertur* echoes his definition elsewhere within the *Expositio* of the figure *enargeia* or *imaginatio*, *quae actum rei incorporeis oculis subministrat* (“which presents the performance of something to the incorporeal eyes”) (*Exp. ps.* 33, 4. 85–6).²⁹ There the figure *enargeia* is defined through a use of *enargeia*, a “making vivid” to the “mind’s eye” of the imaginative process by which pictures are conjured through words. Thus the *schemata* identified and explained throughout the *Expositio* constitute a repository of vivid experience: they are the means through which the psalms make themselves real to us as living speech and the medium of that direct speaking.

Cassiodorus often uses his expositions of the figures to lay bare the emotional power of the psalms. This might be expected for his explanations of the most important tropes such as metaphor, which he defines only once (in Psalm 31), but which he points to elsewhere as a powerful engine of emotion, as in Psalm 2:

Psalm 2:14: *When his wrath shall be kindled in a short time.* The metaphor is drawn from fire, which burns the more when it receives fuel to consume. Walsh 1:66.

But it is surprising when he locates a strong emotional effect in some of the lesser *schemata*, which the grammarians and rhetoricians treat as stylistic ornaments. The *schemata* were the special provenance of the practical grammatical and rhetorical handbooks, and among

²⁹ Agosto, *Impiego e definizione*, 49.

the most important sources for the *Expositio* were book 3 of Donatus' grammatical *Ars maior*, and the anonymous *Scemata dianoëas quae ad rhetores pertinent*.³⁰ Cassiodorus usually identifies the figure and defines it, but his explanations are often much more telling: he will point out not only how the figure is used, but why it is effective in this context, what kind of emotional power the figure produces. In these instances Cassiodorus is not teaching rhetoric, but rather teaching a love of the psalms or, better, demonstrating how the psalms actually achieve their emotional and persuasive effects on readers. A selection of examples, quoted at some length, reveals Cassiodorus' particular skill as a close reader of linguistic nuance:

Psalm 3:2–3: Multi insurgunt adversum me, multi dicunt animae meae. *In tantum multi fuerunt, ut etiam de numero discipulorum traditor Iudas illis fuerit aggregatus. Et cum repetitur saepius, multi ostenditur acerba numerositas impiorum, qui a conspiratione densissima nequaquam rarescere potuerunt. Haec figura locutionis dicitur epembasis, enumerationis studio verba repetens, ut rei de qua loquitur procuret augmentum.*

Many are they who rise up against me: many say to my soul . . . So numerous were they that they included even one of his disciples, the traitor Judas. The repetition, *many*, reveals the bitterly huge number of the wicked, that dense crowd of conspirators which could not thin out. This figure of speech is called *epembasis*, repetition of words out of eagerness to enumerate them, so as to magnify the matter under discussion. *Exp. ps. 3.3, 40–7* (Walsh 1:69).

Psalm 3:4: Tu autem, Domine, susceptor meus es, gloria mea et exaltans caput meum . . . *Factum est autem hic pulcherrimum schema, quod graece dicitur auxesis, quae addendo quaedam nomina per membra singula rerum augmenta congerminat . . . Hoc etiam latius designat apostolus dicens: Quis nos separabit a caritate Christi? tribulatio, an angustia, an persecutio, an fames, an nuditas, an periculum an gladius etc. (Rm 8:35). Huic vicina est figura quae dicitur climax, latine gradatio, quando positus quibusdam gradibus, sive in laude sive in vituperatione semper accrescit.*

³⁰ U. Schindel, ed., "Anonymous Ecksteinii, *Scemata dianoëas quae ad rhetores pertinent*," *Nachrichten der Akademie der Wissenschaften in Göttingen. Philolog. hist.* Kl.1/7 (1987), 111–73. On Cassiodorus' grammatical and rhetorical sources, see Agosto, *Impiego e definizione*, 53–7. The *Scemata dianoëas* provides the language for his definition of *enargeia*; ed. Schindel, p. 153.

But thou, O Lord, art my sustainer, my glory, and the lifter-up of my head . . . We have here the splendid figure called by the Greeks *auxesis*, which increases and redoubles, by appending words in individual phrases . . . Paul exemplifies the figure more broadly in the words *Who shall separate us from the love of Christ? Shall tribulation? Or distress? Or persecution? Or the sword?* and the rest. Close to this is the figure called *climax*, in Latin *gradatio* or gradation, when praise or blame rises step by step, so to say. *Exp. ps. 3.4, 57–78* (Walsh 1:70, modified).

Psalm 37:20: *Inimici autem mei vivent, et confortati sunt super me; et multiplicati sunt qui oderunt me inique . . . Deinde quod gravius horret, adiecit, multiplicati sunt. Hoc schema dicitur emphasis, quod gradatim crescit ad motum animi concitandum.* Multiplicati sunt vero qui eum oderunt inique, quando supra ipsum spirituum immundorum numerus augebatur.

But my enemies shall live, and are stronger than I: and they that hate me wrongfully are multiplied . . . He next added something which made him more aghast still: *They are multiplied.* This figure is called “emphasis,” which gradually swells to arouse the mind’s emotion. Those that are multiplied are they that hate him wrongfully when the number of unclean spirits hovering over him are increased. *Exp. ps. 37.20, 361–73* (Walsh 1:385–6).

It is to such verbal nuance that Cassiodorus directs his most intensive interests. The commentary comes to life when he shows why a particular ornamental figure – a repetition or concatenation, an enumeration or augmentation – carries a certain kind of emotional charge, reflecting a passion in the speaker that should be reproduced in the reader.

We might expect his treatment of the trope allegory to be equally vivid. Yet his explanations of allegory, which he identifies on only five occasions, are strikingly textbook in their restraint, for example in Psalm 99:

Psalm 99:2: *Nam quod dixit: iubilare, et subiunxit: omnis terra, frequenter et per casus nominum discrepantes, magnos indicat sensus. Nam cum terra singulari numero denuntietur, iubilare dicit, quod ad pluralem numerum certum est pertinere; ut hanc terram ad homines, non ad tellurem aestimares esse referendam, quod allegorice constat intellegi. Allegoria est enim figura aliud dicens, et aliud significans.*

As for his statement, *sing ye with jubilation*, and the addition: *All the earth*, he often denotes great thoughts by use of different cases; though the earth is declaimed in the singular, he says: *Sing ye with jubilation* [*iubilate*], which clearly expresses the plural. So you are to assume that *earth* here is intended to denote man rather than soil. Clearly the meaning is allegorical, allegory being a figure which says one thing and means another. *Exp. ps.* 99.2, 28–35 (Walsh 2:444).

The definition of allegory that he gives is standard in the Latin rhetorical tradition. The *Rhetorica ad Herennium* (which uses the Latin term *permutatio*) defines it as *oratio aliud verbis aliud sententia demonstrans* (“denoting one thing by the letter of the words, but another by their meaning”).³¹ Quintilian uses the term *allegoria*, defining it simply as presenting one thing by its words and another or even contrary thing by its sense; thus according to Quintilian it can consist of a succession of metaphors.³² It was only in the Greek philosophical tradition around the first century CE that the term *allégoria* acquired its rich theurgic implications of a truth that lies hidden beneath a surface. This philosophical dimension of the term did not take hold in Latin contexts, even though Latin rhetoricians such as Quintilian began to use the word.³³ Thus in the late antique rhetorical handbook *Scemata dianoemas*, one of the sources that Cassiodorus regularly had to hand, we find the restrained definition *inversio aliud dicens aliud significans*,³⁴ which is the wording that Cassiodorus supplies in Psalm 99.

³¹ (Pseudo-Cicero), *Rhetorica ad Herennium* 4.34.46 (LCL 403, ed. and trans. H. Caplan [Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1954], 344–5).

³² Quintilian, *Inst.* 8.6.44 (ed. and trans. Russell, 3:450–1).

³³ Greek philosophical use of the late term *allégoria* came into use as an equivalent for the philosophically rich term *symbolon*, and was adopted by early Christian theologians writing in Greek. The term was appropriated into Latin rhetoric, but also constricted there. The differences between the Greek philosophical and Latin rhetorical uses of the term “allegory,” and the later implications of that early history, are summarized in the introduction to R. Copeland and P. Struck (eds.), *The Cambridge Companion to Allegory* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2010), 1–12. On the rhetoricians, see also, in the same volume, G. W. Most, “Hellenistic Allegory and Early Imperial Rhetoric,” 26–38.

³⁴ Schindel, “*Anonymous Ecksteinii*,” 48, line 54.

Yet on the other hand, as Astell has elegantly argued, Cassiodorus' approach to the psalms was intrinsically "allegorical" in the Pauline, Neoplatonist, and ultimately Augustinian sense of penetrating beneath the surface to the spiritual sense, reading for the hidden Christ behind the words on the page, and especially in Cassiodorus' understanding of the psalms as a kind of oratory, listening for the speaking Christ in the passionate performance of sacred prayer.³⁵ How then do we account for the discrepancy between Cassiodorus' restrained textbook approach to occurrences of the trope *allegoria* and his embrace of a fully spiritual reading of the Psalter as an inspired collection?

Here we must keep in mind that he brought to his close engagement with the language of the Psalter his technical training in the Roman rhetorical schools. He came to his exposition as a professional writer of panegyric and of a flattering chronicle of Ostrogothic rule. In the Latin rhetorical theory that Cassiodorus inherited, *allegoria* in its narrow technical value as a trope was accorded little philosophical significance or potential; it was understood in a limited way as a difference between expressed and implied sense.³⁶ In this respect, *allegoria* was another ornament of style, and not among those most favored for a subtle power to generate sensual pleasure in the texture of language and a concomitant emotional response. It is telling that Cassiodorus says nothing about the pleasure or beauty or emotional effect of the trope *allegoria*. He reserves those characterizations for figures of speech and figures of thought: *auxesis* is a "most beautiful figure," *synathroesmos* is "one of the most violent," *emphasis* "swells to arouse the mind's emotion."³⁷

³⁵ Astell, "Cassiodorus's *Commentary on the Psalms*," 62–9; and on Cassiodorus' allegorical method, see also R. Schlieben, *Cassiodors Psalmenexegese: Eine Analyse ihrer Methoden als Beitrag zur Untersuchung der Geschichte der Bibelauslegung der Kirchenväter und der Verbindung christlicher Theologie mit antiker Schulwissenschaft* (Göppingen: Kümmerle, 1979), 128–44.

³⁶ Cf. Schlieben, *Cassiodors Psalmenexegese*, 128.

³⁷ For *auxesis* and *emphasis*, see the passages quoted earlier; for *synathroesmos* (*frequentatio*, the "heaping figure"), see Cassiodorus, *Exp. ps.* 11.2, 27–9 (Walsh, 1:140).

As a professional wordsmith, Cassiodorus had found his own success at this level of verbal construction, in his sensitivity to rising and falling cadences, tonal sequences, the satisfying order of similar endings, or the effectiveness of a sudden dissonance. And in turn, these are the features of the psalms to which he is most aesthetically alert and to which he compels his readers' attention. While this linguistic focus is continuous with the pedagogical imperative of the *Expositio*, which became a kind of practicum for the theory of a Christianized liberal arts set forth in the *Institutiones*, we must also recognize it as the inevitable product of his own lifetime formation in the elite culture of rhetoric.

This rhetorical framework, balancing a refined and correct Latin and a codified license to break grammatical rules for the sake of ornament, gave Cassiodorus a heightened sensitivity to what he calls the idioms of Scripture.³⁸ Many of the "idioms" that he finds represent the departures of the Latin Scriptures from classical Latin usage. For example, in Psalm 50:16 he comments on the "divine idiom" *a sanguinibus* (literally "from bloods"), where a classical speaker would expect *a sanguine* (singular, "from blood"). Here his justificatory reading is allegorical (he calls it *exallage*), because the blood is to be understood as sin, and there are many sins (*Exp. ps. 50. 16, 518–29*).³⁹

The imperative to read beyond the grammatical surface of the text so as to arrive at the greater depths of a divine eloquence is continuous with the impulse to read spiritually, against the letter, and in fact underwrites this greater purpose. This is also the value that Cassiodorus places explicitly in discovering the theological

³⁸ On metaplasm, see Donatus, *Ars maior* 3.4 (*Donat et la tradition de l'enseignement grammatical: étude et édition critique*, ed. L. Holtz [Paris: CNRS, 1981], 660, lines 8–9).

³⁹ A. Grondeux, "Teaching and Learning Lists of Figures in the Middle Ages," *New Medieval Literatures, special issue, Medieval Grammar and the Literary Arts*, C. Cannon, R. Copeland, N. Zeeman (eds.), 11 (2009), 133–58, at 143. Another example is his interest in the pronoun *sibi* in Psalm 26:12, where he ponders whether it is used as singular or plural and offers spiritual explanations for either usage.

truths behind the *schemata*, themselves grammatically licensed departures from standard usage. In other words, it was not a theory of allegory, but an aesthetic appreciation of the verbal and grammatical texture of Scripture that generated some of Cassiodorus' most profound theological readings.⁴⁰

The *Expositio psalmorum* was successful for over six hundred years as an introduction to the psalms in monastic communities across western Europe. What gave it its success? It is certainly, as O'Donnell suggests, a textbook of both sacred truths and the liberal arts, and thus an entry into the liturgical life of monasteries.⁴¹ But in this capacity it also provided access to language study and to the rules of eloquence now justified by their originary implantation in Scripture. It was one of the most widely used resources on the figures of speech until, in the early thirteenth century, it was displaced by the new grammatical textbooks of Alexander of Villa Dei and Eberhard of Béthune, which were tailored to the needs of modern students for whom Latin had become a foreign language.⁴² Thus, it owed its long success to something more than its value as an introduction to liturgical life, as important as that is. As a record of Cassiodorus' struggle to comprehend Scripture on the rhetorical and literary terms that constituted his own professional formation, it was a witness to the continuity of classical learning with Christian devotion. What gave it its particular edge is the sense of aesthetic discovery that it brings to the sacred text, the surprise and delight that it registers in its elucidation of the verbal texture of the psalms. Even as the *Expositio psalmorum* teaches theological lessons, it teaches also how to love the Psalms and how the Psalms invite and merit our willing and passionate surrender to their power.

⁴⁰ Cf. A. Quacquarelli, "Riflessioni di Cassiodoro sugli schemi della retorica attraverso I Salmi," in S. Leanza (ed.), *Flavio Magno Aurelio Cassiodoro*, 313–34.

⁴¹ O'Donnell, *Cassiodorus*, 175.

⁴² On the circulation and influence of the *Expositio psalmorum*, see Stoppacci's edition of the *Expositio psalmorum*, 1:273–307, and Grondeux, "Teaching and Learning Lists of Figures," 133–58.

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*Gregory's hermeneutics**Scripture as a path to God**Brendan Lupton*

Gregory the Great (540–604 CE) loved and venerated Scripture. He wrote, “Sacred Scripture without any comparison surpasses all knowledge and learning.”¹ For him, all wisdom and truth is found in the Sacred Page. He also wrote that the Bible is “the lantern that illumines the night of this life.”² Humanity is in exile and is lost. One of its few guides is the written word, which reveals to fallen humans their origin, destiny, and way to live. In a powerful metaphor, Gregory explained why he venerated Scripture so highly. While writing to Theodore, the Emperor Maurice’s physician, Gregory described Scripture as God’s letter to humanity:

What is Holy Scripture other than a letter of almighty God to his creation? And certainly if your glory had been established anywhere else, and you received a letter from an earthly emperor, you would not cease, you would not rest, you would not give sleep to your eyes, before you learnt what your earthly emperor had written to you.³

¹ *Omnem scientiam atque doctrinam scriptura sacra sine aliqua comparatione transcendat* (Gregory, *Mor.* 20.1.1; *S. Gregorii Magni Moralia in Iob*, ed. M. Adriaen, CCL 143, 143A, 143B [Turnhout: Brepols, 1979]). All the translations are my own except when noted. Portions of this chapter are taken from B. Lupton, “St. Paul as a Model and Teacher in the Writings of St. Gregory the Great,” unpublished Ph.D. dissertation, The Catholic University of America, 2013.

² *Scriptura Sacra in nocte uitae praesentis quasi quaedam nobis lucerna sit posita* (Gregory, *Reg. past.* 3.24; *Règle pastorale*, trans. C. Morel, SC 381 [Paris: Cerf, 1992]).

³ *Disce cor Dei in uerbis Dei. Quid autem est scriptura sacra nisi quaedam epistula omnipotentis dei ad creaturam suam? Et certe sicubi esset uestra gloria alibi constituta et scripta terreni imperatoris acciperet, non cessaret, non quiesceret, somnum oculis non daret, nisi prius quid sibi imperator terrenus scripsisset agnouisset* (Gregory, *ep.* 5.46;

God discloses his wisdom, plan for the world, and providence in Scripture. Based on this comparison, Gregory exhorted Theodore to study Scripture often: "Learn the heart of God in the word of God (*disce cor Dei in uerbis Dei*)."⁴

Although Gregory loved the Bible and devoted time to its study and exposition, he did not write a work specifically on scriptural hermeneutics.⁵ There are, however, two principal passages where he addresses the topic: his prologue to his *Commentary on Canticle of Canticles* and prefatory letter for the *Moralia* (i.e., letter to Leander). This chapter will examine these two passages in order to present Gregory's hermeneutical theory. Before turning to the relevant texts, it will first be helpful to sketch briefly Gregory's background and literary inheritance. His biography is especially relevant, since he will allude to it in his letter to Leander.

Gregory the Great's background

Gregory was born circa 540 into an affluent Roman family, who had become wealthy through extensive properties in Rome and Sicily.⁶ Gregory's family's estate rested on Rome's Caelian Hill. In terms of Gregory's immediate family, his father's name was Gordianus and his mother's Silvia,⁷ and they were both Christians. In terms of Gregory's education, contemporary scholars do not have much

S. Gregorii Magni Registrum Epistularum: Libri I–VIII, ed. D. Norberg, CCL 140 [Turnhout: Brepols, 1982].

⁴ Gregory, *ep.* 5.46.

⁵ S. DeGregorio, "Gregory's Exegesis: Old and New Ways of Approaching the Scriptural Text," in B. Neil and M. J. D. Santo (eds.), *A Companion to Gregory the Great*, Brill's Companions to the Christian Tradition 47 (Leiden: Brill, 2013), 269–90, at 284.

⁶ Gregory of Tours, *History of the Franks* 10.1 (trans. E. Brehaut, Records of Civilization: Sources and Studies 11 [New York: Columbia University Press, 1916], 227).

⁷ Gregory's mother's name first appears in Gregory's earliest biography: Anonymous Monk of Whitby, *The Earliest Life of Gregory the Great*, trans. B. Colgrave (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1968), 72: *Fuit igitur iste natione Romanus, ex patre Gordiano et matre Silvia*.

conclusive knowledge of Roman education at this time.⁸ Gregory of Tours, however, reports that Gregory was known as one of Rome's best students: "So accomplished was he [Gregory] in grammar, dialectic, and rhetoric, that he was held second to none in the city."⁹ F. Homes Dudden hypothesizes that Gregory of Tours mentioned "grammar, dialectic, and rhetoric" in this quotation, since these disciplines were fashionable in the sixth century, partly on account of the work of Cassiodorus' *De artibus ac disciplinis liberalium litterarum*.¹⁰

In 573, Gregory was named *praefectus urbi*, urban prefect, of Rome, which was the highest administrative post in the city. He refers to this appointment in one of his letters, "As at that time I was acting as urban prefect."¹¹ Richards outlines some of the duties of the prefect: "[The prefect] controlled law and order, supply and public works, was president of the Senate and judge."¹² These administrative tasks prepared Gregory well for some of the challenges that he would face as pope, such as financing the daily operations in Rome,¹³ ransoming captives,¹⁴ and supplying grain to the citizens,¹⁵ to name a few.

As urban prefect, Gregory believed that this appointment and all its entanglements were a threat to his soul. On account of the

⁸ See, P. Riché, *Écoles et enseignement dans la Haut Moyen Âge* (Paris: Aubier Montaigne, 1979), 15–19; M. L. W. Laistner, *Thought and Letters in Western Europe*, 2nd ed. (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1966), 108–12.

⁹ Gregory of Tours, *History of the Franks* 10.1. In his life of Gregory (*Vita* 2), Paul the Deacon echoes this same quotation ("Sancti Gregorii papae vita," *PL* 75 [1841], 41–59).

¹⁰ F. H. Dudden, *Gregory the Great: His Place in History and Thought* (New York: Russell & Russell, 1967), vol. I, 72–6.

¹¹ *Ego tunc urbanam praefecturam gerens* (Gregory, *ep.* 4.2). Based on some conflicting manuscripts, there is some question whether Gregory was appointed as urban praetor or prefect. The consensus today, however, is that Gregory was a prefect, since the office of praetor had ceased to exist. For more on this question, see J. Richards, *Consul of God: The Life and Times of Gregory the Great* (London: Routledge and Kegan Paul, 1980), 30–1; C. Straw, *Authors of the Middle Ages*, ed. P. Geary, Historical and Religious Writers of the Latin West IV, 12 (Aldershot: Variorum, 1996), 10.

¹² Richards, *Consul of God*, 30. ¹³ Gregory, *ep.* 5.39. ¹⁴ *Ep.* 2.38.

¹⁵ *Ep.* 5.36.

temptations that Gregory experienced as *praefectus*, he left the world and entered the cloister in 574. Gregory transformed his family estate into a monastery, dedicated to St. Andrew, which he entered as a simple monk under the leadership of abbot Valerio.¹⁶

Gregory's withdrawal from the world, however, was short lived. In 579, Pelagius II ordained him a deacon and sent him to Constantinople as an *apocrisarius*, that is, a papal legate.¹⁷ Deacons often occupied this position. In fact, they were often ordained right before their departure. Justinian's legislation describes this office in generic terms: "The apocrisarius conducts the business of the holy churches."¹⁸

Around 585–6, Pope Pelagius II recalled Gregory to Rome where he resumed his duties as a deacon and returned to St. Andrew's. In 589, a plague and floods ravaged the city. Pelagius contracted the disease and died.¹⁹ In 590, Gregory was elected as Bishop of Rome.

One of Gregory's chief duties as Bishop of Rome was to be an interpreter of Scripture. Although wars, famines, and plagues burdened him and his flock, Gregory was productive in terms of literature. There are seven extant works of Gregory the Great, including his letters.²⁰

Literary inheritance

Before discussing Gregory's teaching on exegesis, one should mention his literary inheritance. It is often emphasized that Gregory is dependent on Augustine. Straw writes, "Gregory owes more to

¹⁶ Gregory of Tours, *History of the Franks* 10.1.

¹⁷ There is some debate as to whether Gregory was summoned by Benedict I or Pelagius II. Gregory himself implies that it was Pelagius. See Richards, *Consul of God*, 37.

¹⁸ *Corpus Iuris Civilis* 6.2: *Qui res agunt sanctarum ecclesiarum, quos apocrisarios vocant*; R. Schöll and W. Kroll (eds.), *Corpus iuris civilis* (Berlin: Apud Weidmannos, 1928), vol. III, 41.

¹⁹ Paul the Deacon, *History of the Lombards* 3.24 (trans. W. Foulke [Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1907], 127).

²⁰ For an introduction to each of these works, see Straw, *Authors of the Middle Ages*, 41.

Augustine than to any other individual writer.”²¹ Also, Claude Dagens states, “*Certes, l’oeuvre grégorienne est pétrie de leçons augustinienne.*”²² Given the prominent place of Augustine in Gregory’s thought, it would seem that parallel passages would exist in Gregory’s writing. Meyvaert, however, explains, “Unlike so many of his medieval followers he [Gregory] never borrows slavishly from others.”²³ Augustine serves as a source of ideas for Gregory, but not as a source for proof texts. Reinhold Seeberg summarizes this idea: “*Fast alles bei ihm hat seine Wurzeln bei Augustin, und fast nichts ist wirklich augustinisch.*”²⁴ Also, Markus writes, “When you scratch Gregory, the blood you draw always seems to be Augustinian. And yet somehow the absolute gap persists, and cries out for description.”²⁵ In summary, Augustine serves as a major source for Gregory, but the pontiff does not always follow his lead.

One area where Gregory departs from Augustine is semiotics. He does not repeat, develop, or comment on signs and signification. Markus writes, “Gregory took no interest in theoretical discussion of signification and meaning. He held Augustine in high regard; but it was Augustine’s exegetical practice rather than his theory that he followed.”²⁶ Although Gregory does not delve into semiotics, he does reflect on some principles of scriptural interpretation, which this chapter will discuss.

²¹ C. Straw, “Gregory I,” in A. D. Fitzgerald (ed.), *Augustine through the Ages: An Encyclopedia* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1999), 402a–405b, at 404b.

²² C. Dagens, *Saint Grégoire le Grand: culture et expérience Chrétiennes* (Paris: Études Augustiniennes, 1977), 18.

²³ P. Meyvaert, “A New Edition of Gregory the Great’s Commentaries on the Canticle and I Kings,” *Journal of Theological Studies* 19/1 (1968), 215–25, at 220.

²⁴ R. Seeberg, *Lehrbuch der Dogmengeschichte*, 4th ed., *Die Dogmengeschichte des Mittelalters* (Leipzig: A. Deichert, 1930), vol. IV, 45, quoted in L. Weber, *Hauptfragen der Moraltheologie Gregors des Grossen: ein Bild altchristlicher Lebensführung* (Freiburg: Paulusdruckerei, 1947), 43.

²⁵ R. A. Markus, “The Jew as a Hermeneutic Device: The Inner Life of a Gregorian Topos,” in J. Cavadini (ed.), *Gregory the Great: A Symposium* (Notre Dame, IN: University of Notre Dame Press, 1995), 1–15, at 4.

²⁶ R. A. Markus, *Signs and Meanings: World and Text in Ancient Christianity*, 2nd ed., *Forwood Lectures in the Philosophy and History of Religion 1995* (Liverpool: Liverpool University Press, 1996), 48.

Even though Augustine was Gregory's main theological inspiration, John Cassian also had an impact on his thought. Straw writes, "Gregory's debt to Cassian and the monastic tradition of the desert is substantial."²⁷ On rare occasions, Gregory does cite the names of other patristic authors, such as Ignatius of Antioch, Cyprian, Hilary of Poitiers, Basil the Great, Epiphanius, Ambrose, Jerome, Leo the Great, and Filastrius.²⁸ Gregory also repeats the ideas of some Latin classical moralists, such as Cicero and Seneca.²⁹

Introduction to Gregory's *Commentary on Canticle of Canticles*

From 594 to 598, Gregory preached on the *Commentary on Canticle of Canticles* to an audience of monks and clerics.³⁰ Until the twentieth century, the authenticity of this work was questioned, but it has been established to be genuine.³¹ Unfortunately, only a fragment of the treatise survives, which is his reflections on verses 1–7 of chapter 1. It is possible that Gregory might have commented up until 4:5 of the *Canticle of Canticles*.³²

In the prologue of this work, Gregory discusses exegesis and specifically the role of allegory. Before beginning this discussion, it will first be helpful to preface it with a consideration of a fundamental feature of Gregory's spirituality: the move toward the interior.

²⁷ Straw, *Authors of the Middle Ages*, 43.

²⁸ J. P. McClain, *The Doctrine of Heaven in the Writings of Saint Gregory the Great*, Studies in Sacred Theology 2, vol. 95 (Washington, DC: The Catholic University of America Press, 1956), 10–11.

²⁹ Dagens, *Saint Grégoire le Grand*, 77.

³⁰ P. Meyvaert, "The Date of Gregory the Great's Commentaries on the Canticle of Canticles and on 1 Kings," *Sacris Erudiri* 23 (1979), 191–216, at 203–5.

³¹ B. Capelle, "Les homélies de saint Grégoire sur le cantique," *Revue Benedictine* 41 (1929), 204–17; P. Verbraken, "Le commentaire de saint Grégoire sur le premier livre des Rois," *Revue Benedictine* 66 (1956), 159–217. For a review of how this text came to be authenticated, see M. DelCogliano (trans.), Introduction to *Gregory the Great on the Song of Songs*, Cistercian Studies Series 244 (Collegeville, MN: Liturgical Press, 2012), 29–43.

³² E. A. Matter, *Voice of My Beloved: The Song of Songs in Western Medieval Christianity*, Middle Ages Series (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1990), 94.

This contextualization will clarify Gregory's understanding of the role of allegory.

Many Gregorian scholars have commented on the pontiff's emphasis on the interior life. In fact, Dagens' book *Saint Grégoire le Grand* explores this feature in some detail. He writes, "*il [Grégoire] lui faudra passer par l'intériorité pour trouver Dieu. Tel est le centre de la théologie et de la spiritualité de Grégoire.*"³³ Dagens explains that most likely Gregory inherited this preference from Augustine.³⁴ Like the great Bishop of Hippo, Gregory believed that if one moved inward, one also moved upward toward the Divine. For example, Gregory wrote, "We are not able to die perfectly to the world, unless we are buried within the invisible (*inuisibilia*) things of our heart and separated from all visible (*uisibilibus*) things."³⁵ The more the soul becomes detached and removed from the interior world, the more it ascends the chain of being. This spirituality has its roots in Neoplatonism.³⁶ Again Gregory states, "For one easily finds a treasure in oneself, if one thrusts from himself that heap of earthly thoughts, which oppress him."³⁷ For Gregory, if one removes himself from the "heap of earthly thoughts," he finds "a treasure in himself." This emphasis on the interior as a place of divine discovery will help to explain Gregory's preference for allegory.

Dagens and Aubin have demonstrated that there is link between Gregory's preference for interiority and his teaching on exegesis. Dagens writes, "*Passer d'un sens extérieur à sens intérieur constitue aussi un principe de son exégèse.*"³⁸ The exegete is called to feed his

³³ Dagens, *Saint Grégoire le Grand*, 26.

³⁴ Ibid., 170. To provide evidence for Augustine's emphasis on the interior, Dagens quotes from *conf.* 2.6.14; 3.1.1.

³⁵ *Quia enim perfecte mundo mori non possumus, nisi intra mentis nostrae inuisibilia a uisibilibus abscondamur, recte hi qui mortificationem suam appetunt, thesaurum effodientibus comparantur* (Gregory, *Mor.* 5.5.8).

³⁶ For further information on this theme in Augustine, see P. Cary, *Inner Grace: Augustine in the Traditions of Plato and Paul* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2008); see also P. Fredriksen, *Augustine and the Jews: A Christian Defense of Jews and Judaism* (New York: Doubleday, 2008), 123–5.

³⁷ *Facile enim in se thesaurum inuenit, si eam quae se male presserat molem a se terrenae cogitationis repellit* (Gregory, *Mor.* 5.5.8).

³⁸ Dagens, *Saint Grégoire le Grand*, 234.

flock with the “interior” understanding of the text, which will nourish them and also lead them to contemplation. In his introductory letter to Leander, which will be discussed in this chapter, Gregory explains that at times he will bypass the literal meaning of the text: “Sometimes, we neglect to discuss the literal words of the historical layer lest we arrive too slowly at the hidden (*obscura*) words.”³⁹ He emphasizes the spiritual or allegorical reading of the text, since it often helps the hearer to “move within,” which will be elaborated on in the following.

Gregory's discussion of allegory in the *Commentary on Canticle of Canticles*

To preface this discussion, Ann Matter notes that Gregory's discussion of allegory is “the most theoretical discussion of allegory in the early Middle Ages.”⁴⁰ Gregory begins his commentary and his discussion of the importance of allegory not with a introduction to the book per se, but with a description of humanity's postlapsarian state: “After its banishment from the joys of Paradise, the human race came to the pilgrimage of this present life with a heart blind to spiritual understanding.”⁴¹ It is noteworthy that the Gregory's letter to Leander, which also discusses scriptural hermeneutics in detail, also begins with the story of a banishment; that is, Gregory's own.⁴² In this letter, Gregory narrates how the world entangled him while he was the prefect of Rome. The repetition of fall and exile hints at the fundamental Gregorian presupposition mentioned

³⁹ *Aliquando uero exponere aperta historiae uerba neglegimus, ne tardius ad obscura ueniamus* (Gregory, *Mor. ep. dedic.* 3).

⁴⁰ Matter, *The Voice of My Beloved*, 94.

⁴¹ *Postquam a paradisi gaudiis expulsum est genus humanum, in istam peregrinationem uitae praesentis ueniens caecum cor ab spiritali intellectu habet* (Gregory, *In CC* 1.1; *S. Gregorii in Canticum Canticorum*, ed. P. Verbraken, *CCL* 144 [Turnhout: Brepols, 1982]). In this chapter, the translations are taken from DelCogliano, *Gregory the Great on the Song of Song*.

⁴² For this insight, I am indebted to S. Kessler, “Gregory the Great (c. 540–604),” in C. Kannengiesser (ed.), *Handbook of Patristic Exegesis*, *The Bible in Ancient Christianity* (Leiden: Brill, 2004), vol. II, 1336–68, at 1348.

earlier: a human being is entangled in the world of the senses and needs to become detached from externals and move inward. Scripture is a fundamental aid in this process. As mentioned, Gregory explains that Scripture is “the lantern that illumines the night of this life.”⁴³ Through the fall, humans have become blind to God and spiritual things. As a result, they are unable to read the Sacred Page spiritually, since they cannot read the world in this way either.

In the very beginning of his *Commentary on the Canticle of Canticles*, Gregory explains that not only are humans lost, but they wander with “with a heart blind (*caecum cor*) to spiritual understanding.”⁴⁴ They have difficulty reading a text allegorically, since they are immersed in the world. Gregory insists that if hearers listen to only a surface interpretation of the text, it will be counterproductive, especially if the text is from the Canticle of Canticles. The exegete must therefore draw the listener to an “interior” understanding of it. In a famous example, Gregory explains that it would be “exceedingly ignorant (*nimis stultus*)” to pay attention only to the literal meaning of the text:

Sacred Scripture consists of words and its meanings (*sensibus*), so too a picture consists of colors and its subject: and he is exceedingly dense, who pays such close attention to the colors of the picture, with the result that he ignores the subject depicted. For if, we understand the words, which are spoken externally (*exterius*), and ignore their meaning (*sensus*), it is as if we are ignorant of the subject depicted, and concentrate only on the colors.⁴⁵

Through this metaphor, Gregory emphasizes that one should not just focus on the written words, but rather examine their meaning.

⁴³ *Scriptura Sacra in nocte uitae praesentis quasi quaedam nobis lucerna sit posita* (Gregory, *Reg. past.* 3.24).

⁴⁴ *Caecum cor ab spiritali intellectu habet* (*In CC* 1.1).

⁴⁵ *Sic est enim scriptura sacra in uerbis et sensibus, sicut pictura in coloribus et rebus: et nimis stultus est, qui sic picturae coloribus inheret, ut res, quae pictae sunt, ignoret. Nos enim, si uerba, quae exterius dicuntur, amplectimur et sensus ignoramus, quasi ignorantes res, quae depictae sunt, solos colores tenemus* (*In CC* 1.4). I have slightly modified the English translation.

It is interesting to note that Markus explains that this example is in accord with Augustine's semiotics as presented in *De doctrina Christina*.⁴⁶

After describing humanity's postlapsarian state, Gregory explains one of the ways that God has planned to rescue humanity. On account of their fallen state and blindness, people are unable to follow abstract spiritual commands, such as "Follow God!" or "Love God!"⁴⁷ They need a more tactical or material instruction. Therefore, the divine author condescended and has used earthly language to convey heavenly realities: "Divine speech is communicated to the cold and numb soul by means of enigmas and in a hidden manner instills in her the love she does not know by means of what she knows."⁴⁸ The enigmas, especially in the *Canticle of Canticles*, are often things of the material world, but they are meant to be a type of lure or bait to entice the soul to consider spiritual things. Gregory writes, "We learn from the dialogues of the love here below with what intensity we should burn in the love of Divinity."⁴⁹ Allegory transforms natural phenomena into spiritual disclosure or revelation. As Gregory writes, "Allegories are produced by clothing divine thoughts in what we know. When we recognize the exterior (*exteriora*) language, we attain interior (*interiorem*) understanding."⁵⁰

⁴⁶ Markus, *Signs and Meanings*, 63. Although this metaphor agrees with Augustine's semiotics in *De doctrina Christiana*, Markus states that it diverges from Augustine's distinction between reading a book and seeing a painting in his commentary on John 24:2. When "reading a book," one must at times look beyond the initial meaning to a figurative one. When "viewing a painting," however, often one just sees the colors and picture together. Markus explains how this subtle difference helps to make sense of Gregory's "free-wheeling" exegetical practice. He writes, "For Gregory the visible object is there to be seen through, or seen past" (Markus, *Signs and Meanings*, 64). Augustine would call this type of interpretation "figurative," or a "transferred sense."

⁴⁷ *Sequere Deum uel dilige Deum* (Gregory, *In CC* 1.1). ⁴⁸ *In CC* 1.1.

⁴⁹ *Quia ex sermonibus huius amoris discimus, qua uirtute in diuinitatis amore ferueamus* (*In CC* 1.3).

⁵⁰ *Rebus enim nobis notis, per quas allegoriae conficiuntur, sententiae diuinae uestiuntur et, dum recognoscimus exteriora uerba, peruenimus ad interiorem intelligentiam*; See also *Unde se loquendo humiliat, inde nos intellectu exaltat* (*In CC* 1.2).

For Gregory, allegory is not just a rhetorical tool, but it also helps to transform the soul. Gregory famously writes, "Allegory functions as a type of crane or pulley (*machina*) for the soul positioned far (*longe*) from God so that through it she might be raised (*levetur*) to God."⁵¹ In this important quotation, notice that Gregory does not say that allegory transforms "the text" or "material realities," but rather says that it converts the soul (*anima*), which is far from God. It then raises (*levetur*) the soul to God. Allegory trains the disciple to turn from material realities and focus on spiritual ones, which can lead ultimately to contemplation. To amplify this interpretation, Gregory also states, "For God appears more glorious to the mind that seeks Him the more subtly and interiorly she seeks that he appear."⁵² The struggle to find the Lord in the text prompts the hearer also to struggle to find Him in him or herself.

Gregory's preface to his *Commentary on the Canticle of Canticles* is marked by a movement between interior and exterior, inside and outside, and high and deep. All these antitheses emphasize that the exegete must direct the reading toward a more spiritual understanding of the text, which will illuminate "blindness of heart."

Gregory's exegetical theory as presented in his letter to Leander of Seville

The second text where Gregory explicitly discusses scriptural exegesis at length is his dedicatory letter to Leander of Seville, which serves as the preface for his *Moralia*. In this letter, he outlines his method of exegesis and the role of the expositor. To contextualize this letter, it will be helpful to provide a brief introduction to Gregory's *Moralia*.

⁵¹ *Allegoria enim animae longe a Deo positae quasi quandam machinam facit, ut per illam leuetur ad deum* (In CC 1.2). For further examples of the salvific nature of allegory, see In CC 1.4 and Mor. 5.5.8.

⁵² In CC 1.4.: *menti enim Deum quaerenti tanto Deus gloriosius apparet, quanto subtilius atque interius inuestigatur, ut appareat*. This translation is modified from DelCogliano.

As mentioned earlier, in 579, Pelagius II ordained Gregory, who was a monk at the time and living at St. Andrews monastery, as a deacon and sent him to Constantinople as an *apocrisiarius*, that is, a papal legate. Gregory traveled to Constantinople with some of his confreres from St. Andrew's. At their request, Gregory composed the *Moralia on Job*. As a whole, this work is divided into six books of 35 chapters (books 1–5, 6–10, 11–16, 17–22, 23–7, 28–35).⁵³ Gregory does not examine the book of Job with equal thoroughness. He treats chapters 12 to 24 rather lightly so that he can focus on some of the more obscure passages.⁵⁴

Although Gregory began the *Moralia* in Constantinople, he continued to edit the work as pope. In 591, he promised to send Leander of Seville a copy of the completed work.⁵⁵ In 595, however, Gregory could supply Leander only with the first and second parts.⁵⁶ Carole Straw points out that Gregory continued to edit the *Moralia* until at least 596, because he mentions the conversion of the English in *Mor.* 22.11.21.⁵⁷ It is interesting to note that Gregory's *Moralia* is among "the longest books to have been written in Latin at the time of its composition."⁵⁸

Gregory also begins his letter to Leander with the idea of banishment and blindness. Instead of the human race's exile, this time it is his own. When he was serving as prefect of the city of Rome, he found himself enslaved. He wrote to Leander, "While my soul still compelled me to be of service to this present world [as *praefectus*] . . . many things began to spring up against me from the care of this world."⁵⁹ To flee from this temptation, Gregory moved inward and escaped from the world: "At length being anxious to flee all these temptations, I sought the harbor of the monastery."⁶⁰ Gregory, like many of the Latin fathers, often compares the dangers

⁵³ Gregory, *Mor.* ep. dedic. 2. ⁵⁴ *Mor.* 16.69.83. ⁵⁵ *Ep.* 1.41.

⁵⁶ *Ep.* 5.53. ⁵⁷ Straw, *Authors of the Middle Ages*, 49.

⁵⁸ J. Moorhead, *Gregory the Great*, Early Church Fathers (London: Routledge, 2005), 1.

⁵⁹ *Cum que adhuc me cogeret animus praesenti mundo quasi specie tenuis deservire, coeperunt multa contra me ex eiusdem mundi cura succrescere, ut in eo iam non specie, sed, quod est grauius, mente retinerer* (Gregory, *Mor.* ep. dedic. 1).

⁶⁰ *Quae tandem cuncta sollicitae fugiens, portum monasterii petii* (*Mor.* ep. dedic. 1).

of the world to the sea.⁶¹ The monastery, like a good harbor, provided safety and repose.

After a brief monastic retreat, Gregory is summoned to serve as *apocrisiarius* and sent to Constantinople with a band of his monastic brothers. He then finds again that outward concerns led him astray: "We [i.e., churchmen] . . . are supposed to serve the inner mysteries (*interius mysteriis*), but become entwined in outward cares (*exterioribus*)."⁶² Gregory is supposed to be devoted "to inner mysteries," that is, the *interius mysteriis* of Scripture. In the midst of the distractions of Constantinople, Gregory narrates that his monastic confreres kept him safe through prayer and the reading of Scripture.

I was followed by many of my brothers from the monastery, who were united to me by an authentic charity. This happened, I perceive, by Divine dispensation, in order that through their example, as by an anchored cable, I might be connected to the tranquil shores of prayer, whenever I might be tossed about by the ceaseless waves of secular affairs . . . among them through the appeals of diligent reading (*lectionis*), a spirit enkindled in me a desire for daily compunction.⁶³

In short, Gregory's brothers kept him anchored. They inspired him to pray and read the Holy Scripture. After recounting this experience, Gregory outlines his hermeneutical method to interpret the Book of Job. His autobiography connotes that Gregory will now supply the listener with "an anchored cable" to keep him/her safe at shore.

After his biographical narration, Gregory sets forth his hermeneutical plan for the *Moralia*. Like a good teacher, he first theorizes about exegesis and then will illustrate it with a metaphor:

It seemed good to these same brothers [Gregory's fellow monks who asked him to comment on the Book of Job] . . . that they compel me by

⁶¹ For more on Gregory's maritime metaphors, see Moorhead, *Gregory the Great*, 47.

⁶² *Nos, qui interius mysteriis deseruire credimur, curis exterioribus implicamur* (Gregory, *Mor. ep. dedic. 1*).

⁶³ *Ubi me scilicet multi ex monasterio fratres mei germana uincti caritate secuti sunt. Quod Diuina factum dispensatione conspicio, ut eorum semper exemplo ad orationis placidum litus quasi anchorae fune restringerer, cum causarum saecularium incessabili impulsu fluctuarem . . . inter eos tamen per studiosae lectionis alloquium, cotidianae me aspiratio compunctionis animabat* (*Mor. ep. dedic. 1*).

their insistent requests to expound on the book of blessed Job; and as far as the Truth should inspire me with the ability, that I reveal to them these mysteries (*mysteria*) of such profound depth (*profunditatis*); and they added this additional burden to their petition, that I would not only investigate the historical words (*verba historiae*) through the allegorical sense (*allegoria*), but that I would incline the allegorical sense toward a moral (*moralitas*) interpretation. To this, they even added a more difficult request that I would crown these interpretations with testimonies (*testimonia*).⁶⁴

Here, Gregory articulates a tripartite method of exegesis. He will begin with history, or the literal sense, and then the secrets of allegory, which he will “incline” toward a moral interpretation. Finally, he will crown these interpretations with “testimonies,” which often amplify his exegesis with other scriptural verses.⁶⁵

Further in this same letter to Leander, Gregory repeats the same tripartite schema: literal, allegorical, tropological/moral.⁶⁶ Clearly, he did not invent this threefold method of exegesis. Concerning its source, Stephen Kessler explains, “From the three dimensions of the classical anthropology (body-mind-soul) and from the tradition of Christian biblical interpretation Gregory inherited the threefold form of exegesis (literal-spiritual-and mystical).”⁶⁷ Although he just

⁶⁴ *Tunc eisdem fratribus etiam cogente te placuit . . . ut librum beati Iob exponere importuna me petitione compellerent et, prout ueritas uires infunderet, eis mysteria tantae profunditatis aperirem. Qui hoc quoque mihi in onere suae petitionis addiderunt, ut non solum uerba historiae per allegoriarum sensus excuterem, sed allegoriarum sensus protinus in exercitium moralitatis inclinarem, adhuc aliquid grauius adiungentes, ut intellecta quaeque testimoniis cingerem* (Mor. ep. dedic. 1).

⁶⁵ For more information on these proof texts, see G. Zinn, “Exegesis and Spirituality in the Writings of Gregory the Great,” in *Gregory the Great: A Symposium*, 168–80, at 176; M. Fiedrowicz, *Das kirchenverständnis Gregors des Grossen: Eine Untersuchung seiner exegetischen und homiletischen Werke*, Römische Quartalschrift für christliche Altertumskunde und Kirchengeschichte, Supp. 50 (Freiburg: Herder, 1995), 43.

⁶⁶ *Sciendum uero est, quod quaedam historica expositione transcurrimus et per allegoriam quaedam typica inuestigatione perscrutamur, quaedam per sola allegoricae moralitatis instrumenta discutimus, nonnulla autem per cuncta simul sollicitius exquirentes tripliciter indagamus* (Gregory, Mor. ep. dedic. 3).

⁶⁷ Kessler, “Gregory the Great,” 1351; Dagens, *Saint Grégoire le Grand*, 234; cf. Degregorio, “Gregory’s Exegesis,” 285.

referred to three senses here, Gregory will at times list another sense, which raises the hearer to contemplate the higher things. For example, while commenting on Job 22:26, "Then you shall be filled with delicacies over the Almighty," Gregory writes,

In his words, we find surely so many delicacies, that we obtain different interpretations (*intellegentiae*) for our profit, presently bare history (*historia*) should feed us, veiled now under the literal text, moral allegory refreshes us inwardly (*medullitus*), and now to the higher things (*altiora*) contemplation should suspend us, as it shines on us with the light of eternity in the darkness of this present life.⁶⁸

This quotation is significant, since Gregory includes a final sense that leads to contemplation of the higher things (*altiora*). De Lubac interprets this and other examples as a use of the anagogical sense.⁶⁹ He argues that Augustine laid the foundation for the medieval doctrine of the fourfold sense, but that "Saint Gregory was one of the principal initiators and the greatest patrons of the medieval doctrine of the fourfold sense."⁷⁰

Although this volume is dedicated to the explicit exegetical teachings of some of the Latin fathers, it should be noted that Gregory's actual practice differs greatly from his proposed methodology. Instead of the threefold pattern, Robert Markus has discerned that Gregory mainly observes a twofold distinction throughout his corpus: "This is the distinction variously stated between carnal and spiritual, literal and allegorical (or mystical), historical and typical, outer and inner understanding."⁷¹ In short, Gregory often uses either the literal or allegorical sense.

⁶⁸ *In cuius nimirum uerbis tot delicias inuenimus, quot ad profectum nostrum intellegentiae diuersitates accipimus, ut modo modo nuda nos pascat historia, modo sub textu litterae uelata, medullitus nos reficiat moralis allegoria, modo ad altiora suspendat contemplatio, in praesentis uitae tenebris iam de lumine aeternitatis intermicans* (Gregory, *Mor.* 16.19.24).

⁶⁹ H. de Lubac, *Medieval Exegesis: The Four Senses of Scripture*, trans. M. Sebanc (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1998), vol. I, 134. De Lubac cites Gregory's *Hom. E7.* 1.2.9 as an example.

⁷⁰ De Lubac, *Medieval Exegesis*, 134.

⁷¹ Markus, *Gregory the Great*, 47.

Emphasis on the moral/tropological sense

As mentioned earlier, Gregory emphasizes that he will “incline the allegorical sense toward a moral (*moralitas*) interpretation.” Throughout his letter to Leander, he emphasizes that his exegesis will have a moral tone. For example, in a metaphor to describe the hermeneutical process, Gregory writes,

First, we lay the foundation of history (*historiae*); then we erect through allegory (*per significationem*) the fabric of the mind to be the fortress of faith; finally through the pleasantness (*gratia*) of moral instruction (*moralitatis*) we clothe the building with a colored garment.⁷²

There are several important features in this description. First, Gregory describes how he constructs his exegesis through allegory. Note that here he explains that his interpretations move from lower to higher things. This is an echo of his principle that allegory or spiritual understanding lifts the Christian from the world. Second, Gregory states that he will decorate his exegesis with *moralitas*, that is, teachings on morality. At this point, one might ask: Why did Gregory focus on the moral sense?

To understand Gregory's emphasis on moral exegesis, it is helpful to contextualize his time, which Robert Markus set out to do with his work *The End of Ancient Christianity*. He argued that in order to understand Gregory's written work, one must grasp the cultural shift that occurred from the age of Augustine and Ambrose to that of Gregory. Markus writes,

I have become convinced in the course of many years' work on the history of Christianity from the fourth to the sixth century that the cast of his [Gregory's] mind can be understood only when we have taken the measure of the intellectual and spiritual shift that took place between the Christianity of, say, Augustine, Jerome and Ambrose, and that of Gregory.⁷³

⁷² *Nam primum quidem fundamenta historiae ponimus; deinde per significationem typicam in arcem fidei fabricam mentis erigimus; ad extremum quoque per moralitatis gratiam, quasi superducto aedificium colore uestimus* (Gregory, *Mor. ep. dedic.* 3).

⁷³ R. A. Markus, *Gregory the Great and His World* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1997), xii.

Markus explains that one of the primary differences between the fourth and fifth centuries was the advancement of the Christian culture. Gregory lived in what Markus described as a “biblical culture.”⁷⁴ The general populace knew the essence of the Christian faith, its Scripture, and its narrative. The empire’s adoption of Christianity also dramatically changed the culture. Markus explains how “secular Roman time was transformed into Christian liturgical time; how the geography of the Roman Empire received a thick overlay of sacred topography modification.”⁷⁵ Augustine’s time, however, was much more dramatically heterogeneous. The empire was in the midst of growing pains and was shifting from a “pagan” to a Christian world. Markus states that one of the central questions for Augustine’s period and his writing was “what is a Christian?”⁷⁶ In accord with this question, many of Augustine’s theological writings were in reaction to controversies, Manicheism, Pelagianism, and Donatism. Gregory’s period had matured. This foundation enabled him to focus on a different question: “How should the Christian behave?”⁷⁷ On the whole, Gregory’s exegesis is slated toward morality and practice.

Another factor that contributed to Gregory’s emphasis on morality seems to be his own preference. Gregory was a monk and contemplative at heart. He was uninterested in “life at court,” which often entangled its participants in gossip, politics, and ambition.⁷⁸ He wanted *otium* and *quies* to live out the Christian life. This monastic preference is also revealed in his writings. He generally shies away from purely academic questions or questions of government, but considers how the Christian ought to behave, the challenges that he/she will face, and the temptations that he/she will

⁷⁴ Markus, *Gregory the Great*, 40.

⁷⁵ R. A. Markus, *The End of Ancient Christianity* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1991), 226–7.

⁷⁶ Markus, *Gregory the Great*, 40.

⁷⁷ R. A. Markus, “Gregory the Great on Kings: Rulers and Preachers in the Commentary on I Kings,” in D. Wood (ed.), *The Church and Sovereignty c. 590–1918: Essays in Honour of Michael Wilks*, Studies in Church History, Subsidia 9 (Oxford: Blackwell, 1991), 7–21, at 19.

⁷⁸ Gregory, *Mor. ep. dedic.* 1.

encounter. This is what seemed to catch his heart and attention. These topics must have been circulating in his thoughts, since Gregory often had very little time to prepare his scriptural commentaries. Thus, it seems that Gregory's own preference for morality also shaped his understanding of scriptural exegesis.

Discernment of the exegete

Although Gregory set forth this tripartite methodology, he warns his listeners that he will digress freely and look for opportunities for edification. He explains,

But yet whoever speaks about God, it is necessary that he take care to examine thoroughly whatever might provide moral (*mores*) instruction for his hearers; and should believe (*deputet*) this to be the correct method for his discourse (*rectum ordinem loquendi*), if, when the opportunity for edification (*aedificationis*) demands it, he should divert himself for a good purpose from his initial topic.⁷⁹

Here, Gregory emphasizes that he, and all exegetes (*quisquis de Deo loquitur*), should interpret Scripture in a way that edifies their congregations and helps them to live the Christian life. Like all patristic writers, he interprets Scripture for the sake of his flock. This is the correct method of speaking (*ordo rectus loquendi*). It should be noted that Gregory also subtly connects the task of an exegete again to that of a builder – the exegete “builds up (*intruit*)” and looks for opportunities for “edification (*aedificationis*).”

To accentuate that the exegete should look for opportunities to nourish and assist the congregation, Gregory presents an elaborate metaphor and compares the hermeneut to a river:

He who treats sacred scripture (*tractator sacri eloqui*) ought to follow the way (*mos*) a river flows, for if a river, as it flows down along its channel, meets with open valleys on its side, into these it immediately turns the course of its current, and when they are filled, it pours itself

⁷⁹ *Sed tamen quisquis de deo loquitur, curet necesse est, ut quicquid audientium mores instruit rimetur, et hunc rectum loquendi ordinem deputet, si cum opportunitas aedificationis exigit, ab eo se, quod loqui coeperat, utiliter deriuat (Mor. ep. dedic. 2).*

immediately back into its bed. Therefore, unquestionably, thus, the exegete (*tractator*) should follow this course, that when discussing any subject, if perhaps he might find nearby an occasion of suitable edification, he should turn the current of discourse towards the nearby valley, and when he has sufficiently flooded the field with instruction, he returns to the channel of his original topic.⁸⁰

One wonders if Gregory's setting in Constantinople near the Bosphorus might have inspired this metaphor. With this image, Gregory connotes that the exegete (*tractator*) must be sensitive to the spiritual needs of his congregation. He must be ready to divert his commentary to adjacent "open valleys." The land then will become verdant and ripe through words of moral instruction and edifying discourse. This metaphor emphasizes that Gregory taught that the exegete, and exegesis in general, should not be bound to a particular method or sense, but should look for whatever might edify his listeners.

Grover Zinn in his article "Exegesis and Spirituality in the Writings of Gregory the Great" presents some interesting insights regarding the various metaphors used in Gregory's letter to Leander. An additional metaphor that has not yet been cited is where Gregory describes the exegete as one preparing and serving a meal.⁸¹ Zinn explains that each of them connotes that the exegete "has the task of supplying a need or furnishing something that is not only informative but useful and even delightful for the hearer or reader."⁸² The idea of "delighting" the hearer derives from the food metaphor and from placing the fabric over a building.

Gregory word's for exegete *tractator* reinforces Zinn's insight.⁸³ Originally, the *tractator* was "a slave among the Romans, who

⁸⁰ *Sacri enim tractator eloquii morem fluminis debet imitari. Fluvius quippe dum per alueum defluit, si ualles ex latere concauas contingit, in eas protinus sui impetus cursum diuertit, cum que illas sufficienter impleuerit, repente sese in alueum refundit. Sic nimirum, sic diuini uerbi esse tractator debet, ut, cum de qualibet re disserit, si fortasse iuxta positam occasionem congruae aedificationis inuenerit, quasi ad uicinam uallem linguae undas intorqueat et, cum subiunctae instructionis campum sufficienter infuderit, ad sermonis propositi alueum recurat* (*Mor. ep. dedic. 2*).

⁸¹ Both metaphors are located in *Mor. ep. dedic. 3*.

⁸² Zinn, "Exegesis and Spirituality in the Writings of Gregory the Great," 171.

⁸³ Gregory, *Mor. ep. dedic. 1*.

manipulated and supplied his master's limbs while anointing them."⁸⁴ The *tractator* pulled and pushed on his master's limbs in order to bring renewed strength and refreshment. This subtle allusion to a masseur harmonizes with Gregory's understanding of the role of the exegete and preacher. The interpreter must at times push and pull on the text to convey a helpful meaning for the listeners.

One might ask, however, what types of interpretations should be presented so that the audience might have an "edifying" discourse? It is possible for the literal sense to build up? In the final part of his letter, Gregory answers this question and clarifies how the literal and allegorical senses are related.

Literal and allegorical senses

Based on his love of the allegorical method, one might think that Gregory encouraged exegetes to disregard the literal or historical sense. He was, however, too much a lover of the Bible to make such a claim. He knew that the literal sense also held value and meaning. Even though he does admit to Leander that he will at times rush through the literal sense, "Sometimes, we neglect to discuss the literal words of the historical layer lest we arrive too slowly at the hidden (*obscura*) words."⁸⁵ Gregory does encourage exegetes to pay attention to the surface meaning of Scripture to see if it might bear fruit:

But sometimes he who neglects to accept literally the historical form of words, conceals the light of truth which is presented to him, and when he, with much labor, seeks to find in them a further interior meaning, he loses that which he might easily obtain on the surface.⁸⁶

⁸⁴ C. T. Lewis and C. Short, *A Latin Dictionary* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1969), s.v. *tractator*.

⁸⁵ *Aliquando uero exponere aperta historiae uerba neglegimus, ne tardius ad obscura ueniamus* (Gregory, *Mor. ep. dedic.* 3).

⁸⁶ *Aliquando autem qui uerba accipere historiae iuxta litteram neglegit, oblatum sibi ueritatis lumen abscondit, cumque laboriose inuenire in eis aliquid intrinsecus appetit, hoc, quod foris sine difficultate assequi poterat, amittit* (*Mor. ep. dedic.* 4).

In his *Homilies on Ezekiel*, he explains that the historical sense contains helpful moral instruction or provides edifying examples.⁸⁷

Although Gregory does emphasize the importance of allegory and the spiritual sense in this letter to Leander, his exposition strikes a more balanced tone as compared with his *Commentary on the Canticle of Canticles*. One of the primary reasons for this is that he did not want to interpret the canticle literally. Although the literal meaning has a place and value, Gregory does concede that often the historical words or literal sense are more fitting for the “simple (*simplices*)” rather than for the “advanced (*mentes sublimium*).”⁸⁸ On the whole, in his writings on biblical hermeneutics, Gregory does often maintain this dichotomy.⁸⁹

Gregory also taught that the literal meaning serves as a bridge for the allegorical one. When commenting on this verse from Ezekiel, he writes,

In this place, if we take the gate as Sacred Scripture, it itself has two thresholds, the external and the internal, because it is divided into both letter (*littera*) and allegory (*allegoria*). Indeed, the exterior threshold of Sacred Scripture is the letter (*littera*) and the interior is truly allegory. Because, through the letter we move towards allegory, as if we come from the exterior threshold to the inner one.⁹⁰

Here, Gregory emphasizes that one of the roles of the literal sense is to prepare the hearer for allegory. The words of the text purify and strengthen the hearer so that he/she might be able to appreciate deeper meanings.

Conclusion

Unlike his mentor Augustine, Gregory has little to say on semiotics. He does, however, theorize about other aspects of hermeneutics. In his prologue to his *Commentary on the Canticle of Canticles*, there

⁸⁷ *Hom. Ez.* 2.3.18. ⁸⁸ *Mor. ep. dedic.* 4. ⁸⁹ *Hom. Ez.* 1.9.30–1.

⁹⁰ *Si uero portam scripturam sacram hoc in loco accipimus, ipsa quoque duo limina habet, exterius et interius, quia in littera diuiditur et allegoria. Limen quippe scripturae sacrae exterius littera, limen uero eius interius allegoria. Quia enim per litteram ad allegoriam tendimus, quasi a limine quod est exterius, ad hoc quod est interius uenimus* (*Hom. Ez.* 2.3.18; cf. 2.10.1–2).

were two aspects of exegesis that were highlighted. First, allegory is one of the ways that God has planned to rescue humanity. Enigmas in the scriptural text hide spiritual truths. The exegete should reveal them for the edification of his/her flock. Second, scriptural allegory is also a type of spiritual exercise that forces the hearer to depart from externals and focus on the interior where God is to be found.

In the *Moralia*, three points were discussed. First, Gregory articulated a tripartite method of interpreting Scripture. He emphasizes that the exegete “incline” his/her interpretations toward morality. Gregory's period and his own interest help to contextualize this preference. Second, he emphasizes that the exegete should look for opportunities to edify his/her brethren and should like a river depart readily from his/her initial topic or method. This is the end of exegesis – to edify the hearers. Third, although Gregory had a love for allegory, he also valued the literal sense and believed that it could serve as a bridge for allegory.

After examining Gregory's teaching on exegesis, it might feel as if there is more that needs to be discussed. In his account, there are some significant silences. Gregory does not discuss which disciplines aid the hermeneutical task, as Augustine does in his *De doctrina Christiana*.⁹¹ Unlike Cassiodorus, who endorsed the use of trivium to interpret texts, Gregory explicitly declares that he will ignore the art of rhetoric:

I have despised to follow the art of speaking, which the rules of worldly training recommend . . . I believe it exceedingly shameful that I might restrain the words of the heavenly oracle with the rules of Donatus.⁹²

However, the absence of the endorsement of these technical features should not lead one to presume that Gregory was apathetic toward interpretation; rather, he believed that the most important aspect of

⁹¹ Augustine, *doc. Chr.* 2.27.41–42.63.

⁹² *Ipsam loquendi artem, quam magisteria disciplinae exterioris insinuant, seruare despexi . . . indignum uehementer existimo, ut uerba caelestis oraculi restringam sub regulis Donati* (Gregory, *Mor. ep. dedic.* 5). Although Gregory states that he will not follow the “secular” conventions, these can nevertheless be discerned in his actual exegesis (see Straw, *Authors of the Middle Ages*, 9).

exegesis is to help the hearer move closer to God. This open-ended purpose gives a unique flavor to his exegesis conditioned by his time and monastic preferences.

FURTHER READING

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CHAPTER 9

Isidore's hermeneutics *The codification of the tradition* *Thomas O'Loughlin*

The man and his works

Approaching the work of Isidore of Seville (ca. 560–636 CE) always presents the historian with a dilemma: should one read his works as those of the last major representative of late antiquity or the first medieval writer? In favor of the first approach, Isidore was someone with a more ready access to the books of that culture than would be true of many within a generation or two of his death, and he was a writer to whom the world of Latin thought, whether Christian or not, was perceived as his own rather than an inherited legacy of another culture. In favor of the second approach we could note that he was a supporter of the Visigothic kingdom in Spain whose church he imagined as distinct from those of other places and, in virtually all his writings, there is an emphasis on the classroom, whether that be within a monastery or one dedicated to educating diocesan clergy. Since Isidore, probably quite unjustly due to his influence on later Latin theology, is rarely a subject for those who study patristic thought, his own views are not well researched. By contrast, as an early medieval thinker he is declared the source used by later writers, but again his own thought is bypassed and he is seen principally as the conduit by which earlier learning was made available to later times. Isidore is treated as a quarry for sources and an almost passive means through which bits and pieces of learning were preserved in a ruder world. Within the context of this book, this chapter seeks to move between these interpretations and see Isidore's hermeneutics – or what we shall infer were his hermeneutics – as coming at the close of Latin antiquity, but shall try to present him as making a distinctive

contribution, the editor and compiler as a creative artist, to the shape of the tradition that “survived” through him.

Born in Seville into a family belonging to the older Roman nobility, Isidore’s life can be understood only in relationship to the new Visigothic rulers of Spain – whose rule he supported with his constant work for establishing order, regulation, and law.¹ This theme of order and regularity he pursued as energetically in church matters, canon law, theology, and liturgy as he did in society more generally, and it can be seen as a key to understanding the diversity of his literary output, and indeed his hermeneutics. His most constant belief was that order should exist in the universe as a result of its divine creation; there should be order in revelation and in the accounts of revelation for the same reason. In consequence, the church teacher must seek this order out and make it manifest; while, obversely, disorder, ignorance, and the disruptions in human affairs that result from sinfulness must be challenged by the bishop, who should strive to eliminate them. So the work that he pursued in producing theological manuals, in promoting a more organized canon law, a more stable monarchy, or a more uniform liturgical practice, can be seen as flowing from his fundamental vision of creation as ordered. In terms of his hermeneutics it meant that he viewed all knowing as a deductive process based on a divine *datum*, where the ability to make valid inferences, note connections, and organize details into their correct genera counted as the height of genius and achievement.²

As a young man Isidore became a monk in the monastery where his elder brother, Leander, was abbot, and presumably there received his formative education. From the extent of his own library and the overall structure of his approach, we can infer that the intellectual program of that monastery was deeply influenced by the

¹ There is little contemporary information on Isidore’s life except a brief notice in Braulio of Saragossa’s additions to *De uiris illustribus* (PL 81:15–7). Our knowledge of him is in the main derived from his own writings.

² One needs to examine but one book of his *Etymologiae* to see this process at work: he arranges the details in hierarchical pyramids and assumes that each pyramid should fit into a precise place in an even larger pyramid.

Institutiones of Cassiodorus: a wide-ranging introduction to human learning, but one that was focused on the interpretation of the Christian Scripture as the summit of knowledge – of knowing things divine. Around 580, Leander became bishop of Seville and Isidore succeeded him in that office around 600, but Isidore's experience in the monastery remained with him all his life. He continued to be interested in monastic discipline, and an extension of those monastic concerns was his interest as a bishop in clerical education and the provision of textbooks. Similarly, the work he did to promote liturgical and canonical uniformity can be seen as reflections of the monastic desire for an ordered religious life.³ He presided over two important church councils, whose legislation had widespread influence, in Seville in 619 and Toledo in 633,⁴ whose provisions witness directly to how deep-seated was his desire for organization in every aspect of Christian life.⁵ It impossible to summarize his writings, which range from works aimed at the conversion of Jews to works of piety, but two elements are invariably present. First, an interest in biblical exegesis – quite apart from his formal commentaries, many of his works are broadly concerned with the explication of Scripture and every one of them cites the Bible as a treasury of facts. Second, a concern to reduce the volume of the tradition and reproduce it in orderly, easily transmitted packages; this didactic agendum was a more significant factor in his understanding than any consciously embraced hermeneutical concern.

³ See his *De ecclesiasticis officiis* and his *Regula monachorum*. The structure of the Mozarabic liturgy has traditionally been attributed to him as well.

⁴ Known, respectively, as “the Second Council of Seville” and “the Fourth Council of Toledo.” The canons of the latter council show his stress on ecclesiastic and liturgical discipline, which he wished to extend to the whole of Spain, while they also stress the importance of learning (assumed to be a clerical preserve). For the text of these canons, which give not only a flavor of the man but an insight into his fascination with order in everything, see *PL* 84:593–608 (for details of critical editions, see E. Dekkers, *Clavis Patrum Latinorum*, 3rd ed. [Steenbrugis: In Abbatia S. Petri, 1995], n. 1786a).

⁵ See R. L. Stocking, *Bishops, Councils, and Consensus in the Visigothic Kingdom, 589–633* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 2000).

Anyone seeking to discover Isidore's position on any theological question – and his hermeneutic is firmly within that sphere – runs into two immediate problems. First, few theologians have ever sought to be as unoriginal as he did: the task of his generation, as he saw it, was not to write new material – innovation and heresy were closely linked in his mind – but to respect the existing tradition and make it accessible. This required him to organize the opinions of those whom he held in awe as the great fathers – Ambrose, Augustine, and Jerome in particular – in such a way that they were seen as speaking with one voice.⁶ So the challenge in discovering his hermeneutics is closely linked to his editorial values. He did profoundly affect the tradition but did this, ironically, through his desire to pass on his inheritance without alteration. Second, unlike, for example, Augustine in *De doctrina Christiana*, Eucherius, or Cassiodorus, Isidore did not offer any reflections on his work as a teacher or offer any guidance to others in the act of teaching; instead, he produced an educational end product, his own books, which were to be absorbed by the teachers and their pupils rather than used as guidance for independent didactic endeavors. Few influential writers in theology have been as apparently free from reflection on their own intellectual processes as Isidore.

His hermeneutical approach

The Isidorean “system”

The starting point of Isidore's hermeneutical approach is an assumption such as this dictum that he would have considered authoritative and attributed to St. Paul: “All Scripture is divinely inspired and useful for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in justice, such that the man of God may be complete, equipped for

⁶ On the awe with which he held those whom he saw as the key writers of the tradition, one should read his *De uiris illustribus*. On the process of harmonizing divergent opinions and presenting them in simplified form, see T. O'Loughlin, “Inventing the Apocrypha: The Role of Early Latin Canon Lists,” *Irish Theological Quarterly* 74 (2009), 53–74.

every good work" (2 Tm 3:16–7). The reader not only should expect to find perfection in Scripture, but, more importantly, should proceed on the basis that there is nothing accidental about what is in them. Everything is there by the will of God and, therefore, purposeful – and since the Christian reader was the ideal reader for whom all those texts came into existence, they must have a value for that reader. So when Isidore sought plan, organization, and order in the tradition, he did so in the belief that an ordered system did exist objectively in his materials, that it was one that he was bringing to light, and that the investigator should not rest until everything was, apparently, in its place. It was axiomatic for him that every detail in the deposit of revelation had meaning for him, so one should assume that it could be explained clearly. We see this notion of comprehensible coherence in Isidore's treatment of law. He begins by stating that the first commentator on law was Moses: he had explained the divine law in Scripture. Next, he divided laws between those that were divine, based in nature, and those that were human and based in custom and that vary with peoples and times and, therefore, that may be in disagreement.⁷ The implication is that the divine law permeates nature and is unchanging, internally consistent, and has been given voice in Scripture – the Christian scholar must now bring the details to light for those whom he must instruct. Isidore's sense of the completeness of Scripture, and the purposefulness of each part, can be seen in that he provides a short world chronicle covering the whole of human history,⁸ then a closed scriptural canon with comments on how each book fits into classes within that canon,⁹ and then concludes: "These [men we have

⁷ Isidore, *Etymologiae* 5.1.1 (*Isidori Hispalensis episcopi Etymologiarum sive Originum libri xx*, ed. W. M. Lindsay [Oxford: Clarendon, 1911], no page numbers): *Moses gentis Hebraeae primus omnium diuinas leges sacris litteris explicauit*, and 5.2.1: *Omnes autem leges aut diuinae sunt, aut humanae. Diuinae natura, humanae moribus constant; ideoque haec discrepant, quoniam aliae aliis gentibus placent*. All references to the *Etymologiae* follow the common numeration convention of book number, followed by the chapter number, followed by the number of the sentence. All translations in this are by the author.

⁸ Isidore, *Etym.* 5.39. ⁹ *Etym.* 6.1–2.

listed], therefore, are the authors of the sacred books who when they spoke did so through the Holy Spirit and for our education drew up in writing both the precepts for living and the rule (*regulam*) for believing.”¹⁰

Isidore’s thought began with the notion of an ordered revelation and so with a canon. It then moved to what distinguished that canon; its books, unlike other writings, shared a guarantee of being inspired. So inspiration was more a function of canon rather than the reverse, and consequently, for Isidore, there must be in those books a freedom from contradiction and an inerrancy, which became virtually interchangeable concepts¹¹ and which became basic characteristics of the canonical texts. Each biblical book had its place within the whole and so could be discovered to cohere with every other text.¹² The result was that he treated the Bible as a vast deposit of propositions, each one of which could be used and reused in acts of human cognition. But, equally, it meant that these propositions, with the note of guaranteed truth as their common characteristic, were to be treated differently in how they were read/interpreted according to their distinct natures of the species of the genus – Scripture – in which they were located. Here we come to another hermeneutical principle that Isidore never explicitly expounded, but which is at the heart of his approach: the propositions of Scripture cannot contradict one another, but they cannot all be treated in the same way. Hence, the reader’s task has complementary aspects: he/she must be able to eliminate any apparent contradictions by explaining how and why they appear to be contradictory, and he/she must know the correct strategy to read the propositions correctly in terms of the different species of Scripture, where some items are to be read literally, some figuratively, and some in both ways.

¹⁰ *Etym.* 6.2.50; in this statement we hear an echo of 2 Tm 3:16–7.

¹¹ See T. O’Loughlin, “The Controversy over Methuselah’s Death: Proto-chronology and the Origins of the Western Concept of Inerrancy,” *Recherches de Théologie Ancienne et Médiévale* 62 (1995), 182–225.

¹² See Isidore’s *In libros ueteris ac noui testamenti prooemia*, or the survey of the Bible’s content in *Etym.* 6.1–2.

The closest Isidore comes to stating all this explicitly is in his first comment on the fact that the primary division within Scripture is into the two testaments: "the Old Testament is called 'old' because it ceased with the coming of the new."¹³ While this comment is, first and foremost, a theological affirmation of the position later theologians would label "supersessionism," it also exposes Isidore's central problem with reading Scripture: if those writings have been superseded, how can they be read today as anything more than a historical prologue? So if this material is to be viewed and used as Scripture, inspired and relevant to the Christian, and it is, then it cannot be interpreted in the same way as the new. The old covenant may have ceased, but the documents are, somehow, still communicating to Isidore and his contemporaries. Viewed in this way, the task of exegesis, his activity as the ideal reader, is built into the structure of salvation's history: one reads "the old" precisely as is demanded by its nature given that one is located in the time of "the new," after the supersession of "the old." So the question becomes one of knowing the appropriate reading strategies.

If knowledge was equivalent to the sum total of the facts, and these were to be found par excellence in Scripture, then wisdom was the exegete's skill in knowing which parts of Scripture were to be interpreted in which way. Indeed, given that Scripture formed a well-defined corpus (we have noted that he began with a canon), then once one knew the different and appropriate ways of interpreting each part, one could look at all interpretation as a matter of making, logically, valid deductions. One had, after all, the whole set of true facts. Again, Isidore does not tell us this in so many words, but if we assemble his comments on the means of interpreting the parts of Scripture, we see that he had a consistent vision of this activity, and he was prepared to identify the process with the pursuit of wisdom (*sapientia*).

¹³ *Etym.* 6.1.1 with Paul (2 Cor 5:17) quoted as the authority whose statement closes the question.

In *De differentiis uerborum*, in the course of distinguishing “wisdom” and “eloquence,” he proposes this location for Scripture and asserts that it can be read using three senses (Table 9.1).¹⁴

¹⁴ Isidore, *De differentiis uerborum* 2.39.148–58 (PL 83:93–5):

[148] *Inter sapientiam et eloquentiam ita distinguunt: quod eloquentia constat ex uerbis. Sapientia sine eloquentia prodesse non est dubium. Eloquentia sine sapientia ualere non potest. Melior enim indiscreta prudentia quam stulta loquasitas. Rerum enim studia prosunt, non ornamenta uerborum. Eloquentia enim, ut diximus, scientia est uerborum; sapientia autem, cognitio rerum et intellectus causarum.*

[The ancients] distinguish wisdom and eloquence in that eloquence consists in words, but no one doubts that wisdom needs eloquence to be of benefit, and eloquence without wisdom is not worth much. It is better to be indiscreetly prudent than to foolishly verbose. Studies of things bring benefits, not the ornamentation of words; for eloquence is, as we say, a knowledge of words, but wisdom is the knowledge and understanding of the causes of things.

[149] *Porro sapientiam ueteres philosophiam uocauerunt, id est omnium rerum humanarum atque diuinarum scientiam. Huius philosophiae partes tres esse dixerunt, id est, physiciam, logicam, ethicam. Physica, naturalis est; ethica, moralis; logica, rationalis. Harum prima naturae et contemplatio rerum deputatur, secunda in actione et cognitio recte uiuendi uersatur, tertia in discernendo uerum a falso ponitur.*

So long ago the ancients called wisdom “philosophy,” that is the knowledge of all things human and divine. They also said that there were three parts to philosophy: physics, logic, and ethics. Physics [relates to the things] of nature; ethics to morality; and logic to rational [matters]. The first of these deals with the nature and contemplation of things; the second to action and knowledge of upright living; and the third concerns discerning the true from the false.

[150] *Hoc trimodum philosophiae genus, iuxta sapientes mundi in partibus suis, ita distinguitur. Ad physicsm pertinere aiunt disciplinas septem, quarum prima est arithmetica, secunda geometrica, tertia musica, quarta astronomia, quinta astrologia, sexta mechanica, septima medicina. Ratio autem earundem disciplinarum breuiter, ista est.*

This threefold genus, “philosophy,” is further divided into its parts by the wise men of the world thus: they say that there are seven disciplines pertaining to physics [and] of these the first is arithmetic, the second geometry, the third music, the fourth astronomy, the fifth astrology, the sixth mechanics, the seventh medicine. Here is a brief account of these disciplines.

[151] *Arithmetica est . . .*

Arithmetic is . . .

[152] *Astronomia est . . .*

Astronomy is . . .

[153] *Digestis generibus, siue differentiis physicae artis, nunc partes logices exsequamur. Constat autem ex dialectica et rhetorica. Dialectica est ratio siue regula disputandi, intellectum mentis acuens, ueraque a falsis distinguens. Rhetorica est ratio dicendi, iuris peritorum scientia, quam oratores sequuntur. Hac, ut quidem ait, ‘sicut ferrum ueneno, sententia armatur eloquio.*

We see in the tripartite division of wisdom his debt to Eucherius and in the three senses he applies to Scripture his debt to Cassian. Interpretation using these senses is part of the moral life of humans

With the orderly setting out of these parts, that is the differing aspects of the skill of physics, done, now we can move on to the parts of logic. Now this consists in dialectic and rhetoric. Dialectic is the understanding and rule of disputation, the sharpening of the mind's understanding, and the separating of the true from the false. Rhetoric concerns the matter of speaking, it is the knowledge of the lawyers, and that which the orators take on board. This is to be understood, as someone has said, in this way: "as an iron [arrowhead] is tipped with poison, so a statement is armed by eloquence."

[154] *Post logicam sequitur ethica, quae ad institutionem pertinent morum. Haec enim bene uiuendi magistra est, diuiditurque in quatuor principales uirtutes: prudentiam, scilicet, atque iustitiam, fortitudinem, et temperantiam. Prudentia est agnitio uerae fidei, et scientia scripturarum, in qua intueri oportet illud trimodum intelligentiae genus. Quorum primum est per quod quaedam accipiuntur historialiter sine ulla figura, ut sunt decem praecepta; secundum est per quod quaedam in scripturis permixto iure accipiuntur, tam secundum finem rerum gestarum, quam etiam iuxta figurarum intellectum, sicut de Sara et Agar. Primum quod uere fuerint, de hinc quod tropice duo Testamenta figurentur.*

Ethics comes after logic and related to the establishment of customs. This is the teacher of good living and is divided into the four principle virtues: prudence, justice, fortitude, and temperance. Now prudence is the awareness of the true faith, and the knowledge of the scriptures, and in this matter we should distinguish three kinds of understanding. Of these the first are those things that we should receive in a historical manner without any trace of a "figure" such as [for example] the Ten Commandments. The second concerns those things in the scriptures that are to be received in a mixed fashion: where they are to be understood also according to a "figure" such as Sarah and Hagar. According to the first [kind of understanding] they truly were [historical women], then figuratively they stand for the two Covenants.

[155] *Tertium genus est quod tantum spiritualiter accipitur, sicut Canticis canticorum. Quae si iuxta sonum uerborum uel efficientiam operis sentiantur, corporalis magis luxuria quam uirtus sacramentorum accipitur.*

The third kind of understanding relates to those things that are to be received only in a spiritual way, such as the Song of Songs. For it this [book] were received according to the sound of the words or [effects of the description] of the things done, then it would be felt to relate more to bodily excess than to the power of the hidden spiritual messages.

[156] *Definitio prudentiae . . .*

The definition of prudence is . . .

[157] *Fortitudo est . . .*

Fortitude is . . .

[158] *Temperantia est . . .*

Temperance is . . .

Table 9.1 *The parts of wisdom in De differentiis uerborum*

S	Physics——	Seven Arts		
A				
P				
I		Justice	{	Divine Truth
E	Ethics——	Prudence		
N		Fortitude	{	Scripture
T		Temperance		
I				
A	Logic——	Dialectic Rhetoric		

and essential to that life insofar as it pertains to things divine, an echo of Cassiodorus. Exegesis is distinct from intellectual (logic) and natural (physics) sciences, but not in such a manner that these could be construed in opposition to each other, but being located between them it is central to the human being as a subject of divine interest. It is worthwhile to examine this vision in detail if we are to appreciate his hermeneutic.

Isidore's analysis begins with a question on the difference between wisdom (*sapientia*) and eloquence (*eloquentia*). Wisdom is then identified with philosophy, which, following Eucherius and Augustine, is made up of the three parts of physics (natural philosophy), ethics (moral philosophy), and logic (rational philosophy). Physics is the contemplation of the things of nature, ethics is the knowledge of right living and action, and logic is concerned with discerning true from false.¹⁵ To each branch pertains special skills. Thus the seven arts (the *quadriuium* with mechanics, medicine, and astrology¹⁶) are related to physics,¹⁷ and logic is composed of dialectic and rhetoric.¹⁸ Lastly ethics is the skills of the four cardinal virtues.

¹⁵ This description of logic is in accord with his usual definition of the discipline we call "logic"; see *Etym.* 1.2.1.

¹⁶ Cf. J. Fontaine, "Isidore de Séville et l'astrologie," *Revue des Études Latines* 31 (1953), 271–300.

¹⁷ Isidore, *De differentiis uerborum* 2.39.150–2. ¹⁸ *Diff.* 2.29.153.

One of these, prudence, is concerned with two matters: the ability to know the true faith, and the science of the scriptures (*scientia scripturarum*).

The science of the scriptures (*scientia scripturarum*) has, in turn, three parts. These he describes thus:

We should distinguish in the science of the scriptures three different ways of understanding.

Of these, the first is related to those matters which we should acquire in a historical manner (*historialiter*) without any figure, such as the Ten Commandments;

secondly, [those parts] which are to be understood according to a mixed rule, [both] according to the purposes of things and deeds but which also should be understood as figures [of something else] as in the case of Sarah and Hagar. In the first case they are to be understood as they were [as historical women], then [second] they are to be understood as prefiguring the two covenants.

The third mode of understanding relates to those things which should be understood only in a spiritual way (*spiritualiter*), for instance, the Song of Songs. For if we were to understand [that biblical book] according to the sound of its words or the deeds it describes, it would be interpreted more as relating to bodily indulgence rather than to the power of the sacraments.¹⁹

This was a novel way of presenting the senses. For although they fall within moral philosophy, with the basic implication that Scripture is to be seen as a guide to an upright human life, there is no mention of a moral sense. Indeed, this triple division is based on a double division of historical and spiritual readings of Scripture, along with a mixed sense combining the two extremes. The first sense is “pure” history, that is, history without figurative meaning, where history is defined as covering what truly has happened and is

¹⁹ *Diff.* 2.29.154–5; the example he takes of a book that can be interpreted only figuratively (and for which a literal reading must be rejected completely), the Song of Songs, had for Isidore the character of a *reductio ad absurdum*, and was already a commonplace in exegesis (cf. T. O’Loughlin, “Seeking the Medieval View of the *Song of Songs*,” *Proceedings of the Irish Biblical Association* 18 [1995], 94–116).

to be taken literally at face value.²⁰ It is characterized by being directly accessible in the words of the text. The third genus is “purely spiritual” where the face value of the text must be ignored completely as having any value. Only one book in the whole of Scripture fitted into this category in that its literal message had to be ignored, the Song of Songs.²¹ Here “the other” meaning, which could be called “mystical” or “sacramental,” alone had any value, terms that Isidore used interchangeably with “spiritual” and which for him simply meant a specific nonnatural coding attached to a word. The paradigm for this, which supplied Isidore with his terminology, came from the view that the song was a lovers’ dialogue that was to be read from the perspective of the marriage of Christ and the church on the basis of Eph 5:25–32 where “Paul” describes this marriage as a “mystery” or “sacrament.”²²

Between “pure history” and “pure spirituality” fall all the texts that have to be read at face value *and* with “another” meaning. Here are those texts that should be read using the Old and New Testaments together (old prefiguring new, old and new together amounting to the whole divine message, or any other relationship between them), where the historical had additional hidden meanings, or where a text should be understood eschatologically. Clearly,

²⁰ The example that Isidore gives is the Decalogue. This choice of example is somewhat surprising when we recall that Christians had to adapt the Decalogue from the beginning to their understanding of God as triune, the replacement of the Sabbath by Sunday, their different notion of “rest,” and their different attitude to images/icons. A possible reason for Isidore’s choice may lie in his activity as a church legislator: there Old Testament law was taken at face value as legal mandates.

²¹ In another work from the same period, i.e., before 610, the *In libros ueteris ac noui testamenti prooemia*, Isidore refers in a similar way to the song. The corpus of Solomon’s writings constitutes a complete course in philosophy, and can be seen thus:

Proverbs: Ethics which deals with the emendation of morals.

Qoheleth: Physics which explains the truth of the things of nature.

Song: *ad ultimum theoricam, id est, contemplatiuam* which deals with heavenly things (*Prooemia* 36–8, *PL* 83:164–5).

²² On this language, see O’Loughlin, “Seeking the Medieval View of the Song of Songs,” 116.

Isidore was troubled by the conflicting terminologies and descriptions of the “additional” senses, and his mixed second category combined all those meanings that were labeled “analogical,” “allegorical,” “anagogical,” “figurative,” and “tropological” in earlier writers: from his perspective these were all similar in that they called for decoding in addition to the literal reading. The key to his understanding of this second, mixed category is his example of Sarah and Hagar. This story, from Genesis 16 and 21, had been used by Paul in Galatians 4:21–7 as a means of addressing the relationship between the two Covenants (*testamenta*).²³ Hagar was the woman of the historical mountain in Arabia and is the Jerusalem on earth that points to the old dispensation. Sarah was the wife of Abraham and also corresponds to the new Jerusalem and the new dispensation. In the words of Paul these two historical women convey this message of the two dispensations, and, as Isidore read Paul, they convey this lesson as part of the whole divine plan of revelation, by way of “allegory”: “*quae [Sarah the libera and Hagar the ancilla] sunt per allegoriam dicta, haec enim sunt duo testamenta.*”²⁴ Thus the mixed sense for Isidore is allegory, but this can be a prefiguring of the new in the old, or the complementary sense where both are read together.

Isidore's three senses can be seen as an attempt to clarify the various materials he had received from the tradition by separating out what were clearly distinct readings, and lumping the ill-defined senses where names and definitions varied so erratically into a third “default” category. We should note that in this process, where the two “pure” senses act as the defining poles, the twin senses of actual and contemplative can be operating silently. The actual and contemplative were seen as mutually defining one another as a binary couplet. But in effect they had to admit a third when applied to

²³ This was also used by Paul in Rom 9:9 and Heb 11:11 (taken by Isidore to have been the author of Heb), and in 1 Pt 3:6. In these cases the historical woman is also the bearer of a message of the relationship between the Old and New Testaments, or, as in 1 Pt, a model of the relationship of Christians with Christ.

²⁴ Gal 4:24: “Now these things are spoken about through allegory: these women are two covenants.”

either learning or life. This was the “mixed life,” or learning that was partially theoretical and partially practical.²⁵ This mixed category was obviously the one that he thought would cause the greatest actual difficulties to those teaching from Scripture, for if the *historialiter* part could be read directly in the text, the *spiritualiter* part needed to be supplied from other knowledge, and hence his special handbook: the *Allegoriae quaedam sacrae scripturae*. Not only are “other” meanings of Sarah and Hagar listed, but well over a hundred individuals (e.g., Jonah) and groups (e.g., the Maccabee brothers) are listed from the Old Testament and then explained in terms of what they signify in relation to Jesus or the church. Isidore then moves through figures from the time of the New Testament (some, such as the evangelists, one would expect; others, such as the blind mute demoniac of Mt 12:22, are more surprising²⁶) decoding each person’s significance in terms of Christian teaching.

Isidore’s threefold system can therefore be seen as a refinement of Cassian’s twofold division of knowledge, which then functions as a system of senses that amalgamates the differences found in Jerome, Augustine, and Eucherius into a neat, if not overly defined, category. But this replaces an explicitly moral sense with a new sense of purely spiritual exegesis, modeled on *theoria*, which is dedicated to that tiny category of texts, strictly speaking, just one book, whose meaning is wholly heavenly and where any visible, historical information can be completely ignored.

The *Etymologiae* presents a somewhat different picture (see Table 9.2). In the context of the definition of philosophy (*philosophia*) Isidore notes, as in the *De differentiis uerborum*, that it can be

²⁵ This is exemplified in Gregory the Great’s *Regula pastoralis*; cf. J. Leclercq, *The Love of Learning and the Desire for God*, trans. C. Misrahi (New York: Fordham University Press, 1961), 99–108.

²⁶ Isidore, *Allegoriae* 162 (*PL* 83:119–20): “*Daemonum habens, caecus et mutus*” [Mt 12:22] *qui scribitur a saluatore curatus, indicat eos qui ex idolatria gentium ad fidem dominicam conuertuntur, quibus tamen, expulso a corde daemonum cultu, dum primum lucem perceperint fidei, postea ad laudandum Deum eorum lingua resoluitur, ut confiteantur eum quem antea negauerunt.*

Table 9.2 *Division of wisdom and Scripture* (Etym. 2.24.3–8)

Natural	Physics	Thales	Material Causes	Genesis and Qoheleth
Moral	Ethics	Socrates	Human life	Proverbs etc.
Rational	Logic	Plato	Higher Causes	Song and gospels

broken into three parts, natural (physics), moral (ethics), and rational (logic), which are now defined in terms of not the human disciplines involved in its study, but their essential content.²⁷ Physics, characterised by Thales, is the search for the causes of the order in the heavens and the power in natural things.²⁸ Now those who are interested in these matters find them discussed, in revealed sources, in Genesis and Qoheleth.²⁹ Ethics, linked with Socrates, is concerned with the order of living things, the correction of morals, the good life, and the content of the cardinal virtues.³⁰ In Scripture, these concerns are addressed in Proverbs, and scattered throughout all the other books.³¹ The last class is characterized by Plato and is concerned with reasoned understanding and the search for the reasons that underlie the causes of things and morals.³² This is the most profound kind of inquiry and is likened to the material found in the Song of Songs and the gospels.³³

At no point in this analysis, however, does Isidore refer to the manner in which these books are read.

Isidore then presents, following Cassian, a division of philosophy into two parts: a higher type of knowing, which is “inspective” (*inspectiua*), and a lesser sort called “actual” (*actualis*). Inspective knowing, equivalent to Cassian’s *theoria*,³⁴ is concerned with what is

²⁷ Etym. 2.24.3. ²⁸ Etym. 2.24.4.

²⁹ Etym. 2.24.8; this picks up a theme that he had explored in relation to the Solomonic writings in the *In libros ueteris ac noui testamenti prooemia*.

³⁰ Etym. 2.24.5.

³¹ Etym. 2.24.8; this directly echoes the *In libros ueteris ac noui testamenti prooemia*.

³² Etym. 2.24.6 and 7. ³³ Etym. 22.24.8.

³⁴ Etym. 22.24.9: *Philosophia diuiditur in duas partes: prima inspectiua; secunda actualis*.

Table 9.3 *The twofold division of philosophy* (Etym. 2.24.10–16)

<i>Inspectiva</i> Concerns invisible things, divine matters, and heavenly contemplation [= Cassian's <i>theorica</i> (theoretical understanding)]	Natural*	The creation as it was intended by God [†]
	Doctrinal	The <i>quadriuium</i> founded in the abstraction of number [‡]
	Divine	Concerns the ineffable nature of God; and matters relating to the spiritual creatures [§]
<i>Actual</i> Presumably the opposite of the above: visible, material, and terrestrial things – practical reason [= Cassian's <i>actualis</i> (actual understanding)]	Moral	Honest living and the virtues [¶]
	Domestic	The correct order of living in a household ^{**}
	Civil	Life in the city ^{††}

* This division is made at Etym. 2.24.10.

† Etym. 22.24.12.

‡ Etym. 22.24.10, and 14–5.

§ Etym. 22.24.13.

|| Etym. 22.24.11.

¶ Etym. 22.24.16.

** Etym. 22.24.16.

†† Etym. 22.24.16.

beyond the visible, with heavenly contemplation, and with divine things.³⁵ Isidore breaks up the two parts, as presented in Table 9.3.

While the threefold division appears to be understood by Isidore primarily as a division of subjects dealing with parts of reality, the twofold division appears as ways of looking at reality. As such they cannot be reduced to one another or made fully compatible.

³⁵ Etym. 22.24.10 and 11.

As to the question of whether the systems in the two works can be integrated, at first sight the answer would appear to be negative. They appear to be different systems that, although they have many terms in common, stand parallel to one another. As such they would appear to be two distinct attempts to organize knowledge, one succeeding the other as Isidore's preferred solution, and so incapable of being integrated into a single system. However, against this position is the fact that they do not contradict one another directly. Moreover, while the meaning of "logic" as one of the three branches of wisdom differs between the *De differentiis uerborum* and *Etymologiae* book 2, the earlier meaning is still used in *Etymologiae* book 1.

The key to the problem lies in Isidore's notion of wisdom and philosophy. In the *De differentiis uerborum*, Isidore is concerned with two realities, wisdom and eloquence, that exist as qualities in the person. Hence the question is what characterizes the makeup of the wise person. This person is the person of philosophy and has in his/her makeup the disciplines of philosophy such as the knowledge of physics that goes with being skilled in maths and its related arts, ethical virtues, and dialectical skill. Since all these exist as the unity, wisdom, they are brought to bear together on any problem demanding wisdom. So faced with some question in the whole field of wisdom – all things human and divine³⁶ – the wise person extracts information by his/her skills in the arts and possession of the virtues that enable him/her to turn to the sacred books and extract their message regarding the question, and has the mental abilities to discern true from false conclusions in the search. In the *Etymologiae*, Isidore is concerned not so much with wisdom (equating "philosophy") as a human quality, but with "philosophy" as the body of information on all things human and divine that can be appropriated by the person. Thus the divisions here are in the subject "philosophy"

³⁶ Isidore uses this famous classical definition thus: "Therefore, the ancients called wisdom 'philosophy'; that is, the knowledge of all things human and divine (*Porro sapientiam ueteres philosophiam uocauerunt, id est omnium rerum humanarum atque diuinarum scientiam*)" (*Diff.* 2.39.149).

rather than the various aspects of the thought and action of “the philosopher”/“wise person.” However, Isidore may not even have been aware of this subtlety; in actual practice the distinctions disappeared in that the various books had been decoded by the Fathers and the theory was a justification, after the fact, of how they had done so validly.

Isidore’s view of language

Given the labor Isidore expended in bringing the various schemes of “senses” into an alignment, and his further efforts to make the corpus of Scripture behave in an appropriately ordered way, when we come to his thoughts on words and sentences, we meet such a simple approach, taken uncritically, that one can feel disappointed. Isidore imagines a one-to-one relationship between different “things” and different words, while the origin of each name relates to the essence of the thing to the extent that an investigation of the origins of language can also be a study of the structure of reality.

We see this approach to language explicitly in *De differentiis uerborum*, the first book of which is devoted to distinguishing synonyms or closely related terms – listed alphabetically – in the manner that, at first sight, resembles a modern handbook, but which then in the second book moves on to theological distinctions and the correct use of words in discourses about God, the Trinity, and in Christology. One banal example, from the first book, suffices to give an insight into Isidore’s approach: “What [is the difference] between [the words] *aditus* and *ostium*. *Aditus* refers to that which admits; [while] *ostium* to that which excludes.”³⁷ Isidore starts with the fact that there are two words, and assumes that since there are two words that this must relate to a difference in reality. So disambiguating words is identical with distinguishing facts; and knowing the words more precisely is tantamount to a more precise grasp of reality. Every sound points to a thing; and for every thing there should be a sound. And this assumption then holds good when it comes to religious language: “[What is

³⁷ *Diff.* 1.32.

the difference between] 'god' (*deus*) and 'lord' (*dominus*)? . . . In the appellation 'god' is to be understood 'the Father,' in the appellation 'lord' is to be understood the Son."³⁸ But even Isidore realized that matters might not be as clear-cut as this, because he immediately adds: "Sacred scripture, however, affirms 'god' to be also 'lord.'"³⁹ This then leads to another distinction whereby "god" relates to the name of the nature and to love, while "lord" relates to power and fits with respect and fear. So once again the words are really distinct in connotation and each points to a distinct aspect of the reality of God. Isidore continues in this vein examining in turn the whole complex, and often contradictory, web of terms, in their familiar Latin forms, relating to God used by Christianity in its creeds and early conciliar disputes. Each of these terms not only has a real and distinct referent, but they can also all be consistently used in conjunction with one another. Indeed, once one knows how these terms are differentiated, and the specific range of each within theological discourse, one could produce a valid theological statement by understanding merely the terms themselves. Wisdom and knowledge are, apparently, comprehended by the language of our discourse. Isidore does not give any limits to the process and seems to assume, blithely, that with sufficient words, carefully used, one could have a descriptive language for the deity.

The realism of Isidore's view of language finds its most extensive expression in the unfinished work upon which he spent much of his life: the *Etymologiae*. In the first book, on grammar, he tries to present language as a set of organized signs such that once an intelligent student has mastered this set of signs, then there is little to prevent comprehension: the reader in laying hold of the words can decode reality, both human and divine. So close is this link between words and reality that he presents words as holding, through their origins and etymologies, insight into the essential natures of the realities to which they refer. He picks a very simple

³⁸ *Diff.* 2.1.1.

³⁹ *Diff.* 2.1.1. The combination *Dominus Deus uester* ("the Lord your God") alone is found no fewer than sixty times in the Vulgate.

example to demonstrate this: “A river (*flumen*), for instance, is called by this name because it relates to flowing (*fluendum*) because the river has grown by flowing (*a fluendo*).”⁴⁰

A few other examples, such as “rulers (*reges*)” from “right acting (*recte agens*)” and “human (*homo*)” from “earth (*humus*),”⁴¹ seem to confirm the more general conclusion that words store within them information about the causes of the things to which they refer and hence: “*Omnis enim rei inspectio etymologia cognita planior est.*”⁴² At this point, we might note the difference between Isidore’s notion of “etymology” and our own. For Isidore “etymology” is not, as it is for us, simply a lexical phenomenon, but one that while being obviously lexical is important because it lays hold of realities. Hence the attention he devotes to it while making it a principle of his “encyclopedia.”⁴³

But surely we humans do not have such a ready access to reality through language? The question is anticipated by Isidore with two explanations pointing out that there is noise within the system. First, not every word given by the ancients was chosen with proper care – some were given with the flippancy with which, to use his example, we give names to our slaves and possessions. As such these names do not give us an insight into the nature of things but are a witness to human wilfulness.⁴⁴ Second, some names originate in languages other than Latin or Greek, and consequently it is difficult to discern how the sound relates to the thing.⁴⁵ These “escape clauses” are a confirmation of Isidore’s key position: we are to see, on every occasion, a link between the word and a reality, and, normally, this

⁴⁰ Isidore, *Etym.* 1.29.1. ⁴¹ *Etym.* 1.29.3–4.

⁴² *Etym.* 1.29.2 (“A person’s understanding of each thing is more clear when the etymology [of its name] is known”); on this phrase, see J. Fontaine, “Aux sources de la lexicographie médiévale: Isidore de Séville médiateur de l’etymologie antique,” in Y. Lefèvre (ed.), *La Lexicographie du latin médiévale et ses rapports avec les recherches actuelles sur la civilisation du Moyen-Âge* (Paris: CNRS, 1981), 97–103, at 100.

⁴³ On what he meant by an encyclopedia, the work of E. Brehaut, *An Encyclopedist of the Dark Ages: Isidore of Seville* (New York: Burt Franklin, 1912), despite its age, is still invaluable.

⁴⁴ Isidore, *Etym.* 1.29.2–3. ⁴⁵ *Etym.* 1.29.5.

word's own content gives insight into reality. But there are limits due to the human situation after Adam's sin: humans have to contend with the effect of disordered wills and ignorance.

With the confidence of his linkage of words in texts and external reality and his structured system of senses for reading texts within a system of wisdom, Isidore felt certain that the well-trained reader could master the whole of knowledge and explain the most obscure passage in the Bible. Indeed, many of his medieval readers had just this confidence about him as they read through his works.

Tools for interpretation

There is a direct relationship between Isidore's hermeneutics/view of revelation and the content, form, and extent of his literary output. In the Latin west from the mid-fifth century there had been a growing perception that "the great minds" – the group that were beginning to be called "the fathers" – were in the past and that the task facing Christian writers was that of tidying up the details and effectively disseminating what had been gathered.⁴⁶ This movement saw itself as facing the tasks of being schoolmasters, and, in the language of Thomas Kuhn, being the group that carried on "normal science" within the paradigm established by writers such as Ambrose and Augustine.⁴⁷ This group's collective task was to distill all that had been inherited and make it available as the working knowledge of the clergy and in this process the well-arranged handbook, small in overall size, with pithy scraps of information arranged accessibly, and focused not on discussion but on "facts" ready for the end-user's consumption. Eucherius of Lyons' books, particularly the *Formulae spiritalis intelligentiae*, can be seen as characteristic of this process. However, with Isidore the process

⁴⁶ This can be seen in Eucherius' introductions to his books; see T. O'Loughlin, "The Symbol Gives Life: Eucherius of Lyons' Formula for Exegesis," in T. Finan and V. Twomey (eds.), *Scriptural Interpretation in the Fathers: Letter and Spirit* (Dublin: Four Courts, 1995), 221–52.

⁴⁷ Cf. T. S. Kuhn, *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions*, 3rd ed. (Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press, 1996 [1st ed., 1962]), 23–34 especially.

not only reached its most elaborate form, but was perfectly fitted to his hermeneutics. If the creation was a network of discrete facts, both those visible and those revealed, accessed by language, then lists of these facts and their significance were the building blocks of all true knowledge.

We have already met the two manuals where this agenda is most obvious. In the *De differentiis uerborum* we have lists arranged in accessible sequences that clarify language in ordinary and Christian use. In the *Allegoriae* we have the information that allows us to know the hidden significance of people mentioned in Scripture, and again it is arranged according to a system. In this case, Isidore followed a “historical” order based on the sequence of biblical books in his canon. But there were other lists to be compiled and then explained, and the numbers found in Scripture were an obvious case. Eucherius had already produced a short list, but Isidore produced a much more complete one, the *Liber numerorum*, and assumed that numbers carried specific coded meanings for the Christian reader allowing access to the parts of the text that were not visible on its surface.⁴⁸ As one would expect, the book was arranged numerically. And, of course, we can view much of the *Etymologiae* as organized lists of words and, where relevant, their meanings; the list of cities is a very good example.⁴⁹

In a similar manner, works such as the *In libros ueteris ac noui testamenti prooemia*, the *Liber de ortu et obitu patrum*, and his various chronicles of dates⁵⁰ supply their users (“readers” would be inappropriate here: these are books one “looks up” rather than “reads”) with information in such a manner that each matter covered is

⁴⁸ *PL* 83:179–200 – the entry on this work in *Clavis Patrum Latinorum*, n. 1193, is wholly confused as it conflated this text with that found in *PL* 83:1293–1302. The topic needs a fresh examination; and until that examination is complete, it is better to consider the *Liber numerorum* to be the work of Isidore, as was still assumed in the second edition of the *Clavis*.

⁴⁹ Isidore, *Etym.* 15.1.

⁵⁰ See T. O’Loughlin, “Isidore of Seville,” in R. G. Dunphy (ed.), *Encyclopedia of the Medieval Chronicle* (Leiden: Brill, 2010), vol. I, 880–3, for a listing and introduction.

understood to be purposeful within an overall scheme of history and that purpose can be known. Other works, such as his *De natura rerum*, which very obviously harmonize conflicting strands of his intellectual inheritance,⁵¹ can also be understood as supplying the background to a physical reading of creation as both a fact and a corresponding biblical narrative. In every case what prevents understanding is ignorance – and this is overcome through the careful sifting of the facts and then the convenient provision of the information for others.

Evaluation

Few Christian writers have achieved, almost within their lifetime, the fame that attached to Isidore in the period before the rise of the universities; equally, few have been ignored so completely by the later tradition. But that said, that does not mean that his influence ceased; indeed, it is arguable that many of his assumptions about language survived, anonymously, in biblical studies until the rise of criticism inspired by the spirit of Rationalism in the eighteenth century, while his approach to the language of systematic theology survived even longer, and can still be heard today in some discourses. So while not attempting to trace the history of the reception of Isidore, it is worthwhile trying to get an overview of his most enduring contributions to hermeneutics.

Three points are worth making. First, it would appear to be obvious that he had a naturalistic theory of languages: words name things and names are ideally descriptive within a system of language that maps reality completely. But this is not entirely fair to him because he never sought to evolve a theory of language. What he had worked out was a theology of revelation along with a curriculum for its acquisition of that revelation's message by its intended recipients. What made this appear both simple and comprehensive was that that theology was, in effect, a description of the history of

⁵¹ See T. O'Loughlin, "The Waters above the Heavens, Isidore, and the Latin Tradition," *Milltown Studies* 36 (1995), 104–17.

the divine work in creation and redemption. That history, or at least its core, from Adam to Moses to Jesus to the Church was, in turn, coextensive with the inspired Scripture. A curriculum that enabled these to be read, and where necessary decoded, was the path to wisdom; and in that process of reading there seemed little need for anything more than what we would call a naturalistic theory of language. The neat entailment of the various parts of the process with one another could, with belief in the inspiration of Scripture, lend the whole an air of satisfying cohesion. Abandoning any part of it – as later scriptural exegetes would discover – meant abandoning the whole and perhaps, many feared, even the way to salvation. Many people reading Isidore today would be apt to present him as the father of biblical/theological fundamentalism, but this may be unfair to him. While it is true that he uses a similar hermeneutic, he did not do so in opposition to another body of evidence and science, but on the basis that he was harmonizing all available knowledge. The charge that he confused orthodoxy with orthophony – adherence to faith resembles affirmation of legal formulae to promote uniformity in a society – and formulated his view of doctrine in response to his legal vision of a uniform Spanish church is far closer to the truth, and this may have been his major legacy to western Christianity.

Second, there was no qualitative distinction between the different uses of language, whether one was describing material objects, human emotions, or using language in speaking of God. Language was a simple matter of signs, that are assumed to be comprehensible, which represent objects. Education gives one command of this system of signs, and within the tradition of learning one could master all that was known about them. All these signs had a natural meaning, but some had, in addition, other meanings and these latent meanings could be learned through a deductive study of the available evidence. But whether one was speaking directly of the world of external objects, or using codes, such as allegories, to point to hidden meanings, the reality remained within the grasp of “the ideal reader” – that is, the orthodox Christian – within the creation. This view, though Isidore does not seem to have appreciated the fact, brought all reality, divine and created, within the compass of a

one-dimensional language. This language when fully mastered – perhaps through Isidore's numerous textbooks – is, when it is analyzed and allowances are made for ambiguities, noise, and special code, a univocal language.

Such a view of language marginalizes poetry, for instance, as merely ingenious art and has the effect in religious discourse, most especially in the liturgy, of reifying all the "objects" it names. But its most significant failing is that it inevitably leads to a univocal view of being: "God" is seen to refer to one more object, albeit a wholly unique object, within a universe of being consisting of "God" and "the creation." And when we read Isidore's doctrinal treatises (or sections in any of his works devoted to the trinitarian relationships such as questions in *De differentiis uerborum* book 2) we see that they are wholly amenable to being read with just such a view of the nature of the divine being. Likewise, when we read his works of sacramental dimensions of Christian life,⁵² we see that he has the wholly reified attitude that would follow from such a univocal view of language. In a religious universe where knowledge of God can be divided into those messages *en plein* and those in cipher, there is no room for mystery.

Third, Isidore's approach to understanding, with its emphasis on decoding words, led him to adopt a position where truth was assumed to reside in propositions. As such, the sources of truth – be that Scripture or the decisions of church councils – was a body of true *sententiae* which could be read and manipulated as so many facts. While this has often been identified as one of the key failings of scholastic and rationalist theology, what is noticeable in Isidore is that this has been made the central premise in his view of Scripture, and it is in relation to the question of how Christians read Scripture that that hermeneutical assumption would be most long lived. This position on truth did not emerge with Isidore, but, as with so much

⁵² See, for example, Isidore's treatment of the Eucharist in *Etym.* 6.19.38–42, or 8.5.22–23 and 38; or *Diff.* 2.33; or *Allegoriae* 19: these positions are merely explored in more detail in works explicitly intended to expound doctrine, as in, for example, *De ecclesiasticis officiis* 1.15.

he inherited, he codified it, just as he imagined he was codifying all the works he inherited, and made it appear resplendent as knowledge.

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